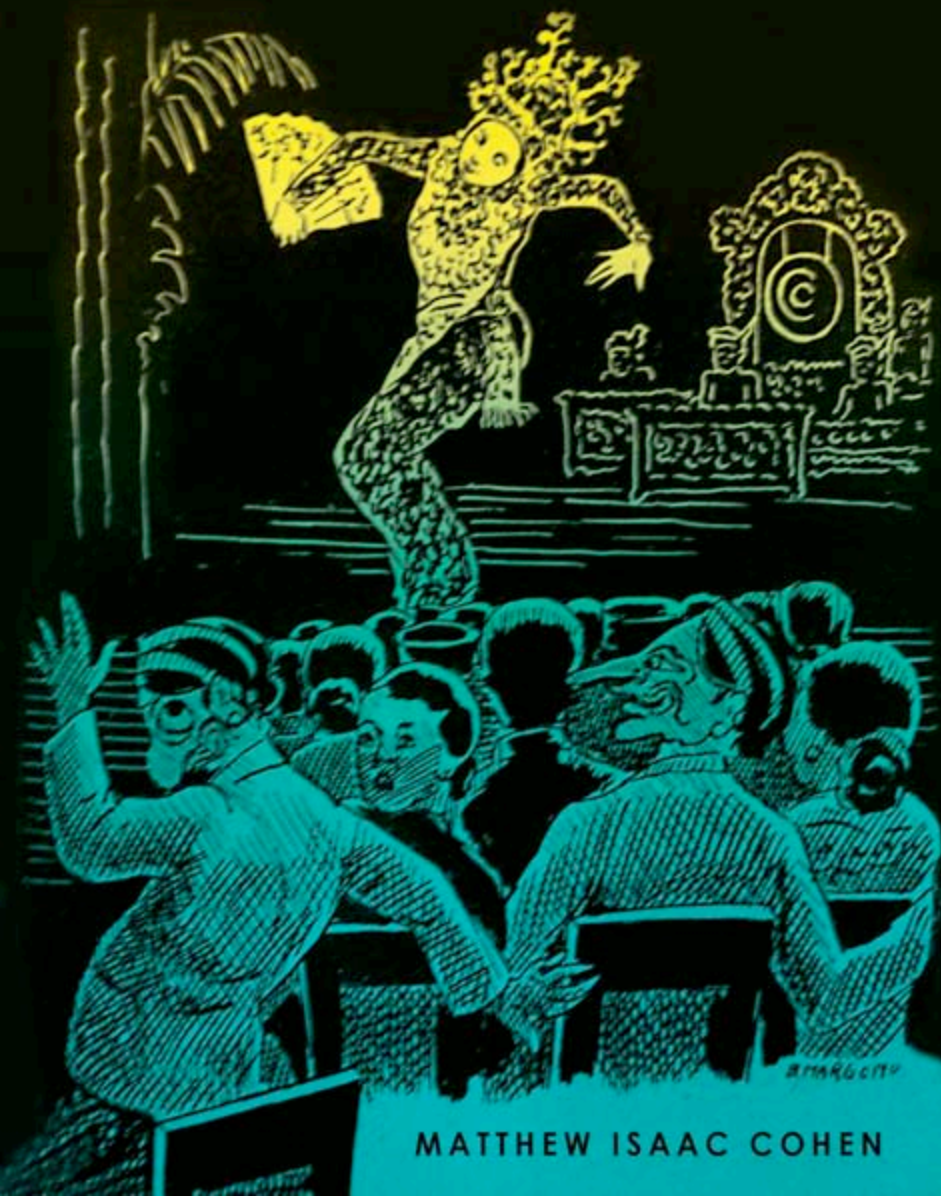


INVENTING THE PERFORMING ARTS

Modernity and Tradition in Colonial Indonesia



MATTHEW ISAAC COHEN

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*Modernity and Tradition
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Matthew Isaac Cohen



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A NOTE ON ORTHOGRAPHY AND LANGUAGE USE

This book references huge quantities of primary and secondary historical source materials in Indonesian, Malay (as Indonesian was known before 1928), Javanese, and Dutch. As with any book dealing with Indonesia before 1972, orthography is complicated and needs explaining. After 1972, Indonesian (*bahasa Indonesia*) and other languages spoken in Indonesia used a standard orthography, the Enhanced Indonesian Spelling System, which is largely phonetic like Italian. Before then, aspects of spelling were derived from Dutch conventions. So *c* (pronounced like the “ch” in church) before 1972 was written *tj*, *j* was written *dj*, *ny* was written *nj*, and *sy* (pronounced like the “sh” in ship) was written *sj*. In addition, before 1947, the vowel *i* (pronounced like the “ee” in feet) was written *ie*, and *u* (pronounced like the “oo” in boot) was written *oe*. Spelling was not standardized in the pre-1947 period, and the same word could have multiple spellings even in a single source—thus *stamboel*, *stambool*, and *stamboul* for *stambul*. My tendency in this book is to use the Enhanced Indonesian Spelling System except when quoting from period sources, referring to titles or names of organizations, or referencing personal names better known by other spellings. Where relevant, I tend to use Javanese over Indonesian spellings, so *pendhapa* rather than *pendopo*.

All translations, unless indicated, are my own. Emphases are in the original with ellipses in brackets to indicate omissions. In Indonesian, Javanese, and other source languages, there is no marked difference between singular and plural word forms, and in this book I follow the academic convention of not adding *s*’s to the end of words in these languages to indicate plurality, assuming the reader can make sense of this from context of use.

Artistic forms (*wayang wong*, *keroncong*) are in lower case and italicized, following the house style of *Asian Theatre Journal*, but on subsequent uses regularly appearing foreign genre names and terms appear in plain face.

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This book was researched and (mostly) drafted during a yearlong sabbatical from teaching and administrative duties in the Department of Drama and Theatre at Royal Holloway, University of London, in 2011–2012. I spent that year as a Research Fellow cloistered at the Netherlands Institute for Advanced Study in the Humanities and Social Science (NIAS) in leafy Wassenaar, a leisurely bike ride away from the world-class libraries, museums, and seminars of Leiden and the world-class dance theater and Indonesian cultural events of The Hague. I had worked earlier in Holland as a postdoctoral researcher attached to the Performing Arts of Asia: Tradition and Innovation project of the International Institute for Asian Studies, and so arrived aware of the sorts of sources on Indonesia—books, popular magazines, newspapers, academic journals, manuscripts, visual artifacts, and so on—I wished to explore in this gift of time. I felt extraordinarily privileged to be able to access materials with such ease during a period when many of the key Dutch organizations concerned with Indonesian arts and culture—the Museum Nusantara, Museum Maluku, the Netherlands Theatre Institute, Leiden University’s Department of Language and Cultures of Southeast Asia and Oceania, the Royal Tropical Institute, and others—were undergoing funding cuts, restructuring, merger, and closure. In the current moment of post-colonial amnesia, it seems urgent to highlight the deep resources in the Netherlands for the study of Indonesia’s past so that they might be properly managed in the future.

Huge thanks go to my Dutch and Netherlands-based colleagues and friends who supported my fellowship in various ways, including Els Bogaerts, Robert Wessing, Suryadi, Ben Arps, Clara Brakel, Yef Darwis, Karina Rinaldi-Doligez, Henk Schulte Nordholt, David Henley, Dafna Ruppin, Doris Jedamski, Marieke Bloembergen, Zweta Manggarai, Francine Brinkgreve, Hedi Hinzler, Joke Leijfeldt, Bart Barendregt, Juara Ginting, Beatriz van der Goes, Henk Mak van Dijk, Joss Wibisono, Susan Legêne, Sadijah Boonstra, Pim Westerkamp, and the staff of NIAS and the Koninklijk Instituut voor Taal-, Land- en Volkenkunde (KITLV). The intellectual and social camaraderie of my NIAS year group, particularly

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I have written elsewhere about how studying Indonesian arts is a lifetime avocation involving a mixture of participation, scholarship, and advocacy in an international moral community; it is a way of being that explodes the scientific container of "the project." In this vein, this book has been nourished by continuing communication with my interlocutors: Catherine Diamond, Mark Hobart, Michael Bodden, Cobina Gillitt, Helly Minarti, Dewanto Sukistono, Henri Chambert-Loir, John McGlynn, Paul Rae, Nano and Ratna Riantiarno, John Pawson, Gerard Mosterd, Chua Soo Pong, Jody Diamond, Alessandra Lopez y Royo, Indija Mahjoeddin, Agus Nur Amal, Margaret "Jiggs" Coldiron, Endo Suanda, Amanda Bear, Tim Behrend, Sumarsam, Ikranagara, Suprpto Suryodarmo, Sam Leiter, Simon Cook, Jan Mrázek, Sarah Weiss, Andrew Weintraub, Andy Channing, Tan Sooi Beng, Jonah Salz, Ledjar Subroto and Ananto Wicaksono, Barbara Hatley, Kathy Foley, Joko Susilo, Didik Nini Thowok, Miguel Escobar Varela, Kirstin Pauka, Made Sidia, Evan Winet, Wayan Sumitri, Anna Ingleby and Haviel Perdana, Lono Simatupang, Pudentia MPSS, Henry Spiller, Larry Reed, Lim How Ngean, Pete Smith, Adrian Vickers, Jon Keliehor, Laurie Ross, Jennifer Lindsay, Tinuk Yampolsky, Waryo Yo, J. Simon van der Walt, Tony Day, Jim Collins, Erik North, Purjadi, Opan Safari, Ghulam Sarwar-Yousof, Alexandra Green, the late Walter Angst, and others too numerous to mention. Students and colleagues at Royal Holloway, above all Helen Gilbert, have been critical sounding boards, and I am grateful to the Department of Drama and Theatre for allowing the sabbatical leave and other support needed to write this book. Naoko Shimazu gave a careful read of the chapters on the Japanese occupation. My good colleague Laura Noszlopy has provided important editorial support—sharpening arguments, suggesting cuts, polishing prose. The Asian Performing Arts Forum, which I convene with my colleagues Avanthi Meduri, Ashley Thorpe, and Shzr Ee Tan, has been a significant site for dialogue and debate both before my sabbatical and since. Final revisions on the manuscript were carried out as a Visiting Scholar at the University of Connecticut, and I would like to thank my UConn hosts, particularly Dan Weiner, Brid Grant, and John Bell, for their collegiality.

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University, Leiden University, the National University of Singapore, the University of Lisbon, and Yale University. The organizers of these opportunities merit thanks too.

Three women—my wife Jungmin Song, my daughter Hannah Cohen, and my mother Phyllis M. Gladstein—bring sustenance, perspective, and purpose to all my endeavors.

This book is dedicated to the memory of six Indonesian teachers and mentors: Pak Sutan Takdir Alisjahbana, Pak Oemartopo, Kang Basari, Mang Sujana “Jenggot,” Wa Saal, and Kang Abihudaya. *Gajah mati meninggalkan gading, hari-mau mati meninggalkan belang, manusia mati meninggalkan nama.*

INTRODUCTION

In 1995, I had been living and studying shadow puppetry in Gegesik, a rice-farming town on West Java's north coast, for about a year when a representative from the provincial office of the Department of Education and Culture paid an official visit. With its many shadow puppet companies, masked-dance performers, gamelan musicians, and glass painters, Gegesik is known locally as "the Artists' Warehouse" or "Cirebon's Ubud." It is an attractive field site both for me as a student of puppetry and for a government official hoping to disseminate information to local arts practitioners. The official in question had been sent by the Bandung office to deliver a prepared speech to the town's puppeteers regarding the challenges of *globalisasi* (globalization), with the explicit hope that they would insert government messages into their performances. He arrived decked out in a safari suit, *de rigueur* for New Order civil servants in the field.

The general theme of globalization and culture had been bandied about government departments for some time before this "upgrading" session in 1995. Two years earlier at a national arts congress, I had heard talks by the head of the Indonesian Chamber of Commerce and Industry and a former minister of forestry about the threats of new technologies and foreign cultural influences in the era of *globalisasi* and about the need to maintain traditional puppet theater as a moral compass.¹ In the midday heat of a village hall, the assembled puppeteers listened with waning patience and credulity to the Bandung official's presentation on the latest moral panic propping up the dictatorship. During the last year, satellite dishes had sprouted up around the town—"like mushrooms," it was said—and some of the puppeteers were probably thinking about the boxing match or soft porn flick they were missing. Partway through the canned speech, the official looked to me for assurance that *globalisasi* would indeed lead to the destruction of traditional values. I felt trapped in a position of extreme ethnographic irony. My presence among Gegesik's puppeteers, generously supported by a number of dissertation fieldwork grants, was proof of globalization's reach, while in a stroke, I was being hailed as a foreign researcher invested in traditional culture's survival in a preserved form. I was at a loss at how to respond.

Chicago sociologist Edward Shils once described tradition as a “consensus between living generations and generation of the dead” (Shils 1981, 168). But there appears to be little ground for consensus in the “constant battlefield” (cf. Hall 1981, 233) of artistic tradition in today’s Asia. Pitched on one side are tradition’s official guardians and experts who monumentalize heritage through the appointment of living national treasures and the standardization and codification of artistic genres. Here, authenticity is king, modernization is critiqued, and regional variety and individual variance are suppressed. This camp comprises an alliance between patrimonial arts bureaucrats and conservative traditionalists who serve what Shils calls “substantive traditionality,” involving “the appreciation of the accomplishments and wisdom of the past and of the institutions especially impregnated with tradition, as well as the desirability of regarding patterns inherited from the past as valid guides” (1981, 21). Tradition’s “moral character offers a measure of ontological security” in a runaway world (Beck, Giddens, and Lash 1994, 65).

Those on the other side of the battlefield eye tradition strategically as a set of resources and a reservoir of ideas available for local practitioners to resist the homogenizing effects of global capitalism. Traditional forms and practices are reconstructed as a means to raise consciousness and regenerate “personal and collective identity” by a pitched alliance of artists, curators, and activists (Beck, Giddens, and Lash 1994, 95). In this camp, practitioners disregard and charismatically break tradition’s ritual taboos and strictures to tap into the contemporary international art world’s “postproduction” praxes. This effort involves a “*détournement*” or “hijacking” of “pre-existing aesthetic elements,” continual recollection, reframing, appropriation, questioning, subverting, parodying, quoting, and reactivating “protocols of use for all existing modes of representation and all formal structures” (Bourriaud 2002, 18; 2009, 150).

Somewhere in between these camps are the traditional artists, like Gegesik’s puppeteers, who continue to perform in the same genres and styles of their forebears, but are quick to appropriate the latest fashions and trends—sometimes with stealth, at other times with open glee—to keep their practices relevant to contemporary audiences.

These conflicting takes on how tradition is to be conceived, represented, transmitted, replicated, appropriated, and disseminated in globalized Asia have roots in the encounters of local institutions and practices with European modernity that began in the nineteenth century and continued through the post–World War II period. This phase of late modernity, which sociologists Anthony Giddens, Ulrich Beck, and Scott Lash refer to as “reflexive modernity,” is “marked [. . .] by the twin processes of globalization and the excavation of most traditional con-

texts of action” (Beck, Giddens, and Lash 1994, 95). One can see both substantive tradition and reflexive modernity emerging in Asia in negotiations with European modernity. As Israeli sociologist S. N. Eisenstadt (2000, 15) argues, the introduction of modernity to Asian societies involved the incorporation of selected aspects of “Western universalistic elements of modernity in the construction of [...] new collective identities, without necessarily giving up specific components of [...] traditional identities.” Modernity brought about new modes for the social organization, invention, appreciation, and representation of old forms of performance. It pressed new functions on existing artistic practices, often under the guise of the “restoration of behavior” (cf. Schechner 1985, 35–116).

The *raison d'être* of the arts in premodern Asia was to buttress status, venerate ancestors, ward off evil, refine moral values, attract and procure sexual partners, forge alliances, and reinforce communal solidarity—as well as to entertain. Performance was predominantly what philosopher R. G. Collingwood (1938, 73) refers to as “magical art,” cultural practices “meant to arouse emotions not discharged there and then, in the experience that evokes them, but canalised into the activities of everyday life and modifying those activities in the interest of the social or political unit concerned.” Performances of magical art righted cosmological imbalances, bore fruit in social unions, and were “a kind of dynamo supplying the mechanism of practical life with the emotional current that drives it” (69).² Art in action had social purpose and public use (cf. Wolterstorff 1997). With colonialism and the spread of European cultural models, music, dance, and theater became abstracted from particular contexts of use. They were performing arts, separate from life, operating at a distance from pressing needs, available for contemplation and the expression of abstracted emotions and sometimes utopian desires.

“Performing arts” has not attracted theoretical scrutiny comparable to its affines and components: “performance,” “art,” “theater,” “drama,” “music,” and “dance.” I use “performing arts” here to demarcate a field of activity that is essentially aesthetic or entertaining rather than ritualistic or “magical” in orientation. In directing attention to more distant goals and aspirations, performing arts act in what Scottish-born anthropologist Victor Turner (1982, 83) refers to as the “subjunctive mode,” articulating “‘if it *were* so,’ not ‘it *is* so.’” With the advent of colonial modernity, the arts became a means to formulate identities in a world of cultural difference and to stage culture to the nations of the world. The reconfiguration of customary practices and rituals as performing arts opened a rift between what philosopher Gilbert Ryle calls “knowing how” and “knowing that.” This gap contributed to the “propositional acknowledgement of rules, reasons or principles” (Ryle 1945–1946, 9) that marks a reflexive turn in culture.³

Starting in the late nineteenth century, Asian performance traditions were reformed, systematized, and modernized. Academies such as the school of music under Baroda's maharaja (opened 1886), Beijing's Fuliancheng School (1904), and Phnom Penh's École des Arts Cambodgiens (1918) were established. Textbooks were written. Arts such as Indian temple dancing (renamed *bharatanatyam*) once restricted to hereditary schools or castes became genteel pastimes available for general consumption. This pan-Asian intertwined restoration and modernization of tradition happened side by side and in conjunction with the introduction of new artistic forms from Europe under colonial and "crypto-colonial" (Herzfeld 2002) conditions. Spoken drama, cabaret, opera, European classical music, ballet, and modern and interpretive dance all found adherents among Asian educated elites. Some of the more adventurous practitioners mixed imported forms with local cultural expressions, creating Ibsenian social dramas exploring topical issues of note, operas using ethnic instruments and vocal styles, interpretive dances with indigenous costume items and props, art songs based on folk melodies, and variety performances drawing on established comic routines. And then there were traveling outfits, such as Prof. Doorlay's Tropical Express Revue Company, which in the 1930s toured a 101-part program around Asia promising a round-the-world tour in song and dance featuring forty-five solo artists from Europe, South America, the United States, Iran, and China, as well as the twenty-strong chorus of the Doorlay Girls. With its impressionistic portrayals of Russia in 1917 on the eve of revolution, the "devil dancers" of Bali, and a South American cabaret, this program was touted by the *Times of India* as "snappy, peppy and vigorous and stimulating as the fizz in good champagne."⁴

Indonesia—and its complex mix of local cultures, languages, and religions; strong sense of national modernity; and cosmopolitan ethos—provides an important lens to examine the creative dialectic of tradition and modernity in the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, the penultimate stage of European colonialism in Asia. Indonesia is a heterogeneous space, a site of trajectories and intersections, with porous boundaries and multiple possibilities for belonging (Lombard [1990] 1996). Indonesia's first president, Sukarno, who plays several small roles in this book as a playwright in exile and a propaganda officer for the Japanese, called for Indonesia's "continuous revolution," a nonstop overturning of established norms that confronted the old with the new. In this Trotskyist vein I take Indonesia as a hope and aspiration to be performed into existence. Indonesia is "a problem, a proposition, a possibility, a position from which to occupy the world" (Strassler 2010, 5).

Indonesia was for most of this period a Dutch colony, and political historians typically prefer to refer to it before the United Nations recognized its independence in 1949 as *Nederlands-Indië*, the "Dutch Indies." But I favor the somewhat



Map of the East Indies, from Raymond Kennedy, *Islands and Peoples of the Indies* (Washington, DC: Smithsonian Institution, 1943). The names of Indonesian islands and cities changed after independence—Batavia became Jakarta, the Celebes became Sulawesi, Indonesian Borneo became Kalimantan, and so on. But Indonesia's postcolonial borders were nearly the same as in the Dutch Indies. This map, published in a time of geopolitical upheaval, also shows the islands of the Philippines, as well as contemporary Brunei, Singapore, and Malaysia, or what scholars generally refer to as peninsular and insular Southeast Asia.

anachronistic term “Indonesia,” not because I take the nation-state as the inevitable outcome of the period under examination, but because so much of the cultural activities described escaped the purview of the Dutch colonizers. As politician Sutan Sjahrir stated in 1937, “they never ever, not even one single moment, have thought about conscious cultural politics on behalf of the people of Indonesia” (quoted in Dolk 2012, 57). *Pace* the heated rhetoric of some 1990s American postcolonial scholars, “the Dutch” manifested little interest in monitoring or controlling artistic flows and formations, except when they stood to benefit economically from them or perceived cultural expressions as undermining colonial

authority. “Too much preoccupation with Eurocentrism or colonialism also disguises fundamental questions of contemporary modernity that cut across so-called cultural divides” (Dirlik 2007, 80).

The absence of “Dutch” in the title of the book also signals that it is concerned with a number of different colonial regimes—Dutch colonialism starting in the early nineteenth century, the Japanese occupation (1942–1945), and to a lesser extent the British interregnum (1811–1816). I pay particular attention to the Japanese colonial period because, in contrast to the Dutch who preceded them, the Japanese colonizers placed a high priority on the arts. The three-and-a-half-year period of occupation wrought innumerable artistic changes. Some innovations like the imported *kamishibai* scroll theater quickly faded after Japan’s defeat. Other developments, including the differentiation made between “Western” and “Asian” art, the yoking of art to propaganda, interarts collaborations, training and “upgrading” of performers, local and national bureaus for the arts, and cultural policies, were in Indonesia to stay. The acceleration of culture (cf. Urban 2001) under the Japanese happened at such a rate that the occupation cries out for focused attention, meriting its own section in this book.

The century and a half of artistic change investigated in this book occurred in conjunction and interaction with important changes in technology, economy, religion, demographics, social organization, politics, and education. We will see that interactions between the performing arts field and these social institutions and forces were complex and often unpredictable. Steamship routes shaped touring circuits for itinerant performers. Education distanced elites from indigenous culture, but also provided new modes and causes for its appreciation. Political affiliation gave new purpose to old forms of expressive culture, with the performing arts becoming a preferred medium for communicating “hidden transcripts” (cf. Scott 1990) under regimes of colonial censorship and surveillance. Changes in religious beliefs meant that ceremonial arts once restricted to particular sites or classes were stripped of their sacred auras and could entertain multiethnic audiences, be studied by foreigners, collected as domestic furnishings, and used to promote products and services. Audio recordings introduced exogenous musical repertoires and affected performance practices of existing traditions. Short dances were created or extracted from larger choreographies to entertain tourists or be performed at school pageants. Newspapers promoted artistic novelty and provided forums for debates on cultural value. Migrant artists fleeing war-torn Europe became music teachers and set up dance studios. Radio broadcasts created stars. We will see further how cash crops, migration from China and India, the multiethnic classrooms of the colonial capital Batavia, and colonial expropriation and privation interacted in diverse ways with the arts.

Modernity in these pages is neither an ideology nor teleology. Nor do I try to define it as a style or specify a modern period. Rather, modernity operates primarily as what cultural critic Fredric Jameson (2002, 41) calls a “narrative category,” a means for “the rewriting of moments of the past, which is to say of previously existing versions or narratives of the past.” I wish to unfurl stories of collective creativity in the modernization and hybridization of culture, the disembedding and remooring of venerable traditions, and the emergence of new art forms and modern attitudes to art. I survey the remains of the past for moments of cultural acceleration, skirting around the archipelago in search of the conjunctures of globalization (Dirlik 2007, 154) and structural reconfigurations that prompt the questioning of old aesthetic values and provide new possibilities for collective and individual expression. I observe how nineteenth- and twentieth-century practitioners sought actively to incorporate aspects of international modernity and reflected on their own cultural activities through embracing modern concepts and modes of analysis. Rather than viewing the performing arts as mirroring or expressing modern ideas already circulating in society, I take artistic practice as a primary mode for inventing and experiencing modernity. In this way, this book gives historical perspectives on issues that remain current in Indonesia today—including debates over proprietorship, cosmopolitan modernity and local tradition, exogenous versus endogenous changes in tradition (cf. Shils 1981), artistic freedom and regulation, civil decorum, enthusiasm for the new and despair for the old, and local culture and national belonging. “The problem is not simply to repeat the past, but rather to take root in it in order to ceaselessly invent” (Ricoeur 2006, 51).

Much of the creative invention of the period involved the hybridizing of old and new, foreign and local. Hybridity and the interweaving of culture (cf. Fischer-Lichte 2009) have arguably always been characteristic of Indonesian arts. A. L. Becker (1979, 232) analyzes *wayang kulit* (shadow puppet theater) as a kind of living archive of all registers and forms of language available to Javanese society, “a means for contextualizing the past in the present, and the present in the past.” Though its dominant repertoire may be derived Hindu epics imported from India in the first millennium, shadow puppetry is popularly believed to be the invention of the legendary Islamic proselytizer Sunan Kalijaga, and through the nineteenth century at least, most Javanese were convinced that the tales enacted by shadow puppeteers actually took place in Java’s distant past. Such apparent contradictions went generally unnoticed or at least unremarked on by exegetes. A puppet maker could add a canon or Dutch flag to a marching army (*rampogan*) figure or dress the gods in fashionable shoes with heels and pointed toes without reflexive deliberation of such anachronisms. Premodern *wayang* seemingly

existed in a state of what Jacqueline Lo (2000) has called “happy hybridity,” accreting layers of history and culture without tension or conflict. In contrast, during the nineteenth and twentieth century, as we shall see, hybridization became an intentional artistic strategy that modern-leaning practitioners used to gain public recognition and achieve artistic distinction. Traditionalists in turn constructed “ideological zones of cultural purity” (Renato Rosaldo in Canclini [1990] 1995, xv). They railed against hybridity to cope with the moral uncertainties of rapid societal change.

Academic histories of Indonesian arts obsessively trace what cultural historian Claire Holt (1967, 3) calls “strands of continuities” from the prehistoric period to the present, looking for signs of ancestor worship, communality, and natural symbols in even the most contemporary of expressions. The book title’s invocation of invention, in contrast, emphasizes the creation of new forms and processes, radical breakthroughs, discontinuities, ruptures, change. Thinking in terms of inventiveness gives agency, voice, and presence to practitioners and creative collectives (Strother 1999). The word “inventing” also intentionally echoes the trope of the invention of tradition (Hobsbawm 1983) and problematizes the construction “the performing arts” as a cross-cultural field. I am inspired particularly by the critical anthropology of Mark Hobart (2007), who posits that dance as an aesthetic practice did not exist in Bali before the arrival of European administrators, scholars, and tourists. Traditions of stylized movement could be discerned in precolonial ritual and dramatic spectacles, as well as in everyday grooming and farming activities, but dance was not a distinct form to be appreciated in its own terms. This book extends Hobart’s line of argument, figuring Indonesia’s entire performing arts complex as a modern invention produced through the encounter of local and extralocal forces (see also Mitchell 2000, 3f).

An initial impetus for this book was my experience of writing two monographs on itinerant Indonesian performance in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries (Cohen 2006, 2010). Following the movements of Auguste Mahieu and his *Komedi Stamboel* musical theater troupe around the archipelago between 1891 and 1903, as well as the various practitioners who popularized Indonesian art abroad in the first half of the twentieth century, I became aware that there was no benchmark history of Indonesian dance, drama, puppetry, or music before independence. I could refer readers to studies of Javanese folk performance (Pigeaud 1991), courtly dance (Lelyveld [1933] 1993), or Balinese dance and drama (de Zoete and Spies 1938) written during the brief flowering of performance scholarship in the late colonial period. I could also mine more recent historical genre studies on courtly *wayang wong* dance drama in Yogyakarta (Soedarsono 1984), court dances of Surakarta (Brakel-Papenhuyzen 1992a, 1995),

and central Javanese gamelan (Sumarsam 1995). But there were precious few attempts to synthesize this literature and other scholarly writings to consider how the larger field of performing arts mediated the changing social, political, and economic circumstances of colonial Indonesia. This book is intended to fill that lacuna, offering a synoptic overview and guiding the reader to relevant primary and secondary literature. Many of these sources are, of course, written in Dutch, the language of the colonizer and educated elites, but because facility in Dutch is increasingly less common among students of Indonesian culture I reference Indonesian and English translations, when available, over Dutch originals.

The paucity of historiographic sources means that out of necessity I rely substantially on the popular press, particularly newspapers and popular magazines, in the construction of my narrative. You can sometimes get a vital sense of a performance scene at a particular moment of time through its remainders in newspaper and magazine articles, letters to the editor, advertisements, and photographs. These sources are always fragmentary and incomplete, however, and shot through with biases that can be difficult to gauge. Their focus is inevitably on moments of controversy, novelty, and scandal: the everyday and the commonplace tend to be left unexamined. You encounter mediations that “remove social relations from the immediacy of context” (Giddens 1991, 28). The correlate is that there are assumptions of prior knowledge and cultural understandings that present-day readers may not share. It is possible to reconstruct through the newspapers the contours of a theater craze or the journey of a celebrated company, though it is easy to get lost on the way. Troupes bifurcate or dissolve, genre names are recycled or used in novel ways, performances are promised but fail to materialize. I have found that generally other sources—a puppet, mask, costume, or musical instrument in a museum collection; an ethnographic account or traveler’s report; a play or manuscript; a painting or postcard—are needed to substantiate and flesh out the popular press materials.⁵

Theoretically, this book is grounded in sociological and anthropological theories of tradition and modernity. I poach the writings particularly of Anthony Giddens, Zygmunt Bauman, S. N. Eisenstadt, Edward Shils, Néstor García Canclini, Raymond Williams, and Arif Dirlik. These theorists view tradition dynamically. Tradition involves an orientation to the past, but it also serves to organize the future (Beck, Giddens, and Lash 1994, 62). In tradition “past time is incorporated into present practices, such that the horizon of the future curves back to intersect with what went before. [. . .] Tradition [. . .] sustains trust in the continuity of past, present, and future, and connects such trust to routinized social practices” (105). Each element of tradition “is open to acceptance, modification, or rejection” (Shils 1981, 45). But it is sometimes necessary to step outside of tradition

because “tradition not only serves as a symbol of continuity, it delineates the legitimate limits of creativity and innovation and is the major criterion of their legitimacy” (Eisenstadt 1969, 454).

Earlier theorists considered tradition and modernity to be antithetical. According to literary critic Paul De Man, “modernity exists in the form of a desire to wipe out whatever came earlier in the hope of reaching at last a point that could be called a true present, a point of origin that marks a new departure” (1970, 388–389). The rise of Christian evangelicalism in the United States, Iran’s Islamic revolution, and other postsecular movements of the late twentieth century challenged this precept. The hallmarks of modernity—the idea that the world is “open to transformation by human intervention” (Giddens and Pierson 1998, 94); the industrialization of agriculture and the elimination of a traditional peasantry; the market economy; modern political institutions including the nation-state; and mass culture or the cultural industries—all might be Western in origin. But sociologists of modernity have observed these institutions and forces articulating in non-Western ways around the world. Modern technologies, goods, ideas, and modes of interaction interact in sometimes surprising ways with pre-extant formations of tradition. This has led to the formulation of pluralizing concepts such as “alternative modernities,” “multiple modernities,” “colonial modernity,” and “Asian modernity.”

Advocates of plural modernities generally admit that the “original Western project” of modernity “constituted the crucial (and usually ambivalent) reference point” (Eisenstadt 2000, 2), but argue that “not every nation-state can be fitted easily into a developmental sequence derived from Western experience of tradition-modernity-postmodernity” (Featherstone and Lash 1995, 3). Although some scholars have continued to see modernity as inherently Westernizing, it has been demonstrated that “in many countries modernization has been successfully undertaken under the aegis of traditional symbols and by traditional elites” (Eisenstadt 1973, 2). What is more, to be fully modern, in whatever cultural context, is to be antimodern, or at least to be aware of the corrosive effects of an ideology of “progress” and continual renewal on the environment, community, and individual psyche (Berman 2010, 14). Sociologists of culture have shown that modernity rebuilds selected traditions to protect against contingency, even as it dissolves others (Beck, Giddens, and Lash 1994, 56, 104).

In this book we see how in relation to the performing arts of Indonesia, with their ever-vital dynamics of invention and convention, ancient and modern, local and foreign, residual and emergent, “the abrupt opposition between the traditional and the modern does not work” (Canclini [1990] 1995, 2), perhaps more than in most countries.

Common Ground for Arts and Popular Entertainments

“Every night there are entertainments”

As editor and chief reporter of the Malay-language daily *Bintang barat* (Western Star), E. F. Wiggers had an agenda. Batavia, known in the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries to sailors and seagoing merchants as “the Queen of the East” for its sheltered harbor and trading-derived riches, had lost much of its luster and glory over the years. Economically Batavia could not hold a candle to the nearby entrepôt of Singapore, founded by the British in 1819 as a hub for Asian maritime trade. Batavia’s nightlife, however, was distinguished by its large variety of entertainment, and Wiggers was a connoisseur bent on promoting his city as a cultural capital.

Most people who enjoy amusements [*plezier*] are pleading earnestly so that it does not rain, as every night there are entertainments. [. . .] No city in Java is as lively as Batavia. [. . .] In the markets every night there are *to-peng* folk plays and in Chinatown in the old town of Batavia every night there are various Chinese performances such as Chinese opera or Chinese-style social dance. What is more, Chinese and Muslims endlessly hold weddings for their children, inevitably featuring performances. In addition, when a rich Chinese person (there are many in Batavia) celebrates a birthday he is sure to sponsor lively performances and set off fireworks. [. . .] In addition, at this time Muslims are observing the month of Maulud, the best month for weddings. [. . .] All races can come here to trade. That is why it has become so lively.

The [*schouwburg*] theater at Pasar Baru has performances almost every night, some days a magic show, others a drama or aerial entertainment. Mr. Smith is producing a magic show and has rented out the theater for 3 weeks for 9 shows. [. . .] The magic is amazing beyond amazing, with new acts at each performance. Very few Chinese or Muslims come to this entertainment, but there are many [European] gentlemen and ladies, who fill the theater to capacity. [. . .] The dog and monkey show has moved

from Gambir Field to Glodok Field. Only four performances are left. Whoever has not seen it to their heart's delight, should come soon, don't let it pass by.¹

In this city news opener in the 28 May 1872 edition of *Bintang barat*, as well as in numerous other editorials and articles, Wiggers expresses his conviction that the quality of life of Batavia can be judged by how “lively” or *rame* its nightlife is, and he invites his readers to participate in the full variety of its cultural offerings.

Wiggers writes as a seeker after *plezier*, a Dutch-derived word meaning “pleasure” or “amusement.” *Plezier* usually denoted a trip away from home and out into the world, but was not, at least for Wiggers, confined to commercial entertainments. Of course, Wiggers does not fail to note the presence in Batavia of English magician and pianist Robert Heller, though strangely the entertainer is not referred to directly, but rather his producer, a certain “Mr. Smith,” is mentioned in his stead. Heller was giving regular performances filled with “wonder, music, mystery, and humor” at the schouwburg, Batavia’s elite European theater.² He would be a headliner in any city in the world. Wiggers also notes the more down-market Gregory family circus entertaining spectators at public squares in Gambir and Glodok with its dog-and-monkey acts, equestrian numbers, acrobatics, comical songs, and clowning. Touring circuses, magic shows, and acrobatic outfits advertised heavily in the paper and were thus important sources of revenue. Maintaining a line of communication would also be important in enabling Wiggers to receive complimentary tickets.

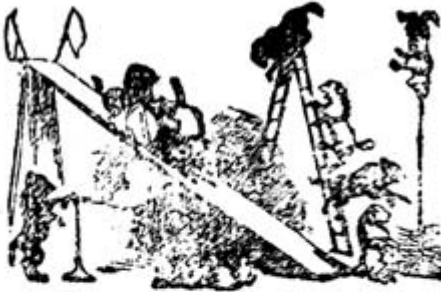
Sources of *plezier* were not limited to the obvious targets. Wiggers notes also *topeng*, a Malay-language folk drama accompanied by a small gamelan ensemble that performed outdoors in public spaces such as marketplaces (Spiller 1999). Nor does he neglect privately sponsored Chinese opera and a form of social dance generally known as *wayang cokek*, in which Chinese male patrons danced with Javanese female singer-dancers to the accompaniment of a hybrid Chinese-Sundanese musical ensemble (Phoa 1949; Kartomi 2000, 291–293; Yampolsky 2013, 354–359). Even without an invitation, “incidental” spectators (cf. Schechner 1985, 303), gathered on the streets, could attend these performances. Wiggers notes as well street processions associated with Chinese and Islamic ritual events, such as weddings, and fireworks for birthday parties.

Wiggers takes *plezier* not in any *one* of these entertainments, but rather in the *extent* and *variety* of his polyglot city’s mix of homegrown multiculturalism and imported novelties. He does not ignore the privileges and exclusions of colonial society, noting for example the small number of non-Europeans attending the

Dengan permissi dari toean Resident.

Komedi

Koeda, monjet dan Andjing,



ini malem
maoe main di **Tanah Lapang**
Glodok,

dengan dia maoe main njang matjem baroe-baroe
njang orang blon taoe liat. Siapa toean-toean
dan sobat-sobat soeka maoe nonton bole dateng
liat.

Dia poenja tempat tiada bole bertjampoer.
Orang-orang laki-laki ada poenja lain tempat
dan orang prampoean ada poenja lain tempat.

Tempat no. 1 bajar	. . . /	3.—
" " 2 "	. . . "	2.—
" " 3 "	. . . "	1.—
Orang prampoean	. . . "	1.—

Anak ketjil bajar separo harga.

Ini komedi tjoema main 7 kali sadja. Saban
hari dia main. (76)

Advertisement for the
Gregory family circus, with
horse, monkey, and dog acts,
playing at Glodok. The
advertisement promotes
separate seating for women
and men. *Bintang barat*,
24 May 1872, 1.

schouwburg and the economic preeminence of Batavia's Chinese. As a Eurasian or "Indo" of mixed European and Indonesian descent, Wiggers would have been referred to on the streets as a *sinyo* (from the Portuguese *senhor*) and have experienced daily affronts because of his skin color and the slant of his eyes, reminders of the systemic prejudices and biases of Dutch colonialism. But his understanding of inequality does not make him averse to imbibing the cultural performances associated with opposing ethnic groups. Quite the contrary. Wiggers sees his city's vitality as a reflex of an "urban swirl" (Hannerz 1993, 173–216) made up of Batavia's signature mix of ethnic groups, populations that are not to be sealed off from each other but open to mutual observation and enjoyment. Wiggers displays elements of the exote delighting in the world of difference around him (Segalen [1995] 2002); the *flâneur* of Walter Benjamin (1983, 9), who walks the city "to set up house in the middle of the multitude, amid the ebb and flow of movement, in the midst of the fugitive and the infinite"; and the "omnivorous" modern consumer of culture described by Zygmunt Bauman (2011).

Writing in Malay, the lingua franca and trade language of Batavia and other archipelagic entrepôts destined to become Indonesia's national tongue, Wiggers offers his readers en passant guidelines on how to describe, experience, and fashion cultural scenes far beyond his hometown of Batavia. He provokes interest in measuring the diversity of entertainment and initiates readers into an evolving "metacultural" (Urban 2001) vocabulary—*penontonan* (spectacle), *keramean* (liveliness), *pemainan* (performance)—for conceiving ritual, artistic performances, and popular entertainments as a single field. Constituent elements of this cultural field might be old or new, sacred or profane, endogenous or exogenous—all were equally available as sources of *plezier*. Wiggers implicitly enjoins readers not to let politics stand in the way of their benefiting from exchange and coexistence with people from contrasting backgrounds (cf. Bauman 2011, 59).

Wiggers is a witness to and agent of an important moment in interculturalism in Southeast Asia, a transnational urban modernity that rearticulates archipelagic cultures with international cultural flows. I stress that this is a rearticulation under the sign of the modern, because the performance cultures of the Indonesian archipelago were linked to each other and the larger world via sea channels long before Dutch and other European colonizers and traders arrived in the region. This earlier linkage is evidenced by the distribution of ancient *dong song* bronze kettle drums from Vietnam as far east as Papua; gongs from Java exported by Buginese traders to Sumatra, Sulawesi, Borneo, and other Indonesian islands (Valentijn 1724, 71; Abell 1887; Skog 1993, 122); a seventeenth-century historical chronicle from south Borneo that describes a Banjarese prince training in wayang kulit shadow puppetry and topeng mask theater in Java (Robson 1992, 37); and a Dutch

oil painting from circa 1662 showing a pair of plumed dancers from the Maluku islands performing *cakalele*—a martial dance from eastern Indonesia—in a Batavia market (Scalliet 1999, 27, 29). Kings and sultans imported exotic performers to mark their status, and itinerant entertainers toured far afield in search of new audiences. Interrelated archipelagic traditions of ceremonial and social dance, poetic dueling, masquerade, bardic storytelling, puppetry, and musically triggered trancing testify to centuries of artistic interactions between and among Indonesian peoples.

Performance in premodern Indonesia offered glimpses into alien cultures. A seventeenth-century Dutch visitor to the Mataram court in central Java noted the presence of slave dancers from “Babylon” who played castanets as they danced and sang (Kunst 1973, 1:117–118). Dancers in Flores in the 1880s wore grotesque palm-leaf masks and top hats to caricature Europeans (Jacobsen cited in Kunst 1942, 28). *Gambuh*, the preeminent dramatic form of Bali’s royal courts before the twentieth century, enacted stories about the legendary Javanese prince Panji and his travels around the archipelago. Performances asserted the descent of Bali’s nobility from the powerful east Javanese kingdom of Majapahit to demonstrate the worldliness of Balinese elites (Vickers 2005). Conquistador helmets and swords and shields preserved from the sixteenth-century colonial encounters with the Portuguese were incorporated into the *cakalele* dances of Sulawesi and the Maluku Islands. The oldest surviving *hudog* masks of East Kalimantan, used by Dayak to scare away malevolent spirits, are constructed of nonindigenous materials: scraps of metal, glass, exotic coins. Edmund Scott, who worked as a factor in the English trading post in early seventeenth-century Banten, observed puppet plays by the western Javanese port city’s Indian inhabitants, Chinese opera, and Chinese-style lion dancing of the sort called *barongsai* in contemporary Indonesia (Scott 1606).

As previously noted, communities, families, and ruling elites in premodern societies sponsored performances to entertain and amuse, display status, commune with ancestors, heal the sick, appease spirits, establish boundaries, indoctrinate the masses, and spark social and sexual interactions. Tradition is an orientation to the past that they tapped to organize future performances: “Past time is incorporated into present practices, such that the horizon of the future curves back to intersect with what went before” (Giddens 1991, 105). Colonialism introduced new ways of thinking about performance. The Dutch had maintained a permanent presence as traders in the eastern archipelago since the occupation of the eastern Indonesian island of Ambon in 1602 and in the western archipelago from the founding of the colonial city of Batavia on the north coast of western Java in 1619. But until the dissolution of the Dutch East India Company

(Vereenigde Oost-Indische Compagnie, or VOC) on 1 January 1800, Dutch mercantile activity had taken place under the auspices of this chartered company. And it was only circa 1850 that the Dutch aimed to consolidate their rule over all the territories of the archipelago. The nineteenth century was the height of Dutch imperialism. The Dutch not only stamped out independent trading outfits, such as the Chinese-controlled mining colonies of Borneo, but also, one by one, they killed, deposed, or transformed the hereditary kings and lords of the islands into “bureaucratic elites” (Sutherland 1979) collecting taxes for the colonial state. Indigenous rulers maintained a vestige of traditional authority under an imperial onslaught only by turning to tradition as both a “historic referent” (Canclini 1995, 202) and a “symbol of continuity” (Eisenstadt 1969, 454). Nobles-turned-civil servants busied themselves with accommodating customary practices to a new “set of historical connections and disconnections” (Clifford 2003, 45). The arts under colonialism became emblems of ethnic identity.

The new modes of communication and transportation—a postal service, steamships, telegraphs and telephones, railways, and newspapers—were institutions of colonial modernity created to serve the interests of global capitalism. But they also transported and translated artistic forms and their enactors and abetted the “metaculture of modernity” (Urban 2001). The formal abolition of slavery in 1860 and the abolishment in 1870 of the Cultivation System, which had required Javanese and Sumatran peasants to cultivate cash crops in lieu of taxes and thus tied them to their places of employment, increased freedom of movement. The opening of the Suez Canal in 1869 and improvements in steamship technology around the same time made shipping goods and people from Europe to Southeast Asia faster and cheaper. Itinerant showmen brought new entertainment forms from Europe: gas balloons, carousels, ring toss games, waxwork galleries, magic lantern entertainments, marionette shows, and panoramas. The itinerant acrobatic troupes from Japan and Parsi theater companies from India that toured Southeast Asia starting in the 1860s and 1870s inspired local entrepreneurs to bankroll similar companies. Social and cultural events and relations at a distance became interlaced with local contextualities (Robertson 1995, 26–27).

Although Calvinist ethical concerns occasionally erupted, leading to censorship and bans, colonial administrators generally permitted “festive expenditures that go against the logic of capitalist accumulation” (Canclini 1995, 198). Articles, stories, poems, letters, images, and advertisements in newspapers situated the latest novelties in relation to familiar cultural forms and practices, and they stoked anticipation of the arrival of traveling entertainments. Print capitalism (B. Anderson [1983] 1991) created solidarity among the far-flung newspaper readers of the archipelago. As sociologist Edward Shils (1981, 267) notes, “It is extremely

difficult for an individual to know who shares the traditions in which he lives.” Newspaper reports stimulated awareness of shared cultural pasts and heralded shared enjoyment of incipient, modern entertainments. The different cultural streams in Java and other islands, once easily trifurcated into “native,” “Chinese,” and “European,” became increasingly muddled and muddied. Dedicated playhouses were constructed, and anyone who could afford the price of a ticket had access to arts once restricted to particular ethnic groups. A “metropolitan super-culture” (H. Geertz 1963) was emerging during the nineteenth century that was to contain the seeds for what became known as “Indonesian culture” in the twentieth.

Culture in Common

Intersecting European, Javanese, and Chinese Art Worlds

Isaac Israël's famous painting *Transport of Colonial Soldiers* (1883), which hangs among the van Goghs and Modriaans of the Kröller-Müller Museum in the Netherlands, pictures somber recruits, fronted by fife and drum, standing on damp cobblestones beneath the cloudy skies of Rotterdam. En route to the bloodbaths of the Aceh War, the vacant-eyed, mustachioed drummer and the dreamy fifer depicted by Israël dramatize the grim, imperialistic functionality of European military music—a barrage of sound to stupefy enemies and to marshal patriotism and courage—as the soldiers depart from Europe to Southeast Asia. Ironically, the musicians are two paces out of synch with the rest of their company, who are distracted by pushcart peddlers and hawkers, the cold that turns noses red, the bags that weigh them down, a wife pulling at an arm. The music's efficacy is in doubt.

In colonizing the Indies, Europeans introduced many more performance forms, practices, and instruments—brass bands, balls and tea dances, chamber music, proscenium theaters, posters and programs, theatrical lighting—that were only indirectly predicated on imperialism. Much European performing art did not address the native masses, but was intended to promote a sense of European identity in the tropics among Europeans. Enacting theater, playing music, attending concerts, and participating in social dances dispelled boredom, demonstrated civility, and allowed colonizers to feel in touch with European cultural trends. Importantly, cultivation of “civilized” arts permitted “true” or “pure-blooded” (*totok*) Europeans to distinguish themselves from the mestizo populace of so-called Indos (cf. Mitchell 2000, 4). Artistic events were rarely completely closed to non-Europeans, and indeed the majority of European performances involved their active participation, though the musicians of house bands at European clubs, distributors of handbills, and backstage technicians leave few traces in the historical record.

The proximity and the prestige accorded to all things European resulted in aspects of European arts being selectively hybridized with long-standing Indonesian traditions. There were not many Europeans living in the Dutch Indies;



Transport of Colonial Soldiers
(1883) by Isaac Israël (above)
and detail (left). Collection
Kröller-Müller Museum,
Otterlo, The Netherlands.

they never were more than 0.5 percent of the total population and were cloistered mostly in administrative and commercial centers and military barracks. As in many colonies, however, European culture wielded disproportionate influence, and not only among educated elites. During the course of the nineteenth century, Javanese and Chinese arts, developing in interaction with the consumption of European arts, underwent significant modifications in the ways they were staged and appreciated. Late colonial Indonesia was a paradigmatically plural society, defined by British colonial historian J. S. Furnivall as possessing only “one place

in which the various sections of a plural society meet on common ground—the market place” ([1939] 1967, 449). But, as we see, the performing arts also offered a meeting ground and site for exchange and for conflict as well, flying in the face of the Manichean compartmentalizations of colonialism. Each of the major ethnic groups of Indonesia had its own partitioned “art worlds” (H. Becker 1982), mobilizing resources according to specific principles and norms. Contravening colonial fears of miscegenation, performance was a “common ground” in which practitioners simultaneously sought and found meaning in the cultural expressions of ethnic Others. Performers borrowed resources and shared approaches, adjusted practices, and retuned performance instruments in a “collective structure” (Beck, Giddens, and Lash 1994, 114). An art form might have originated with a particular community and be patronized by the elect—Javanese princes, European military and business elites, and Chinese merchants. But these so-called ethnic arts were “continuously remade and redefined by [. . .] collective practice” (Eagleton 2000, 119) and thus also constitute what Raymond Williams ([1989] 2007, 193) calls “culture in common.”

Military Music, Missionary Music, and European Theater: The Localization of European Art

Military music was played not only on battlefields but was also thoroughly integrated into everyday life, making civil occasions and public celebrations in colonial Indonesia joyous events. A military band gave weekly concerts on Sunday afternoons in Batavia’s Koningsplein square for much of the nineteenth century, and these concerts were often described in the travel literature. They were a major social gathering for Europeans who watched in all their finery on horseback and in carriages and then dispersed with the setting sun. The staff band of Batavia’s military club Concordia also gave weekly open-air concerts. English journalist and travel writer William Basil Worsfold (1893, 213–214), who attended one of these pleasant evenings in the early 1890s, records the shelter of banyan trees, affable club members seated around small iron tables, and a diverse program of light classical music by composers such as van Suppé, Strauss, Mozart, and C. Ph. E. Bach. Concerts of this sort could be enjoyed in the clubs and public squares of most major towns and cities. Civil militias (*schutterij*) in cities such as Semarang and Surabaya also had their bands that played at parades and gave outdoor concerts of so-called *schutterijmuziek*. Most militia band musicians were young Eurasian men.

Military music was adopted and adapted by Indonesian rulers who wanted to tap its power. The guard of honor of the sultanate of Banten played European



Picture postcard showing a military band playing in the gazebo of Stationspark Buitenzorg (contemporary Taman Ria Ade Irma Suryani, Bogor). Image courtesy of Olivier Johannes Raap.

drums and European trumpets; drums and fifes mixed with Javanese *bendhe* (hand gongs) in processions in central Java's Kartasura court (Sumarsam 1995, 69–70). Corps of drummers and bamboo aerophones on far-flung islands such as Buton and Kabaena (off the Sulawesi coast) are remainders and reminders of the reach of musical imperialism (M. Brenner 2014).

By the nineteenth century, European music had a prominent place in the ritual and artistic economy of Javanese courtly society. European ensembles displaced specialized gamelan ensembles that used to accompany different functions. Bespoke sets of musical instruments such as *gamelan kodhok ngorek*, which in the past had accompanied processions and feasts (cf. Kumar 1997, 138f), ceased to be manufactured. Instead the major courts had their own military bands (*musik prajurit* or *bataliyun musik*) to play background music for formal receptions and greet visitors with “God Save the King” or “Wilhelmus.” Drum and trumpet corps (*musikan salompret tambur*) played at military drills, displays, and processions. The playing of gamelan, combined with cornet and snare drum in *gendhing mares*—marches for gamelan. These pieces accompanied the entrance and exit of dancers in the Yogyakarta royal court's sacred *bedhaya* and heightened the power

of this ritual dance form (Sumarsam 2014). Musicians were Javanese and enjoyed the status of *abdi dalem* (court servants), but played under the baton of a European conductor or *kapellmeister* (cf. Wongsaleksana 1936, 50).

At gala celebrations, bands also accompanied formal toasts or *kondhisi*—a Javanese term borrowed from the Dutch *conditie*, meaning terms or conditions—emphasizing the solemnity of vows of friendship, pledges of peace, and wishes for happiness exchanged by guests and hosts. In the royal courts, there were complex rules governing the music accompanying such *kondhisi*. *Serat Srikarongron*, a protocol guide written in Surakarta during the reign of Paku Buwono X (r. 1893–1939), provides details. In it, we read about Garebeg Besar, a court celebration of Eid al-Adha, an Islamic holiday commemorating the willingness of Abraham to sacrifice his beloved son Ishmael. The first toast of this court celebration is to be offered by the Resident, who asks the king and assembled guests to raise their glasses, giving the Malay-language salutation *Slamet Garebeg Besar* (Happy Big Garebeg). As the Resident, kings, and guests drain their glasses, the band strikes up the anthem “Wien Neêrlands bloed” (Those in whom Dutch blood), and simultaneously the gamelan plays the ceremonial piece “Kodhok Ngorek” as a cannon is fired nine times (Rustopo 2007, 185–186).

Status-conscious Europeans of the Indies, unlike most Dutch in the home country, were lovers of such ceremonies as well as of sumptuous balls and tea dances. Although few non-Europeans partook in European-style social dancing until the twentieth century, dances were enjoyed from afar as “spectacle” (*ton-tonan*), and social dance featured as a component of lavish Chinese weddings and important celebrations in princely houses for the enjoyment of European guests. Typically waltzes, polkas, and mazurkas were accompanied by a small dance orchestra or “string band” (*strijkje* or *strijkorkest*). As with the military bands, musicians were often of indigenous origin. Until the nineteenth century, wealthy Europeans even kept slaves who played European musical instruments. One of the earliest mentions of musician slaves is in a 1689 letter written by a Dutch woman living in Batavia, who describes slaves playing bass, violin, and harp during meals (Schotel 1867, 309). Later sources describe entire slave orchestras (*slaven-orkesten*) that performed at opulent balls.¹

By the end of the nineteenth century, some of the freed slaves or their artistic descendants had formed bands to be hired on special occasions. Newspapers from central Java report on a group named Moesik Kasim, a seven-piece musical ensemble made up of clarinet, trombone, French horn, cornet-a-piston, bass drum, *preng preng* (snare drum?), and triangle, which played at balls and formal occasions in the 1880s.² In western Java, some of the freed slaves seem to have teamed up with gamelan musicians, generating a hybrid musical form now known as *tanji-*

dor that combines the repertoire and instruments of Sundanese gamelan with those of the European brass band (Lohanda 1982).³

Hybrid ensembles that played indigenized European musical instruments sprang up around the archipelago. On the west coast of northern Sumatra, for example, the *kapri* ensemble, composed of a singer, violin, and one or two frame drums, was formed to accompany dances at weddings and after-birth rituals. The locally manufactured violins and structural aspects of the music suggest Portuguese origins (Kartomi 1987). Indonesia's most famous hybrid genre is *kroncong*, associated historically with Tugu, a small Christian village on the eastern outskirts of Batavia founded by freed slaves (*mardijkers*) and once owned by the Portuguese. This village specialized in processed forest products such as *den-deng babi*—feral pig jerky—and produced guitars of various sizes carved from foraged *kenanga* wood (Korr. Kita 1956). Though the original “Portuguese” inhabitants intermarried with other Christians, the residents of Tugu maintained a distinct musical idiom, including songs of Portuguese origin, through the twentieth century. The small Tugu-made guitar, a lute-like instrument known as a *kroncong*, was purchased by poor Indos of urban Batavia to serenade lovers and busk on the streets for money. The Tugu instrument provided the name *kroncong* for the musical genre, and street musicians in nineteenth-century Batavia were tagged *buaya kroncong* (*kroncong* crocodiles), the word “crocodile” also being used to describe street toughs and petty criminals more generally. *Buaya kroncong* were known for their silver tongues and musical stunts, such as playing guitars behind their backs and fiddles on their heads.⁴ Although the handcrafting of musical instruments halted in Tugu early in the twentieth century due to a shortage of wood and the availability of cheaper, factory-made alternatives, *kroncong* music spread to other parts of Java and the archipelago starting in the 1890s, as discussed later (Yampolsky 2010, 2013).

European music also was introduced to indigenous populations via church choirs (Arps 2000a) and mission schools. A prominent figure in the dissemination of European music was the Dutch missionary Joseph Kam, posthumous recipient of the sobriquet “Maluku’s Apostle” (Rasul Maluku). Kam arrived in Batavia in 1814 and was stationed on the eastern Indonesian island of Ambon from 1815 until his death in 1833 (Enklaar 1963; Nivens 2011). An avid amateur musician who played the flute and organ, Reverend Kam studied at the *Nederlandsch Zendeling Genootschap* (Netherlands Missionary Society, or NZG) and the London Missionary Society. He arrived in Ambon when the glory days of the spice trade were a distant memory and the Maluccan islands were a neglected colonial backwater with dilapidated churches and many Christians awaiting baptism. Kam was charged with overhauling Maluku’s seventy-three derelict

Christian schools. With few books or competent teachers, students struggled to comprehend the high Malay language of the translated Bible. It was perhaps for this reason that Kam stressed music in the curriculum of the state-subsidized schools and the teacher-training institute he opened in 1819. Kam had attended prayer meetings of the Moravian Brethren in the town of Zeist as a child, and the Moravian use of harmonized singing in church services gave him a model for spreading the gospel (Nivens 2011). He procured a piano from the London Missionary Society in 1819, and the NZG supplied a church organ two years later (Enklaar 1963, 123). Music in Kam's schools became highly regimented. Students in the lower forms sang harmonized hymns, some written by Kam himself. In the higher forms, pupils received instruction in flute to accompany hymns and devotional songs (Kroeskamp 1974, 63). It was not long before children's choirs and ten-flute orchestras were performing at religious functions and greeting important guests, including the governor general during his 1824 tour of Maluku (Roorda van Eysinga 1831; Olivier 1834).

School inspection reports from 1866–1867 reveal the extent of Kam's musical footprint in Maluku. These documents describe pupils relying on musical notation to swiftly learn songs, "assisted by a natural feeling for keeping time and melody. [. . .] The crude and shrill voices of the newly arrived pupils first had to be cultivated somewhat, but then they quickly sang their part in the choir" (Kroeskamp 1974, 88). There still was an absence of books, which meant that teachers had to write music on classroom walls to be copied by hand by students. Kam's success in music education inspired the adoption of singing and flute playing in Christian schools in other parts of the archipelago, including the Minahasa region of northern Sulawesi (136). The six-holed bamboo transverse flute developed by Kam thereby became a standard instrument around eastern Indonesia (cf. Kunst 1994, 183). Harmonized singing and the European instruments studied at schools crossed over to the performance of *pantun*, a pan-Malay vocal art used to entertain, express emotions, and court lovers. Kam's effectiveness as a missionary has been questioned, but his musical legacy endures in the tradition of harmonized folk songs, or *lagu Ambon*, sung today around Indonesia, as well as in the Malucan diaspora of the Netherlands.

The same year in which Kam reached the Indies saw the founding in Batavia of the Bachelor's Theatre, known also as the Military Theatre, the first purpose-built European theater in the Indies. The year 1814 was the middle of the interregnum, a five-year period in the wake of the Napoleonic Wars when Java and adjacent islands were under British governance. Sir Thomas Stamford Raffles, lieutenant governor of Java during the interregnum, was a social reformer committed to Enlighten-



Flute orchestra processing on Queen's Day in Ambon, c. 1925. Photograph from Collections KITLV Digital Image Library, 51920.

ment ideals. He and his wife Sophia railed against the “degraded” mestizo culture of urban Java—which they associated with the moral evils of Dutch colonialism—and introduced European social niceties, including the arts, to polite society (J. Taylor 1984). Thus military officers established a private theater, funded by subscription and located south of Batavia’s old town in leafy Weltevreden (present-day central Jakarta).⁵ Although actors were drawn from the English military personnel, the Bachelor’s Theatre appears not to have been strictly an elite institution, “since tickets could be paid for in kind, with candles, bacon, butter, soap and the like” (Bosma and Raben 2008, 92). Dutch-language synopses were provided for those unable to follow the English dialogue.

The Bachelor’s Theatre has been described as “an unassuming, temporary building, made of bamboo” seating about 250 (de Haan 1935, 1:600; Kurianingrat 1958, 6). But it was a dedicated theater space, and thus it differed categorically both from earlier European artistic initiatives, such as the so-called *Bataviaschen Schouwburg*, an amateur theater that mounted Dutch-language plays in a Batavia hotel between 1757 and 1770 and from the traditional Indonesian practice of

staging performances in marketplaces, communal spaces, and temporary stages erected near places of work or worship or the compounds of sponsors. The Bachelor's Theatre can be viewed as the modest beginning in Indonesian culture of what sociologists of modernity describe as Fordism (after American industrialist Henry Ford), modernity in its "‘heavy’, ‘bulky’, ‘immobile’ and ‘rooted’, ‘solid’ phase" (Bauman 2000, 57). Earlier "European" performances were permeable to Indonesian eyes and often involved Indonesian performers such as musicians in the "slave orchestras." In contrast, the Bachelor's Theatre led directly to an active theater and opera scene in nineteenth-century urban Indonesia that was exclusively European, establishing and maintaining "boundaries of rule" between European elites and the indigenous population and mixed-race Indos (cf. Stoler 1989). The European identity of this arts scene was reinforced by sartorial regulations: shoes and stockings were required of spectators at the Bachelor's Theatre (Bosma and Raben 2008, 92).

Although performances of English-language drama were rare after the British withdrew from Java in 1816, the interregnum's thespian enthusiasm transferred to a desire for making and seeing theater and opera in Dutch, French, and Italian. A schouwburg or European-style municipal theater with a proscenium stage, wing-and-drop scenery, and focused lighting, was constructed in each of the three principal cities of Java—Batavia (1821), Semarang (1835), and Surabaya (1854)—and subsequently in other cities of the archipelago. Brick-and-mortar municipal theaters received little public subsidy and so were dependent on income from ticket sales and the occasional lottery. Numerous Italian, French, and English opera and operetta companies tread their boards in the nineteenth century, as did acrobats and magicians; illustrated lectures, and demonstrations of the latest scientific wonders were also presented there. Touring troupes frequently appeared in succession in each of the three theaters, generally traveling by steamship before a continuous railroad from Batavia to Surabaya opened in 1894. Thus an embryonic touring circuit was established by the 1840s. Local amateur societies, such as the *Spectacle-Français sous la Direction de Messieurs les Amateurs du Théâtre Hollandois*, established in Batavia in 1837 by the *directeur* F. Minard, also offered spirited renditions of opera or melodrama on schouwburg stages (Diehl 1990, 345–361).

Amateurs clubs, such as *Tot Nut en Genoegen* (For benefit and pleasure), founded in Makassar in 1867, sometimes staged Dutch-language dramatics at military barracks or on the pocket stages of European clubs. Typical nineteenth-century fare was light comedy, farce, and musical revues, sometimes written for the occasion by local amateur playwrights. Plays oozed *gezelligheid*, Dutch-style

cozy intimacy.⁶ In local theater scenes, the occasional “serious” European playwright who sojourned to the Indies, such as feminist activist Mina Kruseman or cultural critic Conrad Busken Huet (see Praamstra 1986, 2003), tended to be overshadowed by charismatic socialites such as the enthusiastic “Mother” C. G. van den Steen, who headed Surabaya’s amateur dramatic society and successfully campaigned for the electrification of Surabaya’s schouwburg in 1883 (von Faber 1931). Theater was generally appreciated more as a social than an aesthetic experience. Europeans living on plantations and in small towns traveled to cities to partake of “opera seasons” presented by visiting companies from Europe. Some women, rather than endure the sultry heat of the schouwburg, “attended” theater by waiting outside in their carriages; alcohol from the schouwburg café made theater bearable for their spouses.

Constructing a hermetic fictional world in drama offered nineteenth-century Europeans a reprieve from the daily headaches of managing a colony, the oppressive climate, and the animosity of “the natives,” and it functioned as an artful reminder of the shared value of social graces. Europeans invested in the theaters’ physical infrastructure, but Dutch-language plays written in the Indies during the nineteenth century were generally ephemeral vehicles for amateur actors of little literary interest. Plays were the disposable trappings of social life and, like the furniture and household goods that were routinely auctioned when Europeans moved house, were rarely published or kept as mementos, though local journalists sometimes celebrated the productions in puff pieces. In contrast with the early and pervasive impact of European music, it is hard to detect influences of European theater on the performance practices of the archipelago’s other ethnicities until the century’s end.

A Javanese “Renaissance”

Around the archipelago, hereditary rulers and their courtiers were not only busy with adopting and adapting features of European modernity. They also were scrutinizing their own performance inheritances through modern lenses and reworking traditions in sometimes quite radical ways. The royal courts were prominent patrons of performing arts and claimed some performance forms as exclusive possessions. Courtly pageants in what Clifford Geertz (1980) famously described as “the theater state” dramatized the divine status of monarchs and displayed their abilities to mobilize performers and impress their subjects. Under colonialism, the reach and authority of rulers changed forever. Some precolonial polities were destroyed, whereas colonial administrators “bundled” others into

“regional-level entities. They [. . .] attempted to prescribe very precisely how the powers of such princes related to those of their neighbors and to the [colonial] authorities above them” (Bayly 2004, 478). Certain courtly arts that had served to buttress authority declined quickly under colonialism. Under colonial rule, for example, Bali’s financially and politically weakened courts could no longer mount such lavish spectacles as *gambuh* dance drama (Vickers 2005). In contrast, the *kraton* (royal courts) and princely houses of nineteenth-century Java supported what has been described as an artistic renaissance (Florida 1995, 26–30; Sumarsam 1995, 51, 57).

A resurgence or even wholesale “invention” of tradition is a common response to the vicissitudes of modernity. Traditions have claims on ritual truth; “they provide continuity and contribute to political legitimacy” (Giddens and Pierson 1998, 132). Java’s rulers turned to the arts to demonstrate their spiritual refinement and cultural superiority, perhaps in an effort to disguise (from themselves or others) their political subjugation. Jousting and blood sports, such as the gory fights between buffalos and tigers, declined in popularity during the nineteenth century (Wessing 1992).⁷ In their place there was a “Byzantine florescence” (Rouffaer quoted in Day 1981, 8) of performing arts in the royal houses, in which received traditions of gamelan music, *tembang* (sung poetry), courtly dance, dance drama, and wayang kulit shadow puppetry were elaborated and refined, and new art forms forged. Java’s “rulers, despite their insistence on the traditional legitimacy of their authority, were constantly being forced to depart from tradition” (Shils 1981, 28).

FEMALE COURT DANCES

Royal patronage developed traditional artistic practices to the pinnacle of aesthetic accomplishment, in the process downplaying the premodern function of art as a means to commune with ancestors and gain protection from ancestors. Elites instead cultivated what the American scholar of Javanese literature Nancy Florida calls the “cult of the *adiluhung*,” meaning “beautiful sublime” (Florida 1995, 32–41). Faced with declining political power, Javanese and other ethnic elites focused on esoteric values. They aspired to be *alus* (refined) in manner and appearance. By the end of the nineteenth century, the arts had solidified into a defined repertoire, which Clifford Geertz (1960, 261), in a classic study of Javanese culture and belief, dubbed “the ‘*alus* art’ complex.” In Geertz’s account, this complex included puppet theater, gamelan music, mythology, courtly dances and dance-drama, *tembang*, and *batik* textiles. Cultivation of these *alus* arts showed taste, distinction, and moral character.

Although many core features of the *alus* arts were arguably fixed before the nineteenth century, colonialism generated intense “cultural involution” (C. Geertz 1963): music, dance, and theater were differentiated into distinct subgenres that were internally more complicated and labor intensive to perform than ever before. This hyperdevelopment necessitated intense training and deep investment of resources. A number of scholars have argued that the courtly arts of Java directly or indirectly emulated advances in European arts of this time; for example, the larger “full” gamelan of central Java’s courts mirrored the Wagnerian orchestra. Although outwardly Javanese arts appeared exotic and quite unconnected with European modernity, the colonial encounter drove their development forward (cf. Kartomi 1990; Sumarsam 1995; Sutton 1997).

The Javanese female group dances known generically as *bedhaya* and *srimpi* provide a good example of this colonial dynamic (Brakel-Papenhuijzen 1992a).⁸ Group dances of this type were common in courts around Southeast Asia during the nineteenth century. They were exhibited to impress palatial guests through the beauty of the dancers, the glitter of their costumes, the refinement of gesture, the coordination of movement and music, and the embellishment of space. An English visitor to the court of Pahang in peninsular Malaysia describes the raja’s offering visitors to his palace a dance known as *joget* in the 1870s. It was performed to gamelan accompaniment by four identically dressed *budak joget* (dance slaves), aged eleven to eighteen (Swettenham [1895] 1984, 44–52). The island of Ternate’s sultan greeted important guests with a dance called *menareh*, also known as *lego-lego*. It was performed in the front reception hall by twelve young women wearing a version of Portuguese dress—pink silk robes, aprons, golden girdles, golden chest plates, golden headpieces decorated with flowers, and fans. Austrian travel writer Ida Pfeiffer, who visited Ternate in the early 1850s during her second round-the-world tour, judged the choreography to resemble the quadrille (1856, 237–238). This dance, accompanied by frame drum, flute, and the song of a female singer, was a “symbol of continuity” (Eisenstadt 1969, 454): its Portuguese sartorial and choreographic aspects recollected Ternate’s past as the epicenter of the Portuguese-dominated spice trade.⁹

Bedhaya and *srimpi*, performed by nine and four identically dressed female dancers, respectively, were likewise often presented to visitors to Java’s courts, princely houses, and regencies—and not only in central Java. When Pfeiffer journeyed to the Sundanese highlands of West Java in 1852, the Assistant Resident of Batavia arranged for her to see a selection of central Javanese-style female dances at the regent’s mansion in Bandung.¹⁰ Pfeiffer witnessed three dances (which she mistook as different “movements” of the same dance because of their similarity),

performed by six female dancers: “The first [was] very calm and simple; in the second the dancers seized plumes of ostrich and peacocks’ feathers, which they waved about like swords, and fenced with them; and in the third they armed themselves with bows and arrows, and represented a regular combat, in which one half of the number was defeated, and the slain remained for some time lying on the field of battle” (Pfeiffer 1856, 131).¹¹ The barefooted dancers wore “closely-fitting jackets without sleeves,” gold-embroidered skirts, golden ornaments, purple sashes, and “open-work helmets” (131). Pfeiffer was distracted by the fact “that the dancers kept their eyes constantly fixed on the ground,” a custom she attributed to a show of “profound respect for the spectators” (131–132).

A later European spectator at a dance performance at Bandung’s regency provides further details, hyperbolically claiming that the accompanying gamelan was one of the most exquisite sets in Java, made up of “two hundred and thirty-eight bells, ten tom-toms, sixteen pairs of cymbals, twenty single-stringed violins, and as many drums” (Beauvoir 1872, 40) and costing a thousand pounds to construct. In this account, the dancers, numbering eight at the time of his visit, were aged twelve to fourteen and all were concubines of the regent living in a “se-raglio [. . .] guarded by sentinels with bayonets at the end of their muskets. [. . .] When he is tired of them, he gives them in marriage to his friends in regular order, which is considered as a high honour” (40–41).¹²

Bedhaya, *srimpi*, and related dances sometimes deployed the trappings of European modernity such as decanters and pistols as stage props, but at ninety minutes or more in duration, they tried the patience of even the most civil European guests. Royal female dances were considered to be sacred heirlooms (*pusaka*) and emblems of power, and Europeans endured performances to demonstrate their respect to their Javanese hosts (see, e.g., Ritter 1855, 176). Europeans were not only disconcerted by the slow pace but were also unable to discern the choreographic patterns or *kembangan* that structured these dances. Because the movement was generally abstract rather than mimetic, and Europeans could rarely understand the texts sung before and during dances, few could make sense of the dances’ symbolic logic.

Europeans were also troubled by cross-cultural differences in the apprehension of dance. European concert dances designed for the proscenium stage emphasize footwork and floor patterns visible from afar. In contrast, as Indonesian anthropologist and dance teacher Koentjaraningrat (1985, 295) points out, Javanese court dances are characterized by “restrained motion and minute movements of the head and hands” designed to be “performed in a large dancing place, which is an open pavilion of about 10 by 20 meters (*pendhapa*). The audience watches from a short distance around the performance. They can therefore



Srimpi dancers of the Regent of Bandung from c. 1863–1865. Photograph by Isidore van Kinsbergen. From Collections KITLV Digital Image Library, 3968.

concentrate more on the details of the movement of every individual dancer rather than on the total effect of the dance movements.” Finally, European attitudes to concert dance might have compelled a visitor to sit attentively in her straight-backed chair, watching every gesture of the dance, rather than indulging in drinking, eating, gossiping, and card playing—all characteristic behaviors among experienced spectators (cf. Sumarsam 1995, plate 4). It was perhaps because of their semantic impenetrability to Europeans that refined female dances became so prevalent in the nineteenth century, with numerous new variants created in the courts of Surakarta and Yogyakarta and dissemination to royal houses outside the principalities. Dances in the *bedhaya* and *srimpi* style were symbolic capital and signs of distinction for Javanese patrons, marking their cultural autonomy from European colonialism.

WAYANG KULIT AND SOCIAL DANCE ACROSS CULTURES

Javanese arts have an ancient literary basis. Wayang kulit puppeteers, for example, sing mood songs or *sulukan* that are excerpts of the *Bhāratayuddha*, a twelfth-century Old Javanese poetic adaptation of a section of the ancient Sanskrit Mahabharata epic. Performances of courtly dance are preceded by the sung recitation of a relevant poetic text accompanied by slow and soft gamelan music. Reading clubs in Java, Bali, and Lombok gather to sing poetic narratives and discuss their meanings. Professional readers of texts sing texts at rites of passage marking the seventh month of the first pregnancy or the first time a child’s feet touch the ground (Arps 1992). Written texts were treated in traditional Java with reverence: volumes commissioned by royal elites were carefully calligraphed and sometimes gloriously illustrated, bound in leather, inlaid with precious stones, and opened on satin cushions to avoid straining book spines (D’Almeida 1864, 2:161–162). But these written texts were always only one component of complex performances. Performers were required to improvise and elaborate on them, guided by “patterns inherited from the past” (Shils 1981, 21).

Fears about the future of tradition haunted Javanese court culture in the wake of the sacking of Yogyakarta’s royal court in 1812, a retributive measure for an insurrection against the English interregnum colonial government. T. S. Raffles, the lieutenant governor of Java and an amateur historian, ordered the court’s library looted and its key texts carted off to England. Drama and other performance practices derive materials from an “unending conversation” that is going on from the time we are born (Burke [1957] 2003, 75), and the eradication of Yogyakarta’s library wedged a caesura into this conversation. The Yogyakarta court soon restocked its library, copying old texts and commissioning new ones. Infected by

“archive fever” (Derrida 1998), the status of the text took on a new valence in Yogyakarta court performance. Under Hamengkubuwana V (r. 1823–1855), all dialogue and narration for *wayang wong*—a type of dance drama considered to be a sacred heirloom or *pusaka* of the Yogyakarta palace and enacting stories from the Mahabharata (and occasionally the Ramayana)—had to be written down.¹³ Actor-dancers were now required to memorize lines, and the narrator or *pemaos kandha* chanted directly from the written script in performance (Soedarsono 1984, 111). In the neighboring court of Surakarta in 1817–1818, royal scribes compiled the *Serat purwacrita* (Book of stories of antiquity), 142 play outlines of the repertoire of the court puppeteer Reditanaya. It was the first systematic collection of plots of shadow plays and possibly was intended to function as an aide memoire for Surakarta’s king Paku Buwana IV (r. 1788–1820), who was known to perform wayang kulit for the court (Arps 2015). Notation for gamelan pieces and the choreography of court dances, referred to in Javanese as *penget* or mnemonic aids, and clearly influenced by European inscriptive practices, also emerged in the second half of the nineteenth century (J. Becker 1980; Brakel-Papenhuijzen 1992b; Sumarsam 1995).

Inscription led to the formalization and codification of courtly performance forms, reflexivity, and a new sense of historicity. Symbolically, written texts facilitated the realization of Javanese aspirations to demonstrate that their arts were equal in status to those of Europe (cf. Sumarsam 1995, 106). Inscription also opened artistic texts to multiple interpretations and uses, not only by the Javanese but also by Dutch and Indo scholars and cultural enthusiasts, as well as Chinese patrons. Javanese artists and noble elites became urbane “experts” (Beck, Giddens, and Lash 1994, 82–85) in their inherited traditions. The close association between these experts and European, Indo, and Chinese patrons and scholars, as well as their shared attention to texts and other performance documents, contributed to artistic ferment (Sumarsam 1995; Sears 1996; Sutton 1997).

European and Indo scholars took a special interest in wayang kulit, designated Java’s “national drama” by Raffles, and its *kawi* (Old Javanese) literary sources (Sears 1996). This interest dates at least to the 1832 founding in Surakarta of the Javanese Language Institute, which trained colonial civil servants and included wayang kulit in its curriculum. In the school’s primary language textbook, *Javaansche zamenspraken* (Javanese conversations), written by the Indo scholar, translator, and newspaper editor C. F. Winter, a Javanese courtly poet named Raden Ngabei Kawitana explains to an anonymous student (“Tuan Anu”) that “it is not only you who have difficulty with kawi but many of my folk [*bongsa*], the Javanese, also can’t understand” (Winter [1848] 1882, 152). Winter’s dialogue

articulates a key colonial concern about the decline of indigenous learning and knowledge under modernity, with this decline serving as a pretext for European scholar-administrators and their local collaborators to “reform” noetic systems and justify colonial rule (Pemberton 1994; Florida 1995; Sears 1996).

Scholars consequently focused attention on wayang as text rather than performance, emphasizing literary features and floral kawi vocabulary over music and spectacle (cf. Kleinsmiede 2002). This gave critical distance on a form that is in practice a complex field of social interactions and allowed the ready application of European philological methods. As Walter Ong states, written texts are “more noetically manageable than oral utterance is, for they are quiescent, passive, fixed, recuperable, manipulable. They are seemingly reified verbalization. They can be treated as things” (1988, 262). Sometimes this scholarly manipulation of texts-as-things involved severe editing. Philologist J. A. Wilkens, who published the first wayang kulit transcription, states in his introduction that he inscribed the play *Pergiwa* “from the mouth of the court puppeteer Ki Redhi Soeto though leaving out the platitudes which would not have been omitted in performance” (1846, 7; see also Sears 1996, 84). Subsequently, European scholars commissioned play outlines and fully scripted plays. Wayang was then dutifully collected as a form of dramatic literature for European archives and the library of the Royal Batavian Society of Arts and Sciences, a learned society founded in Batavia in 1778 that had been revitalized by Raffles.¹⁴

Philological interest in wayang kulit and related arts offered legitimacy for what had been viewed as a disreputable pursuit. Participation in Javanese arts by Europeans was disparaged by polite European society until well into the colonial period. Nonetheless, numerous Indos who spoke more-or-less fluent Javanese were said to be “addicted” to wayang (Serrurier [1896] 1993, 97), and underground gambling dens run by Europeans sponsored gamelan and wayang performances that drew both Indo and Javanese customers.¹⁵ There was even an Indo puppeteer: the Russian-Javanese C. L. Coolen, who founded a small Christian community in the interior of eastern Java in 1830 and performed wayang kulit to spread the gospel. A small number of Europeans were also competent gamelan players. Some were plantation managers and owners, so-called tea lords (*heren van de thee*, in Dutch), who owned gamelan sets and sponsored regular wayang, gamelan, and social dance performances to attract and satisfy their laborers. Typically Europeans played the *rebab* (spiked fiddle) because this instrument had a leading role in the ensemble and could be played while seated on a chair, thus preserving status.

Even more disgracefully, many European and Indo men partook in dancing with professional Javanese singer-dancers (who were known in different parts of Java as *ronggeng*, *tandak*, or *taledhek*) at alcohol-fueled dance parties. Social

dances were practiced in many parts of the archipelago, across different social strata and ethnicities—including *pajoge* among the Buginese and Makassarese of south Sulawesi, *gandot* of the Banjarese of south Borneo, and *joged* in Bali. In Java, formal dance parties accompanied by gamelan music were known as *tayuban*. Although frowned on by devout Muslims, the *tayuban* was an important arena for the display of status and was greatly enjoyed by men (Spiller 2010). There were also street dance parties in Java, known as *marung* or *janggrungan*, in which men paid singer-dancers for each couple dance. “Public dancers” were known to be sex workers, and numerous myths circulated about their mysterious powers of attraction.¹⁶

Europeans varied hugely in their opinions of social dance. When Sir James Brooke, the first “white rajah” of Sarawak and inspiration for Joseph Conrad’s Lord Jim, happened on a social dance in southern Sulawesi in 1840, he found it “dull,” “stupid,” “interminable” (Brooke 1848, 1:116–117). Other European sojourners swooned over “dancing girls.” American ship captain Walter Murray Gibson, who moored his schooner in Palembang in 1852, presents himself as something of a dance connoisseur in his memoir. He describes being serenaded by a Malay singer-dancer named Sedap Malam while visiting a wealthy Chinese merchant, and he made repeated calls to the house of Nora Wangsa, a minor official in the court of Palembang who made a business out of hiring *ronggeng* for parties. Gibson lauds Nora Wangsa as “a Malay impresario” (1855, 213) and translates extemporized quatrains by the “Malay improvisatrice” (153) Sedap Malam. The pride and pleasure he takes in being hailed in Sedap Malam’s song as “the Panglima [commander] of the long black prahu [boat]” (154) shine through. It was common up until the end of the nineteenth century for social functions sponsored by European, Javanese, and Chinese elites to feature both European-style social dance and *ronggeng*; long-term European residents were known to dance gracefully in Javanese style (*joget*) in time to gamelan music.¹⁷

Not surprisingly, the colonial government and Java’s royal courts both had interests in regulating social dance. A 1778 law strictly limited the occasions when social dances could be held in Batavia and its surroundings (van Hoëvell 1849, 259–260). Street dance parties were illegal in some towns and cities of Java because they tended to lead to drunken brawls over the affections of taxi dancers. A Dutch-language regulation, issued during the rule of the Napoleonic, reform-minded governor-general Herman Willem Daendels, compelled Cirebon’s three royal courts to create a boarding school for *ronggeng* in order to maintain public order. According to the school’s statutes from 1809, dancers were to be lodged and receive instruction in art and etiquette in a purpose-built school in Sunyaragi, located near the Kasepuhan court’s Chinese-designed water pleasure palace. In



American captain Walter Murray Gibson (bottom left) is serenaded by the professional singer-dancer Sedap Malam ("Pleasant Night"), "with swaying head, with twining arms, and twirling fingers; and with her soft piping voice," as her employer, the Chinese merchant and amateur musician Teo Chan Beng, accompanies her on a Malay lute (*kecapi*). Illustration from Walter Murray Gibson's *The Prison of Weltevreden and a Glance at the East Indian Archipelago* (New York: J. C. Riker, 1855), 153.

addition to learning the arts of music and dance and giving public performances for visitors, students were to learn how to read, write, and chant the Qur'an (van der Chijs 1896, 528, 686–691).¹⁸ Up through the twentieth century, *taledhek* singer-dancers attached to the royal courts of Surakarta and Yogyakarta were housed in special quarters and assigned court officials, known as a *lurah taledhek*, as managers and pimps (Stutterheim [1935] 1956).¹⁹

Chinese also took an active interest in Javanese performing arts. This interest dates back at least to the 1810s, when the Chinese businessman Tan Tiang Tjhing began to hold gamelan concerts in his private garden in Semarang (Kartomi 2000, 282–284). Hybrid Javanese-Chinese musical ensembles flourished in Java's main cities in the nineteenth century. *Gambang* (known as *gambang kromong* today), an orchestra mixing Chinese bowed string instruments and the Chinese side-blown flute with the Sundanese gamelan, was the music of choice at Chinese brothels and accompanied the singing of singer-dancers at *wayang cokek* dance parties (Phoa

1949; Kartomi 2000, 291–293; Yampolsky 2013, 354–359).²⁰ Gamelan and other Javanese and Sundanese arts were regularly part of Chinese celebrations. For example, a large party in 1872 at the house of a lieutenant of Batavia’s Chinese community featured European music, as well as *wayang cokek*, *wayang golek* (rod puppetry), *ronggeng*, *angklung* (bamboo shakers), *gedebus* (a display of invulnerability magic), and *penca* (Javanese martial arts). The party also featured a display of *ujungan*, or fencing with rattan strips, by performers imported from Banten.²¹ By 1860, affluent Chinese living in Semarang were hiring Javanese social dancers (*tandak*) from Ambarawa and as far away as Surakarta and Yogyakarta (Liem 1933, 130). At the beginning of the twentieth century, the Chinese were renowned as connoisseurs of Javanese art, publishing popular editions of wayang plays, possessing some of the most expensive gamelan sets, commissioning gilded Javanese shadow puppets decorated with diamonds and rare stones (so-called *wayang inten*), and amassing collections of Javanese masks and manuscripts (J. 1940; Kunst 1973, 1:244; Kartomi 2000, 290).

However, Chinese and European wayang fans did not approach Javanese performance in the manner customary to Javanese patrons. The typical, naïve Javanese spectator, according to Carel Poensen—a Dutch missionary who lived in East Java for thirty years and conducted the first ethnographic studies of wayang—watched shadow puppetry “to apprehend stories about the people or countries of old” (*soepados tijang soemereppa tjarijossipoen tijang oetawi nagari kina*) (Poensen 1873, 150). Wayang performances were sponsored to prevent catastrophes and bring fertility and prosperity to families and communities. The puppeteer functioned as both an entertainer and a ritual officiant reciting magical spells and presenting offerings to spirits. Some nineteenth-century puppeteers sat in an incense-filled tent before performances to seek the guidance of these spirits (Serrurier [1886] 1993, 120). Certain plays, including those dramatizing episodes of the bloody *Bratayuda* war that conclude the Mahabharata cycle, were taboo; their enactment threatened to bring disaster to sponsors.

In contrast, wayang for Chinese and Dutch sponsors was not ritual, but entertainment and a source of pleasure. They had no truck with *Bratayuda* prohibitions and found precisely such “old” stories to be the most enjoyable (Serrurier [1886] 1993, 114–117). This new patronage relation effectively prepared the ground for theories and practices of Javanese “art-as-art” (cf. Bourdieu [1971] 1985, 16). The irreverence of Chinese wayang patrons is displayed in a copiously illustrated manuscript of versified wayang plays from 1863, originally possessed by Chinese owners and now in the Leiden University library. One of the plays is the raucous tale of *Kandiawan*, in which the noble Arjuna takes on the form of an ogre and exchanges genitals with his wife Srikandhi.²² An illustration shows the transgendered Srikandhi’s erect penis, fully as long as her forearm and with a smiley face

on its glans, poking through his/her sarong. Kresna, Arjuna's sage advisor, holds a hand over his mouth to contain his laughter.

ARTISTIC INNOVATION IN THE MANGKUNEGARAN COURT

Huge profits from the coffee, sugar, and indigo holdings of the Mangkunegaran, the minor royal court of Surakarta, were channeled into artistic production during the latter part of the rule of the poet-king Mangkunegara IV (r. 1853–1881) and the first years of the reign of his son Mangkunegara V (r. 1881–96). Mangkunegara IV is a revered figure in Javanese cultural heritage. His “great veneration for the old Javanese way of doing things (as he and his circle saw this) [combined] with an open, liberal-ethical attitude to spiritual life” (Pigeaud [1932] 2003, 282). His vision of tradition in modernity took form in the court's magnificent Pendhapa Agung, or Grand Gazebo, an open-air covered pavilion for gala performances and parties completed in 1866. The traditionalist feature of a *joglo* roof overhangs a veranda modeled after European villas, allowing visitors attending functions in the monsoon season to dismount from their carriages without getting wet. With an area of 3,500 square meters, 10.5 meters in height, and accommodating up to five thousand guests, the Grand Gazebo was the largest *pendhapa* in Javanese history. It is an architectural wonder that still impresses. Newly created and modified performance forms were needed to fill this capacious space—the old forms were dwarfed by this new setting, made inaudible and invisible. Its construction thus serendipitously launched a two-decade renaissance of Javanese performing arts.

A court manuscript records Mangkunegara IV's first step to outfit his modern gazebo: the creation of new and reinterpreted *wireng* (warrior) choreographies, a dance genre that displays virility and martial skills and is a key symbolic marker of masculinity and power.²³ Recalling a precedent set by his ancestors, the seventeenth-century rulers of the upstart central Javanese kingdom of Mataram, who abducted artists and art forms from the *pesisir* (outlying, coastal) regions of Java to enhance the glory of the realm (Carey 1997), the prince summoned dance masters from Yogyakarta, Madura, and the kraton of Surakarta. They were instructed each “to dance in turn, and the ruler selected from their dances what was suitable.”²⁴

The courtier charged with arranging these warrior dances for the Grand Gazebo was Mangkunegara IV's son-in-law Raden Mas Aria Tondhakusuma, who gained early fame as a Klana dancer in a courtly adaptation of rural topeng mask drama. An inventive theorist as well as practitioner, Tondhakusuma was to play a significant role in many artistic innovations in the coming years. His aesthetic trea-

tise, *Serat gulang yarya* (1870, Joy of learning), was likely the first Javanese-language book to take as its sole analytical focus the *alus* art complex of gamelan, tembang, wayang, and dance.²⁵ Tondhakusuma's name is associated with a number of other writing projects, including the supervision of a group of court writers in the composition of a set of one hundred play scenarios (*pakem*) for *wayang madya*, a new story cycle for wayang kulit based on the *Pustaka raja* (Book of kings)—a universal history written by Surakarta's leading court poet, Raden Ngabei Ronggowarsita (1802–1873).²⁶ Although *wayang madya* is a minor wayang genre and never gained popularity outside of court circles, two of the performance projects that occupied Tondhakusuma in the 1880s have critical significance for the development of Javanese performing arts: *langendriya* and wayang wong.

Langendriya (literally, “heart's pleasure”) is a refined art in which dancers sing verse dialogue to the musical accompaniment of gamelan: it is a veritable “danced opera” (Holt 1939, 253; see also Pigeaud 1926). The repertoire is derived from Damarwulan plays associated with *wayang krucil* (also known as *wayang klithik*), a form of puppet theater using flat puppets carved from wood. Both the kraton of Yogyakarta and the Mangkunegaran court fielded variants of *langendriya*: where the form originated is disputed.²⁷ The more enduring version of *langendriya*, however, is the Mangkunegaran one, performed by an all-female cast. This form's invention, which drew on Tondhakusuma's topeng background, is also associated with Gottlieb Theophile Kiliaan, the Chinese cashier and steward of the Mangkunegaran court, who also owned a batik factory and possibly a gambling den where wayang was performed.²⁸ According to Serrurier ([1896] 1993, 195), “the headdresses of the female performers are like those of *wayang klithik* puppets, but costumes are more contemporary. Women playing male roles bind their breasts in bodices (*mekah*, *pamekak*) with rows of buttons down the front. The person truly responsible for planning and arranging *langendriya* was Gottlieb Kiliaan.” It has been suggested that the first *langendriya* dancers were women working at Kiliaan's batik factory who were trained by Tondhakusuma. It is possible that Kiliaan had a commercial interest in the art: some say he sponsored *langendriya* only after his batik business failed (Sutton 1997, 27–28).

The first public *langendriya* performance in Surakarta seems to have occurred in 1880 at a family celebration in the house of Pangeran Aria Gondasishwara, an older brother of Mangkunegara V.²⁹ *Langendriya* was adopted subsequently as a court art, and it developed to a very high level under Mangkunegara V (r. 1881–1896). Oral history has it that the monarch presented *langendriya* officially at his coronation in 1881 (Sutton 1997). Like the Yogyakarta court's wayang wong, it was a literary theater. Tondhakusuma's scripts (collected

in a number of volumes titled *Pakem mondraswara*) include dialogue, song lyrics, and stage directions. Ronggowarsita's *Pustaka raja* again served as the major literary source.

The development of langendriya catapulted a raft of artistic innovations, including a new musical form called *palaran*, in which vocalists sing floral melodies over a softly playing gamelan; the introduction of a battery of *kenong* (sound-kettles) into the gamelan; the reorchestration of a class of gamelan pieces (*gendhing lampah*) to include the large gong known as *gong ageng*; and the development of dramaturgical structures and choreographic skills (Kunst 1973, 1:309; Sutton 1997). The form cemented the reputation of the central Javanese courts as centers for refined arts. Numerous other courtly dance dramas and dance operas in the langendriya model flowed in the next decades, including *langen asmara*, which presented Menak stories, and *langen mandra wanara*, which told Ramayana stories and, like the Yogyakarta version of langendriya, was acted from a crouching posture.³⁰

In addition to espousing langendriya as a court art, Mangkunegara V also fashioned a new style of wayang wong, again with Tondhakusuma at the helm. Although it was claimed to be a revival because legend had it that Mangkunegara I also possessed a version of wayang wong (cf. Winter [1848] 1882, 156–157), it seems that no wayang wong had been performed in Surakarta since at least the eighteenth century. According to the Surakarta court dancer Raden Mas Wiradat (1960, 363), the explicit model for the Mangkunegaran court's 1880s "revival" was the wayang wong of Yogyakarta. Tondhakusuma was ordered to practice in the Yogyakarta court as a dancer for several months to acquire direct knowledge of the form. Instructors from Yogyakarta were then imported to teach the Mangkunegaran court dancers. In line with its claim to being a revival of an ancient art, and reflecting Mangkunegara V's modern archaeological interests, costumes were modeled after reliefs from ancient Hindu temples.³¹ New costume items—including wing-like ornaments (*praba*) and armlets (*kilat bau*)—were created by a carver from Blora under the supervision of Tondhakusuma. These costumes were highly embroidered and very expensive.³² One source indicates the set cost 50,000 guilders to construct and 100 guilders monthly to maintain (Schulze 1890, 330).³³

Dancers were selected from among the court servants (*para abdi*) whose physiognomy matched the images of the wayang puppets. Yogyakarta's wayang wong was a text-based form. Its noble actor-dancers were cast in accord with their off-stage status and compelled to adhere to precomposed lines or risk insulting a high-ranking courtier by a slip of the tongue. In contrast, performers in the Mangkunegaran were cast without regard to their status and could extemporize lines, in the manner of puppeteers. The deemphasis of written text allowed for a



A *wayang gedog* play (likely *Ngenaswara* or *Dewi Endrawati*) enacted as a *wayang wong* dance-drama by dancers of the Mangkunegaran court in 1885–1886. Photograph from Collections KITLV Digital Image Library, 3967.

repertoire of at least sixteen plays based on different puppet forms to be produced in only four years.³⁴

THE RISING STATUS OF CENTRAL JAVA'S COURTLY ARTS

The innovations of the Mangkunegaran, and particularly Tondhokusuma's free mixing of traditions, generated controversy. Oral tradition relates that after Tondhokusuma duplicated without due license the tuning of the sacred three-toned gamelan Munggang of the rival kraton of Surakarta, he was struck blind "as a punishment from the divine powers for his audacity" (Kunst 1973, 1:258). The Munggang-based gamelan that Tondhokusuma constructed for his father-in-law received the mocking name, Kyahi Sengkan Turunan, "Venerable Sir Attempt at Imitation." Nevertheless, the reputation of the court-trained dancers of the Mangkunegaran and the rival royal houses of Surakarta and Yogyakarta spread rapidly through newspapers and word of mouth. Railways and modern communication technologies allowed performers from the principalities to be contracted to perform on special occasions in cities around Java. Performers associated with the court centers brought cachet to events, along with the new performance techniques. Tourists traveled by train to attend public performances in Surakarta and Yogyakarta, such as the annual playing of the sacred *gamelan Sekaten* in the royal mosques to celebrate Muhammad's birthday. By the late 1880s, village artists were integrating the artistic innovations of courtly *wayang wong* and *langendriya*.³⁵

Newspaper stories from around Java testify to the rising prestige of central Java's courtly arts in the 1880s. A Madiun correspondent describes an 1885 celebration for the appointment of his town's Chinese captain where a *tandak* from Solo sang a "new-style piece (*kenanti sampak*)"—a vocal setting for the traditional *kinanthi* melody against the background of soft-playing *sampak* in the manner of the *palaran* of *langendriya*. "As a villager [*tiang doesoen*], this is the first I have learned of singing and dancing like this, and I did not feel tired until the performance ended at 2 a.m."³⁶ An encounter with Surakarta's innovative arts brought new perspective on local culture—Madiun was deemed not a city, but a mere village in comparison. A *tandak* dancing at a Kediri celebration is similarly described as "originating from Kediri and therefore is just ordinary [*sedeng*] with regards to her talents or style or clothes," because only a dancer from the court centers was thought to be truly accomplished.³⁷ A traveler returning from a trip to central Java confesses shame in his local culture. Chancing on a social dance with three professional *tandak* dancers near his hometown of Cirebon, he notes,

I found their appearance attractive but their voices and dance were stiff [*kakoe*], and the music especially was rough [*kasar*] and too loud like the sound of a bleating calf. [. . .] Oh! I recalled seeing *wayang orang* in the court of Surakarta, and the fight between Panji and Raden Wirun the knight of Kediri and how they sang out their challenges. The song was so sweet and sonorant that it pulled at my heart. In contrast, the voices of the *tandak* I mentioned above were so stiff and rough. It was like someone accustomed to smoking Havana cigars priced at 1.80 each switching to cigars costing 10 cents a pack.³⁸

The rising profile of the Mangkunegaran as an artistic center and its perceived friendliness to Europeans (cf. Houben 1986) explain why this junior court was selected to send a delegation of musicians and dancers to the National and Colonial Industrial Exhibition held in the Dutch city of Arnhem in 1879. This was the first time that a full gamelan performed in Europe. The nominal leader of the group was Mangkunegara IV's son Pangeran Haryo Gonda Siwoyo, but musical direction from the *rebab* was entrusted to H. G. Lucardie, a Eurasian friend of C. F. Winter who had coauthored a Malay-Dutch dictionary when studying in Delft. Lucardie had left a career in the postal service to settle in Surakarta, where he managed a department store and played gamelan. The group was composed of thirteen musicians dressed in austere blue jackets with brass buttons, bow ties, and batik skirts, as well as two teenaged ronggeng. The court was loathe to release its official court dancers to perform, perhaps fearing impropriety abroad. Dutch audiences were captivated nonetheless by the gamelan's spectacle and exotic sound (Terwen 2003, 49–68; Cohen 2010, 10). In the decades thereafter the Mangkunegaran court regularly featured in international cultural delegations.

The hyperdevelopment of Javanese arts found textual expression in Javanaese-language books such as Raden Mas Panji Kusumawardaya's wayang kulit textbook *Serat Sastra Miruda* (Book of Sastra Miruda) and mask-dance history *Kawruh topeng* (Knowledge of topeng), both of which reflect and address Dutch concerns about the origins and evolution of Javanese art (cf. Sears 1996).³⁹ An even more impressive textual project was the two-volume *In den kedaton te Jogjakarta: Oepatjara, ampilan en tooneeldansen* (In the court of Yogyakarta: Regalia, royal insignia, and theatrical dances, 1888): one volume is text written by Isaäc Groneman, the Dutch physician of Yogyakarta's royal court and a connoisseur of Javanese arts, and the second volume contains photographic plates by Kassian Cephas, a Javanese Christian who was the official photographer of the court. Groneman makes an impassioned plea in the book's introduction. Although the

Javanese possess no named artists of the rank of Shakespeare, Beethoven, or Michelangelo, Groneman argues, gamelan, the court ceremonies and their associated regalia, and the court dances must all be considered as collectively created *kunst*, or high art. This assertion is demonstrated in the book by brief explanations of the different royal forms and figures and the stunning photographs by Cephas. A puff piece in one Malay-language newspaper had it that “nobody but that Doctor [Groneman] would have been allowed to publish the pictures as they show young women hardly seen in public, and clothes and decorations that only the daughters of a king can wear.”⁴⁰ Through this mediation, the kraton was no longer a forbidden city: it was part of public culture.

Chinese Opera and the Beginnings of a Public Theater

Colonial authorities stereotyped the Chinese as solely interested in business, but they were influential in urban culture, not only as patrons of local arts as already discussed but also through their own companies, institutions, festivals, and events. The Chinese were a small minority in nineteenth-century Java and other islands of the archipelago, accounting for only 1 percent of Indonesia’s total population in 1880 (Furnivall [1939] 1967, 347).⁴¹ But their cultural practices were highly visible in cities and towns around the archipelago. Cap Go Meh, the high point of the celebration of Chinese New Year, with its colorful parades, diverse entertainments, street vendors, pungent food, and noisy fireworks, was an eagerly anticipated urban event each year. The dragon boat races of the annual Pecun Festival offered an unusual diversion, with banners and floral decorations, a riot of different sorts of music, and street clowns. At Confucian temples there were also annual Cioko celebrations, a “strange weird orgy” (Hickson 1889, 343) with decorative *jengge* (floats), paraded *toapekong* statues representing guardian spirits, firecrackers, music, dragons, and ritualistic struggles over food offerings on elevated platforms.

Chinese New Year celebrations survived into the twentieth century, and although Cap Go Meh was repressed under the anti-Chinese Soeharto regime, the holiday celebration has reemerged in many cities of contemporary Indonesia since 1998. Pecun and Cioko are celebrated with less flair, but also have been revived. *Wayang potehi*, as Chinese glove puppetry or *bùdàixi* is called in Indonesia, had limited visibility under the New Order, but is today openly performed in shopping malls and Chinese cultural festivals, as well as on the streets in front of temples. Nearly entirely absent from contemporary Indonesia, however, is a theater that once dominated the cultural life of many cities: Chinese opera.

Reports by European travelers dating back to the first decade of the seventeenth century indicate that Chinese opera was performed on temporary stages erected in the streets of Java's port cities to ensure the success of voyages of Chinese junks bearing goods to and from China, and at the houses of Chinese merchants. Street performances would start at 3:00 or 4:00 p.m. and continue until the sun set at 6:00 p.m. After a break for dinner, performances would resume and continue until sunrise (E. Scott 1606, n.p.; n.a. 1783, 3:26; see also van der Loon 1992). Performances were lively events and attracted large, multiethnic audiences. Stages were surrounded by food and alcohol vendors and gambling tents. A watercolor of a Batavia performance sketched by Dutch traveler Jan Brandes around 1780 (reproduced in Chen 2009, 80) shows a crowd gathered around a Chinese street opera stage open on three sides. The stage, assembled from wooden slats covered in the center by a carpet, is elevated about five or six feet above the ground by inverted "V" supports and sheltered by a slanting roof. At the back of the stage is a wall of bamboo blinds, with two curtained doors. This wall serves as a backdrop to the action and a barrier to the backstage area, which can be reached via a wooden ladder. The main actors, dressed in flowing robes and elaborate head-dresses, act on the carpeted area center stage, while a group of five or six musicians sit on chairs upstage left and right playing *pipa* guitar, *erhu* fiddle, shawm, drum, and other instruments. Two Chinese lanterns, suspended from above, illuminate the stage.

Chinese opera could be found elsewhere in the archipelago as well. Valentijn briefly notes a Chinese opera season in Ambon in 1710 (1724, 2:115), whereas the captain of the Chinese community of the town of Riau, Oei Banhok, reportedly the only Chinese person to own a house built of stone, had his own Chinese opera company in the 1850s, with costumes made in China (de Bruyn Kops 1855, 102). Chinese communities of towns in western Borneo, including Pontianak and Singkawang, contracted troupes from Singapore and China for Chinese New Year and festive occasions during the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries (Buys 1892; Adriani 1898). The Chinese in Padang and Medan also regularly sponsored Chinese opera as these communities increased in size and wealth in the second half of the nineteenth century with the growth of Sumatra's plantation economy.⁴²

Accounts of Chinese opera tend toward vagueness, and so it is hard to ascertain which regional styles of Chinese opera were being performed in colonial Indonesia. For example, the town of Riau had neighborhoods of Cantonese and Hokkien speakers, but it is not clear in which language Oei Banhok's troupe performed, nor whether his actors were all men, all women, or mixed; or who trained his troupe, and so on. The only scholar known to collect Chinese opera playtexts



Three Chinese opera actresses in full costume in Batavia in a picture postcard from c. 1900. Image courtesy of Olivier Johannes Raap.

was the Swedish naturalist Clas Fredrik Hornstedt, who worked in Batavia in 1783–1784 classifying specimens in the collection of the Batavian Society of Arts and Sciences. In a letter dated September 1783, he describes attending a Chinese temple festival where he saw a Chinese opera performed on a temporary stage. Though nauseated by the Chinese food, he was interested enough in the performance to make a return visit to “a Chinese comedy” and bribed his way backstage to purchase a Chinese-language manuscript of plays from an actress (Kumar 1989).⁴³

Although off the scholarly radar, Chinese opera had a very specific interest for the Dutch authorities as a source of tax revenue.⁴⁴ The first Dutch record of Chinese opera in Batavia is a 1641 tax on performances to support a Chinese hospital (cf. van der Loon 1992, 26–27). Thereafter, tax laws became increasingly detailed. A 1751 regulation on the performance of Chinese opera and *tandak* places different taxes on Chinese opera depending on the gender makeup of the

troupe, with the highest rate for *wayang perempuan* or all-female troupes (van der Chijs 1889, 13:110–113). Taxes were collected by a Chinese tax farmer who won the wayang tax farm at auction and usually also held the concession to collect gambling taxes because of the close links between theater and gambling. In addition to Chinese opera, he also collected taxes on all puppet performances, though wayang kulit performances sponsored by the Javanese in their own *kampung* (urban neighborhoods) in conjunction with ritual events were tax free (de Waal 1863, 455).

At some time before the middle of the nineteenth century, Chinese opera in Java and perhaps in other Indonesian islands began to be performed in Malay, likely in response to the increasing acculturation of Chinese communities (cf. Salmon 1981, 39). A somewhat muddled report on Java's Chinese populace by the Dutch-trained Ashanti engineer Kwasi Boakye, who visited the island in 1850, indicates that certain troupes were able to perform in both Chinese and Malay; the acculturated (*peranakan*) Chinese preferred Malay, whereas troupes performed entirely in Chinese to recently arrived Chinese émigrés, known as *singke* (Boachi 1855, 822). Earlier troupes were imported from abroad or made up of poor Chinese, but companies active in Java from the 1850s (if not earlier) seem to have been composed largely of indigenous, *pribumi* Javanese and Sundanese actors. Troupes were privately owned, and until slavery was banned in 1860, the performers were likely to be slaves who were also available for sexual exploitation.

The most famous all-female company operating in Batavia at midcentury belonged to Batavia's Chinese major, Tan Eng Goan, who also ran the wayang tax farm between 1849 and 1853 (Chen 2009, 34). Ida Pfeiffer visited Tan's mansion in the company of the governor general in the early 1850s to see a performance of Tan's *wayang perempuan*. The all-female Chinese opera took place in "a wooden booth, put up opposite the major's house, in the street, so that every passer-by could partake of the amusement; and we ourselves witnessed it from the balcony of one of the windows of the house" (Pfeiffer 1856, 117). The Austrian travel writer found the performance monotonous; in her opinion, the gestures of the six actresses who played male as well as female roles lacked grace, and their voices were loud and harsh. She recognized that the costumes "were extremely rich, being made of heavy silk stuff, with embroideries and costly gold fringe," but perceived the "long petticoats with wide sleeves and short trousers. [. . .] very tasteless as to the form" (117). Likewise, she understood that the food served—sea cucumbers and bird's nest soup—were Chinese delicacies, but the spices were not to her liking.

The historical novel *Tambahsia* recollects Tan's *wayang perempuan* as one of four all-female companies operating in the city at the time.⁴⁵ (Intriguingly, it states that one of the other troupes was owned by a woman with a European

name, *nyonyah Boesee*, possibly “Madame Boucher.”) Actors in all four troupes were slaves “taught by clever teachers especially brought from China” (n.a. [1915] 2002, 29). Tan’s actors are described as especially beautiful and well trained. One actress in the major’s troupe had a “charming face and yellowish white skin, precisely like a Chinese girl” (30):

Be that as it may, few wished to see the wayang wherever it performed, as the Major would often be present. Whatever young man dared to watch too close to the stage or winked or smiled at the actors would cause alarm of be whipped by the Major’s henchmen who always carried whips. The actors were nearly all used by the Major as mistresses. That is why they were closely guarded by their dressers and caretakers. (29)

The abolition of slavery in 1860 resulted in the dissolution of private troupes such as Tan’s, but did not bring an end to Chinese opera in Indonesia. Instead, it became more common for members of the Chinese community to pool their resources to import troupes from abroad. Many of these troupes originated in South China and were thus referred to as *wayang Macao*. They performed at Confucian temples and private homes, as well as at business clubs (*rumah kongsi*). The use of dedicated performance spaces and the practice of charging admission began around 1870. An 1869 letter to the editor of the Malay paper *Biang lala* promotes the opening of a new Chinese restaurant in Batavia’s Chinatown opposite a performance space called Kongsi Wajang: the space’s name suggests a private club dedicated to Chinese opera.⁴⁶ In 1872, there is clear evidence for the Indies’ first public theater under Chinese ownership, described as a *rumah wayang*.⁴⁷ A newspaper article reads, “The Wajang Makao which is famous in Batavia and which once performed in a number of *kongsi* club houses, has now collectively erected a public theater [*roema wajang*] situated in Gang Bamboe of Chinatown. Whoever wishes to attend must pay. First class costs 1 guilder, second class 50 cents, and third class 25 cents, so poor people cannot attend and the *kongsi* club houses are not as lively as previously.”⁴⁸ Two months later, a certain Lie Akong, perhaps the theater’s owner, placed an advertisement in the same newspaper that nightly performances of *waijang prampoem Tjina* (all-female Chinese opera) would begin at Gang Bamboe on 30 October.⁴⁹ A letter sent to the paper’s editor the following week complains about the disruption caused by a Chinese spectator who arrived drunk to the theater and had to be carried out, but also reports that the show was still worth the high price of admission.⁵⁰ Playhouses with differentially priced seating modeled on the European schouwburg were constructed in other cities in Java and other islands of the archipelago in the following decades.

The opening of public theaters transformed Chinese opera into a business, and with that, Chinese businessmen turned into theater entrepreneurs, cosmopolitan brokers of global capitalist modernity (cf. Strassler 2010, 14). Commercialization allowed the import of companies from abroad on a scale formerly unknown. For example, the Giok Bing Hiang troupe came from Siam to Java in 1877 with its ninety company members, including four Siamese women. When it performed in a Confucian temple in Semarang, the company gave two shows daily, charged admission prices comparable to those of the schouwburg, and advertised and was reviewed in Semarang's Dutch-language newspaper, *De locomotief*.⁵¹

Yet, the charging of admission prices did not mean that performers were treated with more respect. An 1889 newspaper article by a Surakarta correspondent about a commercial ("you have to pay like at a circus") *wayang Makau* company from Singapore focuses on the troupe's beautiful actresses (*makaupo*), who were the talk of the town. Shockingly, the correspondent quotes prices for sex: two explicitly named actresses were said to charge fifty guilders for a night of pleasure.⁵² Mistreatment of performers was common. Dutch liberals had long expressed concern about children kidnapped or sold into slavery as Chinese opera actors (de Waal 1863, 455). An 1888 article quotes at length the complaint of an actress in an all-female troupe. She was an orphan who had been tricked by the owner of the troupe into leaving her home with the promise of a salary of 300 guilders a month, but had been paid only 150 guilders for two months' work in a theater in Surabaya's Chinatown. The reporter says that the owner should be ashamed, but does not mention him by name—perhaps fearing reprisal from an influential community member.⁵³

At a League of Nations conference held in Bandung in 1937, a Dutch delegate revealed that Chinese opera operated as a front for transporting Chinese prostitutes from abroad: "The victims travelled under the mask of actresses. After arrival [in the Indies], they made one or two appearances on the stage and were then sent to clandestine brothels" (League of Nations 1937, 14). This trafficking had been suppressed by the establishment in 1915 of a government bureau designed to halt the traffic of women and children and the publication of pornography, but it was difficult to monitor Chinese performance groups. A 1930 newspaper article reprints a contract between a Chinese owner and the parents of one of his performers, in which the parents signed away their ten-year-old child for a period of six and a half years to "study acting" for the "salary" of two hundred guilders, paid to the parents in advance. Should the parents wish for their child's return before the contract expired, they were required to repay the advance along with a sum of money to cover food, clothes, and miscellaneous expenses incurred by the troupe owner.⁵⁴ Slavery thus continued de facto.

Opera had been in decline in the Indies for decades by this time, and such abuses were probably rare by the 1930s. In the twentieth century, Chinese patrons and art workers were more focused on modern forms of theater and transethnic popular culture than on traditional opera. Their cultural entrepreneurship capitalized on structures of art making that arose from Chinese opera's commercialization and the wave of public theaters founded from the 1870s on. With the end of dependence on individual sponsors and the emergence of an impersonal market driven by advertising, an era of artistic modernity was ushered in (cf. Bourdieu [1971] 1985, 16).

Hybrid and Popular Entertainments

The rise of the cash economy in the nineteenth century and the creation of leisure time under the work discipline of capitalism, the experience of boredom and alienation in urban centers, the penetration of European goods and ideas, and fascination with the distant wonders of European modernity mixed with a desire for novelty in the invention of popular arts and entertainment in Java, Sumatra, and other islands of the western archipelago. The new cultural formations side-stepped old affiliations based on ethnicity and class. They “entailed the continuous selection, reinterpretation, and reformulation of [. . .] imported ideas” (Eisenstadt 2000, 15), but none were completely new. Rather, novel forms of popular entertainments captured attention to the extent that they resembled and harnessed existing cultural forms (cf. Urban 2001, 16). Some of the new popular forms—including wayang golek and the commercial variety of wayang wong of the 1880s—are now thought of as markers of ethnic identity. But these forms and others emerged through interactions between ethnic groups and were enjoyed by diverse publics.

Circus

For much of the nineteenth century, the dominant form of popular entertainment was the circus. The first circus recorded to reach Indonesia, the Cirque Olympique, named after the famous hippodrome near Paris’s Champs-Élysées, was an equestrian spectacle that played Batavia and Semarang in 1848–1849 (De Haan 1935, 1:602; Diehl 1990, 353).¹ Circuses were a vital source of entertainment that provided laughter, the experience of “amazement” (*heran*), and a window on the wonders of the world for millions of Southeast Asian spectators from the mid-nineteenth century until the start of the Great Depression, when globe-trotting spectacles became financially untenable. Initially, these circuses played in fenced-off arenas open to the sky, but by 1885 the Chiarini circus was touring with a tent reportedly seating five thousand.² There were also many smaller circuses that played to smaller crowds in towns and cities around the archipelago, including dog-and-monkey shows.

GEDURENDE SLECHTS WEINIGE DAGEN TE CHERIBON.
EERSTE VOORSTELLING OP ZONDAG DEN 13en SEPTEMBER.

Na eene afwezigheid van vier jaren, trekt dit uitgelezen gezelschap als een leger geheel Java rond, met zich voerende, **Menschen, Paarden, Rijtuigen, Leeuwen en Tijgers.**

OLIPHANTEN, PONTS, en 100 GROEAKKEN gevolgd door **DUIZEND KOELIES.**

Chiarini's groot Paarden- en wilde Beestenspel,

Elken avond ten 9 ure

Voorstelling in de groote en goed verlichte **TENT** staande op de Aloon-aloon.



Twee Olifanten van Cylon meegebracht,

verrichten op Commando van den Heer **ABADIE** de zeldzaamste **TOEREN.**
 de heer **JAMES FRAME** zal met drie **Tijgers**, en drie **leeuwen** wonderen verrichten.
 De orang oetan **CYNOCEPHALO** rijdt gelijk de grootste kunstenaar te Paard.

PRACHTIGE PAARDEN, PONTS, ZEBRA'S ENZ., ENZ.

Prijzen der Plaatsen.

Loges (6 stoelen)	f 18.—
Loges (1 stoel)	3.—
Tweede rang	2.—
Derde rang	1.—

MAYA.

Secretaria. (29)

Advertisement for the Chiarini circus featuring two Sri Lankan elephants. *Tjerimai*, 12 September 1885, 2.

The circus operated as an engine of “globality” and spread “general modernity” (R. Robertson 1995, 27). It had ready appeal to archipelagic audiences, jibing with long-established cultural forms. Its equestrian displays captivated audiences from the start. Horsemanship was a marker of status for both Europeans and indigenous elites. Although the outward trappings of militarism declined among Javanese after the end of the Java War in 1830, European culture in the Indies had a militaristic slant through the end of the nineteenth century. In Batavia, “the drills of the army provided public displays, its band provided public concerts, and its officers’ club contributed to the social and recreational life of European society” (Milone 1966, 489). Horse racing was a relatively recent fashion, started by the English in the 1810s, but became quite popular among both European and indigenous elites by the end of the century.

The circus also had traction due to an established tradition of animal spectacles. Cockfighting remains a common pursuit in many islands of Indonesia, and through the middle of the nineteenth century fights were commonly staged in Java between tigers and buffalos, goats and boars, and the like (see, e.g., Lith 1894, 2:327–329). These large-scale animal combats declined with deforestation and the dwindling numbers of wild animals.³

The circus, with its colorful sideshows, also resonated with traditions of public display of unusual-looking people and animals. Javanese monarchs historically collected such specimens as emblems of power. The *Nawaruci*, a Javanese text likely dating from the sixteenth century, describes a king and queen at court “surrounded by dwarfs, hunchbacks, albinos, eunuchs, and cripples” (Ras 1978, 464). In the analysis of Dutch philologist J. J. Ras (1978), this practice is commemorated in the shadow puppet theater’s grotesque clown-servants or *punakawan* who inevitably accompany noble protagonists on their journeys (Carey 2014). In the nineteenth century, freaks of nature were displayed in towns and cities for profit. One of these attractions, a chimerical beast with the head of an orangutan and the tail of a fish, was purchased by an American sea captain in Batavia at the start of the nineteenth century. From 1822 on, it was exhibited worldwide by showmen, including American circus impresario P. T. Barnum, under the title of the Feejee Mermaid (Cook 2001, 73–118).⁴ Itinerant showmen, some of Arab descent, ballyhooed stocks of exotic snakes and birds, curious animals such as a three-legged chicken or five-legged cow, adults with shocking medical conditions, and children born with skeletal anomalies. Tickets for these *ajaib* (astonishing) attractions, known generically as *aneh-anehan* (oddities), were cheap—generally ranging from two to five cents—and thus affordable to the masses.

The *komedi kuda*, or “horse show,” as circuses and Wild West entertainments were called generically in Malay, was strongly present in Indonesia but markedly

not of Indonesia. All the major troupes that toured the Indies were of foreign origin.⁵ Many, perhaps most, were in fact road companies formed by foreign circus entrepreneurs for touring Asia, and they drew heavily on Asian personnel, animals, materials, and technologies. Some circuses, including Chiarini's, Harmston's, Willison's, and Klaer & Olman's, toured Asia for years or even decades, merging and splitting periodically. Advertisements and publicity often do not pinpoint a singular origin for these companies. Frequently stressed instead are the geographical diversity of performers and acts: for example, Bengali tigers, Japanese acrobats, Australian horses, Russian dancers, and Indian jugglers. Warren's Circus, which toured the archipelago in 1901, identified itself as coming from Kansas, but also promoted its Japanese jugglers and acrobats from Okohama. The Great Chinese Circus, which toured in 1930, was owned and managed by the Chinese; all its human performers were likewise said to be of Chinese "nationality." However, the troupe's publicity emphasized that most had formerly performed with the large-scale European circuses of Van Hagenbeck and Carré.

Attending a circus affirmed connections to the wider world. A lithograph of a Parisian circus reproduced in a Semarang newspaper in 1885 was said to be "like [circuses] we have seen a number of times in Semarang, namely those belonging to *Tuwan* Wilson or *Tuwan* Chiarini."⁶ Some concessions were made to Southeast Asian audiences such as the introduction of Malay-speaking clowns, including "Mr. Zinga," who performed with Abell, Klear, & Olman's circus in 1893—"much to the amusement of those sitting in the higher rings."⁷ In general, however, circuses remained resolutely more attuned to global trends than to local concerns. Harmston's Circus, which more than any circus is deserving of the predicate "Circus of the Indies" (by my count it appeared in the small city of Cirebon at least eighteen times over a forty-year period), was said in 1930 to be "up to date" (English in the original), with a brand-new repertoire of acts including one featuring "The Daring Devil," who performed a ten-meter leap on his Harley-Davidson motorcycle.⁸

No entrepreneur in colonial Indonesia had the means or connections to mount a circus that could hold a candle to the large-scale equestrian outfits. Instead, entrepreneurs took inspiration from the small-scale circuses known in Malay as *komedi Jepang* and *komedi anjing dan monyet*. *Komedi Jepang* referred to acrobatic troupes from Japan that toured Java regularly for a quarter-century starting in 1867. Audiences were astounded by their trapeze work, bamboo balancing, tightrope walking, foot juggling, umbrella spinning, human pyramid construction, and the like. The early Japanese troupes were produced by Europeans and Americans, including Thomas Lenton and John Smith (whose fifteen-member troupe from Edo toured Java in 1867), James Elliot (1867 and 1873), and H. N.

Rickertsen ("The Mikado Troupe," 1872). A troupe that combined Japanese acrobats with European circus artists, billed in Malay as *Komedie Djepang dan Inggris*, toured Java in 1871 under the management of F. Page and Frank Stebbing. Later companies had Japanese producers attached to them.

Chinese spectators formed affective relations to the Japanese troupes and their members, and sometimes troupes were "contracted" (*dipacht*) by local Chinese producers. A specified fee was guaranteed for each performance, and in turn the producer arranged for a venue and local publicity, then pocketed the box office take. *Komedi Jepang* troupes were welcomed by members of the Chinese community who wished to emulate Japanese assertions of equality to Europeans. A Sino-Malay poem about a troupe that performed in Yogyakarta in 1889 states that those in the "*Komedi Djepang* are like the Dutch/with shorn hair which makes them look nicer/their clothes too do not differ/with jackets, pants, button-down shirts" (Tan T. S. 1890, 21). It would not be until the twentieth century that colonial law would permit the Chinese to cut the queues that marked them as "foreign Asiatics" and to wear Western clothes, but there were many Chinese individuals who were already bending and finding loopholes in restrictive sartorial and crinitory legislation.

Some newspaper articles elided differences between the Japanese and Chinese and referred to *komedi Jepang*'s artists as "Japanese Chinese." A piece of publicity for Rickertsen's *Mikado Troupe* reads, "We hope that the many wealthy Chinese of the city will attend to honor the Japanese Chinese people [*bangsa Tjina Djepang*], who have come to Batavia especially to extend their friendship to the Chinese of this city."⁹ And after there was a good turnout of Chinese spectators, the same source stated, "We praise the Chinese who support the people of their race. Chinese do not need to support a Dutch troupe, for example, but this is a Chinese troupe, so Chinese must attend and support the company, and later Batavia's Chinese will be known in Japan not to be stingy in their support for *komedi Jepang*."¹⁰

Chinese spectators swooned over the beauty of Japanese female acrobats. One Chinese man reportedly bought twenty souvenir pictures from a Japanese artiste during the intermission of a *Komedie Djepang dan Inggris* show in order to chat up the vendor.¹¹ The sexualization of Japanese visitors was perhaps linked to the fact that most Japanese in the region at the time were prostitutes (Shiraishi and Shiraishi 1993, 8). But there is also a whisper of Japan's mounting military might in a comment about the child acrobats of one troupe: "their cleverness is already awe-inspiring, perhaps when they grow up they will fly."¹²

The popularity of *komedi Jepang* led to numerous imitation troupes, which in the 1890s were referred to alternately as *komedi Jepang tiruan*, *Jepangan*, or

komedi Bogor. Some of the tricks introduced to Java by Japanese and European acrobats and aerial artists are still being performed by village acrobats under the rubrics of *kobrasiswa* and *genjring akrobat*.

Komedi anjing dan monyet (dog-and-monkey shows) also found their imitators in the Indies, yielding the form known nationally as *topeng monyet* and referred to in various provinces as *ledhek kethek*, *doger monyet*, *ronggeng monyet*, or *komedi monyet* (Cohen 2005a). Itinerant companies such as the Gregory Troupe, which toured Java from May to September 1872, featured acts such as a dog dancing on a ball and climbing ladders, monkeys balancing on tightropes, a carriage with monkeys costumed as men and women drawn by two dogs, and a monkey pouring a drink for another monkey to drink. A promotional piece for one company promises that “seeing the monkeys and dogs that have been trained to perform like humans, a spectator will be astonished, and some will laugh.”¹³

The small scale of this entertainment and the ubiquity of its animals around Asia meant that the form was not a European monopoly. An Indian (*sa’orang Kling*) is said to have presented a show with two monkeys and a goat in the small eastern Javanese towns of Lekok and Pasuruan in 1900. Spectators, who paid ten cents for admission, “all laughed out of enjoyment.”¹⁴ An 1899 account from the town of Probolinggo describes a Chinese man “just arrived from China, who brings with him a monkey and is busking in urban neighborhoods.” This showman presented his monkey act in the manner of *topeng babakan*, a street mask-dance form, with spectators paying for each act. “It costs 25 cents to hire one act. It is indeed an excellent performance. It can put on a mask by itself and wear a hat and costume like in Chinese opera, and it can dance in a very amusing fashion.”¹⁵

A remarkable piece of reportage from 1885 describes what might be the very first *topeng monyet* troupe. It was sent by a central Javanese correspondent to Semarang’s Malay-language newspaper *Slomporet Melayoe* in 1885, and although its language is stilted, it is worth quoting in full:

In the town of Klaten there is a very amusing dancing monkey [*tandak monjet*], the trainer is from out of town, they say from Temanggung, but we have never seen a dancing monkey we have liked as much as this because he has very funny acts like a Madurese clown, because there are five monkeys, male and female. First comes a big male monkey whose face is covered by a mask and is ordered to dance and when he dances he moves his neck side-to-side [*patjek goeloe*]. After monkey number one then comes the female monkey’s turn, her face is also covered by a mask, and she dances in a female style with her hands flicking her dance-scarf [*sam-*



Goat-and-monkey show by an itinerant Indian showman in a postcard from c. 1900. Image courtesy of Olivier Johannes Raap.

poer], wow! Her coquettish ways sure do make people watching laugh. And after that comes another monkey, even bigger than the first, whom the trainer commands to dance like an ogre and then the monkey obeys and dances like the Klonon *topeng* dance. Then comes another monkey who is frightened into holding a rifle, and when he holds it is ordered about like a soldier drilled by his corporal, exactly like a soldier learning how to march. After that monkey a male and female monkey come out and the female is ordered to ride a dog while the male leads the dog, fashionably moving his arms [*limbejan*]. Oh! It seems from this that monkeys are almost the same as people and if they were taught to speak they probably could; a sign that they learn like a motivated person can.¹⁶

As in Japan's monkey show (Ohnuki-Tierney 1987), the act is a mirror of society—amplifying concerns about colonial discipline, issues of leadership and control, gender dynamics, and aesthetics. In questioning the rigidity of the species barrier between humans and monkeys, the correspondent leans on knowledge of both the old myths of cogent apes—Hanoman from the Ramayana epic, the Sundanese folktale of Lutung Kasarung—and the raging debates over Darwin's theory of evolution. The circus and other popular entertainments that followed in its wake

encouraged audiences to view the world as “open to transformation by human intervention” (Giddens and Pierson 1998, 94). In diverse ways, circuses were harbingers of modernity, compressing time and space in performance and offering hints of “so many wonderful and untried sensations [. . .] from afar” (Bauman 1998, 121).

Object and Puppet Theaters

Ida Pfeiffer spent six months living among the Batak people of Sumatra in the early 1850s, angling to be the first European to reach the fabled shores of Lake Toba, the world’s largest volcanic lake. Although she did not achieve her aim, the intrepid travel writer’s purposeful loitering in Batak country offered her opportunities to attend and sponsor performances and develop a strange sympathy with a people on the cusp of radical religious change.

In one isolated Toba Batak village, Pfeiffer was treated to an elaborate display of Batak dance and ceremony, accompanied by “a full orchestra of musical instruments, drums, gong, and a kind of bagpipe” (1856, 170). It was almost certainly a *gondang* musical ensemble, made up of a double-reeded aerophone called *sarune*, drums (*taganing*, *gordang*), bossed gongs (*ogung*) imported from Java, and a metal clapper (*hesek-hesek*). *Gondang*, traditionally used by Toba Batak to summon the ancestors, accompanied both dances and ceremonial speeches. Such was the centrality of this music among the Toba Batak that communities of worship were known as *sagondang*, “belonging to one *gondang*” (Okazaki 1994, 77).

Pfeiffer found herself moved by this “venerable and imposing” performance and had to remind herself that she was a Christian witnessing “an invocation of evil spirits, a worship, in fact, of Satan” (1856, 171). There was one dance in particular that Pfeiffer yearned to witness: a ceremonial choreography in which a man is killed and eaten. The dancers expressed understandable reluctance to enact this dance for the writer. The mass conversion of the Batak to Christianity and Islam occurred later in the century, but Pfeiffer’s informants were certainly aware that their cannibalistic practices were abhorrent to outsiders. Pfeiffer was insistent, however, and reports that the villagers “yielded at last to my entreaty.” A log, representing the victim, was bound to a stake and topped off with a hat. High-stepping dancers threatened the log with knives, stabbed and decapitated it (knocking off the cap), and mimed drinking blood and licking their fingers. Throughout, they showed delight rather than terror. “The predominant expression, indeed, of their faces was that of pleasure rather than of cruelty. This, however, was only play; it might have been otherwise had they had a real victim before them” (172).

The dancers had reason to be joyful, because Pfeiffer here instigated a significant act of collective creativity. In the substitution of a log for a person, the Batak performers crossed a ritual dance with another ritual known in different dialects of the Batak language as *parsili* or *parsilihi*, in which a mock funeral is held for an ailing person and a banana log, clay image, or figurine made of sugar-palm leaf is buried with the hope that malevolent spirits plaguing the human would shift their attention to his or her buried surrogate. The substitution of a *parsili* for a real person in the dance commissioned by Pfeiffer transformed a fearful ritual into delightful object theater.

Traditions of song, instrumental music, dance, and other expressive arts were being transformed in similar sorts of intercultural situations around the nineteenth-century archipelago. New performing objects were emerging that had roots in sacred art forms while “interweaving” (cf. Fischer-Lichte 2009) modern technologies and ideas.

European puppet theater, at least since the mechanical and pneumatic puppets schematized by the Greek engineer Hero of first-century CE Alexandria, has involved complex mechanisms for masking the human animation of performing objects. In contrast, “illusionistic puppets” (Paska 1990) appearing to have independent agency and autonomy from human operators were rare in Asia until the introduction of modern European technologies. The sixteenth century saw the inception of Asian automata and puppets with pulleys, coils, cogs, gears, springs, and internal stringing. These elements probably developed out of the experience of Asian craftsmen in repairing broken technological artifacts, such as foreign-made clocks and other novelties given as diplomatic gifts or purchased by Asian elites from European merchants. The best-documented instance of this sort of technological transfer is the *karakuri ningyo* of Japan, seventeenth-century salon automata such as crabs carrying sake cups and festival floats with animated acrobats, scribes, and warrior puppets (Senda 2012). In Osaka in the 1720s and 1730s, these technologies were applied to the classical *ningyo joruri* form, resulting in what is now known as *bunraku*, three-man puppets with moving eyes and eyebrows, mouths that open, and articulated fingers controlled by draw-peg systems and toggles.

Related developments were afoot in Indonesian puppet arts. The *sigale-gale* puppets of the Toba Batak people of Sumatra developed in the nineteenth century out of an indigenous religious tradition in which effigies of children were constructed for bereaved parents or childless couples. These figures, incorporating a human skull, were burnt at the end of elaborate ceremonies. *Sigale-gale* appeared outwardly similar to the archaic ritual figures, but were jointed wooden figures with internal stringing that allowed a puppeteer concealed behind a barrier to

move their arms and heads and rock them in time to the rhythms of a *gendang* (drum). Secrets of animation were held in strict trust. The more complex *sigale-gale* were life-size and could roll their eyes, stick out their tongues, or even appear to weep through the wringing of dampened moss inserted into eye sockets. *Sigale-gale* figures sometimes featured in religious ceremonies to honor ancestors, but seem to have been more common as a source of entertainment. A smaller and simplified version of *sigale-gale*, known as *bejan* or *mejan*, was used for “promenade” performances (Voorhoeve 1940). *Bejan* puppets were operated from behind by a puppeteer whose presence was partially obscured by the puppet in front of him. A *bejan* is what puppet scholars call a humanette, because it is a theatrical figure constituted by a human-puppet hybrid, with the torso of a puppet combining with the legs of the puppeteer.

Another inventive puppet art that gained ground in the nineteenth century was the rod puppet theater known as *wayang golek* in the western part of Java and as *wayang thengul* in the island’s eastern part. This form of puppetry developed largely outside of the royal courts and major cities, making it difficult to pin down a precise date or locus of origin. Rod puppetry emerged as an offshoot of *wayang krucil* and bears signs of influence from Chinese rod puppetry (known as *zhang-tou mu-ou* or *zhang-tou kui-lei*) and European marionettes. *Golek/thengul* puppets are fully three dimensional and costumed in a realistic fashion. A central control rod jutting through a hollowed-out torso allows the puppeteer to swivel and elevate the puppet’s head. In the earliest surviving puppets, in common with *wayang krucil* and *wayang kulit* puppets, arms were fashioned from hide and controlled by secondary control rods. Later puppets have more flexible and articulated arms fashioned from rope or jointed wood, often covered by their costume. Generally, the banana logs that serve as the puppets’ playboard are placed at a higher elevation than in other *wayang* puppet forms, partially obscuring the puppeteer’s body from view.

Stories about the Islamic prophets (*nabi*), particularly a cycle centering on Amir Hamzah, the uncle of Muhammad better known in Java as Wong Agung Menak, formed the rod puppet theater’s core repertoire in the nineteenth century. When rod puppetry traveled west to Cirebon the repertoire expanded to include tales of the ancient Sundanese kingdom of Pajajaran and local culture heroes (Schulze 1890, 330). And when in the last decades of the nineteenth century it moved south to the Sundanese highlands, where *wayang kulit* was on the decline, the form took over shadow puppetry’s Ramayana repertoire and later also incorporated Mahabharata stories.¹⁷

Rod puppet theater was and remains a dynamic art, responsive to its times (Weintraub 2004).¹⁸ Its puppets are more lifelike than earlier forms—by the end

of the nineteenth century there were puppets with moving eyes and articulated tongues (Serrurier [1896] 1993, 173)—resonating with trends toward realism and illusionism in popular visual culture. Although sometimes performed for rites of passage and village-wide thanksgiving celebrations, rod puppet theater was considered a secular entertainment rather than a ritual art.¹⁹ Its focus on Islamic tales, and particularly what one source calls “religious warfare” (*prang agami*), granted it currency during a time of increasing piety and awareness of connections to the wider Islamic world (Cantrik 1933, 130–132).²⁰

Malay-Language Theaters

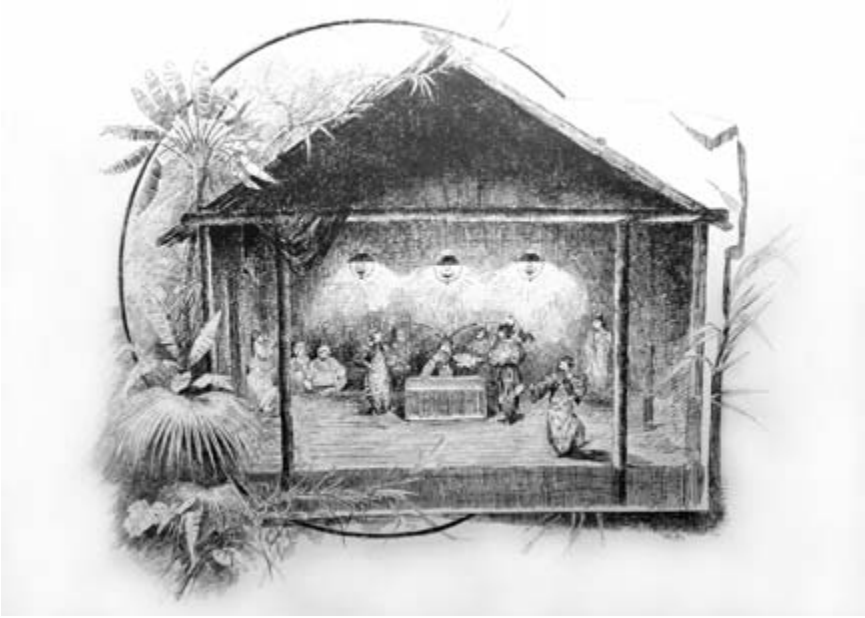
A “community of forms” (Williams [1981] 1995, 156) of popular Malay-language theater, drawing eclectically on traditions of folk drama, Chinese opera, and European melodrama, developed from the 1870s in conjunction with the rapid expansion of a “native school” system where young people aiming at careers in the colonial civil service were instructed to read, write, and speak in the Malay of Riau—considered by grammarians to be the most “pure” Malay dialect. The epic tales of the *alam Melayu* (Malay world) provided a common stock of stories for the text-based theaters of the nineteenth century—*bangsawan*, *komedi Jawa*, *wayang cerita*, *dulmuluk*, and others of coastal Borneo, Sumatra, Penang, Singapore, and Java. Handwritten manuscripts of these epics, categorized by Malay literature scholars as *hikayat* (prose narratives) and *syair* (poetic narratives), had circulated in small numbers in the past, but the emergence of commercial publishing houses in colonial Indonesia, Singapore, and Malaysia starting in the 1850s made cheap editions available to the masses.²¹ Theater became a mode to disseminate such books and the poems and stories published in the Malay-language newspapers of Surabaya, Batavia, Semarang, Padang, Makassar, and Probolinggo to a largely nonliterate audience (cf. Braginsky and Suvorova 2008; van der Putten 2009).

An earlier Malay-language theater, which one source indicates originated in the sultanate of Mempawah in west Borneo in 1712, was called *mendu* (Sutopo and Kasim Achmad 1982–1983, 78). At its inception, this scarcely documented theater seems to have been an indigenized form of Chinese opera. Its repertoire diversified as it spread over the following century to Pontianak, Palembang, Singapore, Penang, and Malacca, focusing increasingly on *hikayat* and *syair* sources (Edrus 1960, 48). In the nineteenth century, an eclectic musical ensemble of Southeast Asian, European, and Chinese instruments accompanied the performances (Skeat 1900, 520). *Mendu* faded quickly in importance during the late nineteenth century and survives today in an etiolated form

propped up by local heritage bodies in isolated backwaters of the Malay world, including the South China Sea's Natuna Islands archipelago (Ghulam-Sarwar 1994, 174–176).

Mendu's audiences were drawn away by one of the most popular theater genres of modern Southeast Asia: *bangsawan*, called in its early days “imitation Parsi theater” (*wayang Parsi tiruan*). As the alternate designation suggests, *bangsawan* originated around 1875 as a Malay-language replication of a foreign theater. Musical dramas were imported by itinerant Parsi-owned theater troupes from India to Southeast Asia, starting with the Parsee Elphinstone Dramatic Society's tour to Singapore in 1862.²² Local audiences had difficulty comprehending much of the Hindustani language (a precursor of today's Hindi and Urdu). However, they were bowled over by Parsi theater's dazzling costumes, fantastic scenic effects such as flying nymphs and disappearing genies, heart-wrenching melodrama, hilarious comedy, and lively song-and-dance routines (cf. Kapur 1993). It was not long before companies in Penang and Singapore were reproducing the Parsi theater's stock Arabian Nights plays and Persian romances such as *Inder Sabha*, and adapting *hikayat* and *syair* sources as well to the genre. The more adventurous *bangsawan* troupes from the Malay peninsula traveled across the Straits of Malacca to perform in Sumatra, and Sumatrans soon launched their own troupes. Actors affected peninsular Malay accents, referred to as *cakap Melayu sultan-sultan*, “the Malay speech of sultans.”²³

C. E. P. van Kerckhoff (1886), a Dutch civil servant who worked as a controller in West Sumatra between 1883 and 1886, provides a detailed account of the vibrant commercial theaters of Padang, Bukittinggi, and Payakumbuh.²⁴ West Sumatra's cities and towns developed rapidly under the Cultivation System, the repressive colonial policy that required the planting of export crops. Schools were scarce in the countryside until the introduction of the three-year “folk school” (*volkschool*) in the 1910s, but boomed in cities, with escalating literacy rates as a consequence.²⁵ Kerckhoff describes a text-based theater performed on elevated stages in bamboo-walled theaters with thatch or galvanized iron roofs to ticket-purchasing audiences hungry for dramatizations of the latest literary texts. Many of the troupes were owned and produced by Chinese businessmen or partnerships (*kongsi*), with florid names such as *Taman Penglipur Duka*, “Pleasure-Ground for Dispelling Sorrow.” Plays were based closely on the classic epic narratives of Malay literature that were being published in popular editions in Malaya and Java—*Syair Abdul Muluk*, *Syair Sri Bidasari*, and *Hikayat Johar Manikam* were popular repertoire items. These poetic texts were sung to Malay melodies, with minor adaptations and occasional ad-libbed humorous comments in the local Minangkabau dialect of Malay thrown in. The large number of characters meant that actors, all male and generally between the ages of fourteen and twenty-one, often “multi-



Malay theater performing a Chinese opera-style play on a temporary stage in the north Sumatran town of Sibolga. This is the same genre described by Kerckhoff (1886). Note up-stage right the musicians playing the Malay shawm and hand drum and what appears to be a Chinese fiddle (*erhu*). Illustration from J. Freiherr von Brenner, *Besuch bei den kannibalen Sumatras: Erste durchquerung der unabhängigen Batak-land* (Würzburg: Woerl, 1894), 141.

roled,” appearing as a man in one scene, a woman in the next. The accompanying musical ensemble consisted of violins, *kecapi* (zither), *rebana* (frame drums), cymbals, and other instruments and could play Malay music, as well as render European tunes such as marches. Musicians were seated at the side of the stage. Lighting and sets were rudimentary, but care was taken with the richly embroidered costumes: one troupe reportedly imported from Singapore the entire wardrobe of a bankrupt Chinese opera troupe.

According to Kerckhoff’s informants, the theater was introduced to the Minangkabau via a circuitous route—“imported from Pontianak to Singapore and from there to Deli and Riau, whence it spread further across Sumatra and found its way via Padang to the Highlands” (translated in Robson 1969, 140; compare n.a. 1924). Like *bangsawan*, it was clearly a theater of the Malay world, practiced and watched by those who “looked to Singapore and Malay (and not Java) for a sense of community” (Hadler 2008, 113).

Newspaper reports indicate that the public theaters of Deli, Padang, Palembang, and Bengkulu that hosted bangsawan, *mendu*, Chinese opera, and related popular entertainment were rough places, associated with crime, prostitution, and violence. Troupes were known to employ medicine men (*pawang*) who offered animal sacrifices and uttered incantations to ensure success, a cause for concern among the religiously devout. A correspondent for a Malay newspaper speculated that trafficking with non-Islamic spirits was the reason why the *imam khatib* of Padang's central mosque refused to give a group of poor bangsawan actors charity on a public holiday.²⁶ A letter sent to another paper from a Singaporean Malay visiting Deli complained about three princes drunk on rice wine and gin who were flirting outrageously with actresses during a *mendu* performance in Deli: "Don't they have any shame? Tsk, tsk, tsk. If I was a prince I would not watch such a show because this is not a good show but a rotten one."²⁷ The reputation of bangsawan was so negative that it was banned outright in the town of Bengkalis.²⁸

Similar social problems confronted Malay-language theaters of Java. The Orientalist and colonial administrator Christiaan Snouck Hurgronje describes a theater called *komedi Jawa*, under the direction of the younger brother of the regent of Pandegelang, which gave regular performance in the courtyard of this West Javanese regency in the 1870s.²⁹ Plays were based on the fiction popular in Java's newspapers at the time—Arabian Nights and folktales such as Abu Nawas—interlarded with improvised topical comedy. Actors were boys at the native school and clerks in the local government. The accompanying music was a mixture of gamelan and European instruments. Playing gamelan on Fridays was a local taboo, so the gongs and sound kettles were replaced in an 1878 performance by a hybrid ensemble of nonmetallic instruments: *calung* (bamboo xylophone), *angklung* (bamboo shakers), *suling* (bamboo flute), and *bedhug* (large drum). Snouck reports that the troupe had many imitators around the Banten region, but because its comedy offended "certain European civil servants," it could no longer be performed by the 1880s (Snouck Hurgronje trans. Kunst 1973, 1:289–290).³⁰

Related popular theaters arrived in waves to Batavia, but most were banned by the local authorities because of their associations with licentiousness and fears of politically subversive content. *Abdul Muluk* (also referred to as *dulmuluk* or *komedi Abdul Muluk*), a popular theater associated today with South Sumatra (Dumas 2000), was banned in Batavia in 1881 or 1882, although underground performances seem to have persisted for some time.³¹ A variant of bangsawan theater, referred to in Batavia as *wayang Persi* (Parsi theater), was banned in Batavia in 1890, though its catchy tunes (*lagu Persi*) remained in the repertoire of urban musical ensembles into the twentieth century.³²



Commercial wayang wong troupe from Sunda performing in Batavia. Note the perspective in the painted backdrop on bamboo poles and the masks worn by the actor-dancers. Postcard published by G. Kolff & Co., c. 1900, in the author's collection.

Less controversial was a Chinese youth theater known in one source as *wayang cerita* or “story theater” (Tio I. S. [1958] 2002, 392–393). Troupes performed in Chinese neighborhoods in Bogor and Batavia and in the courtyards of the houses of the wealthy during the Chinese New Year season. A cast of boys and girls sang poetic settings of popular tales—Arabian Nights stories, Chinese legends such as the tale of the butterfly lovers Sampek and Engtay, and tales by Sino-Malay writers such as Tan Kiet Tjoan’s *Saier boeroeng* (Bird poem, 1871). They were accompanied by a gambang kromong ensemble and played against the background of a painted backdrop stretched between two bamboo poles. Even though patrons paid 75 to 100 guilders to hire the troupe, Lie Kimhok, a leading Chinese businessman and writer who directed a company as a youth, claimed that it was not theater-for-profit, but a form of charity for its impoverished Chinese actors.

Commercial Wayang Wong

A more enduring theater genre that enthused Batavia and other towns of western Java was a commercialized version of *wayang wong* known today as *wayang wong panggung* (“staged” wayang wong). It too was eventually banned by Batavia’s authorities, though not permanently. Some historians attribute the creation of

commercial wayang wong to Gan Kam, a Chinese impresario who launched a troupe in Surakarta in 1894.³³ But although Gan Kam's company might well have been the most famous one operating in the 1890s, it was preceded by a number of commercial companies from the Sundanese highlands and Cirebon from the 1880s.³⁴

These West Javanese companies mostly modeled themselves on Mangkunegaran-style wayang wong by importing teachers from Surakarta. The Mangkunegaran royal court had experienced a sharp decrease in production of wayang wong after 1887 due to a decline in its financial health. The court's overreliance on cash crops for the export market meant that coffee diseases and a global dip in the price of sugar brought a financial crisis so dire that the Dutch Resident was forced to take charge of the Mangkunegaran court's businesses between 1888 and 1899 (Ricklefs 2001, 166). Unlike the kraton of Yogyakarta, the Mangkunegaran did not retain wayang wong as an exclusive heirloom (*pusaka*) of the royal court. Through the court's largesse, immaculately trained court performers were relieved of their duties and then permitted to transmit wayang wong and other courtly arts outside the court's walls. As a result, wayang wong could flourish under the patronage of other members of Surakarta's nobility, who formed their own companies (Wiradat 1960, 363). It was not long before aristocrats in other parts of the island followed suit.

A report from a correspondent to *Bintang Soerabaia* published in 1888 mentions West Javanese wayang wong companies in the Mangkunegaran style directed by the regents of Manonjaya (Tasikmalaya), Garut, and Bandung.³⁵ Casts were made up of boys studying in local schools. Dialogue was in Javanese, a prestige language for Sunda's elites, though sometimes the clown characters spoke in the vernacular Sundanese. Productions were essentially the efforts of dedicated amateurs imbibing the high culture of Surakarta to achieve social esteem. According to the correspondent, the lack of female performers made performances "not sufficiently sweet, like cake without enough sugar." However, a Chinese-owned troupe touring the marketplaces of the Sukabumi district had different aspirations. It was a commercial troupe that used equipment purchased from a deputy tax collector who had earlier sponsored a private company. Shows were "closed off like *abdul muluk* and people enter by paying. It is novel and humorous for it uses 4 or 5 or maybe 6 girls [in the cast]." The indecorous social atmosphere was quite in contrast with the regency performances, and some male spectators in Sukabumi even brought female escorts.

The success of the Chinese-owned troupe in Sukabumi encouraged Chinese impresarios in cities and towns around the Sundanese highlands to form similar wayang wong companies. Troupes naturally gravitated to Batavia with its large

populations of Sundanese and Javanese migrants who had flooded the city since the end of the Cultivation System in 1870. In 1890 Batavia experienced a veritable wayang wong craze, with at least three troupes playing nightly on temporary stages erected around the city's center for ticket-purchasing audiences, as well as troupes that played occasionally in Chinese opera theaters and that could also be hired for private functions.

The commercial wayang wong was a very different form of theater from the grand spectacles performed in the gazebos of Yogyakarta and Surakarta's royal courts. Although one troupe's stage is described as "well decorated and clean like a Chinese opera stage at a rich Chinese wedding," dancing was curtailed and there was a greater emphasis on story.³⁶ As one contemporary report notes, "Spectators like fast-paced plots and not long battle scenes."³⁷ Indonesian anthropologist and dance expert Koentjaraningrat (1985, 305) relates how

in the early days of the *wayang wong panggung*, the stage was of course very limited in terms of decoration and lighting techniques, while the dances were also very simplified, due to the limited spaces. Less dance movements were therefore necessary; the actors only needed to appear from behind the curtains, take up their positions on the stage, and act. When their parts were finished, they only had to do one or two dance steps and disappear again behind the side curtains. The simplification of the dance on the *panggung* stage also caused the actions, gestures, and dialogues to become less stylized, compared to the performances in the spacious *pendhapa*.

Audiences were composed of men and women from all of Batavia's ethnic groups. Male and female spectators alike fell madly in love with the glamorous performers, showering them with gifts and attention. Just as sponsors customarily supplied costume items and other accoutrements to topeng performers (cf. Serrurier [1896] 1993, 190), fans enthusiastically loaned wayang wong performers bracelets, necklaces, and earrings to beautify their idols' stage appearances, along with large mirrors for applying powder and paint, and curtains for decorating stages.³⁸ Dancers emulated the current theatrical fashion. The costumes of a pair of mannequins of wayang wong dancers in the collection of Leiden's Volkenkunde Museum (1309-1, 1309-2) purchased in Batavia circa 1890 are festooned with gaudy glass beads and sport white socks, sartorial influences from the Parsi theater. Articles by *Bintang barat*'s reporters and correspondents describe favorite performers and companies, warn of false advertising, castigate fellow spectators for bad behavior, and praise and condemn the quality of seats.

There was also mounting concern about the impact of the theater on audiences. A Bantenese fan was overheard by a *Bintang barat* correspondent exclaiming on the street after a show, “I would rather divorce my wife than divorce myself from wayang wong, because the image of the performer playing Karna always is in my eyes.” The correspondent questions whether such dedication might be a result of the same sort of sorcery associated with *abdul muluk* and *wayang Persi* and deliberates about whether wayang wong should similarly be banned.³⁹ Letters to *Bintang barat* written in September and October 1890 complain of the theater breaking up marriages, linking it to prostitution and fighting. Wayang wong was said to deplete the pockets of the poor, make police neglect their duties, and cause houses to be empty, therefore making them susceptible to robbery. The newspaper also published an article about a politically subversive wayang wong performance in east Java in which a trial was enacted on stage in imitation of the proceedings of the *landraad* (district council), resulting in the troupe’s permit being withdrawn.⁴⁰

A stigma grew around this popularized form of court art, a tarnish that remained for decades. Koentjaraningrat describes how in the 1930s and 1940s, when he was studying court dance in Yogyakarta, his teachers considered wayang wong actors to be “degenerate entertainers, who sold their art for money (*tiyang mbarang*), and thereby violated the so-called highly sacred values of the classical court art (*kagunan adi luhung*)” (1985, 305).⁴¹ Soeharda Sastrasoeuwignja (1934–1935) complains that wayang wong attracts audiences by “lazy means” through its focus on humor and relations between the sexes, or what school kids call “free love”—*preliep-preliepan* in Dutch. He further casts aspersions on both the moral and intellectual quality of performers.

The colonial government announced that it would place a ban on wayang wong in Batavia, Bogor, and Sukabumi starting on 31 October 1890, giving no clear reason. There was discontent among supporters of the theater about this proclamation. *Bintang barat* editorialized, “We feel this theater is no different than wayang kulit or French or Italian drama. Each people has its own theater and all enact stories of the past which cause spectators to have refined and clear ideas.”⁴² Chinese impresarios protested that, although performers could take up employment in other fields, such as *tayuban*, owners had invested in equipment that could not be redeployed. Bans were a disincentive to artistic patronage, and this ban in particular would cause prospective impresarios to support social dance forms linked to prostitution rather than legitimate theater.⁴³ After the final performances of wayang wong, *Bintang barat* opined, “There is no happiness in a city without soothing entertainment. People await performances to come, other than those currently on offer.”⁴⁴

Conclusion to Part I: Expanding Creative Possibilities

With the incorporation of Indonesian societies into capitalist modernity, traditional cultural legitimations of political order either broke down or were radically changed. Arts embedded in ritual economies were secularized and rationalized. We have seen that the purpose of Chinese opera, for example, changed from serving as a status ornament and ritual offering to unseen spirits to being commercial entertainment in public theaters. Javanese palace arts were likewise democratized, with the once-sacrosanct wayang wong transformed into a dynamic popular theater. Driven by the growth of education, by social change, and by technological innovation, old art forms were renovated and hybridized with markers of cosmopolitan modernity—srimpi dancers wielded decanters and pistols, trained monkeys enacted ancient mask dances, Ambonese folk songs were arranged with European harmonies, wayang plays were published in scholarly editions, and ancient Malay tales were adapted as stage drama.

Traditional artistic forms and practices persisted, but they were now being written about critically in newspapers, transcribed in scholarly tomes, subjected to colonial regulations, repackaged as commercial entertainment, revised to impress European guests, and hybridized with modern cultural technologies. In the following years, tradition's modernization was to force "productive kinds of strangeness and distance: a new consciousness of conventions and thus of changeable, because now open, conventions" (Williams [1989] 2007, 46).

The nineteenth century brought about an expansion of creative possibilities through the importation and creation of new cultural forms, which brought with them new rules for the circulation and management of performing arts. The routinization of time and the marriage of capital and labor (cf. Bauman 2000, 116) in urban centers and peripheral regions made possible a commercial entertainment sector, with public theaters catering to multiethnic audiences, traveling side shows, brass bands for hire, novel puppet theaters, and traveling circuses that played to audiences of thousands. Cities and towns became "extension[s] of an organized global market in the new cultural technologies" (Williams [1989] 2007, 38).

"The world of 'traditional society' is one of traditional *societies*, in which cultural pluralism takes the form of an extraordinary diversity of mores and customs—each of which, however, exists in privileged space" (Beck, Giddens, and Lash 1994, 104). Performing arts in premodern Indonesia were distributed in ethnically marked spaces. Chinese opera was staged in Chinese neighborhoods and temples, courtly dances in noble residences and palaces, spoken drama in

European clubs and theaters, and so on. Yet these cultural spaces were not fully exclusive. Large-scale celebrations might be engineered by one ethnic group or class, but solicited active participation from all. Only Dayak participants wore masks in the feast of *totong kapala* as celebrated in a village in central Kalimantan in 1891, but the Chinese and Malays living there shared in the drinking and feasting (Schadee 1910, 478–482). Celebrations of Cioko in Manado were organized by Chinese, but it was a public holiday involving the entire mixed population without coercion and “without a single case of riot or disorder,” to the astonishment of English zoologist Sydney John Hickson (1889, 343), who witnessed the carnivalesque proceedings in this North Sulawesi town in 1885.

In contrast, in the emerging metropolitan super-culture, “cultural pluralism” no longer took “the form of separated centres of embedded power” (Beck, Giddens, and Lash 1994, 104–105). The popular theater troupes of the 1880s, whether performing wayang wong in western Java or Malay epics on Sumatra’s west coast, conducted business outside of the established power structures. Circuses, animal and freak shows, and acrobatic entertainments did not operate in privileged spaces, but were enacted in the public sphere in which different value systems competed and friction and strife were common, often leading to censure or bans by local authorities. It was a competitive and risky marketplace. Industrial modernity “permanently gave the owners of capital, the business middle class, the right to permanent innovation” (26), not only in the production of goods but also of popular entertainment. “Change, unstoppable and uncontrollable, something that appeared completely inconceivable, even blasphemous, to earlier periods, now comes to be taken for granted” (26). Those who ignored the modern needs for innovation and novelty risked artistic failure and economic demise.

The Maelstrom of Modernity

“Protecting and ennobling our family pusaka”

The memoirs of politician Achmad Djajadiningrat (1936, 35–40) relate a poignant moment of deliberation from the author’s childhood years in Pandegelang in West Java. The son of a *priyayi* blue-blooded elite who rose through the ranks of the colonial civil service to end his career as regent of Serang, Djajadiningrat was privileged to attend a modern Dutch-language elementary school, while also studying at a traditional Qur’anic school. As a pastime, he danced in the regency’s *topeng* troupe, whose young dancers—aged 8 to 11—included members of the regent’s family and other children of favored regency officials. In this part of western Java at this time, *topeng* was considered an aristocratic art, upheld by the regent as a sacred heirloom or *pusaka*; the formation of a mask-dance troupe also served to maintain social harmony among the regency’s rivalrous elites. A guru was hired to teach Djajadiningrat and the other children to dance, and this instruction included associated esoteric practices: Djajadiningrat mentions stretching exercises for the neck and fingers conducted during the morning bath, preferably in a spring. Seeing Djajadiningrat’s potential as a dancer, the guru gave him a great deal of personal attention, training him in solo mask performance with a focus on the specialist role of the virile warrior Klana.

An invitation to perform at a tooth-filing ceremony in a neighboring regency brought acclaim and pride to the young Djajadiningrat—loans of jewelry from the regent’s wife for the boy to wear while dancing and much *sawer*, or showers of coins, that, as Djajadiningrat explains, “can be equated to applause for Westerners” (1936, 38). An encore battle dance, which pitted Djajadiningrat in the role of Klana against Klana’s arch-foe Panji, was interrupted suddenly by a spectator who hugged the two children. It was Djajadiningrat’s revered uncle, a devout Muslim and the boy’s teacher in Qur’anic recitation. In his uncle’s embrace, Djajadiningrat asked, “Is it not a sin to dance like this, Uncle?” “A sin, for sure, son! But the Lord will forgive you, for you are protecting and ennobling our family *pusaka*. When your father was your age, he also was an able dancer” (39).

Returning to Pandegelang bearing gifts from the regent and his wife, Djajadiningrat mulled over his future. Writing with heavy irony in Dutch, Djajadiningrat mused, “What is the use of the Dutch language to me? I will never be able to study it to a high level of proficiency. Wouldn’t I be better off becoming a professional topeng dancer? A dancer’s wages amount to much more than the salary of a clerk” (1936, 39–40).

The young Djajadiningrat could hardly anticipate at this moment, circa 1890, the radical changes that would soon transform him and the world around him. The patronage he would receive from Dutch intellectuals, including the noted Islamicist and colonial administrator Christiaan Snouck Hurgronje, was simply without precedent. This support brought access to higher education and led to Djajadiningrat’s appointment as the regent of Batavia and to a seat in the *Volksraad*, a consultative body made up of non-European elites created in 1916 by the colonial state as a sop to Indonesian aspirations for independence. Among Djajadiningrat’s accomplishments in the cultural field was the fashioning of the *Pasar Gambir* as an annual celebration of arts and culture. His brother, Hussein Djajadiningrat, also was a beneficiary of Snouck’s patronage. Hussein became the first Javanese Muslim to receive a PhD from Leiden University (with a dissertation on Banten’s chronicle literature, completed in 1913); in 1919 he cofounded the Java Institute, a learned society established together with other Dutch and Javanese intellectuals to document, preserve, and develop the arts and culture of Java and adjacent islands through publications, conferences, museum exhibitions, and innovative performances.

Both Djajadiningrat brothers were fiercely devoted to tradition and did much to promote the arts and culture of Banten in particular. They were simultaneously inventive actors and agents who made themselves “somehow at home in the modern maelstrom” (Berman [1982] 2010, 345) of colonial modernity. British historian Christopher Bayly describes the quarter-century after 1890 as “the great acceleration” when capitalism “moved into a new and final phase of monopoly and imperialism” involving “the growing velocity of international connections, and the rise of Western dominance and challenges to that dominance” (2004, 451). These years saw the invention and “extensional spread” (Beck, Giddens, and Lash 1994, 57) of the wireless, film companies, airplanes, motorcars, and institutions of modern life, as well as growing connections among Asian elites. Modernity was associated less with nations than with “institutions and ways of thinking. [. . .]. Deterritorialized from its spatial associations,” discourse on modernity was “transportable across geographic or cultural boundaries” (Dirlik 2007, 77).

The period after 1890 yielded diverse political, technological, and aesthetic changes in the performing arts. A transethnic popular Malay-language musical

theater called *komedi stambul* opened a new window to the world through its modern techniques, structure of feeling, and diverse repertoire, much of it based on Western literary sources and songs (Cohen 2006). Dutch-language dramas about the European experience of Indonesia were written and performed, influencing the emergence of spoken drama in Malay and other languages of the archipelago, and giving new ways to represent experiences, identities, and social milieus. *Pasar malam*, nighttime fairs with entertainment, food, and displays of industry, provided a new commercial context for the arts and fashioned consumers out of its attendees. Western classical music was taken up by elites, phonographic recordings and radio gave access to diverse world musics, and itinerant musicians—refugees from the Russian Revolution, touring Hawaiian bands, Filipino jazz bands—brought about new and hybrid musical forms and cosmopolitan sentiments. Dutch intellectuals and Javanese elites banded together to defend and revivify traditional arts, perceived as being under threat by modernity. Arts were taught at schools to develop moral character and an appreciation of culture. Bali, which had (mostly) escaped colonization through the nineteenth century, was turned into a “living museum,” and its sacred arts opened up for touristic consumption. Cinema, initially derided as “dead wayang” (*wayang mati*), came into competition with live theater and also inspired new theaters such as *tonil* and *kethoprak*. Nationalists wrote anthems and plays for political congresses and imagined the nation-in-formation in cultural terms.

Modern Drama, Spoken and Sung

The new cultural era began humbly in January 1891 with the founding of a Malay-language commercial theater troupe in a Chinese-owned theater in the east Javanese port city of Surabaya (Cohen 2006). The actors in this troupe—which occupied the same stage as Chinese opera companies, Javanese and Madurese topeng troupes, and Italian magicians—were impoverished Indos. Many were from Surabaya’s Krambangan slum and spoke Malay as a first language. Some worked part time in the civil guard and might have played in the guard’s marching band. Plays were based on the Arabian Nights.¹ The association with these tales provided the troupe with its name, Komedi Stamboel: *stambul* being the Malay word for Istanbul, capital of the Ottoman Empire, and a sign of all things Near Eastern. (The Turkish fez was also known in Malay as a *stambul*.)

Musical accompaniment initially was provided by the Italian Quintet, a *strijkje* (string band) under the direction of a certain Signor Prati. This ensemble, familiar to all Surabayan lovers of ballroom dance, played selections of its repertoire of marches, waltzes, polkas, and operatic excerpts by Strauss and Bellini. Malay song lyrics were fitted to European musical standards. One actor who performed *stambul* in the 1910s and 1920s recalled enacting love scenes backed by Romanian composer Ion Ivanovici’s waltz “Waves of the Danube” (1880) and singing songs in the role of an evil genie to the melody of John Philip Sousa’s march “Stars and Stripes Forever” (1897) (Tan T. B. 1971). Original tunes were also composed, and *kroncong* tunes became part of the repertoire after musicians from Batavia joined the troupe during an 1892 tour to the capital.

The Komedi Stamboel’s wing-and-drop scenery and its curtain falls dividing plays into scenes and acts drew on conventions of both European and Parsi theater. The influence of Parsi theater can be seen particularly in its splendid costumes—sequins, gold thread, white socks—and what actors called *ladon-diladon* (Tan T. B. 1971), the practice of characters introducing themselves in a direct address sung to the audience on their first appearances.²

Komedi *stambul*, as a theater that “emerged from and was prepared for bourgeois capitalism” (Effendi 1948, 28), was without precedent in Indonesia. At the



Komedi stambul circa 1905 in a postcard published by Tio Tek Hong. Note the perspective in the painted backdrop depicting a European town square and the richly embroidered costumes. Image courtesy of Olivier Johannes Raap.

time of the Komedie Stamboel's founding, Surabaya was the largest city in the Indies. Its dynamic port society was characterized by a cultural diversity of the sort described by cultural critic Raymond Williams as the "miscellaneity of the metropolis," a condition conducive to the growth of creative cultural institutions. Williams notes that "within both the miscellaneity of the metropolis—which in the course of capitalist and imperialist development had characteristically attracted a very mixed population, from a variety of social and cultural origins—and its concentration of wealth and thus opportunities for patronage, such groups could hope to attract, indeed to form, new kinds of audience" ([1989] 2007, 45). The Komedie Stamboel's audience was largely Chinese in its first months of operation. Many were perhaps drawn by the novelty of seeing beautiful, white-skinned Indo actresses acting in "low" Malay. However, tensions between the Komedie Stamboel's Chinese management and its Indo performers, including accusations of sexual abuse, meant a rocky start for the fledgling company, with frequent turnover of personnel. But the Komedie Stamboel was avidly supported from the start by the city's Dutch- and Malay-language newspapers, which sometimes depicted it as a form of charity for the impoverished performers and a way to lift the status of Indos more generally. It was not long before audiences diversified to include all the ethnic groups of the city.

When the company outgrew the capacity of the modest theater in Surabaya's Doro district, a new, purpose-built theater in more upmarket Kapasan was erected, again with Chinese financing, with a larger auditorium and an orchestra pit and café. Before it opened in August 1891, new backdrops were painted by Lépinat, the concierge and *decorateur* of Semarang's schouwburg who also ran a

carousel concession and performed Dutch-language puppet shows for children. The repertoire expanded with an adaptation of Charles Gounod's opera *Faust* (1859). Plays were only partially scripted by the company's actor-directors, leaving room for improvisation.

The Komedie Stamboel is sometimes depicted as the creation of Auguste Mahieu, the Indo actor-director and musician who was the company's second and longest-serving director. Mahieu was the son of a low-ranking civil servant born in Bangkalan, Madura. He was educated at Surabaya's Dutch-language high school (Hoogere Burgerschool or HBS), where he was exposed to European drama (one account describes him reading Corneille, Racine, and Molière) and perhaps participated in school music and drama clubs. There is no evidence, however, of any professional theatrical activity before he joined the Komedie Stamboel as an actor. Innately talented, Mahieu quickly achieved fame for his beautiful singing voice, comic acting, skills as a violinist and guitarist, and magnetic (some would say demonic) powers of attraction. He was a gifted composer; all the standard stambul tunes, one of which was controversially adopted as Malaysia's national anthem, are attributed to him.

Mahieu was also an inventive dramatist. He fashioned a huge repertoire of plays out of European fairy tales (e.g., *Bluebeard*, *Sleeping Beauty*, *Snow White*) and opera (*Norma*, *La Sonnambula*, *Genoveva*, *Aida*), adapted bangsawan and Parsi theater plays, and also scripted original plays, including ones based on contemporary political events. The "true crime" plays Mahieu composed and adapted for the stage—based on serialized fiction and popular journalism in newspapers and on Batavia legends such as *Nyai Dasima*—might be the first "realist" drama in Malay.

Mahieu promoted the idea that komedi stambul should be considered "Malay opera" (*opera Melayu*) of equivalent status to European opera. This was done initially to avoid Batavia's entertainment taxes, from which opera was exempt, but later became a statement of Eurasian pride. In 1900 he joined the Indies League (Indische Bond), an association established in 1898 to advocate for greater rights for permanent European residents of the Indies (*blijvers*) over temporary residents (*trekkers*) and to provide economic support for poor Indos. Mahieu performed charity benefits and created propaganda plays on the league's behalf.

Just as instrumental as Mahieu in the Komedie Stamboel's invention was a figure mentioned in advertisements as the troupe's "owner" (*eigenaar*), until Mahieu bought out the company in 1894. This was the Chinese impresario, pharmaceutical mogul, and fireworks maker Yap Gwan Thay (Cohen 2009b).

Yap operated behind the scenes in a manner typical of Java's Chinese, serving as a cosmopolitan broker of global capitalist modernity (cf. Strassler 2010, 14). He had a particular genius for reverse engineering, essential for translating imported European and Parsi theater techniques and technologies to the local context. Fueled by a characteristically Chinese passion for all "things modern" (cf. Dikötter 2007), Yap ordered theater lamps from Europe and acquired specialized equipment such as a magic lantern and a phonograph. Although Yap was a cultural and technological visionary, his financial state was often precarious, and he served prison time for debts and counterfeiting charges. Yet his wide-ranging business networks facilitated the troupe's transformation from Kapasan's resident company to a touring company visiting towns and cities around Java and the larger Malay world. In this way, the *Komedi Stamboel* sparked an archipelago-wide theater movement.

Komedi Stambul and Its Structure of Feeling

The multiethnic troupes that sprang up in close imitation of the *Komedi Stamboel* were legion,³ and their aesthetic uniformity allowed personnel and equipment to transfer easily between them; however, most were short-lived. For the numerous towns and small cities of Java and other parts of the Indies, the arrival of a stambul company was an event in itself. Posters went up on walls and other public spaces, circulars were distributed, people stopped to watch the tent's erection in a town square. Audiences marveled at many a troupe's ethnic "mixture of actors including Chinese, Dutch, Arabs, Javanese and Indians."⁴ There was likewise social electricity, and occasionally friction from the people mixing in the auditorium, which cut across colonial society's customary divides of ethnicity, class, and sex.

With money pouring into this commercial theater from ticket sales and wealthy backers, and the increased exposure of spectators to realism in European theater, panoramic displays, and illustrative art, *komedi stambul* progressed toward an aesthetic of spectacular realism (cf. Schwartz 1998). A newspaper review explicitly likened a stambul company's roomy, clean, and well-lit theater tent "to the frame of a picture as drawn by a guru at the pinnacle of his abilities."⁵ The lit proscenium stage and the often elaborate tableaux vivants concluding performances displayed technical virtuosity.⁶ Advertisements mentioned the tableaux, which constituted a major audience draw. Scenes from myth and history depicting the beheading of French naval officer Henri Revière in Vietnam, Adam and Eve's expulsion from paradise, and the sea god Neptune on his throne gave flesh

to book illustrations and prints. The oft-repeated eruption of Mount Krakatau featured “volcanic ash, flashes of lightening, sea tremors and earth quakes, praying country people; all appeared natural and just right.”⁷ Such tableaux, as much as stambul’s plays, assisted in the pictorial conceptualization of the world, a hallmark of modernity (cf. Cohen 2005b, 22–27; Heidegger 1977; Mitchell 2000).

Newspaper correspondents and reporters wrote with excitement about komedi stambul, interweaving descriptions and evaluations of performances with comments on roughhousing and thefts at the theater. Some complained that komedi stambul fell short of European professional theater’s standards and advocated for more rehearsal time, quicker set changes, fresher costumes, and better trained voices. Critics demanded emotional expressivity and a type of realism new to the Malay stage: “When she was reunited with her husband, whom she thought had been killed, I felt she was overly cold in balance. [. . .] When a woman meets a husband who she greatly loves, she ought to show her love with a thankful heart and happiness. She ought to feel compelled to hug him.”⁸

From the beginning there were frequent criticisms of unruly behavior among both spectators and actors and calls for greater police presence and restrictions on the consumption of alcohol. On the back of a celebrated shooting and murder, as well as numerous other infractions and misdeeds, newspaper writers called for bans to be imposed on komedi stambul which were in fact occasionally implemented by local colonial and religious authorities. Discourse on theater’s turpitude provided a way for “polite” sectors of society to define ethical norms; the stambul actor was held up as a negative instance of how *not* to behave.⁹

Drawing again on Raymond Williams, we can read in komedi stambul criticism an incipient “structure of feeling,” “an organic connection between dramatic feeling and dramatic method” that is a sign of “a highly developed kind of drama” (1968, 51–52). According to Williams, in a “developed” or “mature” theater (as opposed to transitional or ephemeral ones), speech, action, scenography, and dramaturgy are one. Meaning and moral pattern are “wholly and vitally present,” and “a compelling feeling, at once individual and general” can be apprehended and appreciated by all theatrical participants—players and spectators alike. A structure of feeling involves “meaning and values as they are actively lived and felt [. . .] social experiences in *solution*, as distinct from other social semantic formations which have been *precipitated* and are more evidently and more immediately available” (Williams 1977, 132–134). Komedi stambul’s structure of feeling came to inform ceremonies, speech making, advertisements, and the whole panoply of public culture in Indonesia. It rarely “precipitated” or became the subject of scholarly reflection in its time, but its influence was pervasive nonetheless.

Chinese opera beginning with the innovative Langen Ngesthi Suka troupe, founded in Surakarta in 1894 by Chinese impresario Gan Kam, used realistically painted backdrops, false perspective sets, flying rigs, fireworks, stage magic, and spectacular scenic effects in stambul style.¹⁰ Wayang wong also took on many stambul trappings (Brandts Buys and Brandts Buys-van Zijp 1926, 99). *Ludruk* (also spelled *ludrug*), a raucous all-male comical folk theater practiced in rural East Java (Poensen 1866, 53–66), evolved into a popular urban theater in Surabaya under the influence of stambul’s structure of feeling. The costumes and makeup of *ludruk*’s female impersonators in earlier times were grotesque, designed to evoke a laugh on “her” first appearance (56). In contrast, the costumes worn by urban youth in 1894 were “very fine indeed,” and by 1900 one Surabaya *ludruk* troupe was lauded for costumes decorated in stambul-style with gold thread and embroidery.¹¹ Although some companies appear to have been ad hoc in organization—one was made up of waiters from a restaurant in Surabaya’s Pasar Besar market—others were Chinese-managed and sported such suggestive names as Komedi Haroem Boekit (Fragrant Hills Theater), with graceful female impersonators renowned for their fine singing voices.¹²

Stambul and Bangsawan

Komedi stambul itself underwent significant changes starting around 1900 when the genre effectively fused with bangsawan. The pivotal troupe was the wildly popular Indra Zanibar, also known as Wayang Kassim after its Indian Muslim owner Bai Kassim or S. Kassim (also spelled “Kasim”).¹³ Kassim’s company was reputedly founded in Penang in 1883 (cf. van der Putten 2014, 273) and toured extensively around the entire Malay world starting in the 1890s. Its diverse repertoire featured Parsi theater standards such as *Hawai Majilis*, true crime stories, Shakespeare, Malay tales, Arabian Nights plays, Javanese legends, and Chinese stories like the famous tale of the butterfly lovers, *Sampek Engtay*. The troupe had at least forty company members and, by 1902, an English agent named Thomas Edward.¹⁴ It performed in public theaters as well as at the palaces of the sultan of Pontianak, the sultan of Johor, and the king of Siam.

Wayang Kassim emphasized magical and spectacular scenic effects. Some were engineered by the troupe’s magician, a certain Sorab or Zorab, who also sometimes did magic shows on Thursday nights, a “dark” night for bangsawan theater. A carriage flew through the sky, pulled by flying geese; a dancer performed with a brazier of fire on her head. A 1911 production showed a “view of the bottom of the sea with mermaids swimming about” (Tan S. B. 1993, 41). Wayang Kassim appears to have been the first Malay troupe to include “extra-turns” inserted

between acts and scenes of plays. This practice started around 1902. We read how “in the intermission, a woman flew through the air and did summersaults, just like the acrobatics in the Harmston Circus.”¹⁵ In 1903, the company added a “set of dances by eight of the company” as an attraction (Tan S. B. 1993, 44). Later items included a cakewalk, a Hungarian dance, a Cossack dance, and a sailor dance (38). Among its many novel performers who performed extra turns were “Lolita, the graceful and charming Spanish dancer” and “the youngest clown in the world” who was “only five years old” (38, 61). The company emulated and borrowed to cater to modern aspirations to be “up with the times” (Bayly 2004, 10).

In August 1901, Auguste Mahieu’s komedi stambul company, known at this time as Sinar India (Light of the Indies), toured in Borneo, where it went bankrupt. Under duress, Mahieu and other members of his company joined a Chinese-owned bangsawan company called Komedi Bangsawan Kioe Kong Hap. Around February 1902, an agent for Wayang Kassim went to Pontianak and recruited Mahieu and other company members. Mahieu and his colleagues then traveled to Singapore and went with Kassim’s troupe to Java, performing with Indra Zanibar in Batavia and Semarang from April to September 1902. Mahieu was appointed music director and played leading roles to great acclaim. Many of the plays formerly unique to Sinar India, including Mahieu’s star vehicle *Ali and the Magical Violin*, were presented, and Sinar India’s entire musical repertoire was thereby transferred to Wayang Kassim. The company garnered rave reviews, but illness haunted the ranks. Mahieu left the troupe before it arrived in Surabaya in October 1902 to restart his own company. Ill health dogged Mahieu, however, and he died of malaria while touring the backwaters of central Java in January 1903.

The designations “bangsawan” and “komedi stambul” became more or less interchangeable after the success of Wayang Kassim; the same troupe might be described as either form in advertisements and press reports, depending on where it performed. The term “stambul” continued to be used after Mahieu’s death all the way until the Japanese occupation under the stewardship of actor-directors such as Wim Kramer, Willem Hunter, Rudolf Hoogeveen, and Marie Oord, some of whom had acted under Mahieu. Famous stambul troupe owners included the Medan-born “Dja’far Turki” (Jafar the Turk), who sat watch next to the box office during performances with a pistol behind his back, and a Jewish impresario named Manok, owner of Orpheus Opera (Pasaribu 1955, 59; Tan T. B. 1971). But homegrown Malay opera companies became stagnant creatively and were outclassed consistently by bangsawan troupes from the Malaysian peninsula such as Indra Zanibar, Royal Opera Poesi Indra Bangsawan, and the Malay Opera of Malacca.

A Reflex of Infamy: The *Indische Toneel* and the First “Straight” Malay-Language Drama

James Brandon (1967, 39) famously characterized spoken drama as Southeast Asia’s “non-popular theatre.” For much of the twentieth century, spoken drama was the preserve of dedicated amateurs in search of a means of self-expression and actualization and of intellectuals curious to explore the aesthetic possibilities of Western dramaturgies and associated philosophical and rhetorical concepts, such as irony. Spoken drama’s audience appeal was limited, at least until the innovations of Miss Riboet’s *Orion* and *Dardanella* of the 1920s. Regardless, spoken drama offers vital insights into processes of identity formation and particularly how structures and ideas of modernity were creatively negotiated, internalized, or rejected.

Spoken-language drama in Dutch preceded the emergence of spoken drama in Malay and other Indonesian languages. In 1900, there were two dedicated art critics writing for Batavia’s Dutch-language newspapers. One of them, Otto Knaap, soon left for Europe, frustrated by the dilettantism, mediocrity, and provincialism of European art in the colonial capital. The other, Hans van de Wall, decided that year to make a cultural intervention. Van de Wall was born in Surabaya, the son of a European bookkeeper and an Indo mother.¹⁶ An inheritance allowed him to attend gymnasium in Delft, but homesick for the Indies, he returned to Java to take over the editorship of a floundering Batavia newspaper. The paper went under despite his diligence. Van de Wall then founded a weekly, but this lasted little more than a year. An enthusiast for komedi stambul and theater more generally, van de Wall then hit on the idea of directing and producing a naturalist drama at Batavia’s schouwburg together with J. A. van Dijk, a fellow art lover and attorney recently arrived from the Netherlands. Their production of W. G. van Nieuhuys’ three-act play *Eerloos* (1892, *Infamous*), about a government tax collector robbed by his son, was an unexpected hit and proved that there was an audience in Batavia for serious social drama in the Dutch language.

Van de Wall went on to a distinguished career as a playwright and director under the *nom du stage* of Victor Ido creating work for the *Indische toneel*, Dutch-language realist drama set in the Indies, a dramatic genre that blossomed during the first quarter of the twentieth century (Baay 1998).¹⁷ Its plays were tropical projections of European modern drama.¹⁸ European playwrights born or living in the Indies drew on their personal experience of colonial life to pen social dramas dealing with issues confronting Europeans in the Dutch Indies—class strife, prejudice toward men of mixed race, the *nyai* or unofficial wife of a European man, unfettered capitalism, social isolation, and intergenerational conflict.

The most commercially successful of the Indies drama playwrights was Jan Fabricius (1871–1964) (Berg 2000). Fabricius was born in the small town of Assen in the north of Holland, the son of a printing press foreman. He worked as a newspaperman in Java starting in 1898 and wrote plays for amateur companies before returning to the Netherlands in 1914 where he established himself as a commercial playwright. By 1915 Fabricius' plays were being produced professionally in Amsterdam and other cities around the Netherlands and within a short time were being translated into German, French, English and other European languages. His plays, and Indies drama in general, indulge in racist stereotypes. There are few indigenous or Chinese characters in his plays, and even fewer with psychological depth. One critic described the titular Indo character in *Totok en Indo* (Pure blood and Indo) as “good at heart, ludicrous, sentimental, responsible for all the laughs on stage, especially through the mixed prattle used by him and his friend Cornellis” (February 1991, 56). When performed in Surabaya, Eurasians protested Fabricius' demeaning stereotypes.

The plays of Victor Ido are exceptional in the corpus of *Indische toneel* because they offer intimate portraits of Eurasians and indigenous Javanese. Ido was not strong on plotting, and his dialogue tended to be bombastic. In the opinion of Dutch critic Rob Nieuwenhuys (1998, 142), “most of what he wrote is unreadable and horribly dated, romancing daggers, murder, poison and pistol shots, passionate sobs, and cries of ‘Ampoen Toean Allah, ampoen!’ (Forgive me, Lord! Forgive me!).”¹⁹ The vividly sketched Javanese settings of Ido's plays, however, make them of greater interest than other Dutch-language playwrights to readers and theater makers today. His most popular play was *Karina Adinda* (1913), about the modern-minded daughter of a Javanese regent torn between duty to the custom of arranged marriage and her love of a Dutch government inspector.²⁰ The eponymous central character is based on Kartini (1879–1904), the daughter of the regent of Jepara and a feminist whose posthumously published letters made her a cause célèbre in the Netherlands and the colony. Ido had a dedicated following in the Netherlands. Het Vaderlandsch Tooneel (Patriotic Theater)—founded in The Hague in 1933 to create ties between the Netherlands and the Indies by producing Indies drama plays—focused on Ido's work. *Karina Adinda* was widely performed in a Malay translation by Chinese editor and journalist Lauw Giok Lan that was published circa 1916, but few, if any, of Ido's plays were translated from Dutch into other European languages, perhaps because of their cultural specificity.

Although Ido's plays show an understanding of the dynamics of Javanese society, most Indies dramas testify to Dutch colonial insularity. These period dramas do not look outward to the ethnic diversity of the Indies and the archipelago's



The Regent of Wiriosari (played by J. A. van Dijk) rebukes his daughter Raden Ajeng Karina Adinda in a scene from Victor Ido's *Karina Adinda* (1913). Photograph from Collections KITLV Digital Image Library, 9062.

connections to the wider world, but focus inwardly on domestic concerns, psychological conflicts, and personal and career angst. Though set in Java, Sumatra, and other islands of the archipelago, the plays compartmentalize European experience, rather than engage with the plurality of the cultural landscape. They avoid otherness to reify and celebrate the Dutchness of the colony.

Indies drama served nonetheless to stimulate the halting development of spoken drama in Malay. There was little in the way of published dramatic literature before the twentieth century. At least two Malay-language komedi stambul chapbooks were published in the 1890s.²¹ A Malay translation of the libretto of the 1885 opera *Le Capitaine Noir* by Joseph Mertens (titled *Kapitan Item*) was printed in 1898 as a souvenir booklet for those attending the opera when it was performed at Batavia's schouwburg to celebrate Queen Wilhelmina's coronation.²² There are also a number of published wayang wong scripts in Javanese, Dutch, and Malay that seem to have been intended for literary consumption.²³

The 1901 Malay-language play by the Indo journalist Ferdinand Wiggers (the son of E. F. Wiggers), titled *Lelakon Raden Beij Soerio Retno* and freely adapted from van Nouhuys' play *Eerloos*, might likewise have also been intended for reading only.²⁴ It is an "orphan" play; no comparable adaptations, translations, or original dramas in Malay would be published in the next fifteen years. The two-act play deserves discussion, however, not only because it is generally considered to be the first Malay-language spoken drama but also because of the ways it indexes the intergenerational stresses and strains of modernity and introduces strategies of adaptation employed by later naturalist theater makers.

The play's eponymous central character, Raden Beij Soerio Retno, is a midlevel Javanese civil servant. He is a devoted government tax collector with a son named Raden Ongko and a daughter of marriageable age named Kartani. A sum of money has gone missing from the office, which the collector discovers has been pilfered by his own wife to give to their profligate son. Ongko is studying medicine in Batavia at the School tot Opleiding van Inlandsche Artsen (School for Training Native Doctors or STOVIA), one of the few channels for higher education in the Dutch language open to Javanese at the century's turn. Attending medical school has brought Ongko into contact with "children of regents, children of Moluccan kings, all sorts of children of the wealthy" and, with that contact, the social pressures to enjoy Batavia's diverse opportunities for *plezier* with them (Wiggers 1901, 37). Primary among these entertainments is *tayuban*, which requires cash and costly presents for singer-dancers. Ongko's mother has not only been surreptitiously siphoning money from her husband but has also pawned Kartani's jewelry and batik cloth to support Ongko's prodigal habits. Ongko can carouse with his classmates and thereby maintain his social status, but Kartani's marriage prospects have been thus compromised. (Kartani expresses her own modern values, inspired by Kartini's brand of feminism, when she says that a simple demeanor can be becoming and that today women can contribute to the domestic economy by taking in sewing.)

In the first act, Ongko returns home from Batavia without warning, in difficult straits. He has been entrusted by his classmates to be the treasurer for STOVIA's gala celebration of the anniversary of Queen Wilhelmina's coronation—a major public holiday in the Dutch Indies—but he has spent the 500 guilders collected on personal *plezier* activities. To pay for the STOVIA party's food, drink, music, and other expenses, Ongko has had to borrow money from a Chinese acquaintance. Now the time has come for Ongko to repay the loan, and he is without the means to do so. After Ongko robs his father's office with his mother's assistance, his father, the tax collector, shoots himself instead of facing dishonor. The play concludes with Ongko's mother's harrowing accusation that Ongko has killed his own father and the moral message or *nasehat* that “a parent, especially a mother, must not overly heed a child's wishes” (Wiggers 1901, 56).

Van Nouhuys' name is not mentioned in the published play, which indeed differs considerably in structure and particulars from *Eerloos*. The Dutch drama provides a springboard for Wiggers to deal didactically with topical issues, including social pressures that come with modern education, the dangers of *plezier* (perhaps reacting against his father's enthusiasms?), urban versus rural culture, attachment to the colonial state, gender, and class. For example, when Ongko complains that he was forced to sit in a third-class compartment among the coolies on his train ride home due to a lack of funds, his father replies,

Son, don't speak like that, you are too young and don't know that those smelly coolies you talk about are the very people who provide us with our livelihood. If it weren't for those lowly coolies, people of the *priyayi* class would die of hunger, because there would be no money to pay our salaries, and Raden Ongko could not enter medical school and Raden Ongko could not enjoy *plezier*. (Wiggers 1901, 25)

This is very much a twentieth-century play, portending the radical social, cultural, and political changes of the next decades. Ongko is paradigmatic of a generation who bonded in the schools of Batavia, experiencing “the amiably competitive comradeship of the classroom” (B. Anderson [1983] 1991, 122) and the exclusions and inclusions of being classified along with peers from other regions and islands as an *inlander*, or “native.” *Plezier* in Ongko's Batavia was indeed parasitic on the base labor of the hinterlands’ “lowly coolies,” as Soerio Retno contends. But increasingly Ongko and his individualist peers were imagining themselves as an autonomous community, creating their own sense of normativity and belonging in the metro-pole that would become the nation's capital.

Opera Derma

Tiong Hoa Hew Koan (Chinese Association, abbreviated as THHK) was an Indies-wide organization founded in Batavia in 1900. THHK aimed to instill Confucian values, promote the Chinese language, establish schools and clubhouses, and collect books to spread knowledge of China (Kwee T. H. [1936–1939] 1969). Acting collectively through the THHK, the Chinese community successfully rallied to overthrow oppressive colonial regulations requiring Chinese dress and ponytails and restricting freedom of movement.²⁵ Local ritual practices were “reformed” and a greater sense of connection with mother China nurtured. Children studying at THHK schools learned English and Chinese, as well as Dutch and Malay, increasing their awareness of cultural developments in China, Europe, the United States, and around the world. Indies dramas aligned only haphazardly with the ideologies of the Indies League or other politically oriented associations; although some playwrights (such as Ido) championed Eurasian culture and comfortably navigated the archipelago’s cultural complexities, others (such as Fabricius) depicted the Indies as a place of work beset with alien pitfalls. In contrast, the Sino-Malay theater had a close relation to THHK for more than four decades. This organization played a significant role in the theater’s ideology and organization.

One of the first THHK-associated companies was Soei Ban Lian, a Chinese-owned commercial theater company founded around 1908 by the cross-dressing actress Theng Poei Nio and her husband, the director Sim Tek Bie. Soei Ban Lian specialized in modern stagings of Chinese classics such as the romance of Sampek and Engtay and the legend of the White Snake. A narrative poem (*syair*) about the company’s tour to Batavia characterizes it as a bangsawan troupe and notes specifically the use of European musical instruments (guitar, violin, drum), European-style costumes, and other devices associated with bangsawan and komedi stambul (Tek Liong 1921). Another source (Tzu 1939, 10) describes it as the forerunner of a new genre of Indo-Chinese opera called *cia im* because it drew on Chinese operatic conventions but had dialogue in Malay. Soei Ban Lian gave charity benefits for THHK and is credited with introducing popular legends to a generation of Chinese spectators, but was also charged with the same moral improprieties as komedi stambul.

Much more respectable, even genteel, was the Chinese amateur theater known as *opera derma* (charity opera) in Malay or *cu te hi* in Hokkien, which emerged in Batavia around 1910. Amateur actors presented musical spectacles, initially modeled after komedi stambul. Proceeds were given to charity—mostly earmarked for Chinese schools, but also for orphanages, disaster relief, and other noble

causes. One can see the influence of THHK in the way that opera derma shrugged off centuries of prejudice against theater. (Professional actors in premodern China were considered to have a lower standing than prostitutes.) Chinese clubs rented out prestige venues for performances, including the municipal schouwburg theaters that had previously functioned as exclusively European cultural preserves. Another important venue was a new schouwburg called Thalia that opened in 1909 in the Mangga Besar district of Batavia (on the corner of current-day Jalan Mangga Besar Raya and Jalan Hayam Wuruk). This Chinese-financed theater also hosted European marionette theater, Chinese acrobatics, film showings, and variety acts, and it functioned as the premiere venue for komedi stambul through the 1930s.

Opera derma plays typically showed the “exploits of a profligate, evil, or brutal tycoon who uses trickery to obtain a pretty virgin, the daughter or fiancée of a pauper. You could be sure that when the tycoon puts his evil plan into effect you will see evildoers prepared to rob or deceive with illegal opium; a Chinese or indigenous medicine man intent on trickery; a bordello with sex workers who drain money from misguided young men” (Kwee T. H. 1919, 5). Opera derma playtexts, referred to as *buku rol opera*, were published, allowing their restaging by Chinese amateur groups that sprang up around the archipelago in conjunction with local THHK chapters. Opera derma performances involved many performers and numerous scene changes. Like in stambul and the Parsi theater before it, plays alternated between “deep” scenes using the entire stage and “shallow” scenes set in front of the curtain, to allow time for changes of scenery.²⁶

Opera derma’s critics complained of actors’ problems with projection and diction, repetitious dialogue, wobbly false mustaches, costumes inconsistent with characters, undisciplined rehearsals, leading actresses cast for looks rather than acting talent, comics who cracked jokes in the saddest of scenes, stages cluttered with extraneous furniture, actors addressing the audience rather than fellow actors, curtains coming up or going down at the wrong times, and crying children in the audience (Chai 1923, 132–168). Yet the strong moral messages of these plays, typically depicting the suffering of the innocent and ending with evildoers’ just desserts, made the theater morally uplifting and a salutary institution in Chinese eyes.

Kwee Tek Hoaij and Sino-Malay Spoken Drama

Kwee Tek Hoaij’s *Allah jang palsu* (1919; The false gods), a six-act spoken drama that loosely adapts a short story by English novelist E. Phillips Oppenheim, instilled a new structure of feeling into Sino-Malay drama. Kwee was one of the

foremost Chinese intellectuals of his time: a prolific dramatist, novelist, and translator, as well as an editor and publisher. Although his formal education stopped at age fifteen, informal English-language lessons with a THHK school-teacher opened a path to studying both traditional Chinese philosophy and Europe's modern culture.²⁷ In the introduction to his first play, Kwee describes the need to create dramas that "are better, more modern, more fitting with current thinking, which can be seen by people from other ethnic groups without embarrassment" (1919, vi). Though conscious of the danger in alienating popular audiences, he urges a break with *stambul* and *bangsawan*, styles of theater that Kwee argues are unconnected to the desires of today's educated class. One should instead "perform in the style of European theater" (*maen setjara tooneel Europa*). Spoken drama, known as *wenmingxi* or "civilized drama," had been gaining ground in China since the first decade of the twentieth century. It was used for propaganda and is credited with fermenting the Revolution of 1911 (Mackerras 1975, 118). Kwee (1919, vii) asks, why should not Chinese in the Indies also "perform modern stories with these new procedures"? Studying drama, and particularly memorizing and rehearsing dialogue, would carry the side benefit of enhancing confidence in speaking in public: it would be useful for both work and life. This is why drama is taught in European schools, he says.

The success of Kwee's play led to a flowering of Sino-Malay spoken drama and the rapid decline of opera drama.²⁸ Chinese opera continued to be produced, but most performances seem to have been by children—a means to improve Chinese-language skills and learn through doing about Chinese culture (Nio 1935). Chinese educated youths avidly read plays by Ibsen, Shaw, Wilde, Gogol, James Barrie, Dumas, Leonid Andreyev, and Sergei Treyakov (Kwee K. B. 1936, 86), typically in English. Magazines and books produced by Chinese publishers disseminated information about the latest developments in Chinese theater, such as the international tours of the *jingju* company of Mei Lanfang. Local THHK branches, Chinese schools, and other Chinese organizations enlisted Chinese intellectuals and journalists to write or adapt plays to be acted by local amateurs for charity benefits. Schools, orphanages, and the Chinese Red Cross were often the beneficiaries.

Dozens of plays were published, both in book form and in Sino-Malay magazines, and a variegated dramatic repertoire sprung into being, with tragedies, comedies, farces, and romances. Tzu You (1938), in a survey of this repertoire, says that this theater was more a means for public education (*djoeroe pendidik*) than a pure art (*kunst*). Ibsen provided the strongest inspiration, with plays aiming to excavate and address social issues, through which it was hoped that "the many illnesses afflicting Chinese society might be healed" (19–20). Tzu outlines four

primary characteristics of the Sino-Malay spoken drama. These plays (1) offer examples for living, with evildoers receiving their comeuppance and the good rewarded; (2) illustrate dangers of evil habits like gambling and drinking; (3) challenge old-fashioned (*koeno*) customs in need of changing because they are not in keeping with the times (*kemadjoean djeman*); and (4) reveal and critique the faults of Chinese society (20). Many of the plays were creatively adapted from European drama, with particulars altered to fit the circumstances of Chinese Indonesian life. Guides to theater making addressed to amateur groups (e.g., Tjoa 1940) demanded naturalistic acting and suggested that actors go to the movies for inspiration.

Sino-Malay drama is well represented by Kwee Tek Hoay's *Korbannja Kong-Ek* (1926; Martyr to the public good), a four-act play overtly inspired by Ibsen's *An Enemy of the People* (1882). The play critiques the apathetic leadership of a THHK chapter as more interested in baccarat, tayuban, card playing, and cinema than in the welfare of the local THHK school. After the chapter's board decides to invest in an expensive wedding gift for the Assistant Resident's daughter to curry favor with Dutch elites instead of repairing the school's broken waterworks, a rash of typhus erupts. A board member resigns to form an alternate school, and the board attempts to murder the defector in revenge. But the plot is discovered, and the play ends with a joyful song set to the melody of the goodnight waltz, "Three O'Clock in the Morning," made famous by a 1922 hit recording by Paul Whiteman and His Orchestra.

When excerpts of Kwee's play were published in the Sino-Malay daily *Sin Bin* in 1925, some readers felt it was too critical of THHK and were perturbed that it failed to depict the punishments and rewards merited by its characters. Kwee retorted, "It is my opinion that it is better for readers and spectators not to feel satisfied as this can awaken thoughts about the many irksome matters which impact public good and thus goad one to rectify such matters" (1926, iv).

Kwee's most passionate deliberation on theater comes in his novel *Penghidoepannja satoe sri panggoeng* (A leading lady's life), published serially in his magazine *Moestika-panorama* in 1930–1931. The novel's protagonist is a THHK-educated young Chinese woman named Lian Nio, who comes from a poor Chinese family and flees an unwanted suitor by joining a touring bangsawan company under the alias of Miss Luna. Her poise, beautiful singing voice (she learned songs as a child from listening to records played on a neighbor's gramophone), English-language skills, and creative imagination elevate her to stardom. Lian Nio initially has a low opinion of theater in line with popular stereotypes and concealed her Chinese identity so that she could act without shame. Gradually she sees theater's potential to change public opinion. In full-length plays and the skits performed as extra

turns between acts, she throws herself into downtrodden roles to garner sympathy for society's poor. Miss Luna becomes completely absorbed in these roles—described by Kwee as *ilmoe* “*meloepaken diri sendiri*,” “the science of ‘forgetting oneself’”—and comes to view herself as a “public priestess” (English in the original) who acts in “a sort of church or holy place that influences and educates people so that they become more sensitive in feeling, more fair in judgment, more expansive in vision, more pure in soul and open in thinking, so that they can see more clearly the differences between right and wrong, which most cannot distinguish” (Kwee 1930–1931, 516, 87, 92).

Miss Luna attracts the attention of the dashing twenty-five-year-old Albert Pang, the son of a wealthy Chinese merchant. Pang also studied at a THHK school before going to Singapore where he passed his Senior Cambridge examination and then traveled to the United States where he studied economics at “California University.” His studies in the United States took second place to his involvement in student theater, however. Tang abandoned economics entirely when he landed small acting parts in United Artists films, stirring hopes of becoming the male Anna May Wong. Tang was deported for violating his student visa, worked briefly in the Chinese film industry in Shanghai, and returned to Batavia without money or a degree, but with the hope of establishing a film studio in Java. (His father refused him a loan and suggested he work as a clerk at General Motors instead.)

Pang and Lian Nio fall in love, Lian Nio reveals her Chinese roots to him, and together they hatch a plan to found a Sino-Malay theater company that will offer morally uplifting plays and elevate the theater as an art, free of base commercial motives. “Artists have higher standing than merchants who speculate for profit, compete, trick, and deceive each other without embarrassment. An artist does not work to cause harm or loss to another person,” Pang explains to a friend (Kwee 1930–1931, 258). Kwee’s novel exposes the cosmopolitan influences, humanitarian principles, expanded horizons of expectation, and transnational aspirations of Chinese theatermakers in late colonial Indonesia. Pang and Lian Nio are idealists and idealizations of the possibilities of theater: there were no ex-Hollywood actors actually working in theater in colonial Batavia. More common were the spirited amateurs represented in a 1941 cartoon in the magazine *Sin po* whose rehearsal is interrupted by a wife who cannot tell the difference between theater and reality (see Figure 3.3). Kwee himself was of a more commercial bent than either the amateurs or his own novel’s characters. He saw writing and publishing as a business, one that supplemented his income from the textile shops and a tapioca plant he owned. Although the protagonists of *Penghidoepannja satoe sri panggoeng* aspire to distance themselves from commercial theater, Kwee was keen to write plays for and have his novels adapted by the leading popular theater companies



Two Chinese actors rehearse a Malay-language war play at home for an upcoming charity benefit. Eavesdropping from the kitchen, the sarong-clad wife attacks her husband when she overhears his lines about leaving his wife, but backs off after he shows her the script and explains he is rehearsing a play. Cartoon from the Sino-Malay photo magazine *Sin po* 18, no. 830 (25 January 1941).

of this time, including Dardanella (to be discussed in a later chapter). He was a full participant in what American anthropologist James Boon calls the cross-cultural system of showbiz and game to its “consumerist cravings—fetishistic, hedonistic, sometimes even wholesome” (2000, 430). Nowhere was showbiz more highly elaborated than in the music business, the subject of the next chapter.

Music on the Market

Music in traditional Indonesian societies is interwoven into the texture of life. Mothers sing lullabies to their children. Shamans and magicians address the spirits through sung incantations. Gongs and drums are struck to excite warriors in battle and terrify enemies. Workers plant, harvest, husk, and transport rice while singing work songs and pounding out interlocking rhythms to coordinate efforts. Ancient texts inscribed on palm leaf manuscripts are not read, but rather are sung out loud. Weddings and other life events are marked by singing duels in which contestants strive to outwit one another in song. Drums and slit gongs sound from mosques and village halls to announce the time for prayer or convey alarm. Villages sing, dance, and play instruments communally to honor ancestor spirits at annual ceremonies. Bridal couples and boys before circumcisions are paraded through the streets on palanquins with raucous marching music.

The “extensional spread of modern institutions” (Beck, Giddens, and Lash 1994, 57)—including exhibitions of culture and industry, the recording industry and musical publishing, schools and churches, cabaret, round-the-world cruises, amusement parks, art circles and musical societies, touring circuits, traveling carnivals, and musical instrument factories—have resulted in new ways of situating, making, and understanding music. Maurice Bloch (1974, 70–71) observes that engaging in ceremonial song is a passive experience, so passive in fact “that it is as though the singer were experiencing language from outside himself. [. . .] No argument or reasoning can be communicated, no adaptation to the reality of the situation is possible. *You cannot argue with a song.*” In contrast, the new modes of music that started to emerge at the end of the nineteenth century argued with, for, and against songs, thereby adapting to the changing realities of the archipelago. Resonating with the “environment of risk” (Giddens [1990] 1991, 35) of global modernity, practitioners invented musical hybrids in search of new audiences and markets. Musicians became professionalized, autonomous markets were forged, traditional forms renewed and made accessible to multiethnic audiences, and novelties transported from afar so that globalization became “dialectically related to even the most intimate aspects of [. . .] lives” (95).

Pasar Malam

The pasar malam, literally “night market,” was a colonial import that can be traced back to the Dutch *boerenkermis*, or annual country fair. Also known in Dutch as either *jaarbeurs* (industry fair) or *tentoonstelling* (exhibition), the pasar malam in nineteenth- and early twentieth-century Indonesia was a ubiquitous festive celebration with vendors, food, performances, cinema, carnival games and rides, sporting competitions, advertising, and often educational and industrial exhibitions. A nineteenth-century pasar malam was typically organized by a local government or committee of Europeans to coincide with a national festivity, such as the coronation anniversary or birthday of the king or queen of the Netherlands or an anniversary of a town or city’s founding. The term was originally understood to mean a market-like collection of stands selling food, drink, souvenirs, and unusual wares. It was one element of a complex of events, including races, animal fights, social dancing, fireworks, competitions, and various artistic performances, which the term then came to embrace (Cohen 2002b).

Pasar malam-like collections of stands also sprang up around the Sekaten celebrations honoring the birthday of the Prophet Muhammad. Newspaper articles about Sekaten in Surakarta and Yogyakarta in the 1880s and 1990s describe the *alun-alun* (public square) cluttered with tombolas, carousels (introduced to Java in 1872), and ring toss games (introduced to Java in 1885); stands selling delicacies such as *nasi liwet*, *nasi Madura*, *sate kambing*, *soto*, noodles with chopped pork, *laksa* soup, and hot drinks; and freak shows, Japanese-style acrobatics, *tandak* social dance, and *wayang setanan*—a mechanized magical attraction in which small figures on a tabletop or pillow appeared to move by themselves. An 1885 railroad tourist from Madiun records his disappointment (*kapok*) and dismay about the event’s commercialization, as throngs of visitors and many market stands prevented him from getting a good look at the festival parade.¹

The 1893 exhibition at Batavia’s zoo and the adjacent grounds of the house of Raden Saleh provided the model for many pasar malam to come (Cohen 2006, 176–178). The event was a local response to the international rage for expositions that combined entertainment, commerce, art, and public education; this fad was launched by the 1851 Crystal Palace Exhibition in London. It was not until the establishment of the Pasar Gambir in Batavia in 1904, however, that the pasar malam was truly institutionalized. The Gambir night market emerged from the recommendations of a governmental welfare committee whose members included Banten-born politician Achmad Djajadiningrat. It aimed to better the lot of the poor by revitalizing arts and crafts and developing a local market for locally produced batik, silver, lacquerware, woodcarving, wickerwork, and other

handicrafts (cf. Bloembergen 2006, 246–255). Other annual expositions were established soon after in other cities, including Surabaya (1905), Fort de Kock (present-day Bukittinggi; 1906), and Semarang (1908).

Performing arts from far and near were prominent features of pasar malam. The first Fort de Kock pasar malam (referred to in the local vernacular as a “pakan malam”) included wayang kulit puppetry, *kuda kepang* hobbyhorse dancing, ronggeng dancing, Malay music, a Chinese magician, Chinese lion dancing, and Chinese opera. The official report on this fête represented it as a vehicle for Europeans and “natives” to learn to appreciate each other’s expressive culture in a festive atmosphere (Westenenk 1907). The carefully documented Surabaya expositions of 1905–1907 were organized by Surabaya’s inspector of police, J. E. Jasper, an important figure in the revival of traditional arts and crafts (Jasper 1908; Ouwenhart 2014). Performances included Javanese gamelan, topeng, wayang, and *tandak*; *gambuh* dance-drama and *gandrung* social dance from Bali; Sundanese and Minangkabau martial arts groups; and *cakalele* dance from Ambon. Visitors could take home photographs of performers made by the Kurkdjian Studio and purchase performing objects such as puppets and masks.² Objects and performances once scarce and considered sacred thus were transformed into pasar malam souvenirs destined to become wall adornments. *Lukisan kaca* (reverse paintings on glass), a new art form to Java probably introduced by itinerant Chinese artists, were also on sale. Many of these paintings featured wayang characters, resulting in shadow puppetry’s further desacralization (cf. Cohen 2005b, 31–34).

Australian historian Joost Coté (2006, 1) writes, with reference to Semarang’s international colonial exhibition of 1914, that public events of this sort stamped the identity of a city as modern and “provide[d] the visitor, already touched by a modern curiosity, with personal access to the wonders of modernity.” Yet colonial exhibitions, pasar malam, and the permanent pasar malam-like amusement parks erected starting in the 1910s did not only indoctrinate visitors into European modernity: they were also hybrid “contact zones” where age-old traditions met scientific modernity. Pigeaud recollects that *gedebus*, a display of Islamic invulnerability magic, was performed at a pasar malam held at Sirene-Park, the Batavia entertainment complex, circa 1920—free for the price of admission to the park. “Dutch doctors examined the performers and did not observe any trickery” (Pigeaud [1938] 1991, 430). Cultural contamination and confusion abounded. As an article on the Pasar Gambir states, “It is rather difficult to make a distinction between the various diversions and to say this is an exclusive native entertainment and that European, for on such an occasion the West rubs shoulders with the East and the natives patronize the European amusements and vice versa” (Resident 1925, 658).³

Artistic performances at pasar malam entered into an environment of competition and commercialism, enacted alongside boxing matches, bird shows, flower shows, and the like. Kroncong at pasar malam was not simply performed, but transacted in competitive *concours* or “matches,” starting with the 1915 edition of the Pasar Gambir (if not earlier) (Keppy 2008, 142–146; Yampolsky 2010, 23–28). Performing groups entered contests under fanciful names, such as De Vriendschap (Friendship), Melaja Boengoer (Wandering bungur trees), and De Doodskoppen (The skulls), and they sometimes dressed in uniforms perhaps inspired by the sporting teams also competing at pasar malam.⁴ Juries or experts evaluated these performances and awarded prizes to the groups, with special commendations for individual performers. Matches were held for all-female and youth groups. This competition served to establish aesthetic norms and standardize this unruly musical genre. By the 1920s kroncong contests were common features of pasar malam around Java, as well as in Sumatra and Borneo.

Competition culture spread to other performance genres. Pigeaud ([1938] 1991, 424) describes a two-day-long contest of *terbangan* groups singing Islamic praise songs to the accompaniment of frame drums, held in 1934 during the Muludan celebration of a small town in the Tasikmalaya district of West Java. A 1939 pasar malam in the West Sumatran city of Padang included a *gambus* (Arabic lute) contest. Gambus was an old musical form in the Malay world that had been revitalized by the introduction of the Arabian *‘ud* and associated playing techniques by Hadhrami Arab immigrants around the turn of the century (Hilarian 2003, 467). This same pasar malam also included a competition of martial arts from Padang and the nearby highlands. Contests of this sort transformed *pencak silat* from a form of self-defense into a performing art that emphasized impressive speed and athletic flourishes over deadly power. The pasar malam thus operated as what Anthony Giddens refers to as a disembedding mechanism: it lifted artistic practices and concomitant social relations from “their ‘situatedness’ in specific locales” ([1990] 1991, 53) and transformed audiences into consumers of expert systems obliged to trust the judgment of juries, promoters, commentators, and critics.

Phonography

An even more powerful disembedding mechanism was the phonograph, invented in 1877 in Thomas Alva Edison’s industrial research lab in New Jersey and introduced to Java less than two years later. A. de Greef, who had arrived in Java in 1865 as a baritone in a French opera company and stayed on to work as a singer, opera director, and voice teacher in Batavia, offered a series of scientific demonstrations

of the talking machine in 1879 in Batavia and Surabaya. These were possibly the first-ever demonstrations of the phonograph in Asia (Suryadi 2006). A prescient article by a correspondent for a Malay newspaper describes how Dutch, Javanese, and Chinese attending the demonstrations by de Greef and other early showmen were invited to sing into the phonograph's trumpet and had their voices recorded on wax cylinders and replayed. Intuiting the phonograph's future as a purveyor of entertainment, the correspondent writes,

For me as a Javanese the machine has three potential functions: 1. We would tell a *tandak* with a strong voice to sing a *gending* with soft accompaniment into the trumpet and afterwards invite friends over for food and drinks and have the phonograph emit the *tandak*'s voice for their pleasure; 2. We would instruct an amusing puppeteer to perform into the trumpet and afterwards invite over friends who enjoy wayang and play the recording; 3. We would instruct a good singer of *tembang* to sing into the trumpet. To sleep we would play back the [recorded] voice.⁵

The writer then admits that this vision is fantasy—the phonograph on display reputedly cost 3,000 guilders, hardly a price tag for home consumption.

But record players from Edison and his competitors *did* become available to consumers during the 1890s, and in the following decades gramophone records had a formative impact on the entertainment industry (Yampolsky 2013). Phonographs were initially marketed as novelty items to the super-wealthy, alongside music boxes and mechanical organs.⁶ However, their price declined, and it was not long before the machine became affordable to elites of all ethnicities. The phonograph had a special appeal, in fact, to status-conscious Chinese aesthetes pining for Mother China. A 1900 advertisement for a phonograph accompanied by plates for seventy-two Chinese opera songs claims that “whoever hears these will nearly lose all energy as if they had flown to CHINA.”⁷

Phonograph showmen also worked the streets in the late 1890s, playing the machine for five cents a song. There were the usual stories of naïve peasants who believed that there was a man inside the machine when they heard it “speak” for the first time.⁸ A notice in a Malay paper for W. Noordhoorn's phonograph demonstrations in Batavia played to local spirit beliefs: “it can imitate human sounds, a cough, a laugh, crying; although we do not see the person, as long as we know the person, we can recognize who it is. It truly is like a machine that has a demon [*setan*] inside. Though I have lived many years, I have only now for the first time seen such a demonic machine.”⁹

Islamic circles in Batavia earnestly debated whether it was acceptable to play recordings of the Qur'an on Batavia's streets for the entertainment of Arabs, Chinese, Javanese, and others. Authorities fretted that phonographic recordings might one day replace the human voice in the *adhān* or call to prayer (as they indeed did), that inexact sound reproduction might lead to Muslims developing poor Arabic pronunciation, that recordings could be used to mock Muslim belief, and that approbation of Qur'anic recordings might indirectly encourage Muslims to listen to recordings of European women singing, thereby arousing forbidden sexual feelings (Snouck Hurgronje 1900, 1915).¹⁰

The phonograph enjoyed only a brief period as a commercial entertainment presented by showmen in clubs, theaters, and on the streets. By 1900, there was little profit to be made in this line, "as many people already owned phonographs. All over one can hear the sound of phonographs."¹¹ But the phonograph only took off in popularity later in the decade, catapulting over the crank organ and other rival technologies, because of the recording and distribution of records by local artists. The first firms to record Indonesian artists were European and American companies. Fred Gaisberg, a technician for The Gramophone and Typewriter Ltd. of London, recorded musicians from Java in Singapore in May 1903 during a pioneering trip to Asia. Some "120 one-sided plates sung by 15 singers from Penang and 90 one-sided plates by 10 singers from Semarang" were advertised in the firm's "first catalogue of Malay songs printed in 1904" (Tan S. B. 1996–1997, 4; see also Gaisberg 1942, 53–65). Most probably singers were drawn from the Indra Zanibar and Wayang Pusi, two bangsawan companies that happened to be playing in Singapore during the month Gaisberg was in town.

Later, technicians working for international companies such as Beka, Odeon, and Columbia went directly to Batavia and Surabaya to record Indonesian artists. Chinese entrepreneurs were crucial intermediaries. Harry Louis Marker, an American agent for Columbia Records, is said to have recorded more than five hundred records in Batavia in 1912, ranging from gamelan music to covers of Broadway songs. The Columbia contract was signed not by individual singers or groups, but by Tio Tek Hong, the owner of a modern, "fixed-price" store in Batavia's Pasar Baru shopping district—currently the location of Restoran Tropic—that sold sporting and hunting goods, picture postcards, musical instruments, and phonographs. Tio also published sheet music, including arrangements of stambul and kroncong songs starting in 1904, and in the mid-1920s, he established his own record company. Tio ([1959] 2006, 24) claims in his memoirs, not without justification, that his famous gramophone plates served to popularize (*memperluas peredaran*) popular Malay, kroncong, and stambul songs all over Indonesia.¹²

A huge amount and variety of recordings were released between 1904 and 1942: American ethnomusicologist Philip Yampolsky (2010, 14) estimates about 17,800, principally *kroncong* and *stambul* songs, songs from the popular *tonil* theater, Javanese gamelan, *wayang wong*, Sino-Malay pop songs, Sundanese music and theater, Qur'anic recitation, and Islamic devotional songs.¹³ Records were sold and consumed alongside music from Europe, the United States, other parts of Asia, and around the world. A 1928 ad for a Semarang store in a Malay-language magazine promoted Malay, Javanese, and Sundanese songs, as well as songs from "Singapore, Hindustan, Arabia, and Turkey," Qur'anic recitation and Islamic devotional songs such as *marhaban* (songs in praise of the Prophet), and Armenian, Dutch, English, German, and American recordings of foxtrot, jazz, harmony band, Hawaiian, and waltz music.¹⁴ Because gramophone plates were played in public spaces, colonial authorities sometimes banned the sale of certain records to deter unrest. For example, in 1933 a Chinese merchant in Medan was prohibited from selling records celebrating the heroic struggle of the Chinese Nineteenth Route Army against the Japanese in the First Battle of Shanghai, to avoid offending the Japanese.¹⁵

Phonograph recordings, however, were not considered a substitute for live performance, at least not initially. During a 1901 ban on Chinese opera performance in Surabaya, one newspaper report admits that "the phonographic recordings of Chinese opera songs are pleasing and melodious," but listening to them only causes the writer "great regret that the Surabaya authorities refuse to grant permission for Chinese opera to be performed here."¹⁶ A record could only contain three minutes of music on a side, a length adequate for popular Malay-language songs, but an awkward constraint on *wayang*, *langendriya*, and other theatrical forms. Records operated as powerful tools, however, for musicians to learn new songs and musical styles, and they allowed audiences to appreciate diverse musical idioms not otherwise accessible locally.

The recording industry's constant demand for novelty accelerated the development of new artistic forms and new inflections of existing genres. Thus, for example, the *pesindhen* or female vocalist of gamelan ensembles assumed musical prominence via phonograph recordings. No longer just one part of a polyphonous ensemble, she was placed close to the horn by recording engineers trained in recording Western art song and popular music, being transformed thereby into a soloist. (Accordingly, *pesindhen* are often the only named performers on record labels.) As Sutton (1984, 127) observes, recordings dissociated a *pesindhen*'s voice from her physical appearance, allowing aging singers to remain popular well after their looks declined as long as their voices remained charming and sexually alluring. Mediation also meant that the crude sexual innuendos and rough humor characteristic of

kroncong and many other performance forms had to be toned down “to protect public decency,” as Dutch historian Peter Keppy (2008, 153) puts it.

Classical Music and *Lagu Seriosa*

Turkish historian and cultural theorist Arif Dirlik states that “modernity is not a thing but a relationship, and being part of the relationship is the ultimate marker of the modern” (2007, 74). One of the cultural modes for entering into this relationship with modernity is playing modern music, which in the late colonial Indies meant European music or music derived from Europe (cf. Yampolsky 2013, 228–238). The adoption of Western music and related dance forms is thus related to a belief current among “subordinated people around the world” that people “could improve their status and life-chances by adopting badges of this mythical modernity, whether these were fob watches, umbrellas, or new religious texts” (Bayly 2004, 11). “Globality” facilitated the diffusion of a “general modernity” (Robertson 1995, 27), of which both classical music and jazz were key components in the late colonial period.

The study of classical music as a genteel pastime among non-Europeans started in earnest in the last decade of the nineteenth century. A newspaper article from 1893 describes Javanese elite women in Surakarta taking lessons in violin, guitar, and piano so that when they played together with Dutch women in musical soirees they would not be considered “ungainly” (*kakoe*).¹⁷ Around the same time, Belgian composer and violinist Charles May headed a small musical society in Surabaya called De Violin that offered violin lessons. May’s compositional opus included an experimental piece mixing gamelan with violin, clarinet, piston, and piano.¹⁸ The Surabaya-born Indo composer and pianist Constant van de Wall (Victor Ido’s younger brother) studied music in Europe and returned to the Indies in 1907 to found a private music school called Genteng in Surabaya. Van de Wall, along with Paul J. Seelig and Linda Bandara, was one of the foremost composers of early twentieth-century Java.¹⁹ These composers diligently mined the diverse music of Java—stambul, kroncong, gamelan, folk songs—for art compositions infused with the harmonies of Debussy and “the moderns.” Their pieces were not only played on the concert stages of the Indies, but were also picked up by European and American dancers and musicians hoping to flavor programs with exoticism (Cohen 2010).

Music was a standard part of the curriculum of many government and private schools. The 1872 regulations of Bukittinggi’s “School of Kings” dictated that students study singing. Learning Dutch songs was challenging for older Sumatran students, who struggled with pronunciation, and might have been in the

curriculum to develop foreign language skills. By 1908 musical education had progressed to include singing using staff rather than cipher notation, and many students also learned violin. There was an extracurricular music club with a *strijkorkest* ensemble that played light European classics. Members of the club were responsible for purchasing their own violins, cellos, and flutes and paid a monthly fee for buying sheet music. More experienced members of the ensemble provided instruction (Nawawi 1908, 21, 54).

An even more impressive foundation in European classical music was offered at Xaverius College, a Jesuit missionary school for training teachers located in Muntilan, thirty kilometers north of Yogyakarta. Students, who came from all over the archipelago, took private lessons in piano, organ, violin, guitar, and other instruments; played in school orchestras, bands, and chamber ensembles; and sang in choirs. A former student recalls how in the hours after lunch the college buzzed with music. Choristers did mouth gymnastics and breathing exercises. European priests taught non-European students how to read musical notation and encouraged them to compose their own art music, a genre that became known in Indonesia as *lagu seriosa*, “serious songs.” Listening to and playing kroncong, Hawaiian music, and jazz were forbidden and constituted grounds for expulsion (Seda 1990, 68–70).

Professional musicians sojourned in the Indies, some for long periods. For example, French Canadian classical singer Eva Gauthier lived in Java between 1910 and 1914, after failing in her bid to become a European opera star. Gauthier gave recitals and concerts around Southeast Asia and Australia and built up a small repertoire of Indies songs by Seelig (her sometime piano accompanist), van de Wall, and others, which she used to launch a career as a singer of exotic song in the United States (Cohen 2010, 48–72). Gauthier’s tours, and the tours of other Western classical musicians, were initially organized somewhat haphazardly. This changed in 1916, with the establishment of the Union of the Dutch Indies Arts Circles (Bond van Nederlandsch Indische Kunstkringen), which brought together diverse organizations of art lovers around the archipelago. The Union organized theater, cabaret, and dance tours; sponsored occasional tours by poets and lecturers—including Indian Nobel Prize winner Rabindranath Tagore and Dutch cultural historian Johan Huizinga—screened “art” films like *The Cabinet of Dr. Caligari*; and organized art exhibits.²⁰ It was perhaps most active in organizing and supporting tours of European chamber musicians, including such celebrity artists as Lithuanian violinist Jascha Heifetz, Spanish guitarist Andrés Segovia, and Polish American pianist Arthur Rubenstein (van Hasselt 1941).

Some of the touring artists interacted with the local arts to a degree, collecting melodies and costumes, observing performances, even taking lessons—which



Singing lesson at Xaverius College in Muntilan, circa 1925. Photograph from Collections KITLV Digital Image Library, 35932.

formed the basis of impressionistic compositions and travelogue-like performances such as pianist-composer Leopold Godowsky's *Java Suite* (1925). But with the exception of Tagore and his Indian followers, there was little direct artistic *exchange* during the colonial period involving these itinerant artists and non-Europeans of the archipelago (Cohen 2010). American dancer and choreographer Doris Humphrey, who toured Java with Denishawn in 1926—a year of agitation, strikes, and quashed rebellion—wrote in a letter home that “from the moment we docked in Soerbaja [*sic*], we were immediately immersed in Dutchness and batik. Java belongs to the Dutch and they possess it thoroughly and completely” (Humphrey quoted in Wentink 1977, 40).

European migrants fleeing the Russian Revolution of 1917 and the rise of Nazism in the 1930s were less immersed in Dutchness and batik, more integrated into local society, and generally more commercial minded than these earlier touring artists. They found work as performers, composers, and dance masters; formed and conducted dance bands; established studios and schools; and disseminated new artistic ideas and practices around the archipelago. In his brief history of European music and *lagu seriosa* in Indonesia, composer and critic Amir Pasaribu (1955, 70–71) argues that “the life of music in our major cities revolved entirely

around musicians from abroad, Italian, Russian, Hungarian, Czech, Filipino, Dutch, and so on.” The “first wave” of foreign musicians, in Pasaribu’s historiography, was made up of Italians, who worked in Batavia as “street musicians,” and of musicians who abandoned touring circus and operetta companies to settle in Java. A “second wave” followed, comprising “former professors from state conservatories fleeing for safety from the Bolsheviks.” Pasaribu mentions prominently pianist Alexander Hmlenitsky, who worked in Java between 1919 and 1938. Hmlenitsky taught piano in Surakarta, Yogyakarta, and Bandung and performed as a member of the Moscow Trio with his wife, who was a cellist, and a Russian violinist. Many of the Russian émigrés arrived in Java via Shanghai, which had a burgeoning European music and cabaret scene fueled by expatriate Russians fleeing the Revolution. There were also Jewish refugees from Europe, including Vienna-born composer and pianist Leo Paul Schramm, who settled in Batavia after a 1933 tour with the Budapest Trio, where he formed a chamber orchestra, wrote scores for the emerging film industry, and gave concerts together with his wife, the Dutch pianist Diny Soetermeer.²¹

Conditions for European music making in the tropics were precarious, and touring was grueling. Russian pianist Leo Podolsky, a former student of Vienna’s Royal Academy and winner of the Liszt and Anton Rubenstein prizes, recalls in his memoirs his experience touring the Indies by steamer circa 1918–1922. Good pianos were in short supply in the small towns he visited, such as Balikpapan (Borneo), Buleleng (Bali), and Sumenep (Madura). Upright pianos had to be borrowed from a local doctor or plantation manager, with internal mechanisms requiring thorough cleaning and priming before use. Audiences were often small and transportation unreliable (Podolsky 1977, 35–41). In Sumatra, Podolsky teamed up with another refugee Russian performer, the modern dancer Vera Mirova. Mirova had studied *danse plastique* under Elena Rabenek at Russia’s first modern dance school, which was founded after Isadora Duncan’s tour of Russia. Mirova’s stock in trade was mostly Duncan-style “free dances,” still very unusual in Asia, which she performed to the music of Debussy, Ravel, and Prokofiev. Her dances made the most of her stage charisma and liteness, emphasized by the use of chiffon in her costumes. The couple eventually married and migrated to the United States, where Podolsky taught and performed piano and Mirova cashed in on her Asian experience to become a teacher and performer of “ethnic” dance in Chicago and New York (Rogosin 1983).

Small touring outfits were received in often unexpected ways. In a survey of dance in Sulawesi, based on fieldwork conducted in 1917–1920, the Swedish ethnologist Walter Kaudern mentions in passing “an Arabian *danse-du-ventre*,” or belly dance,

introduced in the Macassar Peninsula by an itinerant party, a man with his wife and daughter and a musician who played a small piano. The girl did some singing in Arabic, and her father in English, whilst the mother performed a *danse-du-ventre*, although fully clothed. Her dance was imitated by the natives, and very quickly spread over the Macassar Peninsula, but the performers were boys dressed up as girls. At present it is said to have been prohibited by the Dutch authorities since it was abused for perverse purposes. The dance will have originated from Egypt, and its name was *messer* or *masser*. (Kaudern 1929, 468–469)

European concert dance also found its way into schools. The pages of *Weekblad keng po*, an illustrated Sino-Malay weekly magazine published beginning in 1923, are filled with images of Chinese schoolchildren dressed in bonnets and tiaras and billowing white dresses, performing interpretive dances with titles such as *Humoresque* and *Selling Flowers*.

The influence of European artists was felt as well in *kroncong*, which entered a new phase around 1918, characterized by standardized arrangements and a crooning style of singing modeled on American popular singers. The pathbreaking group in Amir Pasaribu's telling was the Lief Java *kroncong* ensemble, under the direction of Suwardi, better known as Pak Wang (Pasaribu 1955, 56).²² There soon developed what composer and *kroncong* artist Kusbini (1972, 25) called *kroncong baru* or "new *kroncong*," defined by the use of musical notation; set lyrics; a vocal style that toned down the characteristic glissandos, ornaments, and quivering of "original" (*asli*) *kroncong*; and an expanded orchestra that included "trumpet, saxophone, clarinet, trombone, piano, etc." One of the most famous *kroncong* artists of the 1920s and 1930s was the Sumatran-born Indo composer, violinist, and conductor Fred Belloni, whose sentimental music was the sonic equivalent of the Mooi Indië (Dutch for "Beautiful Indies") school of painting, all glistening rice paddies, smoldering volcanos, and lush river valleys. Not surprisingly, Belloni's records sold particularly well to Indos, and he also enjoyed an avid following in the Netherlands through the post-World War II years (Mak van Dijk and Schreuder 2007, 284–292).²³

Jazz and Hawaiian

Kroncong bands could be found in cities and towns around Indonesia, but according to Amir Pasaribu, who hailed from Tapanuli (North Sumatra), *kroncong* was essentially a Javanese form and was little liked on other islands, which enjoyed their own forms of hybrid music (1955, 64).²⁴ A form with much more appeal across ethnic lines was jazz, which swept through the entire archipelago in the 1920s.

A popular account of jazz in Batavia suggests that the first jazz band in the Indies was the Batavia Jazz Band, formed in 1922 by a collective of Dutch and Indo banjo, saxophone, cornet, trombone, and drum players. This band performed covers of recordings by American dance band artists such as Art Hickman, Ted Lewis, and Paul Whiteman (Möller 1987, 10–12). But there were earlier appearances of live jazz deserving mention. The touring Columbia Park Boys' Club, a traveling troupe of forty-two young men from San Francisco, gave concerts of song, dance, gymnastics, and jazz in 1919 at Batavia's zoo and Deca Park, an amusement park in the Koningsplein district that had opened in 1915. Also in 1919, Professor Freddy Becker, an exhibition ballroom dancer who ran a private dance school in Batavia, performed "jazz rag" dance at the same Deca Park, along with Parisian tango, Russian waltz, and his own dance creations.²⁵ Pianist Peter Heaton, who also played in a violin trio called the Ragomaniacs, headed a jazz band that performed for several months in 1920 and 1921 at the Casino Café and Cabaret, across the street from Deca Park. The cabaret promoted itself (in English) as serving "up a Merry Musical Cocktail," with "talent [. . .] imported direct from America and the Southern Hemisphere," including cabaret artists and an "experienced Mixologist."²⁶ After the cabaret closed, the band went on tour, and jazz quickly spread to other cities of the Indies. Local and touring jazz bands played at pasar malam, restaurants, movie theaters, clubs, private parties, hotels, soccer matches, amusement parks, celebrations of national holidays, and even village feasts, with an appeal across class divides.

Filipino musicians had a strong presence in jazz bands from the 1920s onward. One of the earliest groups from the Philippines was the Manila Syncopating Jazz Band Ylaya, which played Batavia's N. V. Simpang Variétés & Restaurant in 1924. That same year, a nine-man ensemble called the Levine and Hopkins New York Manila Jazz, also known as the Big Six Jazz Band, headed by American jazz pianist Harry Levine and drummer G. R. Hopkins, was contracted to play nightly at Pasar Gambir's main restaurant (see further Möller 1987, 20–21). Filipino musicians also performed with the traveling carnival tent shows produced by Manila-based American entertainment mogul Eddie Tait, known as "the Barnum of Borneo" (Robb 1939; Beatty 1940; Abbott 1944). The "gilly shows" produced by Tait and others who followed in his footsteps were known locally as "Manila Carnivals." These shows carted modern carnival rides, games of skill and chance, exotic animals and freaks of nature, boxing matches, motorcycle stunt riders, and all the wonders of the modern world to even the most isolated towns of the archipelago in the 1920s and 1930s.

Jazz was apprehended as an American import, a sign of worldly cosmopolitanism. Despite the distance from New York, Chicago, and New Orleans, considerable

expertise developed locally. One of Asia's great jazz aficionados at the end of the 1930s was Harry Lim, described by *Time* magazine in 1939 as a "diminutive, 21-year-old [. . .], editor in chief of the Batavia [. . .] magazine *Swing* (Officieel Orgeaan van the Batavia Rhythm Club), circulation 800 [. . .], whose favorite band leader is Duke Ellington."²⁷ Lim's legendary record collection contained some six thousand discs. As the "rector spiritus" of jazz, he organized jam sessions, gave public lectures, and set "public opinion" through his music criticism (Pasaribu 1955, 65; English in the original). Lim migrated to the United States in 1939 where he similarly organized jam sessions, produced records, and worked as a buyer for the Sam Goody retail record chain of Manhattan.

Many of the same bands that performed jazz also played kroncong, along with a third type of music with huge popularity in the 1920s and 1930s: Hawaiian. Hawaiian music reached the Indies initially through recordings. One of the earliest traveling troupes to play Java was Kaai's Royal Hawaiian Troubadours, under the direction of the great Hawaiian ukulele player Ernest Kaai. The Troubadours presented concerts of song, dance, and music in Java in 1922 on a world tour that also took the ten-member ensemble to Australia, India, and other parts of Asia. When it returned, "at least two members [. . .] elected to settle in Java: Alexander L. Lazarus (also known as Munson) and Herbert Pahupu Byrnes" (Kanahele 1979, 167). Lazarus and Byrnes formed a touring Hawaiian band and taught Hawaiian music to locals—spawning the archipelago's many Hawaiian bands. One of the most famous was the Hawaiian Syncopators, led by George "Tjok" Sinsoe (who played violin, mandolin, and guitar and was also a composer and singer) and his brother Emile Sinsoe (who played steel guitar and other instruments). The band was much in demand for live performances and recorded with His Master's Voice. As the name suggests, the Sinsoes's band also played jazz. Significantly, "many of Indonesia's finest players came from the outer regions: the Sinsoe Brothers from the Sangir Islands in the northernmost part of the country; Willy Pesik and his brother from Menado, Sulawesi; and George de Fretes, Etok Lautmeten, Joost Aipasa, and Nick Mamahit from Ambon, which produced a disproportionate number of Indonesian Hawaiian musicians" (Kanahele 1979, 169). The musical seeds planted by the Reverend Kam in nineteenth-century Ambon continued to bear fruit in the twentieth century.²⁸

Musical Hybrids

Hawaiian music was just one species in the complex musical ecology of eastern Indonesia—an area long characterized by musical heterogeneity. Dutch ethnomusicologist Jaap Kunst (1942, 13) describes the dominant form of vocal music

of East Flores, where he conducted field research in 1930, as a mixture of “all sorts of Amboinese song-melodies, stambul-songs and German melodies (the latter imported by the R.C. [Roman Catholic] mission).” Acculturation of foreign musics had been going on for centuries: Kunst believed that melodies he heard in Flores were based on songs sung by Portuguese settlers and sailors in the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries, though “the original words have not stood the test of 300 odd years of tropical life, not even in a corrupt form, which is far from surprising” (12).

Round-the-world cruise ships began to arrive in Eastern Indonesia in significant numbers in the 1920s, and these ships’ dance bands carried a new stock of melodies to the far-flung islands. Guests disembarking from these ships for island excursions were greeted with welcoming songs and dances performed by locals, who were exposed in turn to the most recent dance and music crazes by the ships’ bands. One of the most popular American songs of the 1930s, “Begin the Beguine,” had its origin in one such Eastern Indonesian exchange. The number was directly inspired by the songs and dances observed by Broadway composer Cole Porter when his cruise ship, the *Franconia*, docked in the town of Kalabahai on the eastern Indonesian island of Alor in 1935. When the song was staged in a tropical nightclub scene in Porter’s musical *Jubilee* (1935), choreographer Albertina Rasch created a dance with “little jerking head movement” intended to suggest the Indian modern dance of Uday Shankar and Balinese dance (Rasch cited in Ries 1983, 125).

Bands playing American and European music sprang up in the most unlikely of locations. The pages of the magazine *Pandji poestaka*, published by the state publisher Balai Pustaka and required reading for all civil servants, are filled in the 1920s and 1930s with pictures of bands from around the archipelago: Brandan Strijk Orkest from Pangkalanbrandan in North Sumatra; the youth flute orchestra Hizboel Wathon from Surabaya; the O. T. S. group of Tanjung Pinang (Riau); the Kraton Band of Tenggarong (a jazz band under the personal direction of the sultan of Kutai Kertanegara, an enthusiastic violin, piano, and trombone player); De Eendracht, a string ensemble in Barabai (South Borneo) whose instruments were donated by a local colonial administrator; the string orchestra Muziek Vereeniging V. O. P. Takeungeun from Laut Tawar, Aceh, which entertained locals deprived of cinema and touring bangsawan troupes; the string orchestra Crescendo from Mempawa (west Borneo); and the Kediri Muslim Jazz-Band, which wore the traditional outfit of devout Muslim students of religion and was said to be one of “four or five” jazz bands operating in Kediri in 1926.²⁹ The Sino-Malay illustrated weekly *Keng po*, not to be outdone, included photographs of Chinese bands, such as the jazz band of Gezelschap Hoa Kiauw Afdeeling Muziek

(Music Section of the Overseas Chinese Society) of Medan, directed by violinist Lim Hian Pek.³⁰ Musicians in many, if not most, of these bands were musically illiterate and learned songs by listening to gramophone records or watching movie musicals (Pasaribu 1955, 62–63).

The popularity of kroncong, jazz, and Hawaiian music sparked demand for quality musical instruments. Kroncong guitars were replaced by ukuleles, banjos, mandolins, and plectrum guitars outfitted with resonators; the cello of kroncong, which played pizzicato patterns resembling the *kendhang* drumming of gamelan, was replaced by the double bass. Virtuoso guitar playing inspired by Django Reinhardt discs (cf. Pasaribu 1955, 56) could simply not be executed on inferior instruments. An indigenous musical instrument industry (*muziekindustrie boemipoetra*) emerged in the 1920s and 1930s to accommodate these new musical needs.

The foremost Javanese manufacturer was Raden Saron, a classically trained gamelan musician and amateur violin and saxophone player.³¹ His company in the Jogosuran district of Surakarta, Muziek Instrumenten Industrie Saron (founded in 1932), used modern manufacturing techniques. Saron's stringed and plucked instruments, including electric guitars and lap slide guitars, were sold in Java, Sumatra, Borneo, and as far away as the Netherlands.³² Designs were fashionably up to date—Saron reportedly based his models on musical instruments he saw in the movies. Saron eventually applied his knowledge of guitar and mandolin making to modernize the gamelan orchestra's plucked instrument, the *siter*, for a 1940 prize competition (A. H. 1940).

Forms hybridizing European and Indonesian musical traditions developed in the 1920s and 1930s in response to this international flow of exogenous music and musical instruments. Four inventive examples from Sulawesi and West Java can be quickly sketched. The hybrid music now known as *musik bambu* was first heard in the Minahasa cultural region of North Sulawesi at the 1923 celebration of Queen Wilhelmina's coronation. It was European-style marching band music with locally made instruments manufactured from bamboo instead of brass. The band's leader Angok Pogaga was a retired soldier from Wioi, a village fifty kilometers south of Manado, and he named his ensemble Oranje Wioi in honor of his village and the Dutch royal house (Boonzajer Flaes 2000, 56; Munger 2009, 92). The form built on the long experience of Minahasa instrument makers in constructing bamboo wind instruments—flute choirs inspired by Kam's Ambonese ensembles had existed since the nineteenth century. Starting in the 1930s, Minahasa instrument makers also made marching band instruments from galvanized sheet iron (*seng*) of the sort used for roofing; these ensembles were called *musik bambu seng* (Munger 2009, 90).

The hybrid music *tarling*, a portmanteau of guitar and suling (side-blown bamboo flute) plus additional gamelan and European instruments, emerged in the 1930s in the Cirebon-Indramayu coastal region of West Java. The form's founder, the guitar player Sugra, related to me in a 1999 interview how his father, an amateur gamelan maker and employee of the Department of Irrigation, was entrusted by his Dutch boss "Tuan Antoni" with a broken guitar to repair. The guitar was never collected, which allowed Sugra to teach himself how to play. He then assembled a group of friends to play gamelan melodies with him on suling, an earthenware flask (*kendi*) substituting for a gong, a soapbox substituting for a drum, and a pair of spoons substituting for gamelan's *kecrek* cymbals. The youths entertained at all-night vigils (*melekan*) and busked on the streets during Chinese New Year. Sometimes Sugra and a female singer (*pesindhen*) sang ballads improvised in the local dialect of Javanese; the love story of Saidah and Saeni was a favorite. In the 1940s a clown (*bodhor*) was added and the ad hoc gamelan instruments were replaced by real gongs and kettle drums. In the 1950s, Sugra and other guitarists in Cirebon and Indramayu formed musical theater groups that acted out folk plays on temporary stages at village celebrations (Cohen 1999).

Daeng Soetigna, a schoolteacher and amateur musician, faced a lack of Western instruments when assigned to a Dutch-language school in the town of Kuningan in West Java. Only wealthier students could afford to purchase mandolins, guitars, or harmonicas, and most students had trouble mastering playing techniques. In 1938, he thus commissioned a local instrument maker to craft a set of bamboo *angklung* tuned to a diatonic scale. Daeng used these instruments to teach European music in his school and to the Boy Scout troop he led. After independence, diatonic *angklung* music exploded in popularity in West Java in response to radio broadcasts by school groups under Daeng's direction (Sumarsono and Pirous 2007).

The Chinese lyricist, composer, singer, and bandleader Hoo Eng Djie, born in a small town near Makassar, invented a hybrid song form in South Sulawesi (Yang 1949; Njoo 1950a; Harmonic and Salmon 1983, 156–162; Sidharta 2003, 180–186). Hoo got his start as an orator at Chinese weddings and funerals. To his repertoire he then added songs and stories adapted from Chinese, Buginese, and Makassarese sources, accompanied by violin and tambourine or a *keso-keso*, a two-stringed violin associated with Makassarese storytelling. Hoo had worked as a young man around Sulawesi and other islands of eastern Indonesia and was familiar with a number of verbal art traditions, which he successfully reworked into pantun verses in Makassarese. Typical song themes were love, mortality, fate, and spirituality. As his popularity increased, Hoo expanded his orchestra Sinar Sedjati to include violin, clarinet, gong, and tambourine and, from 1938 to 1940, traveled



Advertisement for Canary Records, which claims to be a famous label because its “select songs are the most sweet and modern, with lyrics arranged with extreme care.”

Poestaka timoer 1, no. 17
(1 October 1939): 27.

repeatedly to Surabaya to record with Canary Records, a Chinese-owned label mostly associated with *kroncong baru* artists such as R. Kusbini and S. Abdullah.³³

The legacy of these hybridizing inventors in contemporary Indonesia is mixed. Saroni's musical instrument factory is forgotten, but *musik bambu* still enlivens Minahasa weddings and public celebrations; typical repertoire includes *The Blue Danube* (1866) by Johann Strauss and religious hymns. *Tarling* still entertains audiences in Cirebon and Indramayu, though it has been mixed with and to a large extent eclipsed by other musical hybrids. Hoo's songs prophesizing impending war and privation, which resulted in his imprisonment by the colonial authorities, secured his lasting reputation as a “hero” (*pahwalan*) and contributor to South Sulawesi's “regional culture” (*kebudayaan daerah*). And in 2010 UNESCO inscribed angklung on the Representative List of the Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity, one of only six Indonesian cultural forms with this designation as of September 2015.

Artistic hybridity is sometimes mistaken as a sign of the weakness of indigenous culture. But as Edward Shills observes, “it is only when the expansion takes place into a territory which is very sparsely settled by any society or by

societies technologically and military very weak that there is no syncretism of indigenous and exogenous traditions” (1981, 253). Musical innovators of the 1920s and 1930s such as Sarono, Angok Pogaga, Sugra, Daeng Soetigna, and Hoo Eng Djie were strongly grounded and confident in the musical idioms of their local cultures. They were also quick to respond to market contingencies, curious about exogenous practices, and inventive in catering to new modes of patronage.

Ethnic “Awakenings”

Commercial entertainment and popular culture were generally disdained by hereditary blue-blooded elites in the nineteenth century. These aristocrats and landed gentry viewed *komedi* as vulgar pleasure for the masses. Because they were wedded to the stabilized social organization of the colonial state, with its intricate sense of hierarchy and privilege, their “ritualism became sclerotic” (Canclini 1995, 221). A dialogue between *si Tinta* (Mr. Ink) and *si Penah* (Mr. Pen) published in the Malay daily *Bintang Soerabaia* in 1893 sketches the disparity between the “edifying” pursuits of the elites and pleasures of the masses:

Pen: The regent of Sidoarjo greatly enjoys assembling the devout on Thursday nights to hear their uplifting stories. This practice led to him becoming devoted to the mystical sciences. He also goes for nightwalks [an ascetic exercise], returning at 2 at night and then sleeping until 4 o'clock and then getting up to sit down in his chair to smoke cigarettes until morning. And another pastime of the Sidoarjo Regent is to invite the *priyayi* elites of the city and the extended family of the former vizier, as well as the collector, district chiefs, and other notables to a shadow puppet performance on Saturday nights. The Regent sits on a mat on the floor and plays *rebab* [the spiked fiddle in the *gamelan* orchestra] until 1 at night, and on Thursday nights European music is played in the *pendopo* pavilion until 12 at night.

Ink: Aside from that, what other pleasures are enjoyed by the notables or officials there?

Pen: The officials and notables of Sidoarjo hold a horse race in the town square every six months. All the *priyayi* elites, big and small, as well as the village headmen dressed in their fine apparel and Europeans from other cities, come to enjoy the race and whoever wins receives a prize, such as a percent of the gate or something else. It is often the case that the horse race is held in the day and at night they gather at the club house and prizes are dealt out. And once a year there is a fair with vari-

ous sorts of spectacles. Aside from that there are no pleasures that inflict financial loss upon the people of this place like different types of komedi, as these are not enjoyed, and if a komedi does come here there are few who appreciate it.

Ink: What other sorts of pastimes are enjoyed in the mansion?

Pen: The Lord [Regent] of Sidoarjo does not have any pastimes other than turtledoves and horses.¹

When Kartini, the daughter of the regent of Jepara and Indonesia's most famous feminist, attended a komedi performance in Semarang in 1902, she reported that her mind was unable to concentrate on what she saw depicted on stage.² Instead, she dwelt on the image of a beautiful Chinese garden belonging to the head of Semarang's Chinese community that she had seen earlier that day: "When the violins were playing so beautifully we thought again of what we had enjoyed in the afternoon. To hear that violin playing in that cupola, with the quiet splash of the water, the rustle of leaves and, watching before us, through the waving bamboo fronds, the moon rising, that would be heavenly!" (Kartini 1992, 182–183).

Arjun Appadurai (1996, 180–181) has argued that much ritual is centrally concerned with "the socialization of space and time" and that "locality is ephemeral unless hard and regular work is undertaken to produce and maintain its materiality." Starting around 1900, energies that had formerly been invested in venerating ancestors and chthonic spirits or maintaining local shrines or kin-based organizations were diverted to extralocal imperatives. Sedentary devotion to local culture declined with education, mass culture, and increasing mobility. There was still intense pride in local culture—artistic rivalry between the royal courts of Surakarta and Yogyakarta, for example, persists to the present. But elites experienced a reflexive "awareness of a great variety of roles existing beyond narrow, fixed, local, and familial ones" and "the possibility of belonging to wider translocal, possibly changing, communities" (Eisenstadt 2000, 4).

Anthony Giddens and colleagues contend that in premodern societies "spatial dimensions of social life are [. . .] dominated by 'presence'—by localized activities," such as the all-night vigils, wayang performances, and horse races described in the *Bintang Soerabaia* dialogue quoted earlier. Traditional belief systems are grounded in "facework," overseen by authoritative guardians, including ritual practitioners and performers such as shadow puppeteers, who are "tradition made flesh" (Beck, Giddens, and Lash 1994, 89). Modernity, Giddens argues further, "tears space away from place by fostering relations between 'absent' others, locationally distant from any given situation of face-to-face interaction" (Giddens [1990] 1991, 18). Social

relations and cultural forms are disembedded from their “‘situatedness’ in specific locales,” and knowledge becomes reflexively appropriated (53). Tradition is excavated and reinvented, with “particularity [. . .] valorized [. . .] on an increasingly global-wide, pan-local basis” (Robertson 1995, 37). Through this process, “certain key symbols” came “to define the we against the they; certain core elements of a tradition [. . .] [came] to be separated out, venerated, fetishized, defended. This is the normal process, the politics, by which groups form themselves into identities and people recognize each other within a set of symbols and conventions” (Clifford 2003, 62).

An important transitional figure in Javanese tradition’s excavation and reinvention is Ki Padmasusastra, author of *Serat tatacara* (Customs and manners, 1907), an authoritative guide to Javanese tradition, and of *Layang bauwarna*, an encyclopedia of Javanese culture (Padmasusastra [1907] 1911; Pemberton 1994, 137–44; Wieringa 2000). Padmasusastra, a student of the great Surakarta poet Ronggawarsita, worked as an assistant to Dutch scholars in Batavia and the Netherlands after being dismissed from his post at the Surakarta court due to a financial scandal. He strove in his writings to derive rules and norms for Javanese cultural behavior. The introduction to the *Tatacara* expresses a profound sense of alienation: Javanese can no longer understand the ancient poetry, Dutch scholars have monopolized the representation of Javanese culture, the world is “overly full with knowledge” (*kebekan kawruh*). Cut off from kraton life, with nobody in Batavia to speak Javanese with him except for his wife, Padmasusastra writes with the double consciousness that his book will be consulted by Javanese who can no longer imbibe Javanese tradition from social life and by readers from “other races” (*liyan bongsa*) wishing to comprehend Javanese “superstitions.” Significantly, Padmasusastra focuses on a tayuban dance party as an example of cultural performance, laying out norms for how to hire performers, detailing refreshments to be served and protocols for toasts, modeling the order in which male guests should dance and forms of address to the musicians, and even describing how to clean up after the party is over ([1907] 1911, 141–159). An often unruly cultural arena is thus regulated in print, venerated as a marker of rank and wealth, and defended against charges of profligacy, licentiousness, and drunkenness.

Modernists “are moved by a will to change—to transform both themselves and their world—and by a terror of disorientation and disintegration, of life falling apart” (Berman [1982] 2010, 13). Such terror might be one of the reasons why so many arch-modern intellectuals and artists, prominently the poet T. S. Eliot, were most concerned about tradition and their relation to it. Artistic modernists starting with the Italian Futurists waged war against the institutions of art while invoking and relying on their audiences’ prior knowledge and appreciation of the

artistic canon and its conventions. It is not coincidental that, in the same year in which Futurism's founder F. T. Marinetti wrote his first manifesto, Boedi Oetomo (Beautiful Endeavor), sometimes described as Indonesia's "first national organization," was founded in Batavia (Nagazumi 1972, 26). Boedi Oetomo's founding in 1908 by the STOVIA-educated journalist and amateur puppeteer Wahidin Soedirohoesodo and a group of STOVIA students marked the beginning of what is called the "national awakening" or *pembangunan nasional* in Indonesia, though in a number of respects it was prefigured by the Indies League and THHK. Traditionalist in aims, Boedi Oetomo was also in political scientist Benedict Anderson's estimation "the earliest Indonesian attempt to cope with the colonial condition in Western ('modern') ways" (1990, 244). It was modern in organization and outlook, formed by educated Javanese to provide aid for the poor and further education for the Javanese (including access to Dutch secondary schools), develop a middle class, and cultivate markets for Javanese crafts and industry in the Indies and abroad. But from its start it was also staunchly conservative in that it viewed Java as a civilization in decline, in need of cultural revitalization through research into culture and education in the arts. The organization was motivated by the awareness that, if Javanese tradition was to persist, it had to become "available to discursive justification" (Beck, Giddens, and Lash 1994, 105), in dialogue with other traditions and cultures.

In his memoirs, Achmad Djajadiningrat recalls his first meeting with Wahidin, Boedi Oetomo's founder, at the Pasar Gambir of 1906. Working together with Dutch folklorist Cornelis Marinus Pleyte, Djajadiningrat had resuscitated for this occasion the Sukarame gamelan, an ancient set of instruments combining features of the *pelog* and *salendro* tunings that had originated from the royal court of Banten and were stored in the collection of the Royal Batavian Society of Arts and Sciences. When played by musicians brought in from Banten, the gamelan was discovered to be out of tune because it had not been played in at least a hundred years. Nonetheless the Batavia audience found its sound "sweet" (*merdoe*). A sole dissenting voice was Wahidin, who, sitting respectfully on the floor in full traditional costume within earshot of the organizing committee, said softly to himself in Javanese, "Perhaps once this gamelan was very good, but it seems to have been in stasis [i.e., left unplayed] for too long" (Djajadiningrat 1936, 315; see also Nagazumi 1972, 27). Wahidin's sotto-voce, symbolically prescient diagnosis piqued Djajadiningrat's interest. The regent then lent his support to the educational charity headed by Wahidin, an initiative that contributed directly to the forming of Boedi Oetomo.

Informal Javanese cultural associations had, of course, existed before the establishment of Boedi Oetomo. The Thursday night discussion sessions described

in the *Bintang Soerabaia* article quoted earlier were traditionally held in much of Java. Koentjaraningrat (1985, 285–286) characterizes these small-scale *saraseyan* gatherings at which “subjects such as ethics, morals, philosophy, literature, or politics” were discussed by groups of “*priyayi* gentlemen who share some common intellectual interests” as critical sites for the development of national education, language, and the state. An 1872 newspaper article describes the Bambang Nilo Sadhono club, a Javanese *kumpulan* (gathering) and *arisan* (rotating credit union) in Surabaya that met monthly over food and drinks at the house of one of its thirty members to discuss customs, friendship, and mutual aid. Members were expected to discourse politely and without ill will and to wear white waistcoats at meetings. The correspondent who observed one of their sessions was impressed by the seriousness of this gathering, at which notably no gamelan played, in contrast to a more disorderly club of *plezier* seekers called Bambang Plessier.³

Boedi Oetomo differed from earlier discussion groups in its scope (with local branches formed in different cities within months of its establishment) and emphasis on social engagement and instigating cultural change. From the time of its first congress, held at a teacher training school in Yogyakarta in October 1908 with delegates attending from around Java, members debated Westernization and the merits of Javanese tradition, the opposing needs to educate the masses and maintain aristocratic privilege, and whether it was better to alter or reinforce customs (*adat*). These debates resulted in schisms and the formation of other mass organizations, some with more explicitly political aims and with more inclusive memberships. The first decades of the twentieth century was a critical period when intellectuals began to “participate in the institutionalization, in symbolic and organizational terms, of some of the crucial aspects of the quest for the ordering of social and cultural experience. Their participation is especially marked in the crystallization of the common societal and cultural collective identity or identities, based on sharing common attributes or on participation in common symbolic events, and in the articulation of collective goals” (Eisenstadt 1972, 8). There was a heightened consciousness of modernity and “a new epoch formed [. . .] through a renewed relationship to the ancients” (Habermas 1985, 4).

In his analysis of colonialism and modernity, political philosopher Franz Fanon observes that “on the eve of the decisive conflict for national freedom” there are characteristically a “renewing of forms of expression and the rebirth of the imagination” ([1961] 1994, 50). Boedi Oetomo, and the many other ethnically based organizations that followed around the archipelago—including Pasundan (Land of the Sundanese, 1914), Jong Java (Young Java, founded 1918), Young Sumatrans Union (1917), Jong Ambon (1918), Sarekat Ambon (Ambonese Union, 1920), and Timorsch Verbond (Timorese Alliance, 1923) (see Ricklefs 2001,

212)—promoted programs of cultural and artistic renewal as a response to perceived cultural attenuation, defined by Edward Shils as “the diminution of a belief, the loss of skill in the performance of activities, diminution in the degree of precision and detail of the knowledge of the pertinent subject matter, and the diminution of interest in particular objects” (1981, 283).

Central means for cultural revival were public performances by and for elites, staged in elite settings and venues. One of the earliest was a 1909 performance by STOVIA students in Batavia’s schouwburg of a variety program that included three wayang wong excerpts, a comic speech in Dutch with song, a dance impersonation of a Chinese man, and a concluding Ambonese song. It was an amateur evening, but was reviewed in the newspapers and attended by Javanese and Dutch elites, including the wife of the governor general.⁴ The evening’s success no doubt encouraged the formation of the student cultural organization, *Langen Siswo* (Student Pleasure), by STOVIA students. *Langen Siswo* offered regular performances of Javanese dance, drama, and gamelan in the schouwburg and other venues for the Batavia public starting in 1913. It owned its own gamelan and a set of wayang kulit puppets and had its own clubhouse with a dining room that once a week was converted into a practice space for Javanese dance (Judono 1990, 31–33). Other student and amateur performance groups on the *Langen Siswo* model followed, including clubs formed in the Netherlands by students from the Indies (Cohen 2010, 110–113; Cohen 2013).

The Java Institute

Intellectuals increasingly valorized the particularity of their cultural traditions on a pan-local basis (cf. Robertson 1995, 37). They were inspired by the East-meets-West philosophy of Indian public intellectual and poet Rabindranath Tagore, which entered the colonies via the Dutch translations and commentaries of the Javanese poet Noto Soeroto. Many Javanese elites participated in the theological movement, which viewed “the East” as the source of universal wisdom and a means “to overcome the spiritual crisis of the West” (Tsuchiya 1987, 44). A 1918 Dutch-language congress dedicated to the “development” (*ontwikkeling*) of Javanese culture held at the *kepatihan* of the court of Surakarta and organized by Dutch and Javanese intellectuals, including philosophers, theologians, archaeologists, and philologists, resolved that Javanese culture, with the exception of music, had been chronically undermined since the advent of colonialism and that wayang should be used to instruct the masses in ancient values (Supardi 2007, 65). This was the assertion of a new function for wayang, which had become increasingly disenchanted and emptied of its everyday and ceremonial functions. Wayang

was thereafter subject to what Canclini (1995, 118) calls the “aestheticist spiritualization of the patrimony,” interpreted according to theosophical theories and conceptions (Sears 1996).

Having demonstrated the urgency of addressing the decline of Javanese culture, the organizers of the 1918 congress secured funding from the colonial government and the next year established the Java-Instituut (Java Institute), a learned society dedicated to developing the indigenous cultures of Java, Madura, Sunda, and Bali through conferences, exhibitions and performances, discussions, courses of instruction, quizzes, and publications. The main organizers were the future Mangkunegara VII, Hussein Djajadiningrat, Boedi Oetomo leader Sastrowidjono, South African-born archaeologist F. D. K. Bosch, Dutch socialist Samuel Koperberg, Leiden-trained philologist Raden Ngabei Poerbatjaraka, and Dutch architect Thomas Karsten (Supardi 2007, 73–74). The Java Institute launched the academic journal *Djawa* in 1921 and in 1935 established the Sono Budoyo Museum in the northern courtyard of the kraton of Yogyakarta, an institution that remains a key resource for scholars of Javanese culture. There were earlier research organizations dedicated to the study of particular Indonesian cultures and societies, such as the Batak Institute at Leiden University (founded 1906), the Aceh Institute (founded 1916), and a cluster of institutes dedicated to the study of different peoples of Indonesia based at Amsterdam’s Colonial Institute—some of which had branches in Indonesia (e.g., the Medan branch of the East-Coast of Sumatra Institute). The Java Institute distinguished itself from these earlier organizations by not only documenting Javanese culture’s past and present but also by attempting to shape its future. However, it was intended as a time-limited intervention: according to the institute’s statutes it was to be formally disbanded in 1948.

One of the Java Institute’s mechanisms for developing culture was through performances, often held in conjunction with its conferences. Careful curatorship, detailed program notes, and thorough documentation were hallmarks. Some programs were intended to bring attention to marginal, etiolated, or endangered art forms or to revitalize archaic performance genres. Other productions wedded age-old themes, techniques, and structures to modern European modes of presentation. Innovative performances reached back into the Javanese past explored by philologists and archaeologists to create works addressing modern, educated audiences.

The Java Institute’s most inventive production was probably *Loetoeng Kasaroeng* (Stray Monkey), an operatic play presented on an open-air stage during the 1921 congress in Bandung under the patronage of Bandung’s regent, Raden Adipati Aria Muharam Wiranatakusumah V.⁵ The Lutung Kasarung story, which

concerns an exiled princess protected by a godling in monkey guise, was known from the repertoire of *pantun*—a disappearing bardic storytelling form in which a solo reciter accompanies himself on *kecapi* or the Sundanese fiddle known as *tarawangsa* to recount ancient Sundanese myths and legends. *Lutung Kasarung* was traditionally retold as a form of *ngaruat*—a sort of exorcism rite—and thus was considered an appropriate tale to inaugurate the newly-built *kabupaten* building (Java-Instituut 1921, 19). A scholarly edition of the oral epic had been published by C. M. Pleyte in 1910, and Pleyte and Dutch journalist H. J. Kiewiet de Jonge were employed to prepare a script.

For the production, a multilevel stage, influenced by modern European scenography—the program (Java-Instituut 1921, 28) mentions avant-garde German director Max Reinhardt and English theater theorist Edward Gordon Craig—was constructed in a natural outdoor arena in Bandung’s central *alun-alun* square, with semi-abstract background paintings fashioned by a pair of Javanese artists representing mountains and trees. Spectators, who numbered in the thousands, sat on the ground, with the exception of a small number of seated VIP guests. The text was all sung, in the manner of *langendriya*. Musical accompaniment was provided by a variety of local ensembles, under the direction of a Sundanese musician named Idi. The music was intended to sample and profile Sunda’s musical diversity and included *kecapi* (zither), *tembang* (sung poetry to *kecapi* accompaniment), *degung* (a small gamelan associated with “the landed nobility”; cf. Heins 1977, 62), *tarawangsa* (spiked fiddle), *renteng* (a ceremonial gamelan form deriving from isolated highland villages; cf. 72–144), and *angklung* (shaken bamboo rattles). Certain modifications were made to suit the theatrical setting. The *degung* ensemble, for example, was enhanced with a newly designed, high-pitched bamboo flute that became known later as *suling degung* and a battery of *gendang* drums of the sort customarily used to accompany dance (Spiller 2004, 181–183). Directing the all-Sundanese cast was a Sundanese school principal named Raden Kanduruan Kartabrata.⁶ Articles on the production stress how it endeavored to fashion an authentically Sundanese art as an alternative to Javanese *wayang wong* and an antidote to *komedi stambul*, lambasted as an “unconscious parody” of European musical theater.⁷

The stage production generated great excitement and was subject to multiple analyses and interpretations, both nationally and internationally. An article in the English-language magazine *Sluyters’ Monthly* categorized *Loetoeng Kasaroeng* as a Sundanese mystery play, with the godling standing for “the Son of Heaven [. . .] seized with love for humanity” (Kiewit de Jonge 1921, 461). An analysis of the play in *The Theosophist* interpreted its esoteric aspects. For example, it explained the exiled princess’ six sisters as “the interlaced triangles of matter and spirit, sent by

heavenly wisdom to young humanity (the youngest of the sisters) to teach her humbleness and drive her to the forest and loneliness of the physical plane. Here the Teacher comes to men, not as a heavenly prince but disguised as a monkey. Do not the Teachers of humanity always come under unexpected forms?" (van Leeuwen 1925, 798). The production spawned a new genre of Sundanese musical theater, known as *gending karesmen*, suitable for presentation at elite venues and events. A highly exacting performing art, *gending karesmen* required close coordination among dialogue, music, and movement—"late on one note and an entire act is ruined" (Salmoen 1949, 273)—and raised the status of Sundanese performance as a result. Wiranatakusumah bankrolled the play's adaptation into a film—the first feature-length fictional film made in Java—under the direction of L. Heuvel-dorp, who reportedly came with Hollywood experience.⁸ The film, which was produced by a Bandung-based start-up studio called the Java Film Company, was exhibited in cities and towns around West Java, with live musical accompaniment provided by the enhanced *degung* ensemble that accompanied the stage version. Critics were not impressed by the film technically, and it did not do well at the box office, but the innovative *degung* accompaniment was widely imitated, and this tradition-based ensemble remains prominent in Sunda (Taufik Abdullah, Misbach, and Ardan 1993, 7–85; Spiller 2004).

The Java Institute was a meeting ground for European, Indo, Javanese, and Balinese scholars of art and culture. Its performances were launching pads for discussions and debates on the arts and culture, accompanied by "pre-advice" to congresses, presentations of papers, and responses duly printed in the pages of *Djāwā* and congress proceedings. Areas of debate included the positive and negative effects of musical notation, appropriate forms of training, the dangers of "Westernization," and individual versus collective art. Java Institute scholars recognized that the arts were undergoing significant changes in their lifetimes (see, e.g., Pigeaud [1932] 2003), but the focus of nearly all performance research was on traditional culture, taken to be "synonymous with the archaic and obsolete" (Shils 1981, 20) and doomed to be obliterated by modernity if not diligently documented and modified. Work on residual and archaic arts was considered a moral obligation, and "during the still, hot-house colonial 'thirties, [. . .] the greatest florescence of creative Western scholarship on Indonesian life took place" (B. Anderson 1970, 192).

Although the Java Institute was accused of cultural imperialism by postcolonialists, nearly all the Europeans and Indos involved in it were devoted amateurs, who wrote program notes for sumptuous kraton performances, edited scholarly editions of performance texts, and produced monographs out of their love for the arts. Jacob Kats, author of an important monograph on wayang kulit (Kats 1923)

as well as studies of tembang and other arts, worked as a teacher and principal in a Surakarta secondary school (see particularly Arps 2000b). One ex-pupil fondly recalled a half-century later that there was nothing "awkward" about him teaching Javanese language to Javanese students because he "knew so much about the Javanese culture. And he was such a good man" (Mrázek 2010: 238). Theodoor Pigeaud worked for the colonial government as a lexicographer. He wrote his *Javaansche volksvertoningen* (Javanese folk performances, 1991 [1938]), a massive tome covering traditions of topeng, masquerade, stage magic, trance, hobby-horse dancing, Islamic praise singing, and folk dances from all over the island of Java, as a sideline to his work on a Javanese-Dutch dictionary. Architect and town planner Thomas Karsten created "on spec" a detailed plan for a Javanese "folk theater" (*volkschouwburg*). Karsten based his theater on the form of the *pendhapa*, but it included a raked auditorium and backstage area, with walls to exclude unwanted spectators and without supporting pillars to obstruct sightlines. Ten years passed between the publication of his plans and their realization in a modified form in Semarang (Karsten 1921; Jessup 1982; Kusno 2000, 33–38).

One of the most prominent, and among the most impactful, of the Java Institute scholars was Jaap Kunst, who arrived in the Indies in 1919 as a violinist in a musical trio. Fascinated by Javanese gamelan, Kunst stayed on to work in government offices in Batavia and Bandung while conducting research into musical traditions of the archipelago on weekends and holidays. Kunst's scholarly work, supported academically by correspondence with the German comparative musicologist Erich M. von Hornstobel, was self-financed with the exception of a two-year appointment (1930–1932) as government musicologist under the Ministry of Education and Religion.

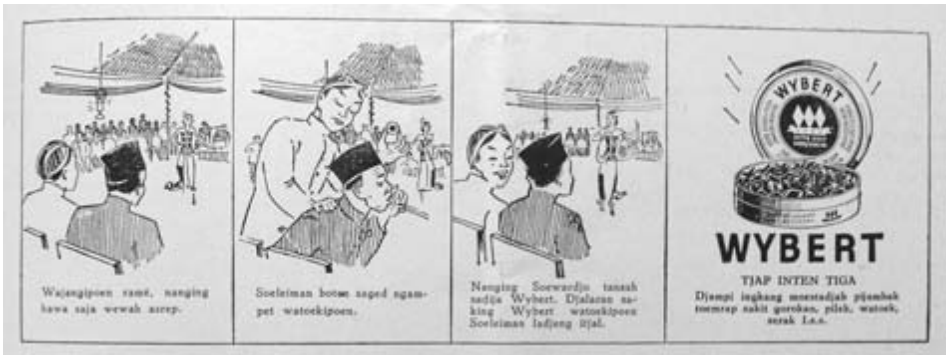
Kunst conducted fieldwork in Sumatra, Sulawesi, Nias, Flores, Timor, and the islands of Maluku, carefully recording the instrumental and vocal music of all these sites. But his major work was on Javanese gamelan, resulting in his monumental *Music in Java* (1973). He established a fieldwork-based approach to the study of world music and coined the name still used for his scholarly discipline, ethnomusicology. He also nurtured a generation of Indonesian scholars, most notably the Sundanese musician, composer, playwright, and educator Raden Machjar Angga Koesoemadinata—who applied (though not without problems) Kunst's approach to studying tuning systems and musical modes to the field of Sundanese music. In a publication written years later, Koesoemadinata recalls his relation to Kunst as being characterized by an unlikely reciprocity, with Kunst teaching Koesoemadinata about Western music and music theory and Koesoemadinata lecturing "the famous musicologist" about Sundanese tunings, modes, vocal ornaments, and the like (Koesoemadinata 1969, 5–6).

Kunst was a “salvage” ethnographer convinced that the musical instruments and modes of music making he was documenting were doomed to disappear with modernization. He had good reason for concern. For example, in 1913–1914, the colonial government confiscated more than 1,300 bronze kettle drums from Alor islanders in lieu of taxes owed. Some were perhaps of Dong Son origin and thus thousands of years old, but all were destroyed—dumped in the sea or recycled as scrap metal (Bernet Kempers 1988, 366). Unlike earlier and later generations of European gamelan enthusiasts, Kunst did not sit down to play gamelan with Indonesian musicians. He would readily demonstrate yodeling and play violin in musical exchanges with indigenous musicians, but manifested a scientific detachment from his “subjects” that prohibited participating directly in their music making. However, as curator at Amsterdam’s Colonial Institute (renamed the Tropical Institute in 1949), a position he held from 1936 to 1956, Kunst supported the development of a youth gamelan group known as Babar Lajar and encouraged his student, the American ethnomusicologist Mantle Hood, to undertake practical studies of gamelan. This contributed to gamelan being played at university campuses and by community organizations around the world (Mendonça 2011).

Kridha Beksa Wirama and Courses of Instruction

The dangers that modernity posed to Java’s artistic traditions were felt acutely by members of the Javanese aristocracy, its hereditary guardians. Most tended toward traditionalism, espousing “certain parts of the older tradition as the only legitimate symbols of the traditional order and uphold[ing] them against ‘new’ trends,” tending “toward formalization on both the symbolic and organizational levels” (Eisenstadt 1973, 22). The youth association Jong Java, founded in Batavia in 1915 by a group of STOVIA graduates and students wishing to instill shared Javanese cultural values into the Javanese who were studying in Batavia, successfully pressured the kraton of Yogyakarta in 1918 to open up a school for Javanese dance and music: Kridha Beksa Wirama (Measured Dance Training).⁹ This marked officially the first time that Yogyakarta kraton-style dance was taught outside the kraton walls. Until that point the kraton had implicitly sided with Walter Benjamin’s point that “the uniqueness of a work of art is inseparable from its being imbedded in the fabric of tradition” ([1936] 1969, 223). However, the nihilism of World War I sparked fears regarding Javanese culture’s future that overshadowed the long-standing effort to preserve the aura of kraton art by prohibiting emulation (Soerjodiningrat 1940, 240; Joesoepadi 1940, 133–134).

Kridha’s founding heralded an age when traditions were disembedded of associated social systems, reflexively ordered and reordered, and offered up in alienable



Javanese-language advertisement for Wybert cough drops. Soelaiman, in his Muslim *peci* cap, is unable to hold back his coughing, though the wayang wong action is *rame* (lively). Thankfully his neighbor Soewardjo, dressed in traditionalist *priyayi* costume, always carries cough drops and can help. *Kajawen* 14, no. 57 (18 August 1939), 923.

forms (cf. Giddens [1990] 1991, 19; Comaroff and Comaroff 2009, 3). Thereafter, images of *srimpi* dancers could be used to sell soap, beer, and cocoa powder and the clown-servants of wayang could be employed for colonial propaganda, including a 1938 film urging Javanese to “transmigrate” to other, less populated islands.¹⁰ The *alus* arts complex was renovated and recharged. Change was felt to be a necessity if it was not succumb to “cultural exhaustion” due to exaggerated formality, the fate of art in the Middle Ages according to the argument of Dutch cultural historian Johan Huizinga (Gouda 1995, 125–127).

Kridha was led by two princes, G. P. H. Tedjokusumo and B. P. H. Soerjodiningrat, and subsidized by Yogyakarta’s kraton. Classes met in the spacious *pendhapa* of Tedjokusumo’s Yogyakarta mansion. Instruction initially followed the traditional system of “learning by imitation,” but as class sizes grew, a new system of instruction was invented, based on European techniques, scientific ideas, and organizational means (Soerjodiningrat 1926, 50; Koentjaraningrat 1985, 308; Soedarsono 2002, 434). The building blocks of dance, with terminology for leg, arm, and head positions and movements analogous to the positions of ballet (first position, second position, etc.), were abstracted from particular dances. Syllabi, textbooks, diplomas, and a system of graded learning became part of the curriculum. British dance ethnographer Felicia Hughes-Freeland (2008, 48) describes the system of instruction in detail:

Kridha Beksa Wirama staff developed a technique based on counting in cycles of eight to help the dancers keep time. They also standardized dance

movement, nomenclature and choreography, and produced photographic records of “correct” movements. They classified court dance movement into eight “basic” dances (*joged pokok*) or modes on a continuum from restrained (*alus*) to rough (*kasar*). They also formalized a practice of walking to music (*tayungan*), derived from the way court warriors used to walk in ceremonial processions, which trained male dancers in a sense of rhythm and the basic movement patterns for all the dance modes.

Completing the full Kridha curriculum usually took three years.

In the early years students were all Jong Java members, but in the 1920s instruction was opened to the public, including to Chinese and Europeans. Starting in 1923 there were international students at Kridha from Russia, Latvia, India, Morocco, Vietnam, China, and the United States, some of whom became reasonably accomplished (Kementerian Penerangan 1953a, 686–687). For example, Claire Holt, the American scholar of Indonesian arts, studied dance at Kridha in the 1930s. Her lesson notes (Holt n.d.) reflect an unprecedented analytical precision, a reflection as much of her own propensity for intense absorption in the performative moment (cf. B. Anderson 1970, 191) as the capacity of her teachers for abstraction.¹¹ As the Kridha textbook, *Serat piwulang joged* (Dance instruction), published by the Java Institute in 1925, explains, “Dance instruction no longer only involves practice [*praktik*], as instruction was formally carried out, but there is also instruction in theory [*teori*]” (Pakempalan Kridhabeksa Wirama 1925, 3).¹²

Kridha also opened courses in wayang kulit and gamelan, and provided a model for schools and courses of instruction in other Javanese refined arts, including tembang. The wayang kulit course, Pasinaon Dhalang ing Surakarta (Puppeteer Training of Surakarta, or Padhasuka for short), was established in 1923 by the royal court of Surakarta at the Radya Pustaka Museum. It was prompted by a 1921 speech to the Java Institute by an amateur puppeteer named Soetopo, who criticized deteriorating standards of performance and the inability of puppeteers to explain world events to their audiences (Clara van Groenendaal 1985, 30–43; Sears 1996, 146–152). This course was followed in 1925 by the Yogyakarta puppetry school Habirandha, supported by the kraton and the Java Institute, and in 1931 by Pasinaon Dhalang ing Mangku-Nagaran (Mangkunagaran Puppeteer Training, or PDMN), sponsored by Surakarta’s junior court. Students at these shadow puppetry courses were instructed in how to perform a written playscript (*pakem*). While traditionally puppeteers extemporized plays based on orally transmitted story outlines, a stock of verbal formulae, and gestural vocabularies, stu-

dents at the modern puppet schools studied from textbooks in which narrations, dialogue, *sulukan* (mood songs), and stage directions were written out in full. Memorization and precise imitation were emphasized, supplemented by theoretical lessons on topics such as "the appropriate wording of the suluk sung by the dalang and the meaning of these words; the explanations of place names; the correct genealogical relations of the wayang characters; the supposedly proper chronological order of the respective stories; and the relation between the Indian epics, the Ramayana and Mahabharata, and the Javanese wayang stories" (Clara van Groenendael 1985, 32; see also Arps 1985). A diploma offered symbolic capital and was valued by professionals even if some of the materials studied were overly esoteric for the tastes of typical wayang audiences.¹³

The wayang courses effectively reconfigured the skills and knowledge of the puppeteer into a form of what Anthony Giddens calls "expertise," "which, in principle, anyone could acquire, and without having to perform specialized, arcane rituals to do so" (Giddens and Pierson 1998, 110). With this disembedding of the theater from its ritual frames, wayang kulit was no longer considered to be a sacred art by urban youths, but was a mere "spectacle" (*tontonan*) (cf. Soeharda Sastrasewignja 1934–1935). The puppetry schools were a wedge in a widening gap between modernizing urban and "old-fashioned" rural (*kampung* or *desa*) cultural practices (Perlman 2010, 91; Cohen 2011, 137–139).

Formal education laid the ground for an experimental, modernizing attitude to wayang. Jaap Kunst notes that eight of the twenty-three students studying wayang at Kridha around 1930 were Roman Catholics interested in using the medium for proselytizing. They subsequently created innovative wayang wong productions based on the story of David and Goliath and the life of Saint Agnes of Purworejo in the 1930s, and after independence a whole new wayang genre was invented called *wayang wahyu* that used shadow puppets and gamelan to tell Bible stories (Kunst 1994, 75; Poplawska 2004). Another invention was a little-documented wayang kulit form known as *wayang wahana* (meaningful or interpretive wayang) created by Raden Mas Sutarto Harjawahana in the late 1930s. This genre presented stories about contemporary life, with newly designed figures in contemporary dress representing the Javanese, Dutch, Arabs, and Chinese. In an interview, Sutarto explained that his plays lasted an hour or two and were stories that had not been seen before so that audiences would wish to stay until the end. Dialogue was meant to be easily understood by modern youth (no kawi words allowed!) and could be in Javanese, Sundanese, Indonesian, or Dutch—"entirely without restriction"; *sulukan* mood songs were optional. When asked if that then meant that anyone could perform *wayang wahana*, Sutarto answered in the

affirmative, “but to attract the audience one must be a skilled speaker and have sufficient knowledge. The story must contain advice about matters such as colonization, health, education, etc.” (Sadono 1939, 2).

Many courses, studios, amateur clubs, and art circles sprang into existence in the 1920s and 1930s to disseminate and modernize Javanese artistic traditions. There were even study-at-home instruction manuals for Javanese dance, including one by Wignjahambeksa (1942), a former Surakarta kraton dancer and the grandson of Tondhakusuma. Occasionally associations offered public performances of Javanese theater, dance, and music, typically as charity benefits.

One of the most influential and inventive of these modern artistic associations was Anggana Raras, a dance studio located in Tanah Abang, Batavia. The principal teacher was the kraton-trained dancer Raden Mas Kodrat; Kodrat’s brother, the Leiden-trained philologist Poerbatjaraka, served as advisor. Anggana Raras, its name taken from a stock phrase of the standard opening narration of wayang meaning “beautiful women,” was established by a coterie of educated women who wished to find space for Javanese culture in modern urban life. Traditional dances were condensed and simplified to suit the pace of the modern lifestyle. Repetitions were eliminated, with no item lasting longer than fifteen minutes so as not to bore foreign spectators.

One of Anggana Raras’s founders was the modern dancer Retnowati Latip, the daughter of a leading physician in Batavia, who had earned a diploma in Dalcroze Eurhythmics from the famed Hellerau-Laxenburg School near Vienna and had danced for two years in Europe in the company of Austrian modern choreographer Rosalia Chladek. On her return to Batavia, Retnowati taught rhythm, musical expression, and dance using the Dalcroze Method, and in 1932 and 1933 gave a number of recitals of her own solo dance compositions, accompanied invariably by Western classical music. Critics found her overly European and compared her unfavorably to the modern Javanese dancer Raden Mas Jodjana, who had built his career in Europe through synthesizing European modernism with Javanese tradition.¹⁴ This might be the reason why Retnowati urged her modern dance students in Batavia, including Carolina Jeanne de Souza-Ijke (who later danced professionally in Europe under the name of Retna Mohini), to supplement their studies with Javanese dance study with Kodrat (Helmi 1997, 261–262).

Anggana Raras was promoted as a cultural destination for tourists visiting Batavia and in 1939 was selected to represent the Dutch Indies at the New York World’s Fair, where it offered performances and private instruction in Javanese dance. The group’s spokesman Raden Abdul Latief, in a lecture-demonstration covered by *New York Times* dance critic John Martin, spoke about the group’s work as being based on a “new and young idea: back to your own culture, developing it

in a modern direction."¹⁵ Poerbatjaraka, in an article in the leading literary journal *Poedjangga baroe* (New poet), argued that institutions like Anggana Raras deserved to be supported by the educated middle class, not only as a bulwark against Westernization but also because gamelan and traditional dance were the only scientific subjects not monopolized by Europeans. Although literary study might be dependent on European philological methodologies, only Javanese were capable of exercising critical judgment in the field of traditional performance (Poerbatjaraka 1940).

Other ethnic groups around the archipelago followed in the wake of Java's modernizing of tradition. West Sumatrans formed clubs dedicated to Minang dance and music both in Java and Sumatra. The Batak music club Oening-Oeningan, under the leadership of H. F. Sitompoel, was one of more than fifty Batak cultural and social organizations operating in Medan in the late 1930s. The influential Wirahma Sari (Essential Rhythm) was a Sundanese dance club in Bandung under the direction of Raden Sambas Wirakusumah, a local administrator (*lurah*) and the son of a Sumedang aristocrat who owned a wayang wong troupe. Wirakusumah invented a set of refined concert dances or *ibing* out of the "raw" materials of tayuban, Cirebonese topeng, wayang wong, and pencak (Soeridiradja and Adiwidjaja 1949). Following Kridha's example, *ibing* was taught in a systematic fashion with preset choreographies and an elaborate nomenclature for movements and positions. Wirakusumah's choreographies, which became known generically as *ibing keurseus* (dances taught in a course of study), were popularized through schools, dance clubs, and pasar malam competitions, and they rehabilitated the image of dance among Sundanese elites (Anis Sujana 1996; Endang Caturwati 2007, 104–109; Spiller 2010).¹⁶

Schools and Churches

Government schools also had roles to play in the modernization of performing arts in Java, Sumatra, Sulawesi, and other islands in the first decades of the twentieth century. Arts that had once been highly individualized in expression, or practiced in different ways in different villages or districts, became more uniform in practice through education. New aesthetic norms and forms were popularized through gala performances marking national holidays and celebrating the end of the school year.

In the 1920s the influential Minangkabau educator Moehammad Sjafai advocated studying the arts in Sumatran schools to cultivate aesthetic appreciation and strengthen local culture. He instructed students in theater games, such as *standen* (Dutch for "attitudes"), in which students, working without props,

improvised group compositions imitating the characteristics of people or things ranging from farmers to an airplane. These compositions were to be created quickly and neatly. The exercise developed groupwork and visualization skills, discipline, and appreciation for social attitudes and manners (Thalib [1953] 1978, 72–73).

Sjafei's emphasis on the arts was mirrored in the work of the influential Dutch educational theorist, G. J. Nieuwenhuis (1920, 521), who saw instruction in local arts as a means to "direct the moral education on its own foundations." Inclusion of what is today in Indonesia called *muatan daerah*, "local content," offered a bridge to learning. Nieuwenhuis cited the example of a Dutch tutor in East Sumatra who found that teaching pencak silat broke down his students' aversion to physical exertion and encouraged participation in sports and games generally. As a result of these influential educationalists, local forms of dance and music, along with children's games, songs, and martial arts, were taught in many schools in Java and Sumatra.

Churches and missions also had significant roles to play in reviving "ethnic" arts as symbols of local identity in different parts of the archipelago. Albertus Soegijapranata, who in 1940 became the first-ever Javanese bishop, published an article in the Dutch-language magazine of Xaverius College to defend Javanese dance as a spiritual practice.¹⁷

In the 1930s, a team of Minahassan researchers under the supervision of school supervisors documented indigenous music and dance forms in North Sulawesi. This material was taught to students at the missionary teaching college in Tomohon, resulting in a secular revival. Songs and dances once solely associated with planting and harvesting were performed in new contexts such as national holidays and racing days (Kunst 1994, 85). Among the dances revived was the harvest dance *maengket*, which was the object of study of a local ethnological research center, the Kruyt-Adriani Institute in Manado, established in 1937. *Maengket* had previously been associated with harvest rituals, but in the 1930s it was aestheticized and danced for pure entertainment with the explicit sanction of the Netherlands Missionary Society (NZG) (Henley 1996, 135).

A prohibition against *gondang*, a ritual music originally associated with trance and ancestor worship, was gradually lifted by the Toba Batak Protestant Church starting in the 1920s. A Synod of 1933 dictated which pieces could be performed and under what circumstances. It was prohibited, for example, to play *gondang* at funerals, nor could one play pieces associated with summoning spirits or curing, but a restricted repertoire of *gondang* could be played at "customary" (adat) events such as the founding of a new village. The expurgated repertoire was known as *gondang riang-riang* (joyful gondang) (Okazaki 1994, 158; Purba 2005,

221) and paved the way for the inclusion of *gondang* in Catholic Church rituals after Vatican II (Okazaki 1998).

Taman Siswa

Even more influential in the “development” of traditional arts than the churches and government schools, however, was Taman Siswa (Garden of Pupils), an independent educational movement founded in 1922 by Suwardi Suryaningrat. Suwardi, or Ki Hadjar Dewantara as he styled himself starting in 1928, was the nephew of Paku Alam V, the ruler of Yogyakarta’s junior court. Suwardi had studied at STOVIA from 1903 to 1909 (though he failed to graduate), worked as a technician in pharmaceutical and sugar concerns in Yogyakarta and Bandung, and wrote for Dutch- and Malay-language periodicals before becoming involved in anticolonial politics. He joined Sarekat Islam (Islamic Union, an Islamic trade union that morphed into a nationalist organization) in 1912, and in 1913 he founded the first Indonesian political party, the Indische Partij, with another former STOVIA student, Tjipto Mangoenkoesoemo, and the Indo journalist Ernest Douwes Dekker. Suwardi published a controversial Dutch-language political essay titled “If I Were a Dutchman” this same year, in which he protested against celebrating Dutch independence. The article concludes, “If I were a Dutchman I would never celebrate the independence ceremony in a country which is still being colonized. I would first give the people whom we still colonize their independence, and then celebrate our independence” (Suwardi quoted in Scherer 1975, 304).

Because of this article, which was widely circulated in Malay translation and gained him notoriety as an anticolonialist activist, Suwardi spent the years 1913 to 1919 in exile in the Netherlands. There he first became acquainted with modern pedagogy, particularly the work of “Montessori and Fröbel in Europe and the Dalton school system in the United States, with their stress on self-expression, the adjustment of teaching to the terms of the child’s world, and the techniques of indirect guidance and control” (McVey 1967, 133). Suwardi also joined the Indische Vereeniging (Indies Association), a student support group led by poet and law student Raden Mas Noto Soeroto, who introduced Suwardi to Rabindranath Tagore’s ideas about education and the synthesis of East and West. Suwardi performed Javanese dance and played gamelan with other Indische Vereeniging members, thereby realizing the importance of the arts for generating solidarity among Javanese of different backgrounds and gaining respect across cultural boundaries (Cohen 2010, 110–113; Cohen 2013). It is not surprising, then, that instruction in folksongs and games (for young children), classical Javanese dance

(for girls), and gamelan (for boys) were prominent parts of the curriculum of his Taman Siswa schools from the start.

Ki Hadjar wrote prolifically about education and culture in Dutch, Indonesian, and Javanese (Dewantara [1967] 1994, [1962] 2004). Citing European cultural theory side by side with Javanese aphorisms, he strove to justify tradition “in the light of knowledge which is not itself authenticated by tradition” (Giddens [1990] 1991, 38), reconstructing its parameters and purposes to generate a collective identity. Across his writings Ki Hadjar reiterated how studying and practicing the arts made students more humane and emotionally balanced, developed “character” (*budi pekerti*) and refined feelings, and provided the tools to lead a harmonious life in an ethical manner, with a refined appreciation of what is beautiful. Specific arts had specific payoffs. *Srimpi*, which was studied in a simplified form by Taman Siswa girls, increased ethnic awareness; spirituality; and a sense of rhythm, control, and bodily health: it was morally uplifting. Spoken drama, which, as shown later, gained popularity starting in the 1920s, developed skills in memorization and elocution; taught etiquette; provided new insights into the world; diminished awkward shyness; created a match among words and thoughts, feelings, will, and energy—what Ki Hadjar called in Dutch *psychis globalisatie* or “psychic globalization”—and prepared the grounds for learning.

In a speech delivered to a 1927 Javanese language congress and printed in *Djâwâ* (reprinted and translated in Dewantara [1967] 1994, 153–159, 236–242), Ki Hadjar categorically rejected European involvement in Javanese arts, arguing that the aesthetic judgments of Europeans were inevitably misguided: Europeans were wrong in believing that Javanese arts were dead, and their efforts to revive them prevented their autonomous development. The Javanese had to take responsibility for their own arts, he argued, which meant being aware of regional differences (such as the court traditions of Yogyakarta and Surakarta), but not fanatically adhering to a single style for the sake of generating collective solidarities. In an article published after independence, he went even further, rejecting the Java Institute, Batak Institute, and like institutions as colonial machinations to “purify” regional cultures and systematically distance regions of Indonesia from each other (Dewantara [1967] 1994, 91).

The examples Ki Hadjar cited in his writings were largely drawn from Javanese traditional arts, the main focus of study of Taman Siswa schools in Java. Both Javanese and local arts were taught at Taman Siswa schools outside of Java, however, and occasionally Javanese Taman Siswa students in the 1930s also studied the art forms of other ethnic groups. Ki Hadjar set up an educational exchange link between Taman Siswa and Santiniketan, a university and cultural center founded by Rabindranath Tagore in a small town in West Bengal, after Tagore’s visit to Java



Bedhaya dancers of Taman Siswa, c. 1935. Photograph courtesy Museum Dewantara Kirti Griya.

in 1927. Santiniketan staff and students interested in studying Javanese dance stayed in the Taman Siswa dorms in Yogyakarta, and Taman Siswa staff were sent to Santiniketan, where they studied Tagore's interpretations of Indian dance at Santiniketan's College of Music and Dance, among other subjects. Indian dance was introduced to the Taman Siswa curriculum in the 1930s as a gesture of solidarity. When the Grand Gazebo fronting the Taman Siswa headquarters in Yogyakarta was formally opened in 1938, former Santiniketan students staged an "Indian version of a Ramayana dance" (Cohen 2010, 165). Ki Hadjar believed that this sort of exchange of cultures, including Javanese studying Sundanese music and vice versa, was important for mutual understanding and comprehension (Dewantara [1962] 2004, 315). He argued that cultural barriers should not stand in the way of Javanese dance being taught in Taman Siswa schools in Bali or of Javanese studying Balinese dance because "mixture will result in new and dynamic energies and forward movement" (n.a. 1940, 165). Starting in 1938, Ki Hadjar endorsed the position that Indonesian culture should be defined by "the high points of regional culture" (Dewantara [1967] 1994, 315)—a definition enshrined in 1945 as national cultural policy. In Ki Hadjar's understanding, this

did not mean purifying cultures of outside influences, but it did mean guarding against passive copying of Hollywood. Javanese cultural organizations allied to the Taman Siswa schools and Ki Hadjar's teachings shifted their orientation and range of activities accordingly. Thus, for example, the Javanese performing arts association Mardi Goeno of Surakarta enlarged its activities to become an Indonesian arts circle in 1937.¹⁸

East versus West

Ki Hadjar understood that the traditional arts not only served to develop ethnic and national awareness, intellect and feeling, brain and heart but were also a bulwark against negative Western influences. One particular performance form that came up for repeated criticism in the 1930s was European couple dancing. European social dance had long been consumed by non-Europeans as a diverting *ton-tonan* (spectacle) at parties, clubs, and pasar malam. (Fences had to be erected around pasar malam dance floors to keep out the prying eyes of "natives.") The waltz and earlier European dance forms had little participatory appeal, however. Not so jazz dance, which generated huge popular enthusiasm. Traditionalists were distressed by men dancing cheek to cheek with women wearing flimsy, open-backed dresses, and particularly by the practice of taxi-dancing in which men purchased tickets to dance with women employed by the venues—which one critic viewed as little different from the illicit Javanese social dance practices known as *marung* or *janggrungan* (n.a. 1931). During a lecture tour of Java, a concerned Javanese intellectual told a German sexologist that "such dances tear down every barrier of sexual restraint and inflame sexual feelings and thoughts in an unhealthy way" (Hirschfeld 1935, 130). Essential differences were drawn between European and Eastern cultural practices: dance in Indonesia and other Asian countries was said to bring form to inner life, whereas the rhythm of jazz dance did not move the spirit, only the body (J. J. 1937). Kridha's cofounder Soerjodiningrat blamed the declining enrollment of teenage boys in Kridha dance classes on the increased popularity of clubs for the study of popular European dances: "We place the culture of Europe in too high a regard" (Soerjodiningrat 1940, 54).

The ideological bifurcation of East and West was also reflected in the establishment of a network of "Eastern" (*Ketimoeran*) radio stations. The first one was the Solosche Radio Vereeniging (Solo Radio Association; SRV), founded in 1933 by Mangkunegara VII, one of the most prominent cultural actors in the last decades of the colonial period. American anthropologist and historian John Pemberton has argued that Mangkunegara VII was a modern proponent of

tradition who sought Javanese culture's recognition as a "very high civilization" (Mangkunegara VII quoted in Pemberton 1994, 130), the equal of Europe. Educated in Leiden, he was active in both Boedi Oetomo and Jong Java and was a cofounder of the Java Institute. He also headed his own theosophically oriented, Dutch-language discussion club, the Cultuur-Wijsgeerigen Studiekring (Cultural-Philosophical Study Circle), which met regularly in the Mangkunegaran palace starting in 1917 after his return from Leiden. The Circle aimed to bring about "closer contact between Western and Javanese culture" (Djajaningrat-Nieuwenhuis 1993, 61); participants included Javanese, Chinese, and European officials and scholars, with invited international speakers.

An inveterate art collector and generous patron of traditional performance, Mangkunegara VII and his principal wife, the Ratu Timur, closely supervised rehearsals of court performances and opened a free dance course at the *kepatihan* residence of the court's prime minister (Holt 1939, 255). Mangkunegara VII distanced himself from the hoary rivalry between Surakarta and Yogyakarta as artistic centers, sending his daughters to study *srimpi* and other dances under Tedjokusumo in Yogyakarta. He took a special interest in *wayang kulit*. With the Java Institute scholar Jacob Kats, he edited a set of summaries of *wayang kulit* plays, which were published in thirty-seven slim volumes by the state publisher Balai Pustaka in 1927–1932; it remains a standard reference for puppeteers and scholars. His 1933 article published in *Djâwâ* on the symbolic and mystical elements of *wayang kulit*, originally presented as a lecture to the Cultuur-Wijsgeerigen Studiekring, is one of the most-cited sources on this topic (Mangkunagoro [1933] 1957; Sears 1996, 165–169). A memorial volume published in 1939 to celebrate the anniversary of the king's ascension compiles tributes from artists and intellectuals around the world. Claire Holt's contribution to the volume describes the palace as "an island within an island," "a spiritual emanation of peace and beauty in sounds of music," a haven from the "destructive powers," "strain and stress," and "convulsions of modern history in the making" (Holt 1939, 250).

The SRV, and the other "Eastern" stations and branches that followed in Batavia, Yogyakarta, Surabaya, Madiun, and Semarang, were by no means run by Luddites. One of Mangkunegara VII's most famous cultural accomplishments was the 1936 live radio transmission of the music of *srimpi* played in the Mangkunegaran palace in Surakarta to accompany the dance of his daughter, G. R. A. Siti Nurul, in the Noordeinde Palace in The Hague (Cohen 2010, 84). From the start, SRV content was focused on arts and entertainment, rather than news and information. (The same was generally true for Dutch-language stations; see Lindsay 1997, 107.) Much of the content, of course, was provided by gramophone records, but there were also many live broadcasts. Listeners could hear music from

the Mangkunegaran, the Tedjukusama's *pendhapa*, Taman Siswa, and the Surakarta and Yogyakarta royal courts (Koentoro 1940, 6). As such, as Australian cultural scholar Jennifer Lindsay (1997, 108) points out, radio contributed to the "democratization" of court arts. Radio and gramophone records made singers and other artists into stars to be interviewed and photographed for newspapers and magazines; the construction of self became to an unprecedented degree a "reflexive project" (Beck, Giddens, and Lash 1994, 74) as performers had to "produce, stage and cobble together their biographies" (13). New performance forms were developed for novelty-hungry listeners. Radio broadcasts from the Bandung station Vereeniging Oosterse Radio Luisterars (founded in 1934), for example, featured ensembles of *kecapi* and *suling* mixed with violin, guitar, and cello. A sketch comedy program known as *Dhagelan Mataram* was created for Yogyakarta's Eastern radio station, *Mataramsche Vereeniging voor Radio Omroep* (founded in 1934) (Karkono 1941, 29–31).¹⁹ Live stage shows of this sort of clowning, known generically as *dhagelan Mataram*, became popular, and the program's star, a comedian named Basiyo, remained a household name in Java into the 1980s and later through his broadcasts and frequently reissued recordings.

"Eastern" radio stations strove to represent the various ethnic groups of the archipelago, with regular broadcasts of *kroncong*, theater songs, *wayang wong*, Javanese and Sundanese gamelan and other musical forms, Melayu music from Sumatra and elsewhere, Chinese music and film songs, Arabic genres such as *gambus*, hybrid musical genres like *gambang kromong*, Hawaiian and Indian music, and radio plays (Takonai 1997). Broadcasts reached into people's houses and lives and engendered a sense of intimate involvement; falling asleep listening to a live broadcast of gamelan from the home of a Yogyakarta prince, one might dream of meeting an ethereal *pesindhen* (n.a. 1935). Radio had many proponents and was reportedly the main reason why small towns in the Cirebon area desired electrification.²⁰ It also had its detractors—for example, Muslims in Medan complaining that Islamic preachers were not adequately represented and the Chinese in Batavia rallying against insufficient Chinese content. Citing Johan Huizinga, an article in *Poedjangga baroe* expressed prescient concerns that radio would lead to the standardization of culture, the mechanization of life, and even spiritual death (Soewandhie 1935).

Bali, Cultural Tourism, Modernized Arts

A Dutch defender of the Lombok expedition of 1894, which resulted in the defeat of the Balinese kingdom of Karangasem and the installation of Dutch colonial rule in Bali's neighboring island of Lombok, interprets the "hyperactivity" of music, dance, cockfighting, ritual, and feasting in Bali and Balinese-dominated Lombok as a form of decadence inflicted by despotic Balinese princes, resulting in their subjects' indolence and poverty (Cool 1897, 100–103). Particularly egregious among the arts was *gandrung*, a same-sex social dance, with boys dressed as dancing girls. Rectification of what American anthropologist Margaret Mead ([1940] 1970, 336) called Bali's "hypertrophy of artistic expression" provided justification for the extension of Dutch imperialism and colonialism and the displacement of Balinese rule.

Fast forward three and a half decades to 1931. At the Exposition Coloniale Internationale in Paris, the Netherlands is heartily promoting Bali as an artistic paradise, a living museum of Java's past, with a company of fifty Balinese dancers and musicians performing excerpts of Balinese theater and dance daily in a Balinese-themed pavilion. The troupe is under the nominal leadership of Tjokorda Gede Raka Soekawati, the Dutch-educated raja of Ubud, a member of the Volksraad (People's Council) and occasional contributor to *Djâwâ*. But behind-the-scenes artistic direction has been provided by Walter Spies, a German painter and musician who worked as a pianist in a Chinese cinema in Bandung and *kapellmeister* (conductor) for the kraton of Yogyakarta's orchestra before Soekawati invited him to set up his studio in Ubud. The popular enthusiasm for *le Théâtre Balinais* rivals even that shown by Parisians and exposition visitors for the banana skirt dances of the African American performer Josephine Baker (Bloembergen 2006, 270). Famously, surrealist writer and director Antonin Artaud ([1931] 1974, 38) is inspired to write an impressionistic essay celebrating the Balinese performers as "re-establishing theatre as pure and independent creativity whose products are hallucinations and terror." The essay is later collected in Artaud's book *Le théâtre et son double*, published in 1938 and a required text today for all students of European and intercultural theater. Artaud's "individual

reading and writing” forms a bridge that allows a “whole society” to make “a fitful contact with a completely different social form” (Jameson 1976, 109).

The influential scholars and artists who researched Balinese arts and culture in the 1920s and 1930s—Walter Spies, Margaret Mead, English anthropologist Gregory Bateson, Canadian composer and ethnomusicologist Colin McPhee, English dance critic Beryl de Zoete, Mexican painter and cartoonist Miguel Covarrubias, and others—generally depicted Bali as “a medieval world [which] had survived intact [. . .] where dance and music of the antique Orient had been miraculously preserved [. . .] until the Dutch conquest in 1906, which brought in its train[ing] schools, hospitals, taxation, Boy Scout clubs, and tourists” (McPhee 1948, 162, 156). “The modern Balinese is forced to recognize that he lives in a changing world, but that is not his ideal, and he does not think in terms of it,” claimed Gregory Bateson ([1937] 1970, 136). This “denial of coevalness” (Fabian 1983, 31), the refusal to recognize the shared historical moment and the global forces that shaped the daily lives of Balinese as much as its researchers, made possible the romantic picturing of Bali as a carefree tropical island, heir to the South Sea island of Tahiti; supported colonial maneuvers to sever Bali from the radical politics of Java; and allowed Bali to be considered as a distinct scholarly object, with minimal reference to neighboring islands or the larger world. More recent scholarship (see particularly Vickers 1989) has patiently deconstructed the imagining of Bali and has demonstrated how interconnected Bali has been historically with the modern world. Dances once considered ancient have been re-conceived as products of colonial modernity’s cultural industries and networks (Hobart 2007).

Bali was colonized in two phases. The north part of the island fell to the Dutch in 1849. By the end of the nineteenth century, its principal port town, Buleleng, was a bustling commercial center, fully linked to the rest of the archipelago by colonial administrators, schools, Chinese-owned shops, newspaper correspondents, visiting stambul troupes, and other touring entertainments. The eccentric Malacca-born Dutch philologist Herman Neubronner van der Tuuk lived in Buleleng between 1870 and 1894, employed by mission societies and the colonial government to translate the Bible and conduct lexicographical research. One of van der Tuuk’s assistants, a Javanese schoolteacher named Raden Soekemi Sosrodihardjo, married a Balinese Brahmin woman, and their son Sukarno became Indonesia’s first president.

During the nineteenth century, the southern part of Bali was under the rule of seven principal kingdoms engaged in slave trading and constant warfare and rebellion. As in the north, these southern kingdoms were culturally connected

with the rest of the world. Chinese traders visited them frequently, speaking to the Balinese about art forms from outside the island (Graves and Kaset-siri 1969). Most Balinese practiced a form of Hindu-Buddhism, but Javanese Islamic texts were read and translated. *Gambuh*, the most prestigious performance form patronized by south Bali's courts, costumed its performers in trade textiles from India and China and batik from Java (Vickers 2005). *Barong landung*, large-scale body puppets representing a princess from China and a prince from south India, featured in processions on important holidays (Gottowik 2010).¹ New art forms were developing constantly. Current scholarship has it that *legong*, a courtly dance form "abstracted and adapted from *gambuh*, using the *semar pagulingan* rather than the usual *gambuh* [musical] ensemble" (Vickers 2010, 6), probably originated around 1800. *Arja*, a danced opera, is said to have been invented for a royal cremation in Klungkung in 1825 (Dibia and Ballinger 2004, 84). The *Calon Arang* ritual drama, which pits the dreaded long-nailed witch Rangda against the protective Barong Ket monster, is believed to have emerged around 1890 in the kingdom of Gianyar (Bandem and deBoer 1995, 113).²

Already weakened by the loss of Karangasem, Bali's southern kingdoms were completely vanquished by the Dutch in military campaigns waged in 1906 and 1908. Just a few years later, in 1912, the first films about Bali were released internationally, and by 1914 the Official Tourist Bureau was promoting the island to domestic and international visitors. Bali was an expensive and hard-to-reach destination, with only a single hotel, the Bali Hotel in Denpasar (built in 1925), and a few small guesthouses. Only 250 or so elite tourists visited per month through the end of the 1930s, not counting the passengers on round-the-world cruise ships who spent a day or two on the island. But these tourists, along with foreign scholars and artists interacting with artistic currents of the archipelago, contributed in significant ways to shaping Balinese performing arts. Old genres were reworked, novel forms developed, and new venues and roles defined. The end of warfare and the imposition of colonial limitations on trading meant that "in those days there was no other work. People 'chased after' the best way to play [music], the best way to dance. Everyone practised faithfully," according to Made Lebah (quoted in Warren 2007, 59), a Balinese musician who worked as Colin McPhee's driver and research assistant in the 1930s. Australian cultural historian Adrian Vickers (1996, 22) describes, in relation to Balinese adaptations of komedi stambul specifically, how "the sense of being modern was given specific forms in Bali. By being able to articulate this sense in such forms as didactic theatrical speech, or as incongruous costumes, or as exciting music, Balinese could become agents of change. They could attempt to wrest back some control over the heady,

threatening, and rapid changes sweeping over their lives. *Stamboel's* satire at least eased the anxiety of the modern." In this chapter we see how other art forms did the same.

Under colonialism, subtle but important changes took place in *arja*, which adopted the stambul repertoire. Plays such as *Nyai Dasima* and *Sampek-Engtay*, known as "Chinese" stories to signify their foreign origin (de Zoete and Spies 1938, 321–323), were performed frequently. Costumes were largely unchanged from the premodern period—the character of Edward Williams in *Nyai Dasima* dressed identically to Abimanyu, a character from the Mahabharata cycle (de Zoete and Spies 1938, 198), though with more emphasis on flashy *prada* (gold leaf), perhaps reflecting stambul costumes. Colloquial Balinese replaced the ancient kawi language, and women dancer-singers were introduced to this formerly all-male genre in the 1920s. Female *arja* performers were said to be "very popular as wives, just as musical-comedy girls are with the British peerage" (196). Musical accompaniment remained largely unaltered, but lyrics reflected a modern understanding of the world, as seen in the following:

Were I rich I would take you to Den Pasar
 And we would go to the Bali Hotel
 There the bedspreads are woven with gold
 The sheets are soft and green
 The pillows come from Java
 And when we had made love
 We'd leave in an Oakland sedan, proudly klaxoning (I Durus quoted in
 McPhee 1966, 303)

Kebyar, a new form of gamelan "as contemporary as jazz" (McPhee 1966, 4) with a raft of associated dances, emerged around 1915 in north Bali and quickly spread to the rest of the island in the next decade.³ Musically the genre is distinguished by its freeness in form, condensing of existing melodies and patterns, strong contrasts, and quick stylistic shifts (Tenzer 2000). Changes in instrumentation in the standard temple orchestra allowed for a previously impossible figurative complexity and dynamic range.⁴ The word *kebyar* in Balinese denotes a sudden outburst or flash, and some see a relationship to the dynamics of European marching bands (Sudhyatmaka Sugriwa 2008, 73). Others point to the economic and social circumstances of north Bali as facilitating its artistic development. A generation of school-educated Balinese no longer looked to the courts for aesthetic guidance and could invent a versatile musical ensemble that might accompany a range of dance and theatrical forms, as well as secular, nonliteral

dances of a sort previously unknown (cf. Ramstedt 1992, 63). American composer and ethnomusicologist Michael Tenzer (1991, 23) writes, “The high speed and capricious pyrotechnics of kebyar music are quintessentially 20th century in flavor, and bear the unmistakable stamp of a music at long last released from the precious refinery of aristocratic means.” The annual pasar malam at Buleleng was a prime showcase for the newest kebyar music.

Kebyar developed through competition—with gamelan clubs of different *banjar* (neighborhoods) vying for patronage and prestige. Competitions along the lines of the kroncong *concours* were organized in the 1930s. Made Lebah recalls an island-wide competition in 1937 judged by the rajas of the former kingdoms (who became regents under the Dutch): “It was so crowded that no one could walk. Each group played in rotation. This went on for several days. The prize for the winning group was exemption from *kerja rodi* (corvée labor service). We won!!! Peliatan won and Denpasar came second. We didn’t have to work rodi [work on the roads] for 3 years! We also received 50 rupiah and a Dutch flag!” (Lebah quoted in Warren 2007, 64). Competition led to uniformity. Colin McPhee attended a 1938 kebyar competition held as part of the celebrations of the colonial government’s grant of limited “self-rule” to Bali’s kings. He observed, “More and more the new kebyars seemed to resemble each other, seemed intended only to dazzle and bewilder. Moments of repose were now almost unknown, and though from time to time there were still snatches of charming melody, before you were aware of a tune it had disappeared, lost in the avalanche of sound” (McPhee 1946, 202–203). Members of the musical groups dressed in uniforms at public performances, and those in the richer clubs wore headcloths decorated with gold.

Balinese music previously was anonymous or composed collectively by members of a gamelan club. In contrast, kebyar’s formal complexity necessitated that pieces be preplanned by a single person who would then teach them to a group—a role analogous to the European composer. Groups imported composer-teachers from outside the *banjar* by *opelet* (a form of cheap motorized transport) and bicycle and paid them to create bespoke compositions. Clubs dictated that these pieces could not be taught to other associations, which nonetheless often managed to “steal” them by eavesdropping on rehearsals and performances. Balinese composers emphasized novelty and “showed a bold disregard for the confining restrictions of traditional musical form” (McPhee 1966, xiv). It was demanding work. I Wayan Lotring, held up by McPhee as the most significant Balinese composer working in the interwar decades, told McPhee, “Ké-wah! It is hard to compose! Sometimes I cannot sleep for nights, thinking of a new piece. It turns round and round in my thoughts. I hear it in my dreams. My hair has

grown thin thinking of music” (McPhee 1946, 175). Lotring sought inspiration from diverse sources: one piece utilized a melody played hourly by a clock owned by a Chinese neighbor.

As a pastiche of different moods and styles, kebyar made for exciting stand-alone concert music, but from the beginning there were also dances created to visualize the music (Seebass 1996, 82). The earliest such dance was *kebyar legong*, created by I Wayan Prapuan of Jagaraga (a village ten kilometers east of Buleleng) in 1915 and performed by two cross-dressed (*bebancihan*) men or two young women. It was based on a combination of existing styles, male and female (Dibia and Ballinger 2004, 90). The most famous dances created specifically for kebyar were, however, the *kebyar dodok* (seated kebyar) and *kebyar trompong* (kebyar with *trompong*) of the inventive Denpasar-born dancer and choreographer I Ketut Marya, better known as Mario. In an interview Mario gave in 1962 to Balinese scholar Dr. A. A. Madé Djelantik, he recounted the origins of his dances. It seems that while touring and performing gandrung around north Bali he was invited to improvise a dance with a kebyar ensemble:

Without a chance to change from the female sarong he [Marya] had been wearing for gandrung, he began to improvise to the music. He began dancing in a gandrung style but playing off of the complex and syncopated rhythms and melodies of the kebyar. Ordinarily the gandrung dancer would do a flirtatious *ngibing* dance, noses almost touching, with male audience members, but Marya was confused since he was surrounded by the gamelan instruments and could not interact with the audience. So he decided to do the *ngibing* sequence with the person closest at hand, and that was the drummer, who was seated cross-legged on the floor. Marya instinctively squatted down to his level and improvised a new kind of *ngibing*, and this was followed by a visit around the gamelan to *ngibing* [dance] with other musicians in his half-seated position. It was this improvisation and adaptation to the moment that gave rise to the “sitting dance.” Another time Marya was trying to *ngibing* the trompong player who was unable or unwilling to join the dance. Marya was impatient waiting so he grabbed the two *panggul* “mallets” from the hands of the musician and began to dance while playing the instrument before him. That was the birth of a new creation—Kebyar Trompong. (Herbst 2009, 19)

Mario’s dance creations were featured weekly on the Bali Hotel’s dance programs (thus the Malay word *dodok* instead of the Balinese *jongkok* or *negak* for his “seated” or “squatting” *kebyar dodok* dance) and were included in the

Parisian programs of 1931. Paris brought international celebrity, and Mario was sought out thereafter as a performer and teacher by visiting photographers, scholars, and tourists, even after he could no longer fluently execute the strenuous scooting around in a kneeling position with one foot tucked over the other called for by his choreographies. Anthropologists Gregory Bateson and Margaret Mead documented on film how Mario taught dance, interpreting his direct manipulation of the bodies of his students as confirmation of what they called Bali's "puppet complex." Ruth Page, an American modern dancer and ballerina, took lessons with Mario, as did Indian modern dancer Nataraj Vashi. Both Page and Vashi created their own dances based on Mario's choreographies, which they performed in the United States and South Asia in the late 1930s. Mario, in turn, demanded that his foreign students teach him their own dances—such an exchange with Vashi was caught on camera by Bateson and Mead and included in their film *Learning to Dance in Bali* (1978; see also Cohen 2010, 170–172).

Kebyar's modernity evoked conflicting responses from Bali experts. Walter Spies, the island's most important cultural broker, was an avid champion. In 1939, while doing time in a Surabaya prison for homosexuality, Spies wrote to ethnomusicologist Jaap Kunst to encourage him to return from the Netherlands to do further research on Bali's "fantastic new kinds of music [. . .] which you will enjoy incredibly" (Spies quoted in Seebass 1996, 87). McPhee, whose aesthetic preferences leaned more to neoclassicism than expressionism and who opposed Western-style education for Balinese because of the "hatred for the past [of] [. . .] the Indonesian teachers [. . .] and their determination to stamp out all traces of native culture" (McPhee 1946, 194), took a more reserved attitude to kebyar. In a speech delivered at the 1937 congress of the Java Institute, held that year in Bali and with a focus on Balinese culture and thus dubbed "*het Bali Congres*," McPhee critiqued kebyar's structural weaknesses, dynamic imbalances, and effacement of tradition, adding that "whatever its faults, it bears witness to the fact that music is still a living art for the Balinese" (McPhee 1937, 56). His attitude appears to have shifted later. In his monumental, posthumously published *Music in Bali*, McPhee conceived his mission as being "to try to preserve in some form of record this period in Balinese music, while older styles and methods survived" (McPhee 1966, xiv). He was concerned with the survival of old forms of gamelan, which were being melted down to form kebyar or sold off piecemeal by rajas wishing to purchase automobiles. McPhee encouraged the revival of disappearing musical styles and repertoires and notated little-played pieces and their variants obsessively, writing, "I wanted to hear every gamelan in the countryside. Each leaf of the tree was precious; one could only know the tree by tracing the contour of every leaf" (McPhee 1946, 117).

McPhee expressed unreserved antipathy to the other prominent modern performance form practiced in Bali in the 1920s and 1930s, *janger*. This genre he dismissed categorically as “a sort of modern vaudeville that was very popular and which I found incredibly dull” (McPhee 1946, 89). *Janger*, which denotes “being off center” (Dibia and Ballinger 2004, 88) or a mad “infatuation” (Bandem and deBoer 1995, 97) in Balinese, is, like *kebyar*, a potpourri form. It combines, among other elements, choral chanting associated with the *sanghyang* trance ritual; festive songs sung by *matuakan* (palm wine drinking groups); dancing based on *legong* and Balinese *wayang wong*; the gamelan associated with *arja* and sometimes also the *gender wayang* of *wayang wong*; acting conventions, costumes, Malay pantun singing, and painted backdrops drawn from *komedi stambul*; *pencak silat*; Islamic frame drums (*rebana*); sporting outfits and soccer chants; military drills with marching and saluting; solfège singing; and circus-style acrobatics and athletic pyramids. Covarrubias ([1937] 1950, 254–255), with more enthusiasm than McPhee, depicted *janger* as a passing trend that demonstrated the Balinese “love of novelty and easy following after all new ideas, which are soon assimilated into traditional forms.” The form has nonetheless persisted, being reinvented in 1965 as a vehicle for political propaganda and again in 1974 as a government initiative to introduce schoolchildren to local culture (Bandem and deBoer 1995, 100).

Janger’s exact origin is unknown, but some of the earliest troupes were formed in 1920 in the northern Balinese district of Kubu, Karangasem, and the dancer I Made Keredek from the village of Singapadu in Gianyar popularized the form around south Bali in the mid-1920s (Dibia and Ballinger 2004, 88). *Janger* was a young person’s art: flashy, exuberant, syncopated, and sometimes frenetic. Clubs dictated that only unmarried boys and girls could be members, with ex-*legong* dancers (who typically retired when they reached puberty) in prominent roles. Rehearsals were called in Malay *sekolah janger*, “*janger* school” (Powell [1930] 1986, 57).⁵

An enduring offshoot of *janger* and the *sanghyang dedari* ritual dance (in which a young girl is possessed by the spirit of a heavenly nymph) was *kecak*, sometimes called *cak* or “the monkey dance” in tourist literature. *Kecak*’s precise origin is contested. (For a recent discussion see Stepputat 2010). Walter Spies, the American choreographer and student of Balinese religion Katharine Edson Mershon, and the Balinese dancer I Wayan Limbak all appear to have played generative roles. Spies was artistic advisor on the 1933 fictional film *Insel der dämonen* (Island of the demons) directed by the German documentarian Dr. Friedrich Dalsheim, with a script by Dalsheim, Spies, and the German explorer and the naturalist-collector Baron Victor van Plessen.⁶ This was one of a number of narrative films made in the 1930s with all-Balinese casts. Most were



Janger performance in Bali, 1930s. Postcard in collection of the author.

marketed internationally as “goona-goona” exploitation films with a target audience of men wishing to catch glimpses of exposed Balinese breasts (Cohen 2015). The climactic scene of Dalsheim’s film pits a reincarnation of the Goddess of Death and her female followers (*sanghyang dedari* dancers) against a virtuous priest and his male followers (*kecak*). The film thus disaggregates the female and male elements of *sanghyang dedari* and *janger*.

For the film’s choreography, Spies enlisted the assistance of American dancer Katharine Edson Mershon. Mershon, who had retired to Bali to study religion and traditional literature with a Balinese priest, had a long career as a dancer and choreographer. She had toured her own solo interpretive dances (many based on “exotic” sources) in the United States and Europe, worked as a choreographer for amateur theater and pageants, headed the New York branch of the Denishawn dance school, and created dances for Hollywood films (including the faux Javanese dances of the 1929 Greta Garbo vehicle *Wild Orchid*). One of Mershon’s most impressive spectacles was the choreography for the 1928 Pasadena Community Playhouse production of Eugene O’Neil’s *Lazarus Laughed*, working with a cast of 151. In one scene of this production the rhythmic chorus sat on the floor while chanting and moving their arms, upper bodies, and heads. Spies agreed to base the *kecak* choreography on this earlier choreography (Brown 2003). In the film, the *kecak* are ordered in concentric circles around a candelabrum, now a

standard kecak feature referred to as a *damar kecak*, which serves to illuminate their faces.

Following *Insel der dämonen*'s filming in 1931, the kecak dance was adapted by I Wayan Limbak, who added episodes of the Ramayana such as "The Death of Kumbakarna" played by a small cast of singer-dancers placed in the center of a circle of fifty or more kecak chanters. Villages around Bali adopted this theatricalized form. Kecak proved popular with tourists and, along with Calon Arang (another form favored by Spies), legong, and Mario's kebyar dances, was considered a must-see item for any visitor. It was regularly included in the agenda of cruise ship tourists with only a day or two to spend on the island.

Other Balinese dance and musical traditions were being altered in particular ways to fit the demands of non-Balinese visitors. For the visit of France's prime minister, Georges Benjamin Clemenceau, the Dutch controller constructed a specially designed bamboo arena and spruced up his troupe of legong dancers by ordering leatherworkers to cut new leather ornaments and goldsmiths to decorate costumes with gold leaf (Kleen 1921, 132). Guidebooks enumerated the major genres of Balinese dance and drama. Aficionados sought out the advice of Walter Spies and other resident European experts on what troupes to see and commissioned performances in villages—usually during daytime hours for filming purposes (see, e.g., Wasserman 1940, 78–114). The Bali Hotel presented cultural shows on a small concrete stage with electrical lighting every Friday night (Shavit 2003, 97–100). Cultural performances that would take three hours or more to enact in a ritual setting were condensed to fifteen minutes. Made Lebah (quoted in Warren 2007, 58–59), who performed on this stage, reported, "The tourists then were very different—like Rajas—they made us feel very embarrassed. We had no shirts and were ashamed. They would ask, 'Did you come here to bathe?' Before that we had only played in the temple for *odalan* [temple festivals], for weddings, tooth-filings, and didn't really have uniform costumes."

"The Bali set," the European and North American enthusiasts who lived in Bali and promoted its arts and culture to the world, did much to establish the reputation of Bali as being "strikingly different" (Holt and Bateson [1944] 1970, 322) from other archipelagic cultures—and even unique in the world. The peculiar imagining of Bali as an island of art, religious culture, hedonism, and bare-breasted women was popularized through travel literature, songs (e.g., "It Happened on the Beach at Bali-Bali," "The Goona Goo"), the many motion pictures from the 1920s and 1930s filmed or set in Bali (see Cohen 2015, 142–150), musicals and musical revues (*Professor Doorlay's Tropical Express* [c. 1935], *Let's*

Go Gay [1935], *Gold Diggers in Paris* [1938]), fashion, domestic furnishings, and themed nightclubs and “exotic” dancers of varying degrees of salaciousness. American and European men fantasized of sailing to Bali to “watch sarong clad temple dancers twisting to the measured rhythm of the gamelan.”⁷

Bali fetishism spilled over to neighboring Java and other parts of the archipelago and Asia. An advertisement in a Padang newspaper in 1938 for medicinal wine was illustrated with a photograph of a well-endowed, bare-breasted Balinese woman and promised its circulatory-enhancing effects would yield breasts of the sort admired by “*modern* young women today, and also admired by members of the opposite sex.”⁸ The Belgian painter Adrien Jean Le Mayeur, who lived and worked in Denpasar and Sanur between 1932 and 1958, regularly exhibited his paintings of bare-breasted Balinese women in Singapore starting in 1933. The ex-legong dancer Ni Nyoman Pollok, who was his principal model and also his wife, accompanied him on these trips and enacted truncated Balinese dances in Singaporean exhibition halls (Wiharja 1976). She also occasionally danced (sometimes bare-breasted) for photographers and filmmakers visiting Bali (n.a. 2000).

Spies, Mershon, and most other European and North American members of the Bali set did not enjoy the sort of fellowship with the Balinese that European members of the Java Institute living in Java had with Javanese intellectual colleagues. McPhee did occasionally pick up a gamelan mallet and play together with his assistants; he also allowed them once in a while to play the piano he had imported from Surabaya. McPhee and Spies performed their arrangements of Balinese music for two pianos at the Bali Congress in 1937 and were criticized by regents and musicians in attendance for lacking drums (McPhee 1946: 222–223). Thereafter, when McPhee performed piano arrangements of Balinese music on ships docked in Padang Bai, he was accompanied on drum by his assistant Made Lebah (Warren 2007, 67). But there were strong imbalances in these relationships. McPhee recounts a moment when he played out a transcription of a *gender* melody before his Balinese musician-informants, “reading from the page beside me on the floor. A miracle! Mystification! Delight! They burst out laughing. Of course; indeed; the superior writing!” (McPhee 1946, 116). Lebah says of McPhee, “He could make the piano sound like a Balinese gamelan. I could never do that” (quoted in Warren 2007, 67). There is no evidence that McPhee tried to pass on his methods. When offprints of McPhee’s academic article “The Balinese Wayang Kulit and Its Music,” published in *Djāwā* in 1936, arrived by post, McPhee reported that he “eagerly tore the package open.” He then described the reactions of his Balinese colleagues:



When legong was performed at the Pasar Gambir in Batavia in 1937 it became the subject of the *Obroloanipun Petruk* (Petruk's dialogue) column in the Javanese-language weekly magazine *Kajawen*. This long-running series cast Gareng and his younger brother Petruk, the two principal clown servants of central Javanese wayang kulit, as blue-collar workers indulging in modern pastimes with their wives. In this episode, at his wife's urging ("I've heard about this legong often but I've never experienced it firsthand"), Gareng purchases tickets to see legong. Gareng is immediately struck by "how fast and quick-changing the dance is." But when he stands up to dance along with the music, his wife complains: "There he goes, dancing gracefully away all by his lonesome. I'm mortified. Come on, let's go" (Hardjadibrata 1937, 1116).

Durus [the composer], Sampih [a dancer supported by McPhee] and Lebah examined the books with respect, and exclaimed with delight as they recognized the rather glum *dalang* from Bangkasa among the photographs.

How much will you sell these books for? asked Durus, practically.

But when I explained that these were for my friends they looked at each other in silence.

All that work, said Sampih. In vain!

They went out, to talk this over. I felt I had greatly disappointed them. (McPhee 1946, 172)

Clearly, the Balinese artists were McPhee's informants, not his true confederates: there could be no explaining the benefits of "pure" scholarship and research.

Yet there were Balinese intellectuals with whom McPhee and the other Baliologists might have had productive dialogues, such as the writers who contributed to the progressive, Malay-language monthly magazine *Surya kanta*. These nonaristocratic intellectuals were reformers critical of the villagers' excessive investment in cremation ceremonies and tooth filings, and what they understood rightly to be the museumification of Bali by agents of Dutch colonialism (a policy known as *Baliseering* or "Balinization.") An article in *Surya kanta* expresses the injury caused by Bali being made into a "*tontonan* [spectacle] of antiquity for foreigners." Although some may argue that busloads of tourists bring money to the island, the author states, the vehicles destroy roads that have to be repaired by *corvée* labor service. "As for advancing art? Impossible! In fact it [tourism] destroys it. Most products sold to tourists are mass-produced, indifferently made" (n.a. 1927a, 30). The ideology underpinning this critique was at loggerheads with the romantic sentiments of McPhee and his set, who preferred instead to consort with Balinese aristocrats invested in upholding custom and with the uneducated peasants who reportedly took McPhee to be a fire eater (because he had taught his cook to make crêpes with burning rum) (McPhee 1946, 126). The Bali set ultimately was interested less in communication with Balinese than with maintaining their cosmopolitan standing in a modernizing "paradise" and propagating their authority and influence in the world. This meant preserving Bali as a special cultural niche—because, as Swedish anthropologist Ulf Hannerz (1996, 111) points out, "there can be no cosmopolitans without locals."

Literary theorist Paul de Man, in an important essay on literary modernism, describes Artaud's championing of "the Balinese theater" as ironic. "The more radical the rejection of anything that came before, the greater the dependence on the past" (De Man 1970, 400). In "rejecting all forms of theatrical art prior to his

own” Artaud “nevertheless finally has to ground his own vision in examples such as the Balinese theater, the least modern, the most text-frozen type of theater conceivable” (400). The performance witnessed by Artaud in Paris, which included kebyar music and dance, an abridged form of *janger*, and Calon Arang as reconceived by Walter Spies, was far more contemporary than Artaud or de Man were aware. Balinese performers put the tour’s profits to good use: the Peliatan gamelan club bought its own instruments on their return to Bali, and Made Lebah used his earnings to marry a new wife. It provided more than just economic benefit, however. It was also a wake-up call for the injustices of colonialism. In a side trip to Amsterdam, the troupe visited the Colonial Museum. Lebah recalled, “At the museum they showed us the crown of gold that belonged to the Raja of Klungkung. There were *topeng* masks, legong costumes and keris [daggers] that had been taken from different Rajas of Bali. I almost cried. I was almost angry, because they had taken it all” (quoted in Warren 2007, 60). Bali-in-Europe and Europe-in-Bali were prime examples of colonial modernity, “best viewed as a structural relationship, made dynamic by a capitalism emanating from Euro/America, that is a product of the dialectics between the structuring forces of capitalism that have been global in scope and reach (not universal or homogeneous for being global), and the many local forces transformed by these forces but also transforming them into many local guises, which then could act back upon Euro/American societies with transformative effects of their own” (Dirlik 2010, 47).

The Heyday of Popular Theater

An amusement park opened in the central Javanese city of Pekalongan on 12 June 1923. Known as Orion-Park, it was described in a newspaper article as an “imitation Deca Park,” after Batavia’s famous entertainment center. It housed restaurants and Chinese-run stands selling sarongs, clocks, and toys—“in a word everything that one would find at a pasar malam.” The fairgrounds were lit by a powerful electrical dynamo, “which had a strong effect,” and on its grounds were a carousel, a tent showing motion pictures, and a tent for “native theater, where a good gamelan could be heard playing,” which suggests that a wayang wong troupe played at the opening.¹ The park was owned and run by Tio Tik Djien, known professionally as T. D. Tio Jr., a newspaperman born in the East Javanese town of Nganjuk and a graduate of a Dutch-language high school in Batavia. Orion competed against another Pekalongan amusement park, struggled financially, and eventually closed. But an offshoot enterprise, a theater company under Tio’s direction known initially as the Malay Opera Orion, survived the park’s demise and went on tour from 1925 on. Tio was the first educated Chinese individual to work in the commercial Malay theater (Tzu 1939, 5).

Jockeying for a place in the “marketplace for modernism” (Oja 2000), Orion drew on Tio’s connections to other educated Chinese and introduced a set of practices previously unknown to popular Malay-language theater. It dispensed with the *ladon-diladon* character introductions of stambul and all nondiegetic singing and dancing (except as “extra turns” between acts). Some of the standard Malay opera plays, such as *Nyai Dasima*, *Jula-Juli bintang tiga*, and *Romeo and Juliet*, remained in repertoire, but there were also numerous new dramas written and directed by Tio and later by other writer-directors. Many were adapted from popular films and swashbuckling adventure stories. The number of scenes was reduced from twenty or more to eight or nine (later five or six), with greater emphasis placed on psychological realism in writing and acting. Lights in the auditorium were dimmed “to enthrall the audience in a stage illusion” (Jedamski 2008, 499). Some improvisation remained, but in general there was stricter

adherence to the written playtext. The director played a more prominent role, and there was greater rigor in rehearsal.

The press referred to Orion initially as a “modern stambul” company.² Its dramaturgy, however, resembled more the Sino-Malay amateur theater and the didactic spoken dramas in Malay, Javanese, Sundanese, and other languages enacted by amateur arts associations. This type of theater was known generically as *tooneel*, after the Dutch word for theater; for example, *tooneel Melayu* (Malay-language theater), *tooneel Jawa* (Javanese-language theater; see Bosnak 2006, 19–21), and so forth. An article that appeared in *Pandji poestaka* in 1924 on the development of *tooneel* reported that this sort of theater was distinguished from the earlier commercial theaters of stambul and bangsawan by being “more meaningful and mannerly.” It used music to “please the hearts of spectators, not to accompany the singing of actors, because the actors only recite dialogue, and do not sing” (n.a. 1924: 459). *Tooneel* plays were enacted for charity benefits (459), religious education and proselytizing efforts (Rijckevorsel 1921), anti-tuberculosis propaganda (S. R. 1935), visits from important guests, or just plain entertainment.

Orion distinguished itself from amateur associations by its technical and artistic inventiveness and canny balance of didacticism with entertainment. Its undisputed star was Tio’s wife, the comedienne and singer Miss Riboet, likened in the press to the curvaceous American film actress Mae West.³ In 1926, Tio recruited Njoo Cheong Seng, another Chinese journalist who had edited the English-language magazine *Interocean* and was active in amateur Chinese theater in Surabaya (Sidharta 1995). Njoo became in effect Orion’s associate artistic director, writing and directing plays and promoting the company in the press. He traveled with the company while pursuing an independent career as a writer, pounding out his many novels until the early hours of the morning. Orion’s superb technical and directorial team, first-rate writing, hilarious clowns, up-to-date extra turns, outstanding jazz band, and above all the charming Miss Riboet attracted many fans, including Chinese and Europeans. Miss Riboet recorded a huge variety of popular songs, as well as classical Javanese music with gamelan. Fans purchased Miss Riboet brand cosmetics and Miss Riboet pocket watches with the actress’s picture inside the hinged lid. Orion quickly became known as Miss Riboet’s Orion or simply Miss Riboet. The company traveled widely and picked up collaborators along the way. For example, the British-born dancing instructor Professor C. Thereses of Singapore and Shanghai taught the company the latest in jazz dance. By 1929, Orion was promoting itself in Dutch newspapers as “the only Malay Company for the EUROPEAN! The only Malay Company that is not STAMBUL!”⁴

Dardanella

As might be expected, Orion quickly spawned many imitators. Foremost among them was Dardanella, named after the 1919 hit song by Felix Bernard, which the company's band played before every performance.⁵ The company's owners were Willy Klimanoff, known professionally as Adolf Piëdro, and his mother Ivera. The Klimanoffs were Russian variety artists who had toured Southeast Asia for decades with European circuses and musical comedy troupes, as well as bangsawan companies including Wayang Kassim. Piëdro was born in Penang and educated in India, and he was fluent in Malay. After the death of his father in a circus accident, Piëdro and Ivera traveled to Java. They performed acrobatic, clown, and ballet acts between reels in Batavia movie theaters under the stage names Signora Guellardo and Signor A. Piedro in 1923, before joining the Italian-owned stambul troupe Opera Constantinopel. Piëdro was soon promoted to be the company's advance man. By 1926 Piëdro and his mother had accumulated just enough capital to launch their own Malay opera company in Sidoarjo, a town in East Java known in the trade as the stambul graveyard for its many failed troupes and stranded performers. Because their bankroll was only 350 guilders, initially backdrops had to be painted on paper rather than cloth. Piëdro, who was the company's artistic director, was a disciplinarian who demanded loyalty, hard work, obedience, and proper behavior onstage and off from his performers. He strove to construct a more wholesome image for theater by suppressing the sexual abuses, drug use, gambling, and other vices of theater people that tarnished stambul and bangsawan.⁶ Highly skilled in stagecraft, his plays and extra turns faithfully restaged Hollywood films and hit song-and-dance routines to suit the popular tastes of "movie-mad Malays" (cf. Kennedy 1942, 84).

First-tier Malay opera troupes dominated the major cities and towns of Java, Sumatra, Singapore, and the Malay Peninsula, and Dardanella needed road testing before it would be ready to face the critical audiences and reviewers of Surabaya or Batavia. It toured the backwater towns of eastern Java and the eastern Indonesian islands for several years, building up and polishing a repertoire of plays and extra turns, and assembling a multiethnic company to rival Orion. For Dardanella's leading man, the half-Chinese stambul actor and kroncong singer Tan Tjeng Bok, Piëdro created swashbuckling plays such as *The Mark of Zorro*, *The Three Musketeers*, and *The Thief of Bagdad*, which yielded Tan the nickname "the Douglas Fairbanks of Java."⁷ Piëdro recruited an actress with a talent for kroncong singing from the Menangkabau Opera, whom he had observed when this bangsawan company played the east Javanese town of Dampit. Piëdro renamed her "Miss Riboet" to dupe provincial spectators. (Her name was changed

to Miss Riboet II or “Miss Riboet Moeda” in 1928 after Tio mounted a legal case.) The dance master and musician Ferry Kok, who had a background in Hawaiian music and jazz drumming, was recruited in 1927 when Dardanella was on tour in Samarinda, in eastern Borneo. Astaman, a character actor and the son of a Jepangan acrobatic troupe owner, was recruited from Opera Constantinopel in 1928, reportedly attracted by Dardanella’s modern sheen.

Piëdro’s most famous discovery, however, was Soetidjah, who had danced on the streets of east Javanese towns as a ronggeng as a child and had been brought up by grandparents who owned and ran a small-scale family stambul troupe. When Piëdro saw Soetidjah perform her signature song-and-dance routine *Kopi Susu* (Coffee with milk) as an extra turn in a show put on by her grandfather’s troupe, he recognized her talent immediately and promptly recruited her entire family to Dardanella. Soetidjah performed under the stage name of “Miss Dja,” but was known to intimates as Erni, from the name Ernesta that she took on marrying Piëdro and converting to Christianity. Dja’s stage appearances were initially limited to extra turns and occasional cameos in child roles, but Piëdro was grooming her for bigger things.

Dardanella’s advertised repertoire of “new creations,” when it played Surabaya’s Stadstuin Theater in 1929, was mostly made up of Hollywood movie adaptations. But it also performed plays based on popular European and Indies novels such as *Annie van Mendoet* (Annie of Mendut). The arrival of “the talkies” at the end of the 1920s offered a rich source for song-and-dance routines.⁸ Piëdro regularly took company members to the movies to study American singing, dancing, and acting; his extravagant restagings of Hollywood and other national cinemas were considered by some to be even better than the originals.⁹

Dardanella’s extra turns were not to be bettered, but Piëdro was no writer (he delivered lines orally to his actors), and as the nationalist movement gained ground, audiences were increasingly interested in watching original plays with local settings rather than adapted “talkies.” Miss Riboet’s Orion achieved a major hit circa 1930 with Tio’s original play *Gagak Solo* (Crow of solo), which dramatized a struggle for succession in the kraton of Surakarta and featured renditions of court dances. The play’s authenticity was sometimes critiqued (its *srimpi* dancers, for example, were charged with wearing Yogyakarta instead of Surakarta costumes), but the promise of a glimpse of life behind kraton walls drew huge crowds. Piëdro’s response was to commission new plays from Chinese writers, including Kwee Tek Hoaij’s 1930 drama about syphilis, *The Living Corpse*, loosely inspired by Ibsen’s *Ghosts* (1881; Kwee [1931] 2010).

Piëdro also approached the Minangkabau-born journalist Abisin Abbas, known professionally as Andjar Asmara, to write plays for Dardanella and work



Ferry Kok and Miss Dja in an extra turn from circa 1930. Photograph courtesy Sinematek Indonesia.

as the company's publicist. Asmara had been a theater fan since childhood and hugely admired Dardanella's craftsmanship. He accepted Piëdro's offer, though it meant leaving Batavia to travel with the company and giving up the editorship of the photo magazine *Doenia film dan sport* (Film and sport world). At Asmara's urging, Piëdro invested in a portable printing press with the most modern of fonts for handbills and programs, which Asmara used to print a souvenir magazine, *Dardanella Revue*. Piëdro also entrusted Asmara with the education of Dja, who had no schooling and was illiterate. (There are intimations of an affair.)

Asmara put all his journalistic knowhow and connections at Dardanella's disposal. The final issue of *Doenia film dan sport* before his departure (15 November 1930) was a "special Dardanella number" that promoted the "Dardanella's Java Big Five" (English in the original), the company's five leading performers: Tan, Kok, Astaman, Dja, and Riboet II. He also rebranded Dardanella. No longer was it to be called "opera" or "stambul," but was to be referred to instead in Dutch as *tooneel* and in Malay as *tonil* (sometimes pronounced *tunil*), asserting its equal standing with European theater. Other companies, including Miss Riboet's Orion, picked up this designation. Newspaper advertisements produced by Asmara were studded with enticing illustrations, alluring quotes from reviews, memorable catch phrases ("The One Show That's Different"), and tantalizing story points—"he was a millionaire's son, she a Hawaiian virgin."¹⁰ Dja was prominently featured in the publicity.

Only weeks after joining the company, Asmara penned Dardanella's most-performed play, *Dr. Samsi*, which crossed the Hollywood courtroom drama *Madame X* (1929) with episodes from Asmara's own life in Bandung and Batavia (Asmara [1959] 2010). The play, which premiered in Medan in December 1930 and was codirected by Piëdro and Asmara, provided Dja with her debut adult role as the abandoned girlfriend of the title character who gives up their baby born out of wedlock. The child is raised by Dr. Samsi and grows up to be a lawyer who defends his mother on the charge that she has murdered her husband, a notorious Batavia ruffian who in fact is killed by Dr. Samsi himself. *Dr. Samsi* presented significant acting challenges for the teenage Dja, and although Piëdro had his trepidations, her performance received accolades, leading to subsequent adult parts.

Plays written or reworked by Asmara aimed to appeal to the educated class or "intellectuals," as he explained in an interview with the photo magazine *Panorama* in October 1931:

Dr. Samsi raises the issue of how a mother and child are toyed with, as is often the case in social life. *The Living Corpse* is anti-venereal propaganda.

Haida debates polygamy versus monogamy. *Medan 1890–1930* investigates the *nyai* [unofficial wife], a societal role often the object of derision. *Dark Shadow over Malacca Street* is a drama demonstrating the love of a mother for a child, and how this relation is broken. *Annie van Mendoet* presents a question: to what extent can Western manners and education be followed by an Easterner? And so on. Every story has an inner purpose. (Asmara quoted in S. 1931, n.p.)

Dardanella and Miss Riboet's Orion came head to head when the two companies concurrently played Batavia in October and November 1931, spending thousands in an "advertising war." Miss Riboet, which pitched its tent in Mangga Besar, heavily promoted *Gagak Solo* and the company's "Manilla Cabaret," a group of Filipino artists who performed cabaret acts, including a Charlie Chaplin impersonation. Dardanella, performing in the Thalia schouwburg, promoted *Dr. Samsi*, the Hawaiian drama *Haiwatha* ("love beneath the palms of the Hawaiian beaches"), and the "sweet seventeen" *Dja*. Dardanella beat out its arch-rival for audiences and over the next years under the artistic direction of Piëdro and Asmara went from strength to strength. *Dja* and Andjar Asmara's wife, Suratna Asmara or "Miss Ratna," were charged by Piëdro to learn the local dances of each region in which the company toured. They were quick studies. It only required a few weeks of lessons in 1932 with Balinese artists recently returned from the Exposition Coloniale Internationale in Paris to gain enough knowledge to create a set of Bali-based dances (*Legong*, *Durga*, and *Garuda*). These dances were staged as individual extra turns and worked into a play titled *Fatimma*, created by Piëdro after H. Rider Haggard's 1887 adventure novel *She*. Fifteen scrimpi lessons in 1934 with M. A. Soekinah, a former dancer of the Mangkunegaran palace and a singer who recorded Javanese *gendhing* and *kroncong* with the Beka label, were enough for *Dja* and Ratna to become "fairly accomplished" (*loemajan kasagedanipoen*) in their teacher's estimation (Karkono 1941, 25).¹¹

Attending a Dardanella performance was figured as a nationalistic act. When the company performed in Manado in 1930, for example, a reporter for the local Indonesian-language newspaper wrote, "Each and every Indonesian and Asian feels proud of the existence of this opera made up of people of our races. Dardanella certainly is in step with the time. The time of change and progress. [. . .] Attending [. . .] bolsters the progress of our people."¹² The company never was formally linked to a political organization or party. But its plays set among the archipelago's different ethnic groups, which showed the public the "characteristics, customs, ways, beliefs, rituals, and *last but not least* [English in original] the dances of *pribumi* inhabitants" (Tzu 1939, 16) of Java, Bali, Sumatra, Borneo,

Timor, Papua, and other islands, were instrumental in generating familiarity and solidarity among and across Indonesian ethnic groups.

New personnel brought new ideas and talents to Dardanella. Henry L. Duarte, born on the Pacific island of Guam, joined as Dardanella's cabaret director in 1931, after working for the City Opera of Singapore. Njoo Cheong Seng and his young Aceh-born Chinese wife Tan Kiem Nio—who performed under the stage name “Fifi Young” after the French Canadian actress Fifi d’Orsay and the Mandarin pronunciation of her husband’s surname (Tzu 1939, 10)—left Orion for a stint in Malaya with the Chinese-owned Moonlight Opera and Crystal Follies, toured Sumatra with their own tonil company Diamond Star, and finally joined Dardanella in 1934. Njoo directed his own plays for Dardanella, transferring gems from his days with Miss Riboet, and Fifi Young was promoted as a leading lady. The Minangkabau actor, writer, and director Bachtiar Effendi, younger brother of poet and communist politician Rustam Effendi, joined Dardanella in 1935 and cowrote the play *Singa Minangkabau* (Minangkabau lion) with Andjar Asmara. Dardanella, like Miss Riboet’s Orion, also fielded its own soccer team, which played local clubs wherever the company toured—serving as a means both to engage with local communities and receive additional coverage in the press. Stagehands were warned not to apply for a job unless they were good soccer players.

The commercial success of Miss Riboet and Dardanella inspired many tonil companies. One was sponsored by a Kudus clove cigarette company; tickets were obtained by presenting empty “Tiga Bal” (Three Ball) brand cigarette packs (Hanusz 2000, 42). This competition, combined with the persisting global depression, forced Dardanella and other large-scale companies to travel increasingly farther afield in search of new audiences. Dardanella departed from Java in January 1935 for a planned four-and-a-half-year world tour that would take them to Singapore and then “through the Malay Peninsula, Siam and Indo-China; thence through China and Japan; down to Manila; across to India; and finally through Europe and America.”¹³ The pared-down company mostly enacted dance and cabaret evenings, going by various names such as “The Royal Balinese Dancers.” The tour did not work out as anticipated. Treacherous agents were rife, money was scarce, and conditions on the road harsh. The filming of *Dr. Samsi* by the Radha Film Company of Calcutta in 1936 depleted Dardanella’s reserves, and the company was forced to sleep outside the city limits in a bus. Andjar Asmara quit Dardanella and, with the assistance of the Dutch Consulate of Bombay, returned to Indonesia along with more than half the company, including his wife Ratna, Bachtiar Effendi, and Henry Duarte. Piëdro went on to Singapore with the remainder of the troupe, recruited new performers, and returned to the road—

touring Asia and then Europe through October 1939 and then fleeing war-torn Europe on board the SS *Rotterdam* to New York. Piëdro's company, renamed Devi Dja's Bali-Java Dancers, toured the United States through the start of 1940. Ferry Kok and others then returned to Indonesia, but Piëdro, Dja, and a handful of the other ex-Dardanellians stayed on permanently in the United States (Cohen 2010, 175–208).

The Dardanella company members who returned to Indonesia found work in tonil companies such as Fifi Young's Pagoda, founded by Young and Njoo in 1937, or Bolero, founded the same year by Bachtiar Effendi. The latter company performed didactic, anticolonial plays in Malaya, attracting British ire. Tonil actors, writers, and directors also migrated to film. Andjar Asmara worked on the Paramount Pictures jungle film *Booloo* (1938), shot on location in Singapore. Ratna was originally cast to play the picture's Sakai "Native Girl" part; however, her scenes were reshot in Hollywood with Honolulu-born actress Mamo Clark because studio executives feared that a romance between the British explorer, Captain Robert Rogers (played by Colin Tapley), and an Asian woman would alienate American audiences. Andjar Asmara went on to become one of the most prolific film writer-directors of the late 1930s and early 1940s. Both Fifi Young and Ratna Asmara became big film stars.

Some critics accused Dardanella and the other major tonil companies of killing off the competition—and certainly audiences showed little interest in stambul or bangsawan after 1930. But in an article published in 1934 in the photo magazine *Radio Review*, Andjar Asmara argued that Dardanella had in fact opened the way for other companies, whetting the taste of audiences for tonil and establishing it as a medium for "racial/national progress" (*kemadjoean bangsa*). He challenged other "intellectuals" to look beyond theater's immoral reputation and uncertain finances and contribute to the art form's growth (Asmara 1934). In an essay published the following year, Asmara argued passionately for tonil as a tool for the moral education of the public, "to eradicate gambling, refine and elevate character, teach chivalry, teach people to love their fellow human beings and not insult or abuse the disabled, inculcate a sense of responsibility, help people return from the path of vice to the path of virtue, discuss polygamy, elevate the status of women, and other important matters" (Yamin and Abbas 1935, 20).

Tonil as Public Education, Sukarno as Theater Artist

In fact, many *pribumi* intellectuals took up Asmara's challenge to use tonil for public education. Chinese culture workers such as the journalist Tan Tjoei Hok (known professionally as Tanu TRH), who wrote plays for Union Dahlia Opera

and Grand Union Opera, also made a conscious effort to “modernize” (*memodernisir*) theater. In an interview conducted in 1971, Tan expressed familiarity with Dardanella and Miss Riboet, but admitted that he had no direct exposure to European theater, other than through plays he had read. His model was Shakespeare, with *Romeo and Juliet* being a particular favorite (Tanu 1971).

The most famous Indonesian intellectual active in 1930s theater was without doubt the politician Sukarno, who in his autobiography recalls having written and produced twelve plays between 1934 and 1938 when in exile in the small town of Ende on the island of Flores following a colonial government crackdown on political activism (Sukarno 1965, 130). To produce these plays, Indonesia’s future president formed a theater association called Tooneelclub Kelimoetoe, named after the Flores mountain range famous for its three-colored lakes. Members ranged from schoolchildren to an automobile mechanic and included Christians and Muslims, Javanese, Chinese, and local Florenese. A rented parish hall served as a performance venue. Sukarno’s scripts were inspected by a missionary friend, acting on behalf of the colonial government, to ensure there were no subversive political messages. Sukarno built the sets, painted the backdrops, designed and erected advertising banners, and acted as producer; the director was a Filipino with experience in a touring Malay opera troupe. In a throwback to the early days of *bangsawan*, men played the female parts: local women were apparently reluctant to appear on stage on religious and moral grounds. In rehearsals, Sukarno read out lines from a script, and actors memorized them by repetition. Because the actors were untrained, much effort was expended on correcting their pronunciation and coaching realistic performances. Sukarno (1965, 130), in his autobiography, recalls how he had to “lay on the ground again and again” to show one actor “how to properly play a dead man.” *Kroncong* songs were sung as extra turns between acts.

Sukarno formed the Ende club to fight off “idleness, loneliness, and friendlessness” and alleviate “acute depression” (Sukarno 1965, 130), and he probably spent more on the productions than they earned. He wrote, “I was grateful for all this work. It gave me something to do. It filled those dismal hours” (131). When the Dutch authorities moved Sukarno to Bengkulu in 1938, he rejuvenated a flagging theater association there named Tooneelclub Monte Carlo by importing the décor he had fashioned in Ende and restaging a number of his plays.¹⁴ Performances in Bengkulu, a much larger town, were at more up-market venues, such as the Royal Cinema, and the Tooneelclub Monte Carlo was a more commercial initiative than his Ende theater, though at least some of the proceeds went to charity. When the club’s band leader Manaf Sofiano, a saxophone and piano player who also acted in Sukarno’s plays, skipped town with the club’s savings, Sukarno

penned an angry letter about how he had worked fifteen years to raise the status and honor of his people and how embarrassed he would be if one of his people had to be dragged before a judge for absconding with funds earmarked for charity (Sukarno quoted in Setiyanto 2006, 39).

Three full scripts in Sukarno's hand survive and have been published alongside reconstructions of other plays based on extant publicity materials and the memories of performers (Setiyanto 2006). One of the most interesting of Sukarno's plays is *Koetkoetbi* (Setiyanto 2006, 166–192), based loosely on the 1932 Universal Pictures horror film *The Mummy* and following a set of characters introduced by Sukarno in an earlier play, *Dr. Sjaitan* (Dr. Devil).¹⁵ *Koetkoetbi* begins with a prologue set in ancient Java in which Koetkoetbi, who works as the cook in a hermitage, is sentenced to death by Mpu Agni, her magically powerful priest employee, for a forbidden love affair with a man of another religion. Contrary to normal practice, Koetkoetbi's body is not cremated but entombed in a sarcophagus, with a curse ensuring that her body will not decompose. The next scene is set two thousand years later in the garden of the scientist Dr. Moezaky. Knowing his esoteric interests, a farmer brings Moezaky a stone tablet that turns out to contain an Old Javanese inscription cursing the burial site of the sinful Koetkoetbi. Moezaky purchases this artifact and promises to buy more, should such be unearthed. The following scene is set in Moezaky's laboratory (allowing the reuse of an intricate set from *Dr. Sjaitan*). Moezaky has acquired a sarcophagus and an inscription on human skin, which he reads aloud and then deciphers: it says that whoever reads the inscription will become the slave of demons (*setan dan iblis*) in Koetkoetbi's body. Koetkoetbi awakens and rises from her coffin with the aid of jolts of electricity and doses of the five *zat* (substances or essences) of esotericism.¹⁶ Moezaky promptly falls under her spell and is ordered to kill his colleague, the doctor-lawyer Amir, because Koetkoetbi recognizes Amir as a descendant of Mpu Agni. Chases and suspense ensue, as Mpu Agni is resurrected to defeat Koetkoetbi and then sent back to the underworld by Amir's fiancée Hajati's invocation of the name of Allah.

The play is a warning, in line with a stream of progressivist ideology, not to have truck with the "brutal past" of pre-monotheistic Java (cf. Winet 2010, 102). The destruction of the two mummies from ancient Java can be read as a dramatization of modernism's "defiance and finally violent rejection of tradition, the insistence on a clean break with the past" (Williams [1989] 2007, 52). Ancient curses and esoteric *zat*, as well as the modern sciences of electrical engineering and archaeology, all possess power. But belief in God trumps them all.

Koetkoetbi is not explicitly an Islamic propaganda play, because the word "Allah" was used at the time of its writing and staging to designate the God of

both Muslims and Christians, but it raises some of the religious issues around tonil being debated by Muslim intellectuals during the 1930s. There was particular concern that Islamic prayers presented on the tonil stage were inaccurate representations of Islamic practice and could be construed as mocking Islam.¹⁷ Many arts used traditionally for Islamic proselytizing or *dakwah* were in decline at this time. *Slawatan* led by a sayyid or descendent of the Prophet, in which a chorus of singers chanted Arabic songs accompanied by frame drums, had been commonly sponsored in the past to evoke the Prophet's love and instill respect for the class of sayyid. But as Pigeaud ([1938] 1991, 474) points out, with increased communication and knowledge of the outside world and with more people "following the pure teachings," *slawatan* and like practices were considered old-fashioned by the 1930s. Newspaper articles consequently urged Muslims to use the modern art of tonil to "demonstrate the glory of our religion" to the tonil-addicted public.¹⁸ An explicitly Islamic *dakwah* theater was not to emerge for more than two decades, however.

Tonil, except in its most popular articulations, was what Bourdieu (1985, 13) calls a field of restricted production, with "economic profit [. . .] secondary to enhancement of the product's symbolic value and to (long-term) accumulation and gestation of symbolic capital by producers and consumers alike." But despite its restricted circulation it had a huge impact on the structure of feeling of many adjacent art forms. For example, tonil's attention to the psychology of characters and its realist acting and scenography filtered into even the most conservative of performing arts, such as courtly wayang wong. To gain understanding of the characters they portrayed on stage, the dancers of Surakarta and Yogyakarta traditionally studied the movement of puppets or sought inspiration by meditating in propitious sites. In contrast, a Yogyakarta court dancer active in the reign of Hamengkubuwana VIII (r. 1921–1939) recounts visiting "the Yap Eye Hospital to observe the movements of the blind" when called on to play a sight-impaired knight (Soedarsono 1984, 222). Tonil was also hugely influential on the colony's nascent film industry, providing it with its key materials—stories, dramaturgies, directors, players, and technicians.

At the end of the 1930s, as anticolonial intellectuals railed against the limitations of Dutch epistemologies, Ki Hadjar Dewantara proposed a newly minted term in the pages of *Poedjangga baroe* to replace the Dutch-derived tonil: *sandi-wara* (Dewantara 1936).¹⁹ Dewantara's article, which concerns the educational benefits of spoken drama (also referred to in the article as *drama* or *tooneel*), does not explain the derivation of this term, which only came into general use in 1942 when the Japanese occupation banned the use of Dutch words on stage and plays from Allied countries (see, e.g., n.a. 1942b). The coinage, sometimes attributed to

Mangkunegara VII (Slametmuljana 1951, 173), is a portmanteau of two Javanese words—*sandi*, meaning “hidden” or “secret,” and *wara*, meaning “proclaim” or “announce.” When combined the words connote a “performance or proclamation of the secrets of society or ways of life”; a common interpretation also has it that sandiwara connotes a means to surreptitiously propagate ideas forbidden by society’s censors—including anticolonial notions.²⁰

Vernacular Modernities

The colonial authorities had good cause to believe that popular theater was a means to stoke insurrection, rebellion, and revolution through hidden allusions, veiled comments, and impenetrable local languages. This fear was perhaps most apparent in relation to the craze around kethoprak, a Javanese-language costume drama that took off in 1926 in Yogyakarta to the consternation of both cultural conservatives and the Dutch colonial authorities. Kethoprak was one of a number of theater genres emerging in the 1920s and 1930s that hybridized the conventions of bangsawan, stambul, and tonil with local cultural forms: other examples include *randai* in West Sumatra (described later); possibly the little-documented *kondo buleng*, a Makassarese folk drama; and *opera Batak*, a bangsawan-derived theater attributed to the Toba Batak composer and theater artist, Tilhang Oberlin Gultom (Carle 1988, 1990). This same period saw the invention of a new version of ludruk by Surabaya comedian Cak Gondo Durasim in collaboration with the politician and labor activist Dr. Soetomo. These theaters drew on local stories and played in local languages, reaching out to audiences who lacked formal schooling and competence in formal Malay or Indonesian.

The hybrid vernacular theaters of the late colonial period are generally celebrated as emblems of local tradition, preserving norms and values from the distant past. Preservationist discourses around these forms flourished under Soeharto’s New Order regime (see, e.g., Sutopo and Kasim Achmad 1982–1983). Government projects were mounted under the dictatorship to document, preserve, and develop popular theater and to yoke them to development agendas such as family planning. Today, preservationist discourse is being continued under the metacultural rubrics of “heritage” and “intangible cultural properties.” It involves complex complicities between local and international actors and agents—a case in point being a current photography project called “Project Tobong” mounted by British community artist Helen Marshall and Indonesian photographer Risang Yuwono and funded by Arts Council England and the British Council; this project aims to present kethoprak to urban audiences both in Indonesia and the United Kingdom, claiming that “lack of government support and

the invasion of modern urban culture makes their way of life [that is, the way of life of kethoprak performers] evermore at risk.”²¹

When kethoprak and randai were first developed in late colonial Java and Sumatra, these cultural forms did not originally oppose modernity, but rather were enabled by it. Both forms of theater articulate what British cultural theorist Stuart Hall calls “vernacular modernity,” performed in the interstitial space between enchantment with cosmopolitan modernity and the familiar comforts of local traditions. Vernacular modernity, Hall states, does not “preserve older traditional ways of life wholly intact, it operates in what Homi Bhabha has called the borderline time of modernities,” preventing “the global system from stabilising itself as a fully sutured or stitched up totality” and exploring “at a level often below the visibility of the global media, the interstices, the gaps, the discontinuities as potential sites of resistance and intervention. [. . .] The very moment of the so called apotheosis of globalisation’s universal mission to closure, is [. . .] also the moment of the slow, uneven, decentering of the west” (Hall 2000).

KETHOPRAK

Kethoprak’s origin is obscure. One account traces it back to an eccentric percussion ensemble combining the sound-producing instruments of *lesung* (a long wooden trough with mortar, used to pound rice) and *kentongan* (a wooden slit drum, used for signaling alarms), with the musical instruments of *kendhang* (drum), *rebana* (frame drum, associated with Islamic music), and *ceracap* (cymbals or castanets associated with Malay music). This ensemble under the innovative court musician K. R. T. Wreksodiningrat accompanied a simple comical drama about farmers and rural life performed at the 1909 wedding celebration of Paku Alam VII.²² After a hiatus of fifteen years, this drama was revived under the direction of one of Wreksodiningrat’s performers as a novelty item for a 1924 pasar malam celebrating Mangkunegara VII’s assumption of his royal title. The drama was officially billed as *wreksatama* (noble wood), punning on the wooden instruments and the creator’s name. But spectators called it kethoprak, an onomatopoeic reference to the *lesung*’s rhythmic patterns (Kunst 1973, 287–288).

Imitator groups sprung up in Surakarta and surrounding villages, but it was in Yogyakarta where kethoprak really found its footing. The first Yogyakarta kethoprak group was formed in mid-1926, and by September 1927 there were reportedly 260 neighborhood groups busking on the streets and performing at ritual events in the city (n.a. 1927). Actors performed in ordinary daily dress, without special costumes or makeup, to the folksy accompaniment of *lesung*, *suling* (bamboo flute), *terbang* (frame drum), and *kendhang*. They sang songs in

the classical Javanese verse forms of *pucung* and *mijil* and enacted simple dances. There were also groups that substituted European instruments such as guitar, mandolin, and violin for the indigenous instruments; replaced rural comedy with legendary and mythological tales such as the story of Joseph and his brothers and the Javanese folktale *Jaka Tarub*; and performed on proscenium stages like itinerant stambul and bangsawan troupes. Performances took place all over the city. Local jazz bands began to do covers of kethoprak songs.

It was not long before professional kethoprak groups were formed. These groups toured the region, often playing pasar malam. Professional companies performed a range of stories rivaling even the repertoire of Miss Riboet's Orion—dynastic histories of the Javanese courts, Bible stories, wayang tales, Arabian Nights plays, Chinese legends, Roman toga dramas, and so on. Costumes were fitted to the plays. Javanese formal wear (*kejawen*) was used for plays set in Java. Middle Eastern-style costumes (*mesiran*) with long flowing robes (*jubah*), baggy pants, and shiny satin vests familiar to audiences from Hollywood films like *The Thief of Bagdad* (1924) were worn in Arabian Nights and biblical plays, and sometimes also Chinese dramas (Wijaya and Sutjipto 1978, 25–27). Sometimes a play was performed serially over several nights (Sudira 1933). Dance was not as important in kethoprak as in wayang wong, but a *keprak* (hollow woodblock) was nonetheless essential for accompanying dance movements (Kunst 1973, 288). The *lesung* that gave the form its name was discarded by the time kethoprak played Batavia in 1928. Some groups used gamelan accompaniment (this became standard only in the 1950s); others fielded a hybrid ensemble of Javanese instruments and stringed instruments such as violin and mandolin.

European scholars and observers generally had a low opinion of kethoprak. A Dutch-language newspaper article from 1927 called it a “cheap distortion” and “democratization” of wayang wong.²³ Ethnomusicologist Jaap Kunst (1973, 288) likewise complained of kethoprak's coarsening of Javanese music and “not very refined dances.” Pigeaud ([1938] 1991, 82) fretted that kethoprak was displacing residual folk dramas such as *kethek ogleng* and *ande-ande lumut*. According to Pigeaud, professional troupes dependent on ticket sales for income were owned by urbanites without direct connections to the life of the countryside and alienated from audiences (349). Although Pigeaud recognized the significance of kethoprak's contemporaneity (35), he felt that its integration of modernity was still incomplete: “Modern, everyday life is usually only portrayed on the stage in the form of short farces, performed as interludes by clown-like characters, and these farces are largely stereotyped. Hence any closer association with modern social conditions can only be found in a few parts of the play, which actually are outside the framework of the story being performed” (Pigeaud [1932] 2003, 306).

New York Times drama critic Brooks Atkinson encountered a kethoprak performance while holidaying in Asia in 1933 and found his experience of vernacular modernity in a Chinese-owned theater located in the Bongkaran district of Surabaya noteworthy enough to share with his Big Apple readers. The play he witnessed was *Djoko Sengoro*, described by Atkinson as “the artless chronicle of an aged king who was sending his ‘No. 1 Man’ into Bali in search of the prince.” Some of the dancing met Atkinson’s approval, but did not offset his dislike of the “long speeches without gestures or expression,” the “wailing voice” of the singing, and the sullen concubines who “exuded contempt.” The accompanying violin and flute sounded like “street mendicants” when mixed with gamelan instruments, because gamelan “brooks no interference” according to Atkinson. The critic met with the troupe’s director and the theater’s owner, a Chinese businessman named T. T. Lauw, who tried his best to convince Atkinson of the drama’s modernity. But, as the *New Yorker* stated,

Modernism is comparative. What is new today depends upon what yesterday was old. And to a Gotham theatregoer the drama in the Bongkaran had the formlessness of a thing that was neither ancient nor modern. The gaudily painted canvas sets with literal pictures, which to Mr. Lauw were modernism, were the antimacassar theatre to us.²⁴

Javanese spectators had their issues with kethoprak too. Aristocrats looked down on kethoprak as plebian entertainment, a bastardization of courtly arts lacking spiritual qualities (Vaníčková 1967, 126).²⁵ One blueblood felt that its portrayal of the ancestors of Javanese nobility was particularly disrespectful and urged authorities to refuse permits for post-Majapahit stories (Sudira 1933). However, the hottest debate was not centered on kethoprak’s authenticity or aesthetics, but rather on the form’s capacity to transmit political messages to the masses through satire and allusion. Kunst (1973, 288) argues that “politics took possession of it: more and more the players started weaving critical sneers and allusions to the police and the authorities, thus unmistakably forcing the performances into a communistic direction.” Kethoprak was Javanese in formal expression, structure, and language, but not narrowly Javanese in its political interests (Vaníčková 1967, 171–172). Plays of the 1920s and 1930s emphasized the greatness of Indonesia’s past to inspire confident strides toward an independent future (175), and kethoprak’s clowns uttered pointed barbs intended to undermine Dutch authority. Spies were sent to monitor performances for “hidden transcripts” (cf. J. Scott 1990), but were befuddled by obscure symbols and the complexities of the Javanese language. A run of performances scheduled at Bata-

via's Thalia Theater in 1929 was canceled at the last minute. The story outline might have appeared innocuous enough, a newspaper article reported, but there was no guarantee that the performers would adhere to it, and anticolonial allusions of the "worst sort" might be slyly inserted.²⁶ Politically oriented urban groups moved out into the countryside to escape detection and bring revolutionary messages to the people after the clampdown on communist-affiliated organizations in 1926–1927 (Vaničková 1967, 131).

Kethoprak also spread to other islands with Javanese migrant populations; during the few months from January to March 1931, at least four kethoprak groups played Medan, where it was said to be "very popular these days."²⁷ *Permainan ketoprak*, "performing kethoprak" in Malay, was used as a code for affiliation with radical, anticolonial political associations in this multiethnic city.²⁸

RANDAI AND ADAT

Equally political, though in a very different way, was the West Sumatran theatrical form of randai. Randai is often interpreted as an emblem of Minangkabau tradition: a composite of oral literature (*kaba*) and pantun recitation, circular dances (*galombang*), pants-slapping percussion (*tapuak*), *silek* martial arts (a regional pencak silat form), *talempong* music and *gurindam* singing, and traditional dress (*galambuak* baggy pants and *daster* headdresses). Stories reference "key elements of Minangkabau cultural life and customs: clan relations, family obligations, arranged marriages, wedding ceremonies, child education, proper protocol and etiquette, the custom of *rantau* (temporary migration), religious learning, and *silat* apprenticeships" (Pauka 2003, 117; see also Pauka 1998). Performed at ground level, generally without backdrops or focused theatrical lighting, randai appears on the surface to be the most unmodern of theaters. But as has been pointed out by Latrell (1998, 178) and others, randai is a prime example of what Eric Hobsbawm (1983, 1) famously describes as "invented tradition," "emerging [...] within a brief and dateable period" and establishing itself "with great rapidity."

Available sources indicate that randai originated in the vicinity of Payakumbuh in West Sumatra in the early 1930s. The first decades of the twentieth century were a period of intense conflict in West Sumatra between adat (customary law) specialists, who were busy formalizing customs and ceremonies to implement their traditional authority in Minangkabau society, and fundamentalist Islamic scholars and leaders wishing to purge the region of accreted local traditions and bring Islamic practice in West Sumatra into line with Middle Eastern doctrine. The religious purifiers tried particularly to suppress *kaba* folktales as expressions of local wisdom and folk Islam. The unsuccessful communist rebellions of the

1920s provided the Dutch authorities with the impetus in the 1930s to repress political parties and modernist Islam and to bolster the authority of conservative adat officials, who were viewed as supportive of Dutch colonialism (Hadler 2008, 104). The dramatization of *kaba* oral tradition in the form of randai must be seen as part and parcel of the adat resurgence in the 1930s.

The immediate theatrical predecessors of and models for randai were the commercial bangsawan troupes that toured the region and the tonil activities of schools and social and charitable organizations. *Kaba* provided an important source for dramatization in the 1920s and 1930s. Abdul Muis, the STOVIA-educated journalist, politician, and novelist, adapted *Cindue Mata* for the fiftieth anniversary celebration of Bukittinggi's "School of Kings" in 1922. An all-girl adaptation of *Sabai nan Aluih* was penned in 1928 by M. Rasjid Manggis, a schoolteacher who went on to direct and write plays for Indonesian students in Cairo, act in Dutch films, perform with Dja and Piëdro's troupe in Europe and the United States, direct films in Java, and found (in 1965) Padang Panjang's high school and conservatory for the performing arts, Konservatori Karawitan and Akademi Seni Karawitan Indonesia. *Poeti Gandonilai*, written by the journalist, translator, and short story writer Saadah Alim, was performed by boys and girls from two single-sex schools in the West Sumatran town of Maninjau in 1930, restaged in Payakumbuh, and featured in a two-page spread in *Pandji Poes-taka*. The photographs published in the magazine (reprinted in Cohen 2003, 219) reveal many recognizable randai features—traditional costume items such as the baggy pants, *talempong* musical instruments, *silek* poses, and the *galombang* circular formation. The images also show stage trappings not generally associated with randai: painted backdrops, a *payung uber-uber* ceremonial parasol, and a traditional *tongkat berambu* spear. Tonil productions in this style followed, including one at a Fancy Fair held in Payakumbuh in 1932.

It is not known precisely when in the 1930s these tonil plays were first imitated by adolescent boys living in *surau* (village prayer houses) in Payakumbuh. But it was almost certainly in this sleepy West Sumatran town where *kaba*-based tonil was hybridized with the already existing circular dance form known as randai. Elsewhere in West Sumatra spoken drama was referred to colloquially as *komidi bitjara* or "speaking shows." But when youths from Payakumbuh began to tour their folk plays to pasar malam in cities and towns around West Sumatra, they referred to their performances as randai or *tonil randai*. Sources are silent about the precise reasons why the youths began to perform outside Payakumbuh. A likely factor was Payakumbuh's subpar rice harvest of 1937, which probably motivated locals to look outside the area for nonagricultural work, however small the remuneration.



Theater performance based on a *kaba* source staged by students at Bukittinggi's "School of Kings" circa 1925. Photograph from Collections KITLV Digital Image Library, 27416.

In any case, once it entered the pasar malam circuit and captured the attention of the press in early 1938, randai spread quickly. In July of that year, five randai groups performed on consecutive nights at a pasar malam in Bukittinggi, a randai competition was held in a Chinese bazaar in Payakumbuh, and Chinese associations were sponsoring randai performances to raise money for charity. Randai was performed at a pasar malam in Batu Sangkar in August, and in the same month a mixed-sex randai troupe from Payakumbuh performed for charity in Padang Panjang's central market. Randai from Payakumbuh was performed at pasar malam held in Padang, Maninjau, and Muara Labuh in September. By December, randai was regularly being performed in a Chinese restaurant in Payakumbuh. One factor in this rapid dissemination was no doubt the recording industry, which took an avid interest in Minang music starting in 1938 (Yampolsky 2013, 133). Beka Records invited the randai group Sitti Baheram from Payakumbuh to record randai songs in a Medan studio in July 1938, and randai albums were available for purchase throughout West Sumatra by November.²⁹

All this movement and resituating led to significant changes. A randai group invited to perform in Tapanuli (North Sumatra), apparently the first time randai was to be performed outside West Sumatra, was busy painting backdrops in

August 1938 because its sponsor had requested it perform on stage. (The normal performance space for randai from the start has been the *sasaran*, an outdoor open space where *silek* is also practiced, with the audience encircling the performers.) Randai groups sprang up in towns and villages around the region. By July 1939, a newspaper correspondent from Sicincin was complaining about the presence of three randai groups practicing and performing nightly in his small town. Because these performances took place outdoors, children could freely watch randai until late at night and would arrive at school without enough sleep.³⁰

Randai is a participatory form—a number of exegetes derive its name from *berhandai-handai*, “to engage in friendly exchange.” Latrell (1998, 294) points out that “the pleasure in creating randai is that of working together, consensus and friendship being the point as opposed to the more product-oriented and efficient Western process.” Putting together a randai play can take as long as a year; many groups have only a single play in their repertoire. This allows for a slow absorption of the play’s underlying messages, which ultimately concern adat values—respect for the *mamak* (maternal uncle), teachers, and elders; prescribed gender roles; the importance of rantau for developing character. Latrell (1998, 288) interviewed a young randai practitioner in the 1990s who reported that randai was not really directly educational “because we already know what’s being shown in the randai, but it does show adat, although the adat is not really shown directly, but we have to learn it from the story.” Randai might not educate, but it did shore up inherited cultural knowledge and confirm membership in a community bound by adat in a time of rapid change and political contestation.³¹

Performing the Arts of Nationalism

Dramas, songs, and other art from the last years of the Dutch colonial period aimed to instill a sense of national belonging by evoking and dramatizing key symbols. Artists conscientiously strove to generate a corpus of nationalist artworks—works that would “extend, open up, and spread our culture” (Dajoh 1940, 28). In the 1930s, while independence was still just an aspiration, politician Muhammad Yamin argued that Indonesia might not (yet) be a nation-state (*staatsnatie*), but it was already a “cultural nation” (*cultuurnatie*) united by a single desire (Yamin quoted in Sutrisno Kutoyo 2004, 85). As Richard Hoggart (1978, 65) points out in his insider exposé of UNESCO, most newly independent nations prioritized in the post–World War II era the creation of symbols that “will reverberate nationally. [. . .] They simply have to create a sense of national unity, often almost from scratch.” Indonesia had a head start over most of the new states. Artwork created in Indonesia in the key decade of 1928 to 1938, including a repertoire of nationalist tonil plays written mostly by Sumatran authors and anthems composed for the nationalist movement—above all, Wage Rudolf Supratman’s “Indonesia raya” (Great Indonesia, 1928)—were stock in trade for Indonesia’s eagerly anticipated independence.

The aim of nationalist art in colonial Indonesia, as in other colonized nations, was to “re-equip the nation culturally” and forge a national culture that was both “adapted to the requirements of progress” and distinct from ethnic traditions, the colonizer’s culture, and cosmopolitan modernity (Chatterjee [1986] 1993a, 2). Contested markers of identity were omitted or amplified to foster what Benedict Anderson calls “unisonance,” glossed by Homi Bhabha as “the collective voice of the people as a performative discourse of public identification” (1990, 309). In the “confrontation between pluralistic and universalizing orientations” (Eisenstadt 2000, 10), nationalist actors and agents took charge of Indonesia’s diverse ethnic heritage while subordinating this “diversity to the modernizing unification expressed simultaneously by scientific knowledge and political nationalism” (Canclini 1995, 143). The political unity of the nation emerged through the displacement of an “irredeemably plural modern space [. . .] into a signifying space

that is archaic and mythical” (Bhabha 1990, 300). There was a tension within the idea of the nation as “a priori historical presence; a pedagogical object; and the people constructed in the performance of narrative, its enunciatory ‘present’ marked in the repetition and pulsation of the national sign” (298). The working out of this tension was apparent in nationalistic performances and the discourse around them.

Nationalist Drama and Pageantry

Poet-politician Rustam Effendi’s verse play *Bebasari* (which can be translated as “Sweet Liberty” or “Essence of Freedom,” 1926) is usually considered to be the first drama of nationalism. The play rewrites the Ramayana as an allegory for national liberation. The protagonist is named Bujang, which is also the Indonesian word for a young unmarried man, and so he is clearly meant to be a surrogate for the prototypical young man (*pemuda*) of the anticolonial movement. Bujang, who is also referred to as Bujangga—a poet-scholar—is charged by an elder (referred to variously as Orang Tua, Ayah, and Si Bapa) to rescue the captive princess Bebasari from the rapacious Rawana, the Ramayana’s principal antagonist and a stand-in for the Dutch colonizers (Effendi [1926] 2010). In a postwar reflection, Effendi describes his play as coming out of a year of intense anticolonial agitation and stern countermeasures, with the colonial regime “muzzling the press in the interest of ‘truth.’ New ‘crimes’ were created, the jails were full, many were exiled” (Effendi [1953] 1967, 204). Effendi turned to traditional poetic “forms as a weapon of freedom, [. . .] adapt[ing] these older ways of singing to our national ideals and aspirations” (204). The play was published in Padang in 1926 and was slated to be performed by local schoolchildren, but Padang’s authorities refused permission for it to be staged; though the play has been widely cited and discussed, it is little performed (Winet 2010, 29). The heroic play’s dense symbolism and bombastic poetry—“Liberate, liberate, oh liberate, body’s sullen sorrows saturate” (Effendi [1926] 2010, 3)—and lack of dramatic action make it more suited for reading than performing. Thus, as an essentially closet drama, *Bebasari* contributes more to the field of Indonesian literature than performance. It is an experiment in expressing nationalist sentiments in verse and writing tonil in the formal, literary register of Malay that was officially designated as *bahasa Indonesia*, “the language of Indonesia” in 1928 (Jassin 1954, 63).¹

Historians sometimes portray *Bebasari* as originating *sui generis*. However, the cultural expressions of pan-Sumatra unity of the 1920s provide an earlier con-

text. “Sumatran nationalism” (cf. Reid 1979, 286–287)—created as a foil to the Javanese nationalism of Boedi Oetomo, Jong Java, and allied Javanese-oriented organizations—was quickly consigned to historiographical footnotes after the 1928 Youth Congress declared all Indonesians to belong to a single motherland and nation and dedicated itself to upholding Indonesian as the “language of unity.” But many Minangkabau and Batak intellectuals were initially enthusiasts of this earlier movement, convinced that Sumatrans from diverse ethnic and linguistic backgrounds needed to forge alliances with each other if their voices were to be heard in the major cities of Java.² It is important to revisit this alternate nationalist movement to understand why Sumatrans were so prevalent in the dramatic canon of nationalism.

We can see aspects of *Bebasari*’s form and sentiments prefigured in pan-Sumatran pageants, among them *Olympiade*, directed by the pedagogue Moehammad Sjafei and his protégé Mara Soetan. *Olympiade* was performed at a cultural evening by the theater club of Medan Perdamaian (Peaceful Medan) in the association’s Batavia clubhouse to a packed audience, including Europeans, Chinese, Arabs, the press, and police, on 3 July 1926. The express purpose of the event was to bring unity to Sumatran youths living in Batavia. The pageant also responded to the growing enthusiasm for sport and physical culture in the buildup to the 1928 summer Olympics in Amsterdam. It can be read as a meditation on Sumatra’s place in the world.

The evening began at 8:00 p.m. After customary thanks and apologies for a shortage of chairs, the curtain was raised and a chorus of girls and boys sang the folk song “Gambang Melaka,” followed by a pantun recited by a three-and-a-half-year-old boy. The curtain was then lowered, and Moehammad Sjafei took the stage to explain that the show is not just an entertainment but also a form of education. All the painted backdrops and symbolic stage actions are intended to convey specific meanings. “Take the first screen,” he says. “It illustrates rice fields, ever-flowing water, a beautiful garden containing trees with rich foliage. This shows the great wealth of Sumatra.” An illustration of two smiling porters bearing a heart symbolizes the pleasure taken in the work to advance Indonesian culture. Pictures of Batak and Minangkabau houses with romantic fantasy gardens demonstrate that traditional architecture is equal to Europe’s villas; the pictures are meant to discourage mindless imitation of the West. A visual showing Sumatra from the air surrounded by fairies (*peri*) and tied to the surrounding islands of Belitung, Bangka, and Riau by a ribbon illustrates the endeavor to raise the standing of Sumatra. But only three of the fairies are shown to be working. Others are just contemplating action or possess stunted wings and so

are unable to assist in advancing Sumatra or show no concern for the island's elevation. As a result the effort has yet to meet with success. The hope is to inspire the people of Sumatra to strive to better themselves through education, so that the whole world might come to know about the island. Sjafei concludes his speech with an apology for the quality of the backdrops, because of the poor quality of the paint used. But even though unaesthetic, the backdrops show that people worked and not only talked. Sjafei's speech was followed by a song expressing a hope that the people from Sumatra living in Batavia will live in peace and harmony, a demonstration of open-hand combat and knife fighting in the style of Palembang martial art (*pentja Palembang*), and finally by the pageant *Olympiade*.

Olympiade opens with children playing soccer, who scatter when thunder sounds. Enter three ancient Greek gods—Zeus, Hermes, and Apollo (played by Sjafei)—and a twelve-year-old boy named Elijas. Apollo discusses the word “sport,” which can be equated to the Malay word *hati* (literally the liver, and figuratively the seat of the emotions) and expresses an aspiration for unanimity in ideals, *bersatoe hati*. He goes on to explain how the Olympic Games originated from a sporting competition between the city-states of ancient Greece. Enemies happily suspended warfare and did not express enmity even when they lost. This led to Greece's everlasting world fame. Stepping out of character, Sjafei explains, “We, the people of the Indies, also possess various sports such as *pencak*, the handkerchief dance, the plate dance, randai, circular dance, and others. We have to advance [*madjoekan*] our sports, throwing away what is rotten, supplementing what is deficient, so that these 10 or 15 types can become 100 or even 200.” Cue Boy Scout maneuvers and old-style *pencak* with knives and swords, followed by songs in front of a backdrop of Sumatra and an assemblage of traditional Sumatran crafts. The next scene shows a young widow with two young children who falls ill but recovers when her children visit their father's grave. A preacher is then called to recite Islamic prayers. The pageant ends with a handkerchief dance in Bengkulu style.³

Moehammad Sjafei and Mara Soetan's pageant, like the Olympics itself, is an expression of diversity, struggle, and excellence on a global stage. It shows a desire for cultural improvement: tradition cannot be passively received, but must be actively advanced. This message aligns with Sjafei's pedagogical philosophy of active learning. Children receive and reproduce instruction with the goal ultimately of creating or producing new work (Thalib [1953] 1978, 41). Islamic religious identity is not forgotten, but is incorporated into a larger dramaturgical structure that can also contain the “pagan” religion of an-

cient Europe. Modernizing local traditions, and transforming them into “sport,” reflects a belief in the possibility of translation and affirms the possibility of both cultural and political communication (cf. Ricoeur [1955] 2006, 52). The nationalist plays that followed would pick up on elements of this approach.

The most important surviving examples of the nationalist-symbolist tonil dramas—the aforementioned *Bebasari* (1926); Sanoesi Pané’s *Airlangga* (1928), *Eenzame Garoedavlucht* (The lonely flight of the garuda, 1930), *Kertajaya* (1932), and *Sandhyakala ning Majapahit* (Twilight over Majapahit, 1932); Muhammad Yamin’s *Ken Arok dan Ken Dedes* (Ken Arok and Ken Dedes, 1928); and Armijn Pané’s *Nyai Lenggang Kantjana* (1938)—were all historical costume dramas written by Sumatran authors that reached back into the history and myths of ancient Java and Sunda to inspire the present nationalist movement.⁴ Plays were published in Dutch- and Indonesian-language literary journals (particularly *Timboel* and *Poedjangga baroe*) and performed at youth congresses, student conferences, and assemblies of political parties, often interspersed with songs, dances, pencak silat demonstrations, and speeches. Although criticized for being overly talky and lacking in action (see, e.g., Teeuw 1979, 1:23–24; Aveling 1974; Balfas 1976), some of these plays received dozens of performances during the 1920s and 1930s.

The stories these plays interpret would have been known to Javanese and Sundanese through wayang, langendriya, kethoprak, gending karesmen, and other vernacular performance forms, but their authors, who did not hail from Java and thus were unfamiliar with the languages and conventions of the island’s regional theaters, encountered them through scholarly sources, largely written in Dutch. Playwrights sought to identify mighty kingdoms, committed heroes, and stirring symbols that could be taken up as models for action and points of reference in the anticolonial struggle. Some of the plays of these educated elites interpolate gamelan music, the comical servants of wayang, and other markers of theatrical tradition, but they are essentially Western in form and substitute footnotes for tradition’s easy assumption of intertextual knowledge. The plays belong to a phase of the national struggle when “the native intellectual” educated in colonial modes of thinking “decides to remember what he is,” but has only a “borrowed aestheticism” available (Fanon [1961] 1994, 40–41). Nonetheless, their invention of history (which involves the forgetting of the past) grants the plays a certain generative power (cf. de Man 1970, 390).

Sanoesi Pané’s *Sandhyakala ning Majapahit* exemplifies this vein of theatrical practice, and conversation around this play opened onto the significant

cultural debates of the time.⁵ The work shows signs of the Tapanuli-born writer's studies of comparative religion with Indian academics at Santiniketan in India in 1928 and of ethnology under Dutch professors at Batavia's Rechts Hogeschool (Law School). It also bears traces of the symbolist drama of Tagore that was so admired by Indonesian and other Asian intellectuals of Pané's generation. Pané refers to his play as a *lakon*, using the Javanese word for play episode, but it in fact collapses what are a number of distinct episodes when the story of its hero, Damar Wulan is portrayed, using wayang kulit or when it is sung and danced as langendriya. In the manner of the *bildungsroman*, the play sketches the hero's development from Damar Wulan's departure from the hermitage of his grandfather, to his service as a stable boy in Majapahit, appointment as Majapahit's commander in chief, victory over the dog-faced Menak Jingga, and eventual execution. An opening invocation by a Buddhist monk character lists the sources consulted (*Serat kanda*, *Damar Wulan*, *Pararaton*, *Nagarakrtagama*) and offers the play to "people who struggle for their freedom and glory," with the hope that this experiment will arouse "the will to write a more beautiful play" (S. Pané [1932] 2010, 36).

In the first scene, Damar Wulan's grandfather reminds him of his duty as a warrior to serve in Majapahit. But it is only a visitation from Wisynu, the god of humanity in wayang mythology, who lifts the burden of existential doubt and allows Damar Wulan to embrace his destiny:

Wisynu: Know, Damar Wulan, that time is only an illusion, only humanity's way of comparing one event with another. Humanity sees a flower grow and blossom, and what lies between these two events is called time. In truth, the flower is not a flower, it doesn't grow and it doesn't blossom, and it is eternally like this because it doesn't have a name or characteristics. [. . .] This is only a dream, Damar Wulan. You exist and don't exist eternally. (41)

When he arrives in Majapahit, Damar Wulan comes to understand that the country's military defeats and the suffering of the people are due to corrupt religious leaders: "Religion has become superstition; all the priests are vicious and cruel-hearted, squeezing the people for all they're worth. [. . .] It used to be that religion improved our character, but it's now become a prison" (47). After Damar Wulan is made regent in recognition of his victory over Menak Jingga, he attempts to reform the religious bureaucracy, making many enemies in the Majapahit court. Loyal to Majapahit's queen, he also refuses to support the gathering forces of Islam. Corrupt officials convince the queen that Damar Wulan is plotting to



The Gedung Permuafakatan at Gang Kenari 15 in Jakarta (currently Museum MH Thamrin) bedecked with bunting and a stage set with a painted backdrop depicting French windows. *Persatoean Indonesia*, 1 August 1929.

overthrow her, and after he is executed the virtuous Menak Koncar prophesizes that Majapahit will be defeated by the *wali sanga*, the nine legendary saints credited with introducing Islam to Java: “The foundation of this kingdom has rotted away; it has no strength anymore. The prosperity which Damar Wulan created was just the last ray of the sun before it set” (71).

The Minangkabau-born cultural critic Sutan Takdir Alisjahbana (2009, 86–93) describes a performance of Pané’s play in a chapter of his oft-reprinted 1936 novel *Layar terkembang* (Sails unfurled). The setting is the closing of the fifth congress of the fictitious organization Pemuda Baru (New Youth) held at the Gedung Permuafakatan (Agreement Building) in Batavia. Before the performance, speeches are given, and the resolutions of the congress read out. Then, *Sandhyakala ning Majapahit* is enthusiastically performed by a group of young people on a brightly illuminated proscenium stage decorated with plants and backed by purple curtains. After the audience has applauded and dispersed into the night, the novel’s protagonist, a young woman named Tuti, reflects on what she has seen and feels compelled to give feedback to friends among the cast. Though touched by the acting and the deep philosophical dialogue, she reports, the play has weakened her heart and drained her strength. If all is *maya* or illusion, as Wisynu says, life has no meaning.

One of the actors counters that Wisynu later says that one cannot exit the world of *maya*, because this would mean escape from the world and people cannot refuse to perform their duties. Tuti responds that this might be true, but that the initial negating of the world drains one of energy—demonstrated in

the play by Damar Wulan's lack of success in reforming Majapahit and his eventual execution. She goes on to say that our people (*bangsa*) are burdened by an Indic heritage that views the world as being a temporary waystation without consequence. This view has resulted in a lack of motivation to achieve honor and greatness, leading to Indonesia's low status in the world. Only by bettering oneself in this world will eternal greatness be achieved. The play's heavy life-and-death theme is not in harmony with the vital energies of the young people who are its intended audience. An actor admits that not every audience member felt that *Sandhyakala ning Majapahit* was suited for the congress's closing party, but there was no other tonal play fit for the purpose.

Takdir decided to include an excerpt of this episode in *Poedjangga baroe*, the literary journal that he edited with the Sumatran poet Amir Hamzah and Sanoesi's brother, the cultural critic Armijn Pané. S. Pané took the publication of this excerpt as the opening salvo in a public dialogue. In the same journal the playwright responded gracefully with a short essay on the aesthetic attitude. Pané agreed with Takdir that art should not only be for art's sake but also argued that Takdir's emphasis on functionality leads to tendentious propaganda, which is not really art at all. S. Pané rejected Takdir's characterization of *Sandhyakala ning Majapahit* as didactic and as dampening resolve, because the play offers valuable lessons for the national struggle. Damar Wulan is a reformer vacillating between dream and action; Majapahit is defeated precisely because of this bifurcation. A new moment is envisioned with the arrival of Islam, a religion that, it is suggested, merges dream and action (S. Pané 1936).

Yet the play's relation to history is more complex and conflicted than Pané lets on. In a discussion of insurrections threatening to overthrow her rule, Majapahit's queen tells her ministers "there's nothing to be gained by discussing all those past events" (S. Pané [1932] 2010, 52–53). In the very same speech she quotes directly from a fourteenth-century chronicle by Mpu Prapañca of Majapahit—known to intellectuals of Pané's generation through a Dutch translation by philologist Johan Hendrik Caspar Kern—and references two other Old Javanese texts made accessible through Dutch-language scholarship as well. History is therefore simultaneously asserted and denied as Majapahit becomes a stand-in for the nation-in-formation, a pedagogical object through which to imagine future glory and critique past shortcomings, generating textual and social affiliation through its acting out on stage (see also Reid 1979; S. Supomo 1979; Bhabha 1990, 292).

The National Anthem

Another tonil play set in Java's legendary past, Muhammad Yamin's *Ken Arok dan Ken Dedes* (Ken Arok and Ken Dedes), includes gamelan and other markers of tradition, while leaning on Dutch scholarship—an annotated Dutch translation of the *Pararaton* that the author likely knew from a 1920 edition published by the Royal Batavian Society of Arts and Sciences. The play premiered at the second Kongres Pemuda (Youth Congress) held in 1928, which assembled youth organizations from around the archipelago, including Jong Java, Jong Sumatranen Bond, Jong Batak, and Jong Celebes. The congress was held at Langen Siswo's clubhouse in Batavia, the same space used for the weekly Javanese dance practices of STOVIA students.⁶ This congress has a canonical place in Indonesian history for its declaration known to all Indonesians as the Sumpah Pemuda (Youth Oath), which pledged that “we the sons and daughters of Indonesia” belonged to one motherland and one nation to be called Indonesia and pledged to uphold the Indonesian language “as the language of unity.” In one stroke, the diverse peoples of the Indies branded as “natives” by the Dutch subordinated ethnic particularisms in favor of modernizing unification.

The 1928 congress also saw the premiere of Indonesia's national anthem “Indonesia raya” (Great Indonesia), composed by the journalist and musician Wage Rudolf Soepratman. Soepratman was the son of a Javanese sergeant instructor in the colonial army. In the early 1920s, he had played violin in a jazz band while working as a teacher in Makassar and, after moving to Bandung, played in a dance band as a sideline to his work as a reporter (Oerip Kasansengari 1967). In 1925, Soepratman moved to Batavia, where he sold used books and worked as a news gatherer for the Sino-Malay newspaper *Sin po*. Attending nationalist meetings for the paper, he came into contact with the leaders of the nationalist movement and became an ardent nationalist himself. A call by a newspaper for songs to “awaken the people's spirit [*semangat*]” (Wartawan Kita 1963) resulted in Soepratman's first patriotic air, “Dari barat sampai ke timur” (From West to East). This was followed by “Indonesia raya” (originally titled simply Indonesia) and a string of other songs including “Bendera kita” (Our flag), “Indonesia ibuku” (Indonesia, my mother), and “Ibu kita Kartini” (Our mother, Kartini). Although other tunes were under consideration as the anthem for the nationalist movement in 1928—one candidate being the song “Bagi ra'jat dan sri iboe” (For the people and honored mother) sung to the melody of the rousing Dutch patriotic song “In naam van Oranje, doe open de poort!” (In the name of Orange, open the door!)—Soepratman's song was quickly endorsed by Sukarno and other nationalist leaders.⁷ As composer L. Manik (1951, 174) observed, “Indonesia raya” was a song that

neither reiterated Mooi Indië clichés about Indonesia's tropical beauty nor called for the blood of the colonial oppressors, but instead "pushed and moved us in the direction of action."

Newspapers published the lyrics and melody of "Indonesia raya," and a recording was issued. The song was sung at gatherings, receptions, and meetings of nationalists around the archipelago. It was not long before clubs with nationalist sympathies were refusing to play the Dutch anthems "Wilhelmus" and "Wien Neêrlands bloed," even to greet Dutch officials, and nationalists were standing at attention during the singing of "Indonesia raya."⁸ The Dutch colonial government understood these as signs of insurrection, resulting in the banning of "Indonesia raya" in the late 1930s.

As a composer, Soepratman fell short of the caliber of the composers of Indonesia's most famous patriotic songs, such as the Muntiran-trained composer and singer Cornel Simanjuntak, the kroncong violinist and composer Kusbini, or the multitalented composer and musician Ismail Marzuki, who possessed equal facility in composing in kroncong, Hawaiian, and *lagu seriosa* idioms. Amir Pasaribu (1955, 45–50), on the occasion of the twenty-fifth anniversary of the Youth Oath, wrote how the lyrics of "Indonesia raya" did not fit the music. He discerned also the melody's overly close resemblance to the Dutch anti-Chinese comic song "Pinda-pinda lekka-lekka" (Peanut, peanut, tasty, tasty) and the Yale fight song "Boola-Boola." He pointed out the difficulties posed by singing it chorally, which contravened the Sumpah Pemuda's ideological emphasis on unisonance. Pasaribu felt the song was a compromise between musical and ceremonial values and proposed it was time for new national anthems. Sukarno was likewise not entirely satisfied with the song and authorized the Dutch composer Jozef Cleber, who worked for the state radio station Radio Republic Indonesia after World War II, to make alterations in its music and text in a symphonic arrangement of 1951 (Gommers-Dekker 2011, 187–197).

Sanoesi Pané put forward a detailed literary critique of Soepratman's anthem in a 1934 *Poedjangga baroe* essay. Here, Pané complains about the ambiguities and apparent grammatical errors of its lyrics. The (original) first verse has the first-person subject *mendjaga pandoe iboekoe* "guarding the mother[land]'s pathfinder." Pané notes that "pathfinder" today connotes a Boy Scout, though in the past it denoted a leader. It is not appropriate for a national anthem to begin with an allusion to the international scouting movement, and if the word indeed refers to the nation's leaders, why should they be in need of guarding? The couplet in the following verse, *Indonesia kebangsaankoe/kebangsaan tanah airkoe*, "Indonesia is my nationality/the nationality of my homeland," Pané takes as a simple

mistake. *Kebangsaan* (nationality) is an adjective, not a noun, he says, and should be replaced by *bangsa* (folk)—one refers to *bangsa Belanda* (the Dutch), not *kebangsaan Belanda*. The sentiment might ring true, but not the grammar. Regarding the next verse's *hidoeplah tanahkoe, hidoeplah negerikoe/bangsakoe djiwakoe semoea* (Long live my land, long live my country/my nation, my soul, entirely), Pané says the feelings are again clear but the meaning vague. What does “my soul” mean here? And does not the word “*semoea*” (entirely, all) connote plurality, when what is surely intended is unity? Furthermore, the verse seems to signal a shift from a first-person singular to plural subject. About *bangoenlah raktjatnya/bangoenlah badannja* (let us build the people/let us build the body), Pané asks what it means by the body of Indonesia. *Badan* or “body” refers to physique, but how can a nation possess a physique? The third stanza's *bagi kita disini/disanalah kita berdiri* (for us here, we stand over there) makes no sense. How can one be here and stand there? Pané worried that these inconsistencies meant that “Indonesia raya” could not stand alongside other national anthems such as “Bande Mataram,” the “Marseillaise,” “God Save the King,” or “Wilhelmus”—and indeed most of these “errors” were corrected in the revised lyrics of 1958 (see Oerip Kasansengari 1967).

But the “mistakes” Pané identified point precisely to the interesting ambiguities in late-colonial Indonesian nationalism. History shows that the nation's leaders, such as Tan Malaka, were indeed vulnerable and in need of protection, and although it seems odd to begin a national anthem with an allusion to the Boy Scouts, it was precisely scouting that provided the nationalists with a model for mass behavior—marching, saluting, choral singing, making pledges, and the like. The people of Indonesia were not a singular folk in the same way as the Dutch, but rather a collection of *bangsa* who aspired to fashion a national culture that did not efface local particularities. Rather than insisting on uniform essence, there was instead a yearning for a national soul that was both plural and singular. The national body existed, but it occupied an indeterminate space: here, there, and everywhere in between.

Cultural Polemics

Polemics on culture (*polemik kebudayaan*) that raged in the 1930s in the pages of *Poedjangga baroe* and other periodicals and books focused on the creation or identification of a collective Indonesian cultural identity and how one might “incorporate some of the Western universalistic elements of modernity in the construction of” Indonesian identity, “without necessarily giving up specific

components of [...] traditional identities (often couched, like the themes of Western modernity, in universalistic, especially religious terms)” (Eisenstadt 2000, 14f).⁹ The place of traditional cultural forms in modernity had been fiercely debated since the 1910s. Some saw “ethnic” arts such as wayang as warehouses of hoary spirit beliefs and outdated feudal values and thus impediments for progress, whereas others leaned on theosophy to argue that they contained core values that could be extracted and used as moral compasses in an age of rapid change (Shiraishi 1981; Sears 1996, 131–139). The urgency of fostering a pan-Indonesian culture in the 1930s pushed these debates forward. Some cultural critics, especially Sutan Takdir Alisjahbana, continued to espouse an anti-traditional ideology, aspiring toward what Shils (1981, 150) calls “uniqueness and originality” in artistic endeavors. Indonesian culture for Takdir and his school was inalienably modern and had perforce “to create its normativity out of itself” without recourse to “models supplied by another epoch,” to draw on Habermas (1987, 7).

In contrast, Muhammad Yamin argued that genuinely Indonesian art (*kesenian Indonesia*) could not be created by intellectuals working in isolation from the people: “We must deliver art at the bequest and for the purpose of society” (Yamin and Abbas 1935, 5). Yamin envisioned this art as allied to Marxist ideology and the workers’ movement, balancing the local and the international, popular and high culture, the past and present. His vision was clearly related to Armijn Pané’s championing of syncretic popular cultural forms with pan-ethnic appeal such as kroncong as legitimate forms of Indonesian culture. Although Pané admitted that, in comparison to gamelan, kroncong was still at an early stage of artistic development, it had the advantage of being unencumbered by traditionalism and was receptive to an eclectic range of sources, not only Western but also “Chinese, Arabic, Romanian, Javanese, Sundanese, Batak, Manadonese, and Ambonese. This proves that kroncong contains a fresh energy. Kroncong widens out to all directions, inner and outer” (A. Pané 1941, 259).

Yet Armijn’s beautifully emblematic modern novel *Belenggu* (Shackles, 1988), published in 1940, complicates this admiration for kroncong. The novel’s protagonist is a successful Batavia doctor who leaves his wife, an amateur pianist and organizer of charity benefits, for a beautiful kroncong singer and recording artist. The kroncong singer presents herself as a traditional-minded homemaker, but at the end of the novel she leaves her lover and sails away without a forwarding address; all the furnishings of her home turn out to have been leased. Kroncong, Armijn seems to be telling us, offers only the illusion of home. It can never truly belong to anyone.

In a manifesto published in 1937, Ki Hadjar Dewantara ([1967] 1994, 189–190) mapped the derivation of national art from ethnic root sources as necessarily involving three principles: continuity, convergence, and concentricity. Continuity with the past, without sentimental attachment to ancestral ways, provided direction for cultural change, whereas a program of modernization could be aimless. Convergence recognized the impossibility of cultural purity. Those espousing doctrines of purity and isolation doom their arts to certain death. Cultures should not and cannot stand alone, but need to adapt to each other. Convergence automatically involved going beyond the copying the past. Through participating in intercultural convergence, one was contributing to a discussion and establishing a mode of cooperation that could provide capital for future collaborative projects. The principle of concentricity concerned the handling of cultural difference: a strong sense of unity could not be generated by imposing sameness. Instead, unity meant aiming for equal degrees of connection and valuation across groups, with these relations to be characterized by decency and harmony. Ki Hadjar, with Yamin, argued that Indonesian culture could not be artificially engineered, but would need to emerge gradually as an evolution of the mingling of people from different ethnic backgrounds. If people did not remain actively involved in their traditional cultures, they would only have recourse to foreign cultures in the future.

Sukarno, in an open letter to Sanoesi Pané that was widely published in 1933, asked rhetorically, “What grand work have we accomplished? Where are our giant Buddha images, our Angkor Wats, our Mahabharatas, our Homers, our Dantes, our cathedrals, our Beijing temples! We were and are a weak people. We do nothing but copy: we are incapable of originating things. It will take a long time before the national movement amounts to anything, before we are genuinely free.”¹⁰ Sukarno’s words were, of course, intended as a salutary challenge to Indonesian artists. But his stress on monuments revealed his blindness to the most significant Indonesian cultural achievements of the late colonial period, the “displacement of rule-bound production” by “reflexive modernity” (Beck, Gidens, and Lash 1994, 115), the creation of spaces for dialogue, the freedom to select from and mix competing cultural options.

Conclusion to Part II: New Symbolic Frameworks

Franz Fanon tells us that “a national culture is not a folklore, nor an abstract populism,” but a “body of efforts” of people to “keep itself in existence” ([1961] 1994, 44). The collaborative creative work conducted by and for educated elites in Java’s urban centers in the 1920s and 1930s gave unisonance to diverse groups. Many of

the nationalists had a respectful, if not reverent, attitude to religious and ethnic traditions of the past. But across the board, these traditions were partialized and privatized, seen as binding only for some members or in certain spheres. Past “symbols of collective identity” could be “discarded or incorporated into the new symbolic frameworks” without regard to tradition’s guardians (Eisenstadt 1973, 21). The West Sumatran playwrights who appropriated Javanese motifs and forms could do so through citing authoritative Dutch sources. Songs from other islands could be picked up by singers from phonographic recordings. Simplified courtly dance could be learned at school or in courses of instruction, or even in home-study manuals. The shaping of a new, pan-Indonesian symbolic framework involved not only reflexive modernity but also “reflexive traditionalization” with “an ethic of commitment and obligation [. . .] to a *community*,” namely the imagined nation-in-form and its components (Beck, Giddens, and Lash 1994, 126). The fashioning of a “‘modern’ national culture that is nevertheless not Western” was nationalism’s “most powerful, creative, and historically significant project,” according to Partha Chatterjee (1993b, 6).

Robert Bellah et al. ([1985] 1986, 309) define a living tradition as “an historically extended, socially embodied argument, and an argument precisely in part about the goods which constitute that tradition. [. . .] Traditions when vital, embody continuities of conflict.” Traditions that successfully weathered the maelstrom of modernity were not locked into colonial protocols and sclerotic, ceremonial postures, but instead were able to react and adapt to vicissitudes of the moment. In this vein, late colonial debates concerning the mediation of traditional music on records and radio, the lifting of restrictions on the study and performance of court arts, the hybridizing of indigenous and exogenous forms, and their codification, aestheticization, commercialization, and modernization were not signs that traditional arts and their interpretive communities were etiolated. Rather the controversies around these changes demonstrated the continuing vital purchase of the arts in the public sphere.

The reinvention of tradition occurred in conjunction with the emergence of artistic modernism, and practitioners were prone to “oscillation between cosmopolitanism and localism” (Eisenstadt 2000, 13). In Perry Anderson’s analysis, European modernism “flowered” in the early twentieth century “in the space between a still usable classical past, a still indeterminate technical present, and a still unpredictable political future” (1984, 105). The same conditions prevailed in Indonesia. Popular theater troupes such as Dardanella and Miss Riboet not only purveyed the latest in Hollywood song-and-dance routines but also promised intimate portrayals of the lives and customs of social elites, including royalty, and reinterpreted old dances and songs for modern audiences. The multiethnic

makeup of these troupes, no less than their plays' structure of feeling, intimated political futures that could not be articulated elsewhere. In the appropriating of global forms by vernacular modernity, the synthesizing of new arts and the renewal of old ones, artists, patrons, critics, and audiences both made sense of their changing world and made an impact on it.

Occupation and “Greater Asian” Modernity

“No more musicians, no more writers”

March 1942. The *Sakura Maru*, a Japanese army transport ship carrying the military propaganda unit Jawa Sendenhan, has been torpedoed and is sinking off Java’s coast in the harbor of Banten. One of the propaganda corps’ members, composer and conductor Iida Nobuo, remains below decks. He is frantically completing a piece of musical propaganda titled “The Sounds of Battle” under orders from his commander. Like many in his unit, Iida is a civilian employee, a “man of culture” (*bunkajin*). Iida received composition training from opera composer Kōsaku Yamada after his initial studies of mining engineering at Tokyo University and is credited by IMDb.com with having written seventeen film scores between 1935 and 1941. In a newspaper article published in Japan a month after the Battle of Sunda Strait, Iida recollected landing in western Java as a transformative moment in his understanding of art and life:

As a composer, I wanted to experience the war as a musician, sensing the war through sound, and to record the war as I had thus experienced it. [. . .] With the first bullet, my consciousness as a tradesman vanished. Not only that—the opinion I had held up to then towards music, my attitude towards my own pieces—these vanished too. [. . .] In this total war that will determine the fate of the nation and the fate of Asia, there are no more musicians, no more writers, indeed no more “private citizens” at all—only soldiers of various stripes, each, in his own way, mobilizing all his powers towards the final victory. (Iida trans. in Erkelens and Heidebrink 2010, 389; see also Mark 2003, 77)

Iida’s unit was part of a new initiative in the Japanese war effort. Japanese leaders attributed the slow progress of the China campaign to the failure to convince the Chinese people of the merits of the New Order in Asia and the Greater East Asia Co-Prosperity Sphere, as Japan referred to its expanding Asian empire.

Close study of Nazi Germany's *propaganda korps* resulted in a 1941 decision to attach military propaganda battalions to each of Japan's armies fighting in the push south to acquire the resources (above all, Indonesian oil) needed for the war. Japanese and Korean writers, painters, musicians, filmmakers, technicians, and other culture workers were mobilized and charged with "the duty of counter-enemy propaganda and of crushing the enemy's will to fight, and other numerous duties such as the prevention of the destruction of resources due to the particular nature of the Dutch Indies, the stimulation of the morale of the officers and soldiers of the Imperial Forces, reporting to Japan proper, and the propaganda and pacification operations to stabilize the popular feeling" (*Java Nenkan* quoted in Shigetada and Kishi [1959] 1963, 247; see also Mark 2003, 45).

The Japanese had expected fierce resistance from the populace during their assault on the Dutch Indies. Instead, as Japanese forces advanced in a series of well-planned campaigns, peasants fled from their villages or ruefully turned against Dutch soldiers and civilians. The Dutch surrendered Ambon on 3 February 1942, followed in short order by Java on 8 March, Sumatra on 28 March, and Borneo on 1 April that same year.

The lack of Indonesian resistance was in part a dividend of nightly broadcasts from Radio Tokyo in the run-up to the invasion. Claims that Japan was arriving to liberate Indonesia from Dutch colonialism and bring unity to Asia seemed more credible when preceded by the playing of a stirring arrangement of the anthem "Indonesia raya," scored by Iida's teacher Kōsaku Yamada for a Japanese chorus and the Tokyo Philharmonic Orchestra.¹ The promise of sovereignty appeared less certain, however, after the Japanese carved up the archipelago into three separate zones: the Twenty-Fifth Army ruled Sumatra and Malaya, the Sixteenth Army controlled Java and Madura, and the Navy administered Eastern Indonesia and Borneo.

In the initial euphoria surrounding Dutch defeat, a Bandung newspaper printed the lyrics of "Indonesia raya" without authorization. Editors and reporters were promptly summoned for reprimand by a representative of the propaganda unit, who told them,

"Indonesia raya" is a song you fellows sang when you were under the oppression of the Dutch government [. . .], a form of resistance against the stingy Dutch government. [. . .] In this age of great change, I do not know why anyone would want to publicize such an outmoded song. I don't know why you fellows can't at least remake the song, so that it doesn't say *Indonesia raya*, but rather something like *Asia raya* [Greater Asia] or *Pacific raya* [Greater Pacific]. (Tomizawa Unio quoted in Mark 2003: 216)

By April 1942, the playing of “Indonesia raya” and the display of the red-and-white Indonesian flag were banned in Java, prohibitions that were extended to the other administrative zones in the months ahead. Discontent caused by the ban on “Indonesia raya” was initially of minor concern to the Japanese occupiers. The Japanese cultural workers charged with making the 125 million inhabitants of the former Dutch Indies gung ho about the war brought with them little prior knowledge, and even less appreciation, of Indonesian cultural conditions and practices. Only eight of the two hundred members of Iida’s unit had even a passable knowledge of the Indonesian language. This was not surprising because, up until 1942, there had been little opportunity in Japan to learn about Indonesia. A national Japanese association called Nichi-Ran’in Kyōkai (Japan-Dutch Indies Society) was essentially inactive by 1938 (Gotō 1998, 195–196). Scattered research on music and dance had been conducted in the 1930s by Japanese ethnomusicologists Tanabe Hisao, Kurosawa Takatomo, and Masu Genjiro. Tanabe’s 1941 music anthology *Tōa no Ongaku* (Music of East Asia) included pieces from Java and Bali, but these were cribbed from the trailblazing twelve-volume German anthology *Musik des Orients* (Music of the Orient) released a decade earlier (Shuheii 1998, 13–14).

Also in 1941, a play titled *Onnabahansen* (She-pirates) with an Indonesian setting was produced in Japan by the popular Takarazuka all-female musical theater revue. The production was noteworthy for featuring gamelan instruments, the first set known to be imported to Japan, purportedly purchased from a Javanese nobleman. It was otherwise imperialistic, primitivist hokum comparable to Hollywood South Sea island pictures. The play ends with an Indonesian sultan welcoming Japanese travelers to reside permanently in his land where they will be a “bridge between the hearts of the natives and the Japanese,” cooperating toward “a brighter future for both countries.” The curtain line, “Long live the emperor of Japan!!!,” is proclaimed by all onstage characters, Japanese and Indonesian alike (Steele 2012, 538).

In a postwar interview, Shimizu Hitoshi, head of the propaganda section of the Jawa Sendenhan, expressed that he was initially certain that Japan’s superior cultural technologies—film, radio, photography—would so awe the masses that they would not question Japanese propaganda messages (Mark 2003, 203). Shimizu masterminded the Asian unity movement and the associated 3A movement propaganda campaign, which inverted the “V” of the “V for Victory” of the Allies and declared Japan as leader, light, and protector of Asia (*Nippon tjahaja Asia, Nippon pelindoeng Asia, dan Nippon pemimpin Asia*). But the “natives” of Indonesia, avid consumers of European and American culture and proud possessors of their own sophisticated cultural forms, were not the impressionable primitives

of Takarazuka's *Onnabahaman*. Indonesians from the lowest of peasants to the highest of nobility were forced to bow to Japanese military personnel and civilians, but Japan's claims to higher civilization grated. The Indonesians found Japanese claims of being the source of all Asian culture, buttressed by Nazi-style geopolitical theory, to be "surprising and ridiculous" (Jassin 1945, 16). An article from early April 1942 in a Japanese-language periodical claimed that wayang wong performers were seeking to incorporate *kabuki* motifs into their art, gamelan musicians desired to "let the masses hear Japanese music played on their instruments," and tonil actors were planning to perform Japanese-language dramas (quoted in Mark 2003, 295). The reality was quite different. Armijn Pané, citing the influence of Japanese aesthetics on Russian director Sergei Eisenstein's theory of montage, suggested tentatively that "we too could certainly obtain materials from *noh* and *kabuki* to perfect our own theater" (Pané 1945, 109). This attitude was a far cry from passive imitation and blind wonder. Indonesians refused to "ape Japanese culture as a 'mature' Asian culture" (Jones 2013, 70). Just as the Japanese needed to work together with the indigenous elites who made up the colonial civil service (*pangreh praja*) under the Dutch to collect taxes and agricultural products, recruit laborers, and maintain the rule of law, so they could not effectively develop and disseminate propaganda without taking into account indigenous symbols and premises. This meant collaborating with established and emerging Indonesian intellectuals and artists.

Although the Japanese occupation lasted only three and a half years, it had a profound impact on the bureaucratization and modernization of the arts. Playwright and director Usmar Ismail (1949, 146) is not alone in his assessment that the arts had "never before had grown or flowered with such fertility." Discouragement of and bans on cultural practices associated with the Dutch and the Allies, the need to create or implement pan-Asian cultural expressions, and the establishment of organizational structures imported from Japan created many new possibilities for cultural production. Postcolonial theorist Franz Fanon describes how the break with colonial regimes in the 1940s and 1950s brought "new vigour" to non-European expressive cultures around the world—with "forms of expression and themes which are fresh and imbued with a power which is no longer that of invocation but rather of the assembling of the people, a summoning together for a precise purpose. Everything works together to awaken the native's sensibility and to make unreal and unacceptable [*sic*] the contemplative attitude, or the acceptance of defeat" (Fanon [1961] 1994, 49). In Indonesia this process took off under the aegis of the Japanese occupation. Symbols of nationalism and ethnic and religious identities changed in meaning and function. Performances became caught up in a mass movement leading to what Walter Benjamin called

"a tremendous shattering of tradition," "the liquidation of the traditional value of the cultural heritage" (Benjamin [1936] 1969, 221). Many of the new and hybrid cultural institutions invented to sway the populace to support the war effort were resilient and continued through the revolution and beyond.

Under the conditions of colonialism, Indonesian intellectuals and artists had reached what postcolonial critic Partha Chatterjee (1993a, 50) calls the "moment of departure," an "awareness—and acceptance—of an essential cultural difference between East and West" and an espousal of belief that modern Europe is "culturally equipped for power and progress, while such attributes are lacking in the 'traditional' cultures of the East, thus dooming those countries to poverty and subjection." Although there was not universal consensus, it was commonly assumed among the archipelago's educated elites that the "East is superior in the spiritual aspect of culture" and that "true modernity for the non-European nations would lie in combining the superior material qualities of Western cultures with the spiritual greatness of the East" (51). Japanese occupation complicated this East–West conceptual divide. The "national-cultural project," as Chatterjee describes it, was no longer "to create a cultural ideal in which the industries and the sciences of the West can be learnt and emulated while retaining the spiritual greatness of Eastern culture" (73). Instead, modernity was to be sought within Asia. Asian traditions were not only to be preserved or mourned but also boldly proclaimed as compatible with modernity and transformed into the basis for a claim to an alternative modernity (cf. Dirlik 2010, 35). Sutan Takdir Alisjahbana, who worked for the Indonesian Language Commission under the Japanese, retuning Indonesian so that it could replace Dutch as the language for science and politics, describes the elimination of "all traces of Dutch and Western influence" as a "huge cultural experiment" ([1978] 2008, 87).

The occupation was thus for Indonesia what Chatterjee (1993a, 51) calls a "*moment of manoeuvre*, a crucial moment with many contradictory possibilities. [. . .] It consists in the historical consolidation of the 'national' by decrying the 'modern,' the preparation for expanded capitalist production by resort to an ideology of anti-capitalism—in other words, 'the development of the thesis by incorporation a part of the antithesis.'" Under the guise of traditionalism, arts and culture operated as fascist propaganda tools to increase production. Indonesia's performing arts were both unfettered from traditional structures of authority and shackled to new ones, opened up to new influences and shuttered from others.

Toward Greater East Asian Culture

Japan's parceling of the Dutch Indies into distinct administrative zones meant that the arts and propaganda efforts were organized in different ways in different parts of the archipelago. As Jones (2013, 57) points out, "the Japanese strategy in Java was centered around mobilization based on the nationalist movement, whereas the [...] other occupying administrations relied more on traditional leaders to muster support." In Java, the Jawa Sendenhan was initially an independent department of the military government in charge of propaganda and publications; it was known unofficially as the Sendenbu or "Propaganda Department" in Japanese and *Barisan Propaganda* or "Propaganda Front" in Indonesian. In October 1942, it was reduced to a subsection of the Planning Section of the General Affairs Department and became known officially as the Information Department, while retaining its old nicknames (Mark 2003, 490). Several months later, many of the *bunkajin* (men of culture) who participated in the invasion of Java in March 1942 returned to Japan, their one-year contracts having expired. Regional Sendenbu offices in Bandung, Yogyakarta, Semarang, Surabaya, and Malang, each headed by a Japanese propaganda officer overseeing local Indonesian staff, were established to implement propaganda programs and manage local cultural initiatives. Propaganda and oversight of publications and the arts were handled in Sumatra by the Bunka-Ka, or Department of Culture. The Sendenbu's equivalent in Borneo was known as Borneo Simboensja and seemed to have a limited budget; its sponsored events were regularly billed as being held "with the help of the Borneo civil administration department" (*dibantoe oleh Borneo Minseiboe*). The equivalent organization operating in Sulawesi, Ambon, and the rest of eastern Indonesia was known as Ceram-Sinbun-Sya.

Despite having differing structures, there was much exchange and overlap between these administrative zones in practice. Policies formulated in the Sendenbu's head office in Jakarta, as Batavia was now officially called, were exported to other parts of the archipelago. Plays and music written in Java were performed outside of it. Experts were sent from Jakarta to Borneo for consultations, Java-based commercial theater troupes toured Sulawesi under government sponsorship, and

Balinese dancers were transported from Bali to Jakarta to perform at official functions.

Relations between government departments and sections with Indonesian culture workers were brokered and negotiated through a host of organizations that had sprung up within weeks of the start of the occupation. An ad hoc Komite Kesenian Indonesia (Indonesian Arts Committee), for example, organized an evening of Indonesian arts in the city of Banjarmasin on 5 April 1942, only four days after the Allies surrendered Borneo. It included gambus music, a Javanese wayang wong fragment and *kiprah* dance, a demonstration of Banjar-style pencah, an Ambonese flute orchestra, and a folk dance staged by local performers, including a Javanese doctor, for an audience of Japanese soldiers and local elites in the city's Oranje Theater, renamed the Tokio-Opera under the occupation. Although the alleged purpose of this event was to "introduce Indonesian arts to Japanese soldiers here," a local scout troop was vigorously applauded for its rendition of a Japanese patriotic march.¹

Even earlier, the Jawa Sendenhan had arranged a meeting with sixty of Indonesia's most prominent writers and artists in Jakarta on 27 March 1942, only eighteen days after the Dutch surrendered. The meeting was described as a first attempt for "the two parties to get to know each other" (*kenal-mengenal diantara kedoea belah pihak*) with the intention of creating a Greater East Asian Cultural Association—an ambition that was never realized, it seems (n.a. 1942a). Discussion was more open than might be expected. The Indonesian culture workers present readily endorsed the principles of Shimizu Hitoshi's Asian unity movement and Japanese aspirations to erase Western cultural influences to fashion an *Asia Raya* or "Greater Asia." They did not challenge assertions of a shared Buddhist cultural history that conveniently ignored five centuries of Islamization, perhaps because many among them had similarly ignored Islam in formulating cultural nationalism under the Dutch (cf. Mark 2003, 264). Disagreement was, however, expressed with the dictum of Machida Kenji, the Sendenhan's head, that Japan must be "at the center of the sphere of Asian cultural exchange" (quoted in Mark 2003, 291). Writer-director Andjar Asmara, one of the meeting's most outspoken participants, countered that Indonesia should be considered instead as Japan's neighbor, a neighbor that needed to set its own house in order for the sake of the whole neighborhood's tranquility: "Our culture will be shaped first among ourselves, so that we might at a future date seek a way of steering it towards the culture of Greater Asia—so long as it is not in conflict with the fundamentals of [our] race" (291).

A highlight of the meeting was the premiere of the song "Hidoep Indonesia" (Long live Indonesia), subsequently printed in *Pandji poestaka*, the magazine that

remained required reading for Indonesian civil servants during the Japanese occupation. The song had music by Iida Nobuo and lyrics by Ichiki Tatsuo, an Indonesian-speaking Japanese national who had previously worked as a photographer and reporter in Palembang and Bandung and as a researcher in the South Seas Bureau of Japan's Foreign Ministry. The lyrics harkened back to a golden age of the pre-Islamic kingdoms of Majapahit and Srivijaya, evoking the fertility and beauty of the land and the nobility of the Indonesian people (Iida and Ichiki 1942). Ichiki's sentiments were genuine: an ardent supporter of Indonesian nationalism, he died fighting the Dutch during the Revolution (Gotō 1976)—and the song was warmly received by those present.

The arts responded quickly to the transition from Dutch to Japanese rule. During the first months of the occupation, European artists and technicians were employed to run the radio stations and make essential propaganda films until their replacements could be trained. Several European performing artists also remained active. The Hungarian-born pianist Lili Kraus, who was living with the family of a Chinese doctor in Bandung when Japan invaded, was initially permitted to live outside of the ghettos and camps where Europeans were imprisoned. In exchange for this privilege, she gave solo recitals of Beethoven, Mozart, Bartók, Debussy, and Schubert in prison camps around Java and performed concertos with the Jakarta radio orchestra under Iida's baton. After more than a year's liberty, she was finally imprisoned, but continued to give concerts and offer piano lessons to her prison guards. Iida ensured she had a piano to practice on. Love of music sustained Kraus through the physical deprivation and hardship of the camps. She reported that her hands strengthened with physical labor, giving "a new physicality" to her piano playing when she resumed her international concert career after the war (Robertson 2000, 82).

Sandiwara

The huge financial success of the kroncong musical film *Terang boelan* (Full Moon, 1937), loosely based on the Hollywood picture *The Jungle Princess* (1936) starring Dorothy Lamour, led to a burgeoning film industry in the late 1930s and the exodus of tonil directors, writers, actors, and musicians from theater to film. After the Japanese shut down Java's independent film studios, however, film artists were eager to return to theater. As Usmar Ismail (1949, 146) quipped, "One without a hope of governing the world would be a king on stage."

One of the Sendenbu's most impressive artistic projects was developing tonil as a propaganda tool to educate the masses and develop and intensify *semangat* for the war effort. *Semangat*, meaning "enthusiasm" or "spirit," was an Indonesian

translation of the Japanese term *seishin*, and it would become a key term in all wartime discourse. To further these educational and *semangat* aims, the Sendenbu founded a theater academy, Sekolah Tonil, at Soendaweg 1 (present-day Jalan Gereja Theresia) in Jakarta in June 1942. This academy trained performers in music and dance, offered variety shows to the Japanese military and civilian elites, and sent out troupes to perform propaganda plays to heighten jingoism among the masses. The academy's director was the modernist Japanese novelist Takeda Rintarō. Other staff included composer Iida Nobuo, Japanese playwright Yasuda Kiyō'ō, and Raden Ariffien (known familiarly as Pak Ping)—a journalist who had been a member of the Bolero tonil company along with Andjar Asmara and Bachtiar Effendi and had written and directed several films for the Union Film Company and Star Film in 1940–1941.

Students of the theater academy performed versions of the Sumatran plate dance, Balinese janger dance, and Javanese srimpi dance at Jakarta's schouwburg (renamed Siritu Gekizyo under the Japanese) and at the residences of Japanese officials. A propaganda play produced by the academy and written by the novice *bunkajin* playwright Sakuma Masaru and directed by Ariffien titled *Seorang pro Nippon* (Someone pro-Japanese)—about the conflict between two brothers, one pro-Dutch and the other pro-Japanese—attracted large audiences, but received mixed notices in the press. Andjar Asmara, who reviewed the play's second outing under the revised title *Poetra Asia* (Child of Asia), considered the plot to be contrived. He noted that the suicide of the pro-Japanese brother after his release from a Dutch prison was so far-fetched as to evoke laughter: suicide was hardly behavior fitting for a noble knight (*satria*). Effective propaganda had to be more subtle (Andjar Asmara quoted in Mark 2003, 312). Perhaps in response to this critique and because of his other contributions as a cultural commentator in newspapers, Asmara was subsequently recruited as an instructor at the academy; more effective propaganda plays followed.²

Some tonil troupes active during the occupation had been founded in the Dutch colonial period, though they often operated under new names. Outfits that had been known as bangsawan, tonil, stambul, or opera companies in 1942 were uniformly rebranded as “sandiwara” by 1943—a reflection not only of the eradication of Dutch theatrical terms but also of the modernization and standardization of theatrical practices. Propaganda departments formed, sponsored, or took over a number of the commercially oriented sandiwara companies and instructed them to perform plays related to the dominant concerns of the propaganda office in 1942—explaining the purpose of the war and the Greater East Asia Co-Prosperity Sphere, conveying the idea that “Asia is one,” and propagating the ideals of the 3A movement.

Two of the biggest sandiwara companies operating in Java in 1942 were Bintang Soerabaja and Dewi Mada. Sandiwara Dewi Mada, jointly managed by the ex-Dardanella actress and dancer Dewi Mada and Dardanella's former dance master Ferry Kok, was billed as being "under the protection of the Japanese propaganda front" (*dibawah perlindoengan Barisan Propaganda Dai Nippon*).³ Dewi Mada's plays emphasized the evils of the Dutch and of Western imperialism and lauded traditional "Asian" values such as anti-individualism, mutual cooperation, and heroism in the samurai spirit. Kok and Mada, who had been part of Dardanella's tours of Asia, Europe, and the United States in the 1930s, were promoted as "international stars." Dances advertised as extra turns inserted between acts were the products of their wide-ranging Asian tours and included Javanese dances, Balinese *kecak*, Indian *kathakali*, and dances of Thailand, Cambodia, Burma, and other Asian countries. Jazz and other markedly Western forms were fastidiously avoided. A newspaper article attributed to Ferry Kok described Dewi Mada's dances as acts of "worshipping the world" (*sembahjang alam*), faithfully executed on stage with only minor adjustments due to limitations of time and space and taking into account the needs of modern spectators. These dances, the article concluded, aimed to "demonstrate the cultural riches of Indonesia and Greater East Asia."⁴ A *Pandji poestaka* article looking back at the history of popular theater from komedi stambul, unsigned but almost certainly written by Armijn Pané, stated even more clearly that "though currently not everyone will admit it, one can already take pride in Dewi Mada's dances as Indonesian dance" (n.a. 1942b).

Bintang Soerabaja was established in Malang in August 1942 by Fred Young, owner of a chain of cinemas and the former studio boss of the Majestic Film Company. This troupe, under the direction of writer-director Njoo Cheong Seng and Dardanella's former cabaret director Henry Duarte, featured many of the major tonil actors and film stars of the 1930s, including Njoo's wife Fifi Young and their daughter Sally Young, as well as Astaman and Dhalia. Also attached to the company during 1942 and 1943 was the Surakarta-born kroncong artist Gesang, who sang between acts of plays and wrote music for the company. Njoo created the play *Bengawan Solo* (Solo river) about a materialistic Surakarta nobleman whose craving for wealth results in the death of his own child, with Gesang's kroncong song by this title, which was already famous, as the play's theme song.⁵ Njoo also commissioned Gesang to write a song titled "Jembatan merah" (Red bridge) as the theme song for a play about a man who parts from his girlfriend on this famous Surabaya landmark with the promise that they will one day be reunited on that very spot. The song was a hit in an orchestration by the company's Filipino pianist-arranger and remains a staple of the kroncong repertoire. Bintang Soerabaja

continued the tradition of variety entertainment; one of its most popular extra numbers was a “mode show” with beautiful Eurasian models (Kamajaya 1978, 413). Eurasian women, with their white skin and wide eyes, were ideologically suspect, but still heavily favored by both Indonesians and Japanese as entertainers (Alisjahbana [1978] 2008, 104).

Sandiwara companies in other islands tended to be much smaller in scale. For example, schoolteachers in Sumbawa banded together in 1944 to form Sandiwara Soembawa, which traveled the island performing plays that offered “positive examples to spark the *semangat* and consciousness of inhabitants.”⁶ In the towns and cities of south Borneo, Sandiwara Pantjar Surya (which fielded both an “A” and “B” troupe) and Tokio Sandiwara performed tonil standards such as Miss Riboet’s signature play *Gagak Solo* and propaganda plays like *Samoerai seisin* (The samurai spirit) with the assistance of Borneo Simboensja. Sometimes the Pantjar Surya and Tokio troupes combined for special performances in Banjarmasin. Companies active in Sulawesi included Kembang Selebes (formerly known as Stamboel Indonesia) and Sinar Matahari, both from Makassar.⁷

Artists were not given free rein in the management of their companies, however. For example, Sandiwara Ardjoena, an Ambon-based company directed by M. Tahir Akil with performers who had previously worked for such high-profile tonil and bangsawan outfits as Dardanella, Manila Opera, and Palestina Opera, was taken over directly by the propaganda department Ceram Sinbun Sya. An announcement in the local paper stated that the department would “not only improve the artistic quality of performances, but also the standards of living of performers [. . .] in keeping with the current times and conditions.”⁸ The company was renamed Sinar Matahari (Sunlight), which was also the name of the Ambon newspaper published by Ceram Sinbun Sya, and its direction was handed over to one of the company’s actors, an ex-Dardanella actor named Amir Bandjir. The play performed at the company’s relaunch on 1 September 1943, which was preceded by speeches from the newspaper’s Japanese and Indonesian editors, was *Gadis komedi* (A young actress) and concerned the reputation of actresses. Formerly actresses were scorned and derided, but now, the play argued, they merited respect. A letter to Sinar matahari about the company’s relaunch reported a decline in artistic standards and conveyed a hope that Tahir Akil would at least remain on board as a writer.

Despite such interventions, sandiwara practitioners expressed gratitude for the attention offered their art and the financial, administrative, and artistic support of the Japanese authorities, which included the use of public transportation without charge.⁹ The cultural emphasis on and support net for sandiwara during the Japanese occupation made these the glory years of Indonesian popular theater,

as recalled nostalgically by a sandiwara manager interviewed by American theater scholar James Brandon in the early 1960s:

The best time sandiwara ever had was under the Japanese. We had to do what they said but they got us lights, generators, costumes, and even built theatres to play in. We were charged a 10 percent “interest” fee to pay for the equipment we got. Now our government charges us 27 percent tax and we get nothing in return. I’d rather be under the Japanese. (Brandon 1967, 237)

Inevitably, however, there were tensions between the Japanese and Indonesians working together in the field. One of the most egregious incidents was the rape of the dancer and film actress Misna by a Japanese soldier on a Sendenbu-sponsored tour of Java in June 1942. Politician Achmad Soebardjo, who worked in naval intelligence during the Japanese occupation and was appointed the first Minister of Foreign Affairs by Sukarno in 1945, worried that the incident might “be used by the enemy to implant hatred of Japan amongst the inhabitants” (Achmad Soebardjo quoted in Mark 2003, 469).

The recollections of Kamajaya, who codirected the youth sandiwara company Tjahaja Timoer (Eastern light) with Andjar Asmara and Ratna Asmara, provide further evidence of the difficulties faced by commercial sandiwara under the Japanese (Kamajaya 1978, 417–422).¹⁰ Money had to be raised to bankroll the company (which in Tjahaja Timoer’s case came from an advertising executive named Nasrun A. S.), and inexperienced performers had to be trained: it took two months’ preparation before the company was road ready. The company was once refused a permit to perform in Semarang because the city’s Sendenbu head thought Kamajaya *sombong* or “proud” for not visiting him personally to request permission. Only after Kamajaya traveled from Jakarta to join the Japanese official for *sukiyaki* was the ban lifted. “Don’t be *sombong* [proud],” he was warned, as the official motored off, half-drunk on *sake*. More disturbingly, Andjar Asmara was severely beaten and permanently disfigured after refusing to permit a high-ranking Japanese officer to spend the night with one of the troupe’s actresses.

The company possessed a first-rate dramatic repertoire, including Asmara’s *Noesa Penida* and Kamajaya’s *Solo di waktu malam* (Solo at night), released as films in 1944 and 1952, respectively. To create more dramatic focus, Tjahaja Timoer moved all the extra turns to before the plays, rather than inserting them between acts. Audiences rejected this innovation, however, and the extra turns moved back to their customary places. The company had to cater to popular tastes. Spectators were also unhappy that the company did not allow performers,

who came from educated backgrounds, to wink at them and move in sexually suggestive ways in song-and-dance routines. Money was always tight, and Tjahaja Timoer was bought and sold every six months or so; it finally dissolved after Indonesian independence.

Traditional Arts under Occupation

During the occupation, the practice of the traditional arts was also actively encouraged around Indonesia. Japanese officials expressed their admiration for the beauty, sacred quality, and purely Eastern spirit of dances such as *srimpi* and *legong* (see, e.g., Keikichi Okada 1944). Important dignitaries, such as members of the imperial family, were treated to elaborate programs of traditional dance and music when paying official visits to the state palaces in Jakarta and Bogor (the former residences of the governor general). The best-known arts organizations were in great demand; a dancer with Kridha Beksa Wirama estimated that the association performed at least ninety times during the occupation to entertain Japanese officials visiting Yogyakarta, a “moral sacrifice” (*pengorbanan moral*) but yielding benefits for dance technique (Pringgobroto 1959, 20). Companies of artists assembled to perform a potpourri of music and dance from around the archipelago were sent on tour by propaganda departments to entertain military personnel. A shared repertoire of popular ethnic songs developed, contributing to the rise of a national consciousness.¹¹

Traditional arts that had declined under Dutch colonialism were revived. One example was *masri*, a social dance of South Sulawesi in which adult men danced with prepubescent boys dressed as women and stuffed money down their blouses as payment. The Dutch found the dance’s “sexual incitement” indecent and banned it, but its practice was avidly resumed under the Japanese (Chabot 1950, 156–157.¹² Kroncong was purged of Western popular songs such as “Yes! We Have No Bananas” that had been increasingly common repertoire items since around 1930 (Yampolsky 2013, 228, 332).

Leading arts practitioners identified new reasons related to the war for supporting the traditional arts. Soerjodiningrat (1942), the Yogyakarta prince who cofounded the Kridha Beksa Wirama dance school, advocated the Javanese tradition of the “art of martial dance” (*kesenian-tari-perang*) as a means to increase bravery and *semangat*. Amateur wayang wong productions followed suit by performing plays that emphasized fighting, such as a 1943 Taman Siswa production of *Kangsa adu jago* (Kangsa’s cockfight). Machjar Angga Koesoemadinata, Jaap Kunst’s old collaborator, urged the retraditionalization of Sundanese gamelan music. In former times, he claimed, Sundanese gamelan music was mostly fast

paced and martial in character. Under colonialism, tempos slowed, and comic songs such as “Es lilin” (Popsickle) dominated. This sort of popular art was divorced from music’s traditional functions of sharpening hearing, increasing sensitivity, opening minds, and extending creativity. The repertoire needed to be purified of European influences, Koesoemadinata argued, so that gamelan could regain its social utility.¹³

New organizations were formed locally to support the traditional arts. The Poesat Kesenian Priangan (Priangan Cultural Center) was founded in January 1943 to revitalize the traditions of the West Javanese highlands. Its stated goals were to research the indigenous arts of all of the highlands, to preserve them so that they would remain authentic, to ensure that the arts would remain timely but uncontaminated by foreign influences, and to be an information center for those interested in learning from the arts. It was intended as a Sunda-wide initiative. On its board were representatives from many of Sunda’s major cultural centers, including Bandung, Sumedang, Garut, Tasikmalaya, Ciamis, and Panjalu, and there were divisions of song, music, martial arts, sandiwara, storytelling, visual art, dance, and handicrafts.¹⁴ In December 1943 a cultural organization called Sendangan was formed in Jakarta by residents from Sulawesi to foster an appreciation of traditional culture, collect and collate ancient arts and culture so that they fit with the demands of New Society, raise standards so that the culture accords to values of “Eastern civility,” and introduce the Minahasa ethnic culture of northern Sulawesi by performances of dance, sandiwara, visual arts, and songs broadcast on the radio.¹⁵ In Banjarmasin, Kesenian Pemoeda Bangsawan Banjar (Art of the Young Nobles of Banjar), was formed in January 1944 for the purpose of “re-studying gamelan pieces and associated dances, especially the ancient pieces for Banjarese gamelan.”¹⁶

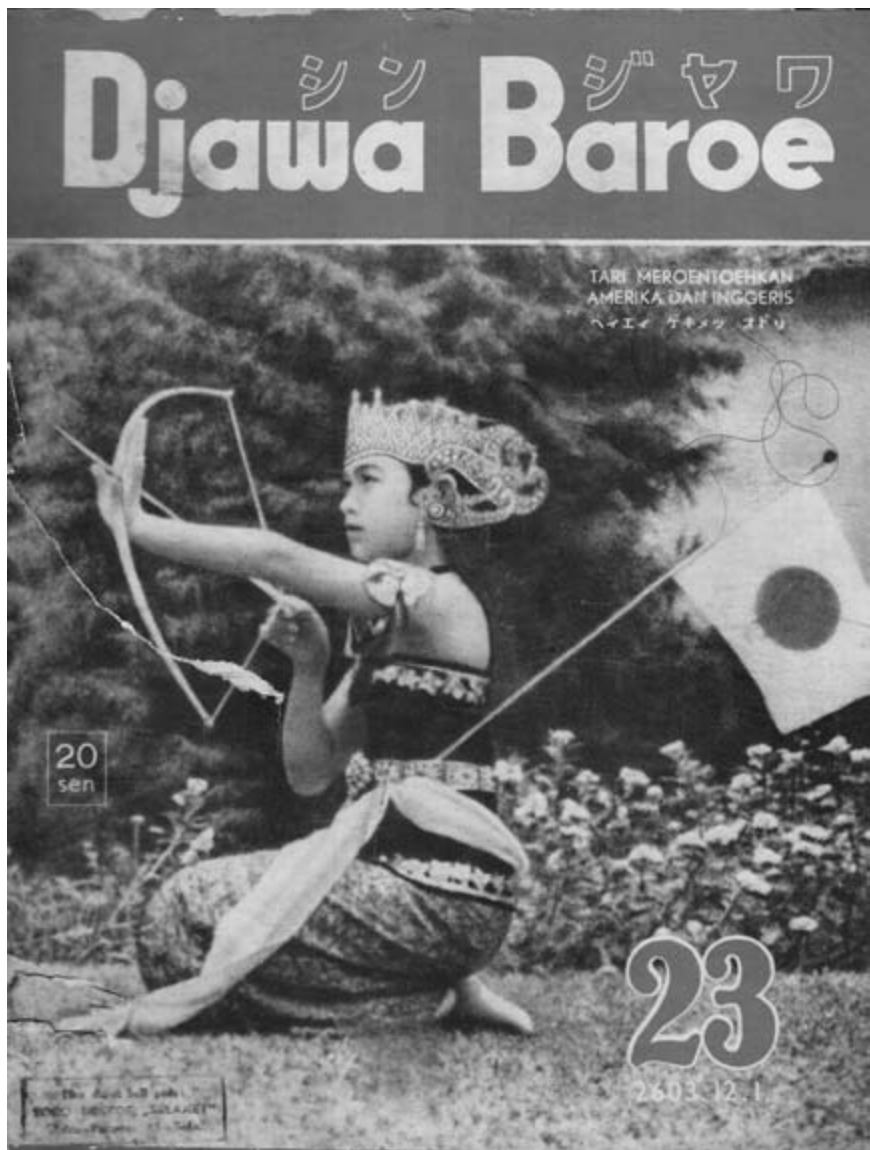
Certain innovations in traditional arts were also permitted, if not encouraged. A one-man gamelan band called Raras Hadi, with *gender*, *penerus*, *demung*, *ketuk*, *kenong*, and gong fitted inside a wooden cabinet, was invented by a retired opium dealer named Raden Partowirjono from Kartosuro. A six-year-old child offered a demonstration of the machine in June 1943, playing a traditional gamelan suite of pieces, *Gendhing randhu kentir* and *Ladrang ayun-ayun*, to the approval of court musicians and nobles; the machine was subsequently placed on display in Surakarta’s Radya Pustaka museum.¹⁷ A Ciamis-based choreographer named Raden Soenarjo created a new Sundanese dance, *Tari meroentoeh-kan Amerika/Inggeris* (Demolishing America/Britain), in which bow-wielding Daughters of the Sun fought women representing twenty-five Evil Nations, stand-ins for America and Britain. To make sure that the audience recognized the Daughters of the Sun as symbolic of Japan, Japanese flags were tucked into their

dance belts. The dance ended with the enemy's surrender and a dance by nymphs (*bidadari*) who descended from the heavens to celebrate world peace and the New Greater East Asia (n.a. 1943b). There were also experiments in 1943 to translate wayang into Japanese, which was said to be a far more fitting language for wayang than Dutch.¹⁸

Propaganda was inserted into traditional art forms, and symbols and characters were reinterpreted in light of wartime themes. Newspaper and magazine articles, for example, held up wayang's refined and noble knights and princesses as models of *semangat*. They praised Abimanyu for his kamikaze-like death in the Bratayuda war, while interpreting the ogres Buta Terong and Cakil as caricatures of Europeans and Americans.¹⁹ In West Java, wayang golek puppeteers were instructed to perform stories in which the heroes were directed by Batara Surya, the god of the sun, and threatened with imprisonment if they refused the god's demands (Foley 1991, 17). The Surakarta-based puppeteer and puppet maker Raden Mas Said created a new wayang form known that he called *wayang sandi-wara*. Plays were set in the present and addressed contemporary issues, puppets had naturalistic faces, and performances lasted only three hours (9:00 p.m. until midnight; cf. Kurasawa 1987, 83–84). To rally anti-Western sentiments, kethoprak groups emphasized tales of anti-Dutch rebellions, such as the rebellion led by the former Balinese slave Surapati in the seventeenth century and the Diponegoro revolt of the nineteenth century. Newly minted *kidung* (song poems) were performed in East Java's ludruk theater with lyrics about how "Indonesia is a fabled land/with millions of people/who all now feel/that Japan has aided us" (*Indonesia tanah kawarto/akeh rakjat majoeto-joeto/kabeh saiki pada roemongso/Dai Nippon sing noeloeng kito*) and how "the elder sibling [Japan] advances at the front/while the younger sibling [Indonesia] guards the rear" (*doeloer toewo mad-joe neng ngarep/doeloer nom ndjogo neng boeri*) (Iswojo 1943, 98).²⁰

A major institutional booster for reformulating tradition was the Poesat Kesenian Indonesia (Indonesian Arts Center), or Badan Persiapan Poesat Kesenian Indonesia (Preparatory Body for the Indonesian Arts Center) as it was officially known. It was formed on 6 October 1942 with the express aim of creating "art of the New Indonesia, among other things by adjusting and improving regional arts in this direction" (*Asia Raya* quoted in Mark 2003, 422; see also Kamajaya 1978, 409). "The art of New Indonesia," the Preparatory Body declared, "must fit the times."²¹

The founding meeting took place at the house of Sukarno, who had been released from his exile and was collaborating with the Japanese to deliver propaganda speeches. Both Sukarno and Ki Hadjar Dewantara, along with other prominent civil, political, and religious leaders, sat on the Preparatory Body's Advisory



Tari meroentoehkan Amerika dan Inggeris (Demolishing America and Britain dance) created by Ciamis-based choreographer Raden Soenarjo. *Djawa baroe* 2, no. 23 (1 December 1943), cover.

Board. The impressive list of founding members included the playwrights and cultural critics Sanoesi Pané and his brother Armijn, novelist Sutan Takdir Alisjahbana (principal editor of the European-oriented literary journal *Poedjangga baroe* until it was closed down by the Japanese), writer-director Andjar Asmara, children's radio presenter and composer of children's songs Bintang Soedibjo (popularly known as Iboe Soed), kroncong composer Kusbini, painter Basoeeki Abdoellah, playwright and director Inoe Perbatasari, philologist Dr. Poerbatjara, and dancer-choreographer Kodrat of the Jakarta dance studio Anggana Raras. Although there was only one Japanese person on this board—the Sendenbu radical nationalist Ichiki Tatsuo—the Sendenbu appears to have backed the initiative and offered financial support behind the scenes (cf. Mark 2003, 423). According to Kamajaya (1979), also a cofounder, all the board members were united by a desire to rejuvenate the stale cultural shows being presented in elite urban venues.

The Preparatory Body's founding was followed quickly by the creation of a Language Commission and a Commission for the Investigation of Ancient Customs, similarly composed mostly of Indonesian intellectuals. All three organizations aimed to distinguish what was "authentically" Asian from a legacy of Dutch colonialism and to decide "what we must discard and what we must keep from Western culture" (Darmawidjaja quoted in Mark 2003, 422).

Through the press, under the military government's strict control, the Preparatory Body regularly issued statements about art. An ordinance issued by the military government in consultation with the Preparatory Body in April 1943 dictated that all art and handicrafts, ranging from the design of pedicabs and lamps to sandiwara backdrops, had to be connected to life. Stressing the union of art and life, it was announced, would make artists conscious of the need to serve society and lift the spirits of people in the society around them and, indeed, around the whole world.²² The Preparatory Body was not simply a policy think tank, however. To renew traditions and develop new forms of art, it also sponsored art exhibitions and performances.

One of the Preparatory Body's most ambitious initiatives was *Lukisan zaman* (Portrait of the ages), a dance drama staged at the former schouwburg in Jakarta on 8 December 1942 commemorating the first anniversary of the bombing of Pearl Harbor. Music was by Kusbini, costumes and décor by the modern painter Sudjojono, and choreography by Austrian-trained dancer Retnowati Sudjono née Latip. Retnowati had been living in Tokyo with her husband, the Leiden-educated lawyer R. Sudjono, while he was employed as a lecturer in Malay language; the couple returned to Java in 1942 because the Japanese army urged Sudjono to contribute to the liberation of his country from the Dutch. *Lukisan*

zaman depicted the struggle of the Indonesian people from the age of kings through colonialism. A dancer in the semifictional treatment of the production in the novel *Defeat and Victory* (Alisjahbana [1978] 2008, 102) describes the production as a demonstration of “the wealth” of Indonesian “dance heritage which was second to none in subtlety and beauty,” “built up by centuries of tradition.” With some difficulty, dancers were gathered “from the different regions and ethnic groups of Indonesia so that a truly spectacular dance performance representing all parts of Indonesia could be organised for the commemoration” (102).

To portray Bali, Sukarno hatched the idea of importing an entire troupe of Balinese dancers and musicians. To find this troupe, the young writer and theater director Kamajaya was dispatched to Bali with a letter in Japanese (illegible to both Kamajaya and Sukarno) and one thousand guilders in Dutch money. After a perilous journey, Kamajaya was refused permission by the local authorities to bring back a troupe, but with the assistance of a Taman Siswa schoolteacher and amateur actor named Kotot Sukardi, Kamajaya “abducted” a group of twenty-seven dancers and musicians from the area of Denpasar and Tabanan. This Balinese troupe stayed on in Jakarta after the show, with Sukardi functioning as their manager (cf. Kamajaya 1978, 409–411).

Such appropriations and renovations of traditional forms were avidly covered in the press, described as proof of the vitality of Asian modernity. Sudarso Wirokusumo, the future director of the Central Film Laboratory PFN, recalled in a postwar interview how he had once believed that the performing arts of Java and other regions were inherently “static” (*statisch*) and boring. Seeing a performance of a dance drama of the classical story of *Banjaransari* performed in wayang wong style by the Jakarta branch of Kridha Beksa Wirama during the Japanese occupation “changed his mind.” This dynamic (*dinamisch*) production, condensed to an hour or so in length, held his attention throughout with its “moments of surprise [*verassende momenten*], when one was forced to pay heed,” including exciting battle scenes with some twenty dancers moving in synchrony.

Sudarso was unequivocal about why he was not bored. It was because *Banjaransari* was directed by an “artist” (*seniman*), namely Dr. Prijono, a trained Javanese classical dancer who held a doctorate in Old Javanese literature from Leiden University and was a professor in the war years at Kenkoku Gakuin, an academy of civil administration and law established in Jakarta in 1944. Sudarso described Prijono, who later became dean of the Faculty of Arts at the University of Indonesia (1950–1957) and Minister of Education and Culture (1957–1966), as a “strong person” (*orang yg. kuat*) who, like Anna Pavlova or Walt Disney, could alter the contours of his art and create something unprecedented in the world.²³ “Dr. Prijono is an artist. For me, he is the man for Javanese dance arts in Indonesia

today. Whether he is strong enough depends on whether he wishes to work or not for the sake of the art of dance.”

Performing arts call on social collectivities and traditions sustaining “trust in the continuity of past, present, and future” (Giddens [1990] 1991, 105). But it is evident that despite Japanese anti-individualistic propaganda, Sudarso attributed advances in Javanese dance to what T. S. Eliot would call “the individual talent,” a solitary genius whom Eliot insisted “must develop or procure the consciousness of the past” ([1919] 1982, 39). Sudarso conveniently ignored Prijono’s codirectors Yudhokusuma and Sumilah, the many other Kridha practitioners who contributed to this production and others before it, and the long tradition of Javanese dance that informed their work. To Sudarso, these collaborators and predecessors might be “expert” (*achli*), but possessed only the status of craftspeople (*tukang*): “It is actually not the fault of the Javanese arts that they are not dynamic, but the fact that artists are lacking. [. . .] This applies not only to the field of Javanese arts but also to regional arts outside Java. All indigenous Indonesian arts actually only await their artists” (Wirokusumo in Huyung and Sudarso 1949, 43). The hegemony of European aesthetics is evident in his Dutch critical vocabulary and categories (*statisch/dinamisch; verassende momenten*).

Censorship and Registration of Artists

Practices of censorship and the registration of arts practitioners introduced by the Japanese military government have had lasting reverberations in Indonesia. Registration began in November 1942 with an announcement urgently requesting that the particulars—name, date of birth, names of parents, educational details, employment history, contributions to society—of all Indonesian university graduates, societal leaders, prominent businesspeople, religious and political leaders, educationalists, journalists, athletes, and artists be submitted by postcard to the authorities in Jakarta. This data, it was reported, would be used for restructuring and developing Indonesian society.²⁴ One of the immediate products of this effort was an Indonesian “Who’s Who,” which remains a significant resource for historians of Indonesia (Gunseikanbu [1944] 1986).

This directive was followed in January 1943 by a regulation requiring playscripts to be preapproved by the Japanese authorities:

All intending to hold performances of sandiwara, komedi stambul, ke-thoprak, etc. are informed that: a. all plays to be performed must be sent to the government censorship office at 3 Gambir Selatan, Jakarta, for

inspection; b. submission of a summary is not sufficient, all dialogue to be spoken on stage must be included; c. plays must be written out in the language to be used in performance (Indonesian, Javanese, or Sundanese); d. all companies that perform frequently or continually must register the name of their company and the name of the person responsible. Registration can be done by post. This regulation applies for all Java.²⁵

An ordinance of February 1944 further stipulated that any public performance had to submit a script or detailed plan in order to be awarded a license; violation would lead to fines and imprisonment. These regulations resulted in improvised theaters such as Jakarta's comical *lenong* folk drama being effectively "suffocated" because their often illiterate practitioners were unable to supply written scripts. This was a blow not only to the artists who made their living in the theater but also to the public who needed light entertainment to counteract the increasing deprivations of the wartime economy (Jassin 1945, 17). Entertainment became even more scarce after 1 April 1943 when the military government banned the showing of American and British films as "instruments of imperialism [. . .] poisoning Eastern nations and destructive of Eastern customs and traditions."²⁶

Surveillance of the arts intensified in July 1943, when all cultural practitioners, including musicians, actors, dancers, writers, and critics, were required to complete a questionnaire at branch propaganda offices about their activities. Sandiwara, kroncong, Hawaiian music, gambus, Chinese music, classical music, gamelan music, traditional dance, wayang, and kethoprak were singled out for special mention in the announcement.²⁷ Dutch researchers of the Java Institute had previously conducted surveys of the arts, using local government officials as their agents and informants, but an information gathering effort at this scale across so many cultural sectors was unprecedented. These information systems and continual surveillance formed "new systems of administrative power" (Giddens and Pierson 1998, 96) that could be harnessed for the war effort and the control of the populace.

***Kamishibai* and Other Japanese Arts**

Along with the revitalization of tradition and sandiwara, the performance arts inculcated appreciation and knowledge of Japanese language and culture. Japanese-language songs taught to children at schools, which reopened in June 1942, are still recalled by elders many decades later. Japanese-language patriotic music was played on the radio, and by August 1942 children could be observed

in the streets of Jakarta marching with toy guns and singing Japanese-language military songs (Mark 2003, 295). Kimono-clad schoolgirls learned Japanese folk dances such as *bon odori*. Schoolchildren regularly enacted the standard Japanese-language script of the patriotic folktale of Momotarō the peach boy on stage and radio in Java, Sumatra, and Sulawesi starting in September 1942. Articles about Japanese traditional performance forms such as *noh* and *kabuki* appeared in magazines and newspapers. Japanese songs and translated Japanese dramas were published and performed.²⁸

New performance forms were also introduced from Japan for propaganda purposes. One of the most prominent around Indonesia was *kamishibai* (paper theater). A forerunner of Japanese anime, *kamishibai* was originally a street entertainment for Japanese children, in which a storyteller narrated short stories illustrated by pictures inserted into a small proscenium stage, roughly one square meter in size, mounted on the back of a bicycle. Storytellers rented picture boards from a production house and earned their money by selling candy to their audiences. “National Policy Kamishibai” plays produced in Japan from the late 1930s were propagandistic, ennobling hard work and glorifying sacrifice for the empire; they were aimed at adults (Nash 2009; Dym 2012).

Propaganda departments around Indonesia adopted *kamishibai* starting in early 1943. The form was referred to alternately as *wayang beber* (after Java’s archaic scroll theater) in much of Java, *dalang mengembara* (roving puppeteer) in Sunda, *wayang gambar* (picture wayang) in Sumatra and Sulawesi, and *sandiwara kertas* (paper sandiwara) in Borneo. Scenarios and picture boards (normally six to twelve per story) were prepared by propaganda offices, where local storytellers were also trained to perform in both Indonesian and local languages. Storytellers were selected on the basis of a speech test and came from a variety of backgrounds. Of the two full-time *kamishibai* operators employed by Yogyakarta’s propaganda office, one was a tailor and the other a former schoolteacher (Kurasawa 1991, 41–42). Performers were then sent out to tour towns and villages, performing free of charge for children in schools and for adult audiences in public squares, meetings, ceremonies, factories, and other workplaces. One storyteller sent to the East Javanese former residency of Besuki in 1943 reportedly performed in 150 locations to 72,994 spectators over three months.²⁹

A number of short picture stories, lasting ten to twenty minutes each, were performed at each venue. On offer, for example, at a 2 February 1944 afternoon performance outside a Surabaya government office were five short plays: *Tinggal-kanlah sifat malas* (Cease being lazy), *Menambah hasil boemi* (Increase crop productivity), *Menjoembang padi* (Donate rice), *Mengoempoeikan padi* (Gathering rice), and *Tabiat jang baik* (Good character). These plays were said to be more

than a mere show (*pertoendjoekan*), but to have an essence that could be a foothold in life (*bekal hidoep*) during changing times.³⁰ Stories concerned the cruelty of the Dutch, Indos who maintained sympathy for the Dutch, similarities between the samurai and *satria* ethos, defense of the homeland, the reasons behind the war, the danger of spies, the bravery of Japanese soldiers and *semangat* of Japanese mothers, love for the homeland, solidarity between the military and people, the health benefits of *taiso* (Japanese calisthenics), exporting rice, the postal saving scheme, corvée labor, and ways to economize. Audience members were encouraged to stop using Dutch as a language of communication, increase handicraft production, trample individualism underfoot, and value *kesederhanaan* (austerity). Some sets of pictures were sent from Japan (with dialogue printed on the back of each picture board), whereas other plays were written and illustrated at the central Sendenbu offices and then copied by hand on cardboard at local offices. Plays were also created locally, responding to local issues. The outlines of stories were always set, but operators could ad lib some of the dialogue and use local dialects and expressions.

A kamishibai story performed in open-air markets around the city of Makassar in February 1944 gives a good sense of the genre. A villager from a poor family works as a lowly coffee sorter, but through diligence saves some money that he gives to his child, who has just completed elementary school. The child takes his parent's trust seriously and opens a *warung*, or roadside food stall, with the gift. She also plants a garden behind the house. From the produce of this garden and profit from the *warung*, she is able to expand the food stall. Because of her diligence in saving money and healthy work ethic, she has sufficient means for the future. This story, a newspaper article reported, was intended to increase consciousness of the value of saving and instill awareness that saving money is in one's own future interests.³¹

Kamishibai storytellers usually traveled by bicycle alone or in teams of two, but sometimes they were members of mobile propaganda units known as *barisan penhiboer* (entertainment fronts) or *rombongan penhiboer* (entertainment groups) that performed in villages on the back of trucks fitted with panels that could be opened up to form small proscenium stages. Units of ten entertainers offered kamishibai, speeches, short stories, instrumental music and songs, and *lelucon*—a comic form described later. Sometimes propaganda films were also shown—this was reportedly the first time that villagers in Borneo had seen motion pictures. Tours were very intense. A troupe of about ten entertainers, for example, sent by Malang's propaganda office to tour eastern Java, played 240 locations in the ex-residencies of Malang, Besuki, and Kediri in two months. Some performances attracted as many as three thousand spectators.³²

It is telling that kamishibai performances ceased immediately after the end of the war. The performers and makers were well trained, the touring infrastructure well developed, and the impact of the propaganda apparently high. But despite efforts to draw equivalences with Indonesian arts such as *wayang beber*, kamishibai was perceived as an alien art form, indelibly Japanese. With the brutalities and deprivations of the occupation fresh in memory, when the Japanese withdrew, so too did their arts.

The Cultural Center

With its founding in April 1943, the Keimin Bunka Shidōsho (Center for the Guidance of Popular Cultural Enlightenment), better known in Indonesian as the Poesat Keboedajaan or “Cultural Center,” assumed coordination of all artistic activities in Java. The Cultural Center aimed to shake off Dutch cultural influences and “accelerate the enlightenment and awakening of the people” through the arts (Shigetada and Kishi [1959] 1963, 251). Its specific tasks included

(1) the preservation, fostering, and guidance of wholesome traditional arts, (2) the expulsion of hostile or unwholesome arts, and the exaltation of genuine culture based on new ideas, (3) the dissemination and introduction of the situation and culture of Japan, (4) the providing of mass recreation and enlightenment through such media, (5) the control of arts and cultural organizations and the fostering of arts, and (6) the liaison and cooperation with other cultural bodies in the Greater East Asia Sphere. (251)

Centralized cultural organizations of this sort existed in Japan, but the Cultural Center was something quite new in Indonesia and had a broad impact on how the arts were to be organized and conceived in the future. Over the twenty-nine months of its existence, the Center produced performances and traveling exhibitions, organized competitions, published books and magazines, ran training courses for artists, organized seminars and discussion groups, registered artists, censored scripts, issued proclamations about the social and political functions of the arts, advised the military government on cultural policy, and much more.

The significance of the Cultural Center and its legacy in independent Indonesia have been much debated by Indonesian cultural workers and historians. Its Japanese name carries paternalistic overtones—it suggests that locals need “enlightenment” because they are uncivilized. To Sutan Takdir Alisjahbana ([1978] 2008, 136), the Cultural Center was equivalent to the Nazi’s *Kultuurkamer*—a repressive cultural instrument of military rule. Those working for the Center

and attending its events were required to take regular oaths of allegiance; for example, “on this conference on the occasion of the Ceremony of Inclusion in East Asia, we literary men and information agents swear that we will be loyal to Japan, and that we will exert every effort to assist Japan in gaining final victory.”¹ Artists who were too heavily identified with the Cultural Center were later denounced as collaborators.

However, for writer Aoh K. Hadimadja, who worked there as a translator, participating in the intellectual discourse with the intellectuals and artists who convened there was nothing less than revelatory: “I learned at least as much by socializing with artists there as I would have in ten solid years of isolated study” (1952, 30). Idealistic young artists, “the children of the new age, who have not been influenced by the views of the old times” (Takeda Rintarō quoted in Pourpouas 2010, 371), were privileged over established figures. Discussions, including on the topic of Indonesian independence, ranged quite freely. Lasmidjah, a censor and former schoolteacher who arranged the discussion sessions at the Center, recalled in an interview with Indonesia’s National Archive in the 1980s that politicians such as Muhammad Yamin and Mohammad Hatta rehearsed their radical political ideas under the cover of panel discussions of Indonesian culture (Lapian 1988). The Cultural Center might be considered to be what French art theorist and curator Nicolas Bourriaud describes as a “microtopia” that enabled “concrete inter-relations among artists and agents that inform[ed] artistic production” (Blanes and Maskens 2015).

The central office in Jakarta, located at Jalan Noordwijk 39 (present-day Jalan Ir. H. Juanda), absorbed personnel from the defunct Sekolah Tonil as well as Japanese *bunkajin* working for the Sendenbu (Kamajaya 1978, 416; Mark 2003, 500, 526–528).² Regional offices were established in the capital city of each former residency in Java. The Japanese propaganda chief, Shimizu Hitoshi, entrusted by the military government to direct the Center, seems to have left its day-to-day management to his Indonesian subordinates, particularly Sanoesi Pané. Japanese working at the Center largely stayed out of cultural debates (Lasmidjah Hardi quoted in Lapian 1988, 77). Communication between Japanese and Indonesian culture workers probably never acquired real fluency. Sudjono (1970, 64) recalled speaking a mix of Japanese, Dutch, Indonesian, and English with the *bunkajin* who landed with him in Banten in 1942, and by the end of the war the linguistic gap between occupiers and occupied seemed to have narrowed only slightly. Sendenbu officers came to the Cultural Center to order artworks for propaganda campaigns, but Indonesian culture workers exercised a surprising amount of agency. The painter S. Sudjojono, in a National Archive interview, recalled being asked to create a Ramayana illustration with a Japanese man



Employees of the Cultural Center gather outside its headquarters at Jalan Noordwijk 39 (present-day Jalan Ir. H. Juanda) for a group photo to mark their first meeting on 2 April 1943. *Djawa baroe* 1, no. 8 (15 April 1943): 408.

pictured as Rama and Indonesians as the hero's monkey army. The painter perceived this request as an insult and politely declined (Lapian 1988, 82).

Literary critic and orator H. B. Jassin, in his introduction to an anthology of occupation-era writings he assembled less than a year after Japan's surrender, wrote about the Center's impact:

One might mock the institute as the Japanese-Stamped Cultural Center where various artworks were manufactured on demand, but one cannot deny that its products were useful at the time and after for uniting *semangat* and power. It was there where our young artists [...] experienced the torture and ripening of their souls for the upcoming revolution. (Jassin [1946] 1985, 17)

Thrown together by wartime contingencies, the social energies and connections generated by the convergence of so many artists and intellectuals in the Jakarta office fertilized creative endeavors and generated cross-art form collaborations that would have otherwise been hard to conceive.

Music and Literature in Theory and Practice

Iida Nobuo, one of the few *bunkajin* who arrived on the *Sakura Maru* and remained in Java for the duration of the war, directed the music division of the Cultural Center. His Indonesian staff included Mr. Raden Oetojo, a prominent figure in Eastern Radio before the war, and the kroncong artist Kusbini. Amir Pasaribu, a Batak-born musician who had worked as a cellist on a Japanese cruise ship and studied music in Tokyo, often acted as translator.³ At a speech at the Center's opening, Iida spoke of having to weed Indonesia's musical landscape of unhealthy growths—meaning music from the United States and Britain, as well as kroncong—and of the need to be diligent in keeping these weeds from sprouting again. The West's music is highly developed, but should not be blindly imitated; instead it should be carefully filtered so that it can become our own flesh and blood, he said. New songs should be created that are filled with meaning and express the souls and *semangat* of Indonesian composers. Music that is not played expressively is not art, but mere imitation (Iida 1943a).

Under Iida, the Center's music division organized meetings of composers and leaders of musical groups, wrote and published patriotic songs, held concerts of new music, and organized instrumental and songwriting competitions. The Jakarta Center's focus was primarily on classical art song—a musical language shared by Iida and other Japanese musicians attached to the Center and their Indonesian counterparts. It only gave lip service to gamelan and other traditional Indonesian musics. In an article in the inaugural issue of the Center's annual journal, *Keboedajaan timoer* (Eastern culture), which featured stage and radio plays, cultural criticism, and news items related to the arts, Iida notes his pleasure that American and British music could now rarely be heard, but opined that there were still too many saxophones and that songs created by Indonesian composers had yet to express the *semangat* and forwardness demanded by the times (Iida 1943b). Music experts who met at the Center on 15 August 1943 concluded that heroic airs in praise of wartime bravery were needed, as well as songs "picturing the natural beauty of Indonesia, its mountains, rivers, expansive seas, skies, fields, and fragrant flowers." The latter sort of song would allow people to appreciate the bountiful gifts of the motherland. The important thing was for musicians to be socially conscious, which would facilitate art music's eventual acceptance by the general Indonesian public.⁴

Many of the songs now enshrined in the canon of *lagu perjuangan* (songs of struggle) and *lagu pahlawan* (heroes' songs) were Cultural Center products (Erkelens and Heidebrink 2010, 389; Gommers-Dekker 2011). These include songs by Ismail Marzuki, Kusbini, Cornel Simandjoentak, and Iboe Soed.

Japanese-language wartime songs and anthems were translated into Indonesian, and prewar Indonesian songs were rewritten. Gesang's famous "Bengawan Solo" was rewritten as "Negeri Sekoetoe" (Country of the Allies), damning the Allied forces for greed, rapaciousness, and criminality (Erkelens and Heidebrink 2010, 397).⁵ Songs encouraging productivity and love of the motherland and praising the "heroes of Asia and Indonesia" and happy workers in factories and fields were printed in newspapers and compiled in books. "Indonesian school children were obliged to sing them and, in so doing, voiced the official ideology and became part of a larger indoctrination campaign" (389). Iboe Soed's 1943 songbook *Mari kita bernjanji* (Come let's sing) collects her uplifting songs about the joys of coming together as a group, marching in straight lines, riding on trains, brave hunting, rowing, playing after school, riding in a pedicab, and singing chorally. The stirring *larghetto* anthem "Tanah airku" (Homeland) expresses pride for neighborhood and home (*kampoeng dan roemahkoe*), where one is always more content than in any fabled overseas destination (Soed [1943] 1945, 39–40).

The most talented musician nurtured by the Cultural Center was arguably Cornel Simandjoentak, a Batak composer born in North Sumatra from a devoutly Catholic family. Cornel was a star musician at Xaverius College in Muntilan when Japan invaded. The college was closed, Cornel received an equivalency degree, and he went to Jakarta to continue his musical studies under the tutelage of Iboe Soed. Cornel was given the Cultural Center's choir to conduct, wrote Schubertesque lyrical songs for radio broadcasts and stage performances, and composed propaganda songs and marches on order. He was extraordinarily prolific for the first two years of the occupation—boasting to a friend that he could write the technical and musical structure of a propaganda song in thirty minutes (Binsar Sitompul 1987, 49). Some of his compositions, such as the rousing "Tanah tumpah darah" (Blood-stained land) and "Maju tak gentar" (Advance without hesitation), are still studied at schools and performed on national holidays. As the war ground on, Cornel began to have trouble making ends meet, became dependent on handouts from Iboe Soed, and likely suffered from depression. He complained of being treated like an "expeditor" unhappily charged with easy, "three-and-a-half cent noodle soup" tasks like finding new lyrics for the famous Yiddish song, "Bei mir bist du schön" (quoted in Hesri 1982, 79).⁶ Minang poet and dramatist Asrul Sani once asked Cornel whether writing mind-numbing propaganda songs was not a betrayal of his own integrity as an artist. Cornel retorted that such songs operated as a mode to introduce the diatonic scale to the masses, and thereby implant musical feelings into their hearts. Cornel's depression is a sign perhaps that such rationalizations—which Asrul Sani ([1948] 1997, 483) called Cornel's

impian-impiannya yang muluk, “pompous dreams”—cannot be sustained without long-term psychic costs.

The Cultural Center’s literature section was headed by Japanese novelist and screenwriter Takeda Rintarō, best known for his avant-garde portraits of Japan’s underclass written in the 1930s under the sway of Marxist writers such as Bertolt Brecht. Takeda worked together with his Indonesian counterpart, the novelist and cultural critic Armijn Pané, who managed the section’s day-to-day affairs. The section produced slogans, poems, song lyrics, novels, playscripts, and other literary expressions; translated works on Japanese culture (such as Sakae Shioya’s book on the kabuki play *Chūshingura*, published in English in Tokyo in 1940); ran literary competitions and courses; and held readings and discussions. Indonesian literature developed rapidly during the occupation. Used-book markets were flooded with quality Dutch- and English-language books sold for a pittance by desperate Dutch intellectuals as they were being rounded up and sent to prison camps. Aspiring Indonesian authors snatched up volumes of Hemingway and T. S. Eliot—and in this way modern ideas came into circulation beyond circles of elites. Opportunities for publishing works that did not demonstrate complicity with the military government’s objectives were, however, limited. The Cultural Center advised writers to keep nonideological writings to themselves until the conflict ended (Jassin [1946] 1985, 14).

Aoh K. Hadimadja (1952, 136), in a speech given in 1951 to high school students in Medan, described Armijn Pané as “systematic, everything was done to a Western-style plan, ordered.” We see such systematicity in Pané’s theory of drama, a synthesis of Aristotle, Hegel, Eisenstein, and other European theorists that he developed during the war. In “The Current State of Sandiwara: Initiatives and Paths for Improvement” (*Keadaan sandiwara sekarang: Oesaha dan djalan mermperbaikinja*, 1943), Armijn Pané lambasts Bintang Soerabaja, the most successful sandiwara company of the 1940s, for kowtowing to popular taste, with its cheap jokes and overemphasis on romance and spectacle. A play (*lakon*) is not just a collection of speeches, but rather it is a string of acts (*lakoe*). The writer’s intentions are to be realized by a director acting as his intermediary with actors. A well-executed play weaves together all these acts, which can be physical actions as well as internal shifts in characters, into a large action (*lakoe jang besar*) that can be compared by spectators to other actions on stage or in everyday life. This, Pané states, is the sign of superior theater: it connects directly to the world and provides spectators with a chance to meditate on otherwise obscure thoughts and feelings, bringing their personal experiences to a play’s thematics. That is not to say that dialogue, costume, scenery, and lighting should mirror quotidian reality. Theater is its own reality; it is a dream world, a shadow of life.

Applying this theory to Bintang Soerabaja's recently presented plays, Pané finds the company wanting in many respects. Characters act inconsistently with their types, personal details are extraneous to roles that characters enact in plays, physical actions are prioritized over inner acts—more like the “action” of a cowboy film than the psychologically based drama admired by Pané. Bintang Soerabaja plays are characterized by a profusion of subplots rather than a grand action, more like Shakespeare than German drama. Asmara and his fellow writer-director Njoo Cheong Seng value entertainment over art. Art today should not be for its own sake but for victory—*l'art pour la victoire*. Grasping connections between small and large actions, inner and outer change, will allow spectators to feel *semangat* for the war effort.

Pané's later essay, “Initiatives to Advance Sandiwara, Especially with Regards to Action” (*Oesaha memadjoekan sandiwara, teroetama dipandang dari soedoet lakoe*), written in July 1944 but not published until 1945, expanded this theory and laid out rules for practice. Sandiwara, like film, is based on montage—it is not the individual scene that is important but the scenes' sequencing. A spectator who can appreciate only one theatrical aspect, such as music, décor, or costume, would be better off attending a concert, looking at paintings, or observing everyday life. Spectating requires vigilance and constantly anticipating what will happen next on stage; in other words, following a play's action, which consists of joined-up changes in existence (*peroebahan kedjadian*), by attending to dialogue, bodily movement, perhaps a chair that topples. Plots have three parts, often corresponding to the different acts of plays. First, we learn about characters, their relations, and the issues they confront. Then an issue is taken up; for example, through a conflict between two parties. The play concludes with the issue's resolution. Each line of dialogue spoken must reflect what has already taken place, exists presently, and anticipate what will come. “Cheater!” says a spectator to him- or herself when a plot develops in ways contrary to tenets laid down in exposition. Acting, costume, décor, lighting—all should support the play's central action. Actors should not aim to get laughs or seduce their fans. They must interpret characters and act in accord to their backgrounds, or a play will be farcical. Emphasis on physical action over intention risks “*overacting*” (English in the original).⁷ Sandiwara is not based on tradition, though it sometimes incorporates traditional dances. Traditional theaters such as wayang operate through metaphor and allusion, whereas sandiwara communicates directly. Sandiwara shares with wayang, however, a common principle—both serve to picture reality for society. The amateur theater, inspired by ideals rather than profits, will allow for experimentation (such as abstract scenery) and the correction of aesthetic faults. Spectators will learn to appreciate such developments eventually.

Pané's theory of drama was more than just an analytical operation: it offered a method for writing and producing plays, as well as a means to judge plays in competitions. A play that did not comply with Pané's published aesthetic ideals could be accused of being overly Shakespearean or too much like an American cowboy movie. Thus theory became a weapon to be wielded against dissenting artists. We see this autocratic side of Pané in Amal Hamzah's one-act comedy, *Tuan Amin* (Mr. Amin, 1979 [1946]). Amal Hamzah, the younger brother of the famous prewar poet Amir Hamzah, worked as a clerk in the Cultural Center's literature department, which he characterizes in the play's dedication as a "Mad House" (*Rumah Gila*) (92).⁸ Characters in the play occupy their time complaining about the coffee or skipping out to go shopping in Pasar Baru. A typist explains that she arrived late at work because "a sun god" (i.e., a high-ranking Japanese official) was parading through Jakarta's streets and everyone had to turn around and "show him our butts" (100). "Amin" (i.e., Armijn Pané) is caricatured by one employee as a bootlicking opportunist:

Aman: How did he get to be chief of this division with a monthly salary of 250?

Amat (mockingly): The regular way. When Japan arrived, he busied himself with writing, not caring whether what he wrote was any good or not, the main thing being that it was full of *semangat* in the fight against the enemy, or referred to shared prosperity. [. . .] His name became known to our "older brothers" and when this office opened he was appointed division chief (97).

The play ends with Amin shouting madly about the need for organization and principles as he writes a letter to his superiors reporting that his underlings have "disobeyed the Japanese military government and thus are foreign spies" (103). The only one left to listen to him is the fifteen-year-old office boy, who is in desperate need of the toilet.

It is difficult to reconcile this vituperative depiction of Pané with the subtle thinker of the prewar years. Collaborating with the Japanese and supporting the fascist regime offered artists unprecedented resources, but placed them in strained moral postures. Amal Hamzah subjected himself to the same caustic treatment he gave Pané in a dramatic dialogue titled *Seniman pengkhianat* (Apostate artist), one of a number of underground playlets he published after the war. In this playlet, Amal bifurcates himself into "X," a hack writer who produces short stories and sandiwara scripts about savage enemies and certain future victory according to established formulas, and into his conscience "Y."

When Y expresses concerns that X's propaganda writing has no soul, no "I" inside it, X counters that today placing one's "I" in a work can lead only to summons from the Japanese secret police. Unlike Y, X says he has no pretensions of being an artist. His only aspiration is to enjoy the good life and slurp noodle soup at Toko Oen. At the end of the play, Y vows to denounce X as a traitor to the people (Amal Hamzah [1946] 1985).

Plays from the Cultural Center

Armijn Pané continued his own artistic activities despite his administrative load. The plays he wrote and translated served wartime imperatives and initiatives and also generally garnered positive reviews. His 1943 one-act comedy *Kami perempuan* (Us women), about two young men cajoled by a wife and fiancée into joining the newly established voluntary army, received numerous performances by amateur drama groups (Pané 1953a). This lively play is filled with sight gags and exchanges of insults, as well as patriotic declarations and a song titled "Tentara pembela" (Defending soldiers) that encouraged men to join the armed forces to defend the homeland. The third verse goes, "Rather than being slaves of the Allies again, better to die as a true hero in the Bratayuda," invoking the cataclysmic battle that concludes the Mahabharata cycle of plays in wayang kulit.⁹

Another successful Armijn Pané script was *Ratna*, a three-act adaptation of Henrik Ibsen's *A Doll House*.¹⁰ *Ratna* was aired as a radio drama (*sandiwara radio*) and performed by both amateur and professional sandiwara companies, including Bintang Soerabaja (which retitled the play *Isteri boneka*, "A doll wife"). Ibsen's 1879 drama, which famously ends with Nora slamming the door behind her and thus ending a marriage to a hypocritical banker-husband who values his professional reputation over his wife, has been received worldwide as a feminist statement of emancipation. A production in Japan in 1911 is attributed with launching *shingeki* (spoken drama) as a genre and making possible a public discourse on women's issues (Fischer-Lichte 2009, 396). Ibsen's play, as "labored upon" (*dioesahakan*) by Pané, was promoted as a contribution to advancing Indonesian sandiwara through its literary qualities and dramatic techniques (n.a. 1943a). Pané's introduction to the adaptation emphasizes the play's break with the past: Ratna (Nora in Ibsen's original) leaves her husband and children to pursue self-realization, just as we must shed attachment to the colonial regime to rise to the new age of Greater Asia.

A review of Bintang Soerabaja's production of *Isteri boneka* praised the company for its "bravery" in performing a work by a world-renowned writer and

demonstrating that sandiwara was now “attempting to climb the international ladder.”¹¹ The play, however, was too “heavy” (*berat*) for “the many spectators as well as actors still tied to the norms known as tradition, mainly: cheap effects, two-for-a-penny philosophy, actions and stories empty of meaning.”¹² Njoo was accused of an “infatuation” for classical plays that was alienating Bintang Soerabaja’s audience (Njoo 1950b, 15).

Considering the play’s radical image, it is interesting, then, that one of Armijn Pané’s adaptation’s most powerful scenes is a rehearsal of a tradition-based dance at the end of Act II. It is a transposition of a Tarantella dance that Nora rehearses for a Christmas costume party in Ibsen’s original. In *A Doll’s House*, Nora, who had learned the dance while holidaying on the popular island resort of Capri, is costumed at her husband Torvald’s request as a Neapolitan fisher-girl, with Torvald at the piano. The rehearsal is a delaying tactic: Nora feigns unpreparedness so that Torvald will avoid checking the mailbox that contains a letter incriminating her.

In Pané’s indigenziation, Ratna rehearses a new dance based on *srimpi* created by her husband Martojo for a Lebaran party celebrating the end of the Islamic fasting month:

Ratna (holding her husband’s hand, she draws him to sit at the table): I will not be able to dance tomorrow, unless we practice now.

Martojo: You seem nervous, Rat.

Ratna: Yes, very nervous, I don’t know why. Come let’s practice some. There’s still time before dinner. You can use the table as a *keprak*. Just a minute (*she goes into the bedroom and emerges momentarily while tying a sampur [dance belt] around her waist*). Now, let’s begin!

(*Ratna dances while Martojo raps out keprak patterns on the table, with Doctor Rahim behind him*)

Martojo: Slowly.

Ratna: This can’t be done slowly.

Martojo: Don’t be so *kasar* [rough], Rat!

Ratna: That’s how it has to go!

Martojo (standing): No, it’s not like that.

Ratna (laughing): See? I told you so.

Rahim: Let me do the *keprak* part.

Martojo: Good, and I’ll correct her.

(Doctor Rahim sits down and raps on the table. Ratna dances, with her movements getting increasingly kasar. Martojo stands near the divan and admonishes and corrects her repeatedly, but it seems that Ratna is not listening; her hair loosens and falls below her shoulders as, unaware, she keeps dancing. Miranti enters.)

Miranti (at the door, startled): Oh!

Ratna (while dancing): A *ramai* [lively] party, Ti!

Martojo: Rat, my sweet, you dance as if to redeem your soul.

Ratna: Indeed.

Martojo: Rahim, please stop. This is crazy. *(Rahim stops rapping, and Ratna stops dancing suddenly.)*

Martojo (approaching his wife): I had no idea. You remember nothing, all my coaching has gone to waste.

Ratna (untying her sampur): I told you.

Martojo: Yes, you need another rehearsal.

Ratna: I do indeed, you saw that yourself. You need to coach me all the way up until tomorrow night. You'll do that, won't you, Mas Tojo?

Martojo: Of course!

Ratna: Tonight and tomorrow, up until night, you won't concern yourself with anything but coaching me. You won't open up the letter, I mean the letterbox. (Ibsen [1879] 1943, 73–74)

The substitution of *srimpi* for the Tarantella opens up an interesting Javanese dynamic.¹³ The Tarantella in Ibsen's play is itself an exotic import. As traditionally performed in Italy, the tempo becomes increasingly frenzied, and dancer and drummer vie to see who can endure the longest. By costuming his wife as a Neapolitan fisher-girl, Torvald transforms Nora into the sort of souvenir doll collected on holiday. A newly minted dance based on *srimpi*, in contrast, positions Ratna, Martojo, and Dr. Rahim among the Javanese artistic elites of Anggana Raras and similar urban studios, progressive art makers in search of methods and approaches to adapting tradition to the pace of modern life. Unlike in the Tarantella, the relation between dancer and *keprak* player in *srimpi* and related court-derived dances is never antagonistic. Rather, the *keprak* (typically played by the dance master) subtly underscores or anticipates movement, marking out rhythmic units and punctuating gesture. Performing *srimpi*, even a modernized version of it, is an epitome of the *alus* or refinement, a suspension of time. A *ramai*

(lively) or *kasar* (rough) srimpi beggars the imagination. The rehearsal shows Ratna, Martojo, and Dr. Rahim to be experienced performers in the ways that Ratna can casually tie on a dance scarf while walking and can talk to her friend while dancing, and the flexibility shown by Martojo and Dr. Rahim with the impromptu replacement of table rapping for keprak. It is thus astounding that Ratna performs in such a *kasar* and *ramai* manner. She actively resists Martojo's control and asserts her autonomy in disrupting this sacred dance. The play thus demonstrates a complex and multifaceted relation to tradition and suggests a greater awareness of female agency than does Ibsen's original.

The same subtlety of expression is not to be found in plays written for competitions under the sponsorship of the Sendenbu and the Cultural Center. Writing competitions were held frequently in the different administrative zones of Indonesia. One sandiwara contest was launched in January 1943 by the newspaper *Asia Raya* and the Sendenbu to "enrich and cultivate a new awareness in the literature and arts of Indonesia so they can help develop bold and knightly characteristics [*sifat-sifat satria jang gagah perkasa*] in the people of Indonesia who have been freed for some time from the chains of Western colonialism and have risen to bring a New Asia into being, with Japan as leader"; the five-act drama *Pandoe Partiw* (1943) earned first place.¹⁴ This heavy-handed anti-Semitic drama by "Merayu Sukma," the pen name of Balikpapan-born novelist Mohamad Sulaiman Hasan, was published in the first issue of the Cultural Center's organ *Keboedajaan timoer*, as "improved" (*diperbaiki*) by the Center's literary division. An unsigned afterword (probably written by Armijn Pané) explained the play's allegorical symbols and pointed to its deficiencies, including a villain portrayed stereotypically in the manner of American gangster films.¹⁵ Although Pané (1943) was hopeful that sandiwara groups in Java would be mandated to perform it, theater professionals were understandably averse to staging this didactic and symbolically overwrought play. There was as yet no direct mechanism to enable the dissemination of Cultural Center dramas in performance.

A similar competition sponsored later the same year by Borneo's propaganda department, which aimed to attract sandiwara scripts to entertain and raise *semangat* for Greater East Asia and the war effort, produced a more palatable product.¹⁶ Among the forty-four entries, first prize in the sandiwara division was awarded to a script by a Banjarmasin schoolboy named Abdoerrachman Noor. His winning entry, titled *Pengoerbanan membawa keinsjafan* (Sacrifice brings consciousness), was published serially in a Banjarmasin newspaper.¹⁷ The play recapitulates the conflicts between Western modernity and traditional values typical of 1930s novels, with more nuanced characterizations than Merayu Sukma's play. A young man named Imberan returns home to Banjarmasin after

some years living “overseas,” likely to pursue an education in Java. He mocks his older brother Hairoel for settling for a low-paying civil service job in the agricultural department. Imberan refuses to take jobs that will not pay enough to support his profligate tennis and badminton hobbies and jilts his fiancée Ratna because she is a backward *anak desa* (villager). When Imberan beats up Ratna’s younger brother for delivering a pleading letter from Ratna, Ratna’s hot-tempered older brother vows revenge. But the knife intended for Imberan stabs Ratna instead. Imberan, crushed by Ratna’s death, claims there’s “no use living without her” because he will never be happy again. In a harrowing coda, Hairoel tells his brother that desire can never be sated and that the poets are wrong when they claim happiness can be found in isolation. Only in devotion to a social cause can one achieve satisfaction, and only death brings ultimate happiness. Imberan vows to devote himself fully to the cause of Greater East Asia.

Plays and Comic Sketches from the Theater and Dance Division

The literary division under Armijn Pané had occasionally strained relations with the Theater and Dance Division (*Bahagian Sandiwara dan Tari-Menari*), which under the direction of Yasuda Kiyo’o manifested a generally more populist approach to theater.¹⁸ At the Cultural Center’s opening in April 1943, Yasuda criticized the low standards of sandiwara, which he attributed to negative American influences. He called for research into indigenous performance forms and their development into a new sort of tradition-based sandiwara that could be used as a weapon in ideological warfare. Sandiwara needs to go out to the Javanese countryside and play to entertainment-deprived, hardworking peasants and fishermen. Artists cannot afford to distance themselves from the world like snails in their shells, but neither is the whatever-goes liberalism of the past, which neglected indigenous arts, suitable. All local arts must be further developed, and all nations of Asia must cooperate in creating a new Eastern culture (Yasoeda 1943).

However, Yasuda’s ambitious program to cultivate local tradition could only be partially realized at best. Not only was it at loggerheads with Armijn Pané’s internationalism but it also was superordinate to the theater section’s core tasks: “the formulation of basic policies on the use of drama for political propaganda, and [. . .] the encouragement, training, guidance, and control of all sort of theatrical activities” (Kurasawa 1988, 347–348). The drudgery of managing the unruly theatrical field is clear from an article Yasuda published seven months later that dealt with complaints about sandiwara companies raiding each other for

performers and advocated theory-based performer training (*latihan jang berdasarkan teori*).¹⁹

Several innovations, however, can be attributed to Yasuda's division. One was the development of mobile sandiwara units known as *sandiwara keliling* (itinerant sandiwara) or *sandiwara penghiboer* (entertaining sandiwara), which played to primarily rural audiences in village squares, factories, and plantations. Rosihan Anwar (1992, 6), who worked in Jakarta as a reporter at *Asia Raya* during the occupation and was a frequent visitor to the Cultural Center, described it as "a kind of rolling-theatre, where artists performed on an open truck, in the middle of a square, moving from town to town, and presenting the audience—common folks—with popular plays, with loads of entertainment but always with some message such as 'Love your country and people,' 'Stand up for *Indonesia merdeka* [free Indonesia],' etc." Two of the leaders of these groups based in Jakarta were Djadug Djajakusuma and Suryo Sumanto, who went on to careers in film after independence. In a 1984 interview, Djajakusuma recalled that "inside the comedy, we gave intimations that Indonesia would at a future date be independent. That was the expression used then, 'a future date.' Nobody knew when" (Lohanda 1988, 5). Cultural Center branches around Java sent out mobile companies of this sort, and similar units toured south Borneo and possibly elsewhere in Indonesia.

Related to this development was the creation and patronage of a new form of sketch comedy known as *lelucon*, which combined features of Javanese comedy such as *dhagelan Mataram* with Japanese *manzai*, a team comedy form in which two outlandishly dressed comedians—a smart *tsukkomi* and a foolish *boke*—play with words, exchange insults, execute song-and-dance numbers, and push and shove each other around the stage. Traditionally performed in kimono with fans and drums, *manzai* was modernized in Osaka public theaters in the 1920s and 1930s; actors wore suits, sported Harold Lloyd eyeglasses and Charlie Chaplin mustaches, and sang jazz songs (Stocker 2006).

The hybrid *lelucon* comedy was launched in Java in 1943 via a national competition held at the Pasar Malam Djakarta. An open invitation was issued to comedy teams from all over Java, made up of two or three comedians, male or female, to perform acts at the fair lasting from fifteen to twenty minutes. These acts' themes were preset: performances should explain how defeating the United States and Britain was the noble aim of all Asians and the Will of God, encourage confidence in and support for the military, demonstrate the inhumanity of Americans and the British, and show how the Allies deserve no mercy for the sake of world peace. Scripts had to be sent to the Cultural Center in advance for censorship. Free transport and a small per diem (*oeang makan*) were provided for out-of-town contestants. Some contestants were comics from

national sandiwara companies, but regional entries—such as comedians who customarily performed entr’actes (*selingan*) in Sundanese *kecapi-suling* chamber music concerts—were also encouraged to enter the composition.²⁰ Nine groups from Jakarta, Bandung, Surabaya, and Gresik were in the end selected to perform in Jakarta on 6 and 7 July before a jury of the public. The audience awarded first prize to a sketch titled *Churchill dan Roosevelt dalam impian* (Churchill and Roosevelt in a dream) by a group from Bandung led by radio comic Kartadimedja. Second and third prizes went to groups from Jakarta performing *Hari Gemblengan Semangat* (Semangat indoctrination day) and *Inggeris kita linggis, Amerika kita seterika* (We’ll gouge out England and iron America flat). The latter title was a slogan often used by Sukarno in his fiery public addresses.²¹ Some of the *lelucon* troupes were then sent on tour, and plays were written and government-backed troupes formed at the local level in Java, Borneo, Sulawesi, and elsewhere.

We can get a good sense of the form from *lelucon* sketches by Ananta Gaharajah, Djadug Djajakusuma, and Aoh K. Hadimadja published between February and July 1945 in the photo magazine *Djawa baroe* and the Cultural Center’s multivolume anthologies *Pangoeng giat gembira: Lakon sandiwara dan leloetjon* (Cheerfully energetic stage: Sandiwara and lelucon plays). In Djadug Djajakusuma’s *Djarak* (Castor oil plant), a farmer named Pak Bopeng (Mr. Pockmarked) tries to process the oil of castor oil plants in his fields by himself, believing it can be used for cooking oil. His wife gets sick from eating the plant’s fruit. A more intelligent villager named Pak Tembak (Mr. Shooting) explains that the government needs farmers to grow castor oil plants to produce motor lubricant and that seeds requires industrial processing. The sketch ends with Tembak taking Bopeng’s wife to the village headman for a doctor’s note (Djajakusuma 1945). Other sketches urged parents to take responsibility for educating their children, showed the evils of gambling, promoted the value of saving money, and familiarized audiences with new governmental initiatives, such as the Roekoen Tetangga or Tonari Kumi neighborhood association system, which was used to organize labor, collect resources, survey the populace, and disseminate information at the most local level. *Lelucon* characters used Japanese words and expressions (e.g., *ah so desu ka*, “so that’s how it is”; *hai, wakarimashita*, “I understand”) and sang propaganda songs. In one sketch, a character explains the reasoning behind Barian Berani Mati kamikaze squads and why they were not contrary to Islamic belief. In another, a man one name short of his target of thirty *romusha* manual laborers is mocked for “forgetting” to include his own name on the list.

Sometimes characters joked about propaganda terminology such as *penghi-doepan baroe* or “new life”:

Krempeng: That's what's been turning round in my head until my nerves are half-fried! How could there be "new life"? I've no clue even about the old one. From the moment I popped out of my mother up to the moment my hair and teeth changed into the three colors they now have, life has always been the same!

Djangkoeng: Yeah, yeah. . . . maybe it's some new kind of invention, Péng! Our lives now will be replaced with the new. Someone old can become young. Someone scrawny, strong. Someone hollow-cheeked, tough. . . . But, sorry, I've got a question and don't be angry. What did you mean before about your hair and teeth having three colors?

Krempeng: See, take a look (*pulling his hair*). This is black, the original color. This is white, the color of age. This is gray, black on the way to white. And my teeth have three colors too, see (*showing his teeth*)? This one's ivory colored, the original. This one's black, camouflaged by cigarette tar [. . .] And this one's special. . . . (*Smiles.*) A gold tooth!

Djangkoeng: Right, I get you now!

(*Bang Kumityoo, the neighborhood chief, enters. They shake hands.*)

Krempeng: What good luck you're here Bang Kumityoo! We want to hear from you what "New Life" means.

Djangkoeng: We've been thinking about this til we got dizzy, but haven't come up with an answer. These times are really something. Everything has to be new. Asia, New. Indonesia, New! Java, New! Market, New!

Krempeng: New Market [*Pasar Baroe*] is near Djembatan Besi [a Jakarta neighborhood].

The neighborhood chief berates Djangkoeng and Krempeng for not staying up to date by listening to *radio oemoem*, outdoor radios the Japanese erected on poles in villages to disseminate news, referred to colloquially as "singing trees" (cf. Jones 2013). He then explains that New Life means accommodating one's way of living to the current conditions. It does not mean you have to die in order to live again, but it might mean suffering if this is required (Ananta 1945).

Dissident Voices? Chairil Anwar and Maya

The Cultural Center's investment in exploring tradition's potentials and constraints explains in part Armijn Pané's negative reaction to the most radical artist to present work under the auspices of its literary division: the long-haired, avant-garde poet Chairil Anwar. As one eyewitness put it, "to Armijn Pané, Chairil

Anwar was a naughty child, a disturber of the peace of the Cultural Center's building where Pané ruled as a dictator" (Hamdijaja 1952, 33). Anwar sharpened his poetic skills by translating European and American poets such as Rainer Maria Rilke, Conrad Aiken, W. H. Auden, and E. Du Perron—most likely from volumes formerly owned by interned Europeans, which could be picked up for a song in Jakarta's used-book markets.

Unlike the *Poedjangga baroe* poets, Anwar makes no reference to traditional forms, such as pantun. His poetry does, however, sometimes invoke the symbols of New Asia strategically, which allowed the publication of two of the poems in his short collection *Kerikil tadjam* (Sharp gravel) to be printed in *Asia Raya* in September 1943. His February 1943 poem *Dipo Negoro* resurrects the nineteenth-century Javanese rebel to explore the making of meaning in death and destruction (Anwar 1993, 6–7). More characteristic is his March 1943 poem *Semangat* (later retitled *Aku*, or "Me") in which the poet-warrior cries out: "The hell with all those tears!/I'm a wild beast/Driven out of the herd/Bullets may pierce my skin/But I'll keep on coming,/ [. . .] I want to live another thousand years" (18–19). The poem both conforms to Japanese kamikaze ideology and criticizes group mentality, seeks glorious death in battle and immortality in art, protests sentimentality and commemorates personal injury.

Anwar's other work circulated privately as mimeographed booklets and through public readings. An untitled speech Anwar gave to a meeting of the youth literary club Angkatan Baroe (New Generation) at the Cultural Center on 7 July 1943 interwove letters addressed to a girlfriend named Ida, a poem, and reflections on the creative process (Anwar 1993, 159–164). Don't equate me with an overweight ronggeng singing pantun verses as she dances, he tells Ida. Beethoven, and his discipline in sketching and rewriting his work, provides a better model. "I'm an artist, Ida. I have to deal sharply, boldly in considering things—and in discarding them" (160). "No one's going to make us play at being life's musical instruments, not any more they're not. We play life's own songs, so we have to be honest, blunt. Because we've got courage and awareness and confidence and the skill too. We know where we're going, Ida. We're living, now, at a thousand miles an hour!" (163). One can only guess how Armijn Pané reacted to this radical lecture-performance, which began, "I didn't want to write this talk like a formal speech, because speeches ruin good conversation" (159).

A discussion between writers (many of them members of Anwar's New Generation group) and sandiwara practitioners held at the Cultural Center in January 1944 attempted to bridge the gap separating the litterateurs and theater people congregating at the Cultural Center. The young writers claimed that sandiwara might be commercially successful, but that it lagged behind the literary quality

of fiction and poetry. It had to be improved if it was to be an effective instrument of communication in these times of renewal. Litterateurs urged that the old repertoire be replaced wholesale by new plays, whereas sandiwara artists spoke practically about precarious finances and the need to maintain audiences. The idea of a theater school was proposed to train artists to interpret the new plays, but skeptical about the theatrical worth of the proposed new plays, the theater practitioners showed slight willingness to introduce them into the repertoire.

According to an unsigned report (n.a. 1944), this summit meeting occasionally was overly abstract, and the two groups thus had difficulty reaching a common understanding. Criticism that sandiwara plays tended to be “materialistic” while what was needed was “idealistic-romantic” drama went over the practitioners’ heads: a shared theory of sandiwara was clearly needed. (Pané’s essay “Initiatives to Advance Sandiwara” [1945], discussed earlier, might have been intended precisely as a response to this perceived need.) But one point that clearly enthused all those assembled was the founding of an amateur theater group made up of educated young people: “We eagerly anticipate that steps will be taken as quickly as possible in this direction by the sandiwara division of the Cultural Center!” (n.a. 1944, 32).

Such a theater group—the “amateur theater” or *sandiwara penggemar* known as Maya, from the ancient, Sanskrit-derived word for “illusion”—was indeed formed under the Cultural Center’s auspices in the wake of this discussion. This noncommercial theater, founded in Jakarta in July 1944, produced small-scale naturalist drama, both new plays as well as translations from Japanese- and European-language sources. There were precedents for this sort of theater in the prewar amateur tonil groups, as well as in the little theater movement that started in the 1910s in the United States and the *shôgekijô* movement of 1920s Japan. Maya was short-lived, effectively disbanding after independence was declared in August 1945.²² The company’s influence on post-independence theatrical production, however, has been confirmed by all major historical studies of twentieth-century sandiwara (see, e.g., Oemarjati 1971; Sumardjo 1992; Winet 2010). Part of its historiographical presence can be attributed to the fact that the doyen of Indonesian letters, H. B. Jassin, was an actor in the company. But it is hard to dispute that its prominence also springs from the literary quality of the plays written for the company. One can question, however, claims made in postwar writings by key members of the group, including Usmar Ismail, Abu Hanifah, Rosihan Anwar, and Djadug Djajakusuma, that Maya performed no propaganda plays and resisted Japanese fascism.

Maya’s principal members were part of an artistic salon that met during weekends in 1943 at the house of the physician and politician Dr. Abu Hanifah.

Discussions revolved around Western literature and art, including canonical plays of modern drama by Strindberg, O’Neil, Pirandello, and Shaw; members “tried their strength” by translating Ibsen (Hanifah 1972, 136). After Hanifah impulsively wrote a play titled *Taufan di atas Asia* (Storm over Asia), his younger brother Usmar Ismail, along with Ismail’s school friend Rosihan Anwar and other members of Hanifah’s literary circle, decided to stage it, booking the old schouwburg, or Siritu Gekizyo as it had been renamed, for three nights in August 1944.

Hanifah’s four-act play, set in the months after the bombing of Pearl Harbor on 7 December 1941, alternates between scenes set in Singapore and Jakarta. Chinese, Indian, and Indonesian businessmen based in Singapore are trying to get out, settling their affairs, selling off assets, contacting relatives and colleagues overseas, packing possessions, and booking tickets before the city’s anticipated fall. World affairs—advancing armadas and refugees—are on the minds of everyone. As they go their separate ways, a group of friends of different nationalities recall nostalgically cross-ethnic alliances struck in the Lion City:

Sardar Khan: I will always remember our good relations here in Singapore. See, if our friend Buang Maw were to be here now, we would have representatives from different Asian nations, Indonesia, China, Burma, and me from India.

Cheong Fung: Right, that’s exactly what I’ve been thinking. Hopefully this will be a sign for the good relations our peoples will one day enjoy.

Abdul Azas: That’s the hope.

Cheong Fung: Hopefully our own domestic affairs will be robust and peaceful as a basis for mutual prosperity in Asia outside the influence of the White Man, whether he’s named England or America. (Hanifah 1949, 43–44)

In the scenes set in Jakarta, politicians plot alliances between the nationalists and Islamic factions and anxiously listen to the wire service to follow Japan’s southward advance. After the Indonesian businessman Abdul Azas receives a head wound in the evacuation from Singapore, he returns to Jakarta and rants poetically about the storm over Asia, a darkness enveloping the world, and a light from the east. Beethoven’s *Pastorale Symphony* was used as incidental music—a choice justified by an aspiration to synthesize East and West in an ideal world of harmony without desire or conflict.

Although Maya was nominally headed by *Asia Raya* reporter Rosihan Anwar, the director of *Taufan di atas Asia* and the company’s indubitable driving artistic

force was Usmar Ismail. Ismail was born in Bukittinggi in 1921 and attended Dutch-language high school (Algemeene Middelbare School) in Yogyakarta, where he participated in school theatricals. He was employed as a writer and translator in the Cultural Center's literary division. Though he frequently differed with Armijn Pané in Cultural Center discussions, he clearly was indebted to the senior writer in matters of technique. Ismail came to prominence as a writer of propaganda poems and a writer and director of radio drama. Ismail's prize-winning dramas included *Pedang samoerai* (Samurai sword) and the anti-colonial play *Moetiara dari Noesa Laoet* (Pearl from Nusa Laut). The latter was published in 1944 in *Keboedajaan timoer* and received professional stage productions by Bintang Soerabaja and the sandiwara division of Perserikatan Ahli Film Indonesia (Indonesian Film Professional Union). He adapted a one-act play by the Japanese playwright Kikuchi Kan as *Ajahkoe poelang* (My father returns).²³ It aired as a radio drama in October 1943 and received a number of additional stagings by amateur theater groups.

Ismail's first outing as a stage director was a one-act play by Sanoesi Pané. Ismail employed a self-consciously "avant-garde" staging device in which a follow spot shifted from actor to actor with each line of dialogue, which Ismail argued increased the play's dramatic intensity. Veteran sandiwara director Dr. Roesmali, who was on the board of the Cultural Center, publicly criticized Ismail's scenographic conceit at the play's dress rehearsal. The scandal was not a deterrent—if anything it fired Ismail's revolutionary zeal for theater.

The enthusiastic reception of *Taufan di atas Asia* as performed by Maya's amateur actors with "an élan and a spirit and a seriousness" the playwright "didn't believe possible," encouraged more Maya productions for the stage and radio (Hanifah 1972, 136). Plays written by Hanifah and Ismail for Maya focused on dilemmas faced by educated elites and conflicts between generations. Hanifah's three-act play, *Intelek istimewa* (Remarkable intellect), concerned medical ethics, specifically the conflict between serving society and achieving power and influence, and it drew on Hanifah's own experience as a practicing physician. It premiered in Jakarta in February 1945 in a double bill with *Semalam di medan perang* (A night in the battlefield), a propaganda musical drama directed by Iboe Soed with a cast of children under age twelve.

The following month saw the premiere of Ismail's *Liboeran seniman*, or *Artists' Holiday* in Michael Bodden's translation (Ismail [1945] 2010), a meta-theatrical drama in the spirit of Pirandello about a group of amateur theater makers rehearsing and performing a play written by one of their number titled *The Awakening*. It meditates on conundrums faced by idealistic young artists in society—difficulties in securing funding, criticism by the old guard for staging drama

with too much talk and insufficient action, actors forced to leave the company to join the armed forces. Andjar Asmara is parodied as the populist sandiwara director Kertalasmara, who criticizes the company for being insufficiently Eastern and not catering to the needs of the public. He attends a rehearsal, but leaves early to go watch a boxing match.

Hanifah's *Dewi Reni*, which premiered in Jakarta in June 1945, is an allegorical drama in which Dewi Reni, the embodiment of the nation, is courted by suitors representing different segments of society. Dewi Reni chooses country doctor Abdullah Hasjim over poet Harlono Adiasmara, businessman Ukar Sumodikromo, and politician Nasar Tohir, because of the physician's devotion and boundless energy. The company also performed a version of Ibsen's *Little Eyolf* (1894), translated by Karim Halim under the title *Djeritan hidoep baroe* (New life's shout)—described in publicity as an "international play" (*lakon internasional*). In July 1945 it put on a musical evening called *Seni-rhapsodie* (Rhapsodic Art) that included new works by composers associated with the Cultural Center and a fragment of a new opera by Cornel Simandjoentak opera titled *Madah Kelana*, based on a poem cycle by Sanoesi Pané.

The 1945 production of Ismail's play *Tjitra* (Image) by the Pantjawarna sandiwara company was a testament to Ismail's growing theatrical reputation. Pantjawarna was a commercial company under the direction of writer-director Njoo Cheong Seng and his wife, the famous Chinese actress and film star Fifi Young. Njoo records that Ismail's play was written with a "mixed audience" in mind—"academics, genuine intellectuals, the middle class, youth, traditionalists, shop owners, grandmothers and grandfathers, Chinese aunties and uncles, carriage drivers, vegetable sellers, and others." The play challenged spectators to improve themselves, in Njoo's analysis, but in an entertaining and nonthreatening way (Njoo 1950b, 26). The play is set in an East Javanese textile factory and is based on observations made by Ismail while in Bangil in a September 1943 study tour under the auspices of the Cultural Center. Ismail and his traveling companions, painter G. A. Soekirno and composer Cornel Simandjoentak, were charged with creating art works to increase *semangat* in the production of cotton. Cornel and Ismail reportedly knocked out a set of four songs in five days—"Ke pabrik" (To the factory), "Di paberik" (In the factory), "Di keboen kapas" (In the cotton plantation), and "Ajo poelang" (Let's go home)—that were sung by a hand-clapping children's choir with piano accompaniment.²⁴

The title of the play, *Tjitra*, was taken from another of Cornel's songs, which Maya had earlier performed in a November 1944 tour to Bandung. The play depicts two young men, the industrious Sutopo and dissolute Harsono, both sons of the textile factory owner Suriowinoto, striving for the affections of the beau-

tiful Tjitra. A composer named “Kornel,” who is visiting the area to seek inspiration for his music, makes a brief appearance in the play and writes a song in Tjitra’s honor—which is played on piano and sung repeatedly in the play. Harsono impregnates Tjitra and skips town, and then Sutopo marries her to defend her honor and the family’s good name. A penitent Harsono returns at the play’s end and announces that he has volunteered for the army.

In his postwar essays, Ismail argues for theater that balances literary quality with theatrical aesthetics. The key to good theater is the ability of the playwright to represent society and to generate a relationship with an audience: “The playwright, more than any other artist, must contain, feel, and understand the complexes that plague the human heart. Because of this he can be called a thousand-and-one-tongued human. Sometimes for days or even months at a stretch he gives life again and again to the variety of human types he holds within” (Ismail 1946, 11). Theater is to be built out of the materials of everyday life and needs a “total and collective” relation to the public. The avant-garde theater artist’s task is particularly fraught. To possess meaning, theater must attract spectators because theater without an audience is just craziness.

Maya made many technical contributions to Indonesian theater. H. B. Jassin (1954, 132) noted Maya’s innovative use of prologues and epilogues, protracted dialogues, naturalistic diction, background music, and what is now in Indonesia called *musikalisasi puisi* (musicalized poetry)—the reading of poetry to music. This last device was used in radio broadcasts and to great effect in a patriotic poem (“the thoughts of one brother to another on the struggle to the death for the people and land of Indonesia”) recited by the poet Harlono to piano accompaniment in *Dewi Reni* (Hanifah 1949, 150).

Maya’s understanding and expression of the human heart and the company’s relation to the public were, in contrast, somewhat less articulated. Maya’s principal members, with the exception of playwright Abu Hanifah, were men in their twenties who would probably have been studying in university if the Japanese had not mostly shut them down (Hanifah 1972, 136). Theater offered a replacement for the social and intellectual life of college days—a sort of an extended bull session that allowed a group of young men (and a smaller number of women enticed to join them on stage) to experiment and act out ideas about art, love, power, knowledge, duty, and belonging. In the words of one of Maya’s actors, Djadug Djajakusuma, Maya offered *pelepasan* or “escape” from the drudgery and tedium of the occupation (quoted in Lohanda 1988, 7). The plays provide insight into the moral universe of educated Indonesian elites, but do not represent society as a whole, being mute on crucial issues. Most of Maya’s plays, for example, feature onstage pianos, but no mention is made in these plays that these instruments

entered Indonesian homes in large numbers only after they had been confiscated from or sold off by Europeans imprisoned in work camps by the Japanese—where some 40 percent of male civilian detainees were to die (Jones 2013, 60).

Autocratic cultural bodies all over the world—ranging from France’s Académie Française, to Brazil’s Academia Brasileira de Letras (1898), the Academy of Arab Learning in Damascus (founded 1919), and Iran’s Farhangestān or “Language Academy” (founded in 1935 to purge Farsi of Arabic and European borrowings)—are characterized by similar structural dilemmas stemming from their isolation from popular cultural flows. As Néstor García Canclini (1995, 7) put it, “The elites cultivate vanguard poetry and art, while most of the population is illiterate. Modernity, then, is seen as a mask. A simulacrum conjured up by the elite and the state apparatuses.” The aesthetic accomplishments of Maya and other projects of the Cultural Center were considerable, but their limitations were marked. Although they aspired to create a pan-Asian culture, in practice much of the art created under the Cultural Center’s auspices was Western oriented. Opportunities for Indonesians to study Japanese performing arts were extremely limited—only a handful of Indonesian artists went to study in Japan, and none returned before the end of the war to contribute their learning to society. The culture held in common by Japanese and Indonesian elites was thus *de facto* Western.²⁵ Any official project to create an East–West hybrid culture, as Chatterjee (1993a, 73) argues in the case of India, was bound to be elitist because “the act of cultural synthesis can, in fact, be performed only by a supremely cultivated and refined intellect. It is a project of national-cultural regeneration in which the intelligentsia leads and the nation follows.”

Domination and Resistance

A monthly Japanese-language report on propaganda in Java dating from December 1943 that was confiscated and translated by the Allies reveals that Japanese operations entered a new phase at the end of 1943. Previously, efforts had focused on increasing production. The formation of a “volunteer” defense army described in that report meant that the Japanese war effort would now be focused on “the fostering of a national defence consciousness” (*Monthly Propaganda Report from Java* 1944, 2). Calisthenics were introduced to schools and adult education programs. Free pencak silat courses were opened, and mass martial arts demonstrations were held with three thousand or more participants. Propaganda films depicted muscular Indonesian men engaging in military drills or doing martial arts to the rhythms of gongs and drums. Girls were instructed in militaristic flag dances with titles such as *Tari benteng perdjoengan Djawa* (Javanese fortress of struggle dance) and *Kanak-kanak baik dari Asia Timoer* (Good children of East Asia). *Cakalele* and other martial dances were encouraged because these forms displayed bravery and increased *semangat*.

The Japanese introduced harsher austerity measures, and by 1944 it was a common sight to see impoverished peasants dressed in gunnysacks. Corpses of *romusha* who had fled the harsh life of manual labor only to die of starvation turned up daily in city streets. Peasants in the west Javanese regency of Indramayu staged rebellions against the forced delivery of their rice crops to the Japanese. The idea of contributing labor to the common good was romanticized at the start of the occupation with the neologism *gotong-royong*, meaning “mutual cooperation.” By 1944, people spoke of being *digotong-royongkan*, which took on the meaning of “being mobilized for forced labor” (Mark 2003, 576).¹

The performing arts and other forms of expressive culture in Java became sites of resistance against Japanese oppression. Anti-Japanese doggerel circulated from mouth to mouth. Wayang puppeteers inserted anti-Japanese comments into performances; one wayang golek puppeteer “was jailed for joking about the rice shortage that got progressively worse as the war continued” (Brandon 1967, 285). Another puppeteer in Brebes was imprisoned for joking about the Kei Bodan or

“Vigilance Corps,” a network of auxiliary police who acted as informers and spies for the Japanese. To emphasize his bad character, it was reported that the puppeteer also insulted the honor of women.² American propaganda that was broadcast over long-wave radio and dropped as leaflets from airplanes stoked discontent starting in 1944. Radio shows produced by the Office of Strategic Services (OSS) often featured Indonesian music by members of Devi Dja’s dance troupe (Kratoska 2009, 99). Piëdro and Dja had opened an Indonesian-themed nightclub in Chicago after Dardanella’s world tour had wrapped up (Cohen 2010, 194–196). Money was tight, and they probably agreed to collaborate with the OSS as much out of financial need as sympathy with the Allied cause.

It was in part economic need that drove people to become informers and join the Vigilance Corps. Paranoia about Allied spies increased as neighbors reported on each other. An elaborate spy ring said to be transmitting strategic information by radio to the Allies was “busted” in January 1945. At the head of this ring, according to informants, was Patih Soerojo, a blue-blooded novelist and the outspoken head of Malang’s Cultural Center who had played host to Usmar Ismail and Cornel Simandjoentak when they conducted their study tour to Bangil in 1943. The Chinese writer Pouw Kioe An and other intellectuals and journalists accused of being members of Soerojo’s ring were rounded up and tortured by the military police. Pouw confessed that he knew Soerojo slightly and had visited his house in 1944 to obtain permission to adapt his novel *Kali Brantas* into a play for the commercial sandiwara troupe Warna Sari; however, Pouw refused to admit he was a spy until he broke under torture. He survived 198 days of imprisonment and published a powerful prison memoir after the war (Pouw 1947).

The most famous artist to fall afoul of the Japanese authorities was the ludruk innovator Cak Gondo Durasim from Surabaya. Durasim is credited with modernizing this urban folk art, bringing ludruk into its present form by combining dance (*ngremo*), song (*kidungan*), and comic skits (*dagelan*) with plays (*lakon*, *cerita*). Starting in 1928, the actor-director collaborated with the STOVIA-educated labor activist Dr. Soetomo “to portray, discuss, and advocate what was modern and progressive” on stage (Frederick 1983, 369). As Durasim’s patron, Soetomo reinterpreted ludruk’s core features so that they became symbolic of the nationalist movement—for example, the red and white of the costumes were Indonesia’s national colors and the torch that traditionally illuminated performances symbolized the enlightenment of the people. Soetomo helped promote ludruk by renting a permanent venue for the troupe—income from ticket sales was divided between the troupe and nationalist and labor projects—and set up performances at nationalist meetings. Durasim in exchange inserted songs into his performances about Soetomo’s organization, the Indonesian Study Club.

Ludruk became a more genteel form of entertainment in the process of their collaboration. Ludruk clowns, like those of wayang wong and other traditional theaters of Java, customarily went shirtless. Durasim originally wore a fez with a simple white skirt and cotton belt. With his appearance at a 1931 pasar malam celebrating the opening of Surabaya's Gedung Nasional Indonesia, a center for the nationalist movement, Durasim started to wear a waistcoat (*baju rompi*), considered "a step in the direction of propriety" (Kementerian Penerangan 1953d, 852).

Durasim had been a regular on radio during the 1930s, typically presenting variety programs including song, comedy, and comic skits. He had acted as a spokesman for the common man and as a proponent of social and political change. His critical commentary appears mild in retrospect, along the lines of "If there aren't enough schools, why don't we go ahead and set them up ourselves?" (Frederick 1983, 368). But even this was enough apparently to instigate a Dutch ban against him. This ban was quickly rescinded under the Japanese, and Durasim was performing again on radio and at Sendenbu-sponsored pasar malam by October 1942. The first page of an article on the history of ludruk published in 1943 contained a photograph of Durasim with a caption praising his *wahyu*, or divine gift, for comedy (Iswajo 1943, 97).

Durasim's fatal misstep was an infamous kidung couplet he improvised in a 1944 performance—*bekupon omahe dara, sajege ana Nippon awakku sengsara* (a dove kept in a cage, I have suffered since Japan arrived).³ He was picked up, severely beaten in a military police cell, and died on 2 July 1944. Published obituaries reported that he had suffered for a number of days from an unspecified ailment and also mention that he had committed some "mistakes," but that like the proverbial tiger who leaves behind his stripes, his good reputation would live on.⁴ After independence, Durasim became a national cultural hero—Surabaya's art center and an international arts festival are named after him.

Idrus, a Padang-born writer who worked as an editor at the state publishing house Balai Pustaka during the war years, penned a series of short stories that compiled common grievances and injustices perpetrated under the Japanese. One of these, "Pasar Malam in the Japanese Period," was included in a collection of Idrus' "underground writings" published after the war (Idrus 1978). This tale looks at a Sendenbu-sponsored pasar malam held in July 1943 in Jakarta's Prinsenpark amusement park, renamed Rakutenci by the Japanese, and presently the location of Lokasari Plaza on Jalan Mangga Besar Raya. It was a major cultural event attracting hundreds of thousands of visitors, much advertised and hyped in newspapers. The wayang wong company Ngesthi Pandowo from Semarang, the *dhagelan Mataram* group Wargo, Bintang Soerabaja, and many others performed free for the price of admission to the park.

In his story, Idrus writes that nobody knows why the propaganda office sponsors events like this pasar masam, or sandiwara or musical performances, or soccer matches, for that matter. But visitors come happily, because whatever the Sendenbu sponsors guarantees pleasure. Affluent Chinese purchase tickets from scalpers at double the price, rather than standing in line with commoners reeking of stale sweat. Music sounding like rattled tin cans drifts out of the pasar's eateries. Guests throng to these cafés; hunger and thirst disappear when they glimpse the sexy waitresses, who treat all comers politely as they eye their wallets. Visitors dwell only briefly at a hall of Javanese industry displaying wartime products: tires for airplanes from rubber trees and shirts plaited from palm leaves. People stand for hours at the roulette tables concentrating fully, as if watching a wayang. A vegetable seller from Pasar Senen asks a friend if roulette too is sponsored by the Sendenbu. His friend affirms it is. "If it wasn't," he says, "it wouldn't be this popular." A gambler sells first his tropical shirt and then his pants and his imported Robinson's shoes, and would sell his tattered undershirt if anyone would have it. Rumors circulate a few days later of a man who hanged himself after losing at roulette.

American victories in the Pacific and the ever-greater need for military personnel and manual laborers prompted Tokyo to make concessions to the Indonesian nationalists in September 1944. Independence was promised at some unspecified date in the future, the red-and-white flag could be unfurled next to Japan's flag on specified national days, and the nationalist's anthem "Indonesia raya" could again be sung in public, as long as it was preceded by the Japanese anthem "Kimigayo." A thirteen-member committee headed by Sukarno and including the prominent intellectuals and artists Ki Hadjar Dewantara, Sanoesi Pané, Muhammad Yamin, Kusbini, Iboe Soed, and Cornel Simandjoentak, worked for two months to standardize the anthem's lyrics, melody, and performance practices, which were published in November 1944.⁵

A newsreel released in 1945 by the national film company Nippon Eigasha Djakarta illustrated the revised song with images of marching soldiers, balloons, cheering crowds, a poster reading *Indonesia Diperkenakan Merdeka* (Indonesia has been granted independence), flag waving, a procession with a banner reading *Indonesia-Nippon Sehidoep Semati* (Indonesia and Japan together in life and death), saluting, a marching band, parades in traditional Minangkabau dress, a banner reading *Banzai Dai Nippon, Hidoep Indonesia!* (Long live Japan and Indonesia!), quick shots of speechmaking by nationalist leaders, lingering shots of rice terraces and grazing cattle and harvesting, a bemused farmer smoking a hand-rolled cigarette, bare-chested marching Indonesian soldiers-in-training bearing pieces of wood carved in the shape of rifles, marching *romusha* laborers

holding hoes on their shoulders like rifles, marching youth corps, and a military convoy—all ending with the fluttering Indonesian flag (n.a. [1945] 2005).

The Japanese authorities courted traditional artists as folk propagandists (*penjuluh ra'jat*) with unprecedented intensity. Aware of the intimate connection between the populace and wayang puppetry, they set up indoctrination and training courses for puppeteers around Java in 1945. For a week or longer, puppeteers listened to speeches regarding their influence and respect among the rural poor. They were told that they needed to disseminate ideas about Indonesian independence and counteract enemy propaganda. This required increasing their skills so that they could be in step with the times. They learned that the taboo against performing plays about the bloody *Bratayuda* war that concludes the Mahabharata cycle was a Dutch ploy to dampen the people's *semangat* that would otherwise threaten colonial rule. They swore oaths: "We, the representatives of the trained puppeteers, respectfully vow to assist, strive, struggle, and sacrifice in the Greater East Asian war until final victory is achieved and a New Java is raised, and a genuine Independent Indonesia is quickly achieved."⁶ Diplomas and awards were issued and model wayang performances enacted.

POSD: Java's Sandiwara Union

The last year of the occupation witnessed the increasing militarization of all facets of cultural life. Among the most important new cultural institution formed was Java's Sandiwara Union, Perserikatan Oesaha Sandiwara Djawa (POSD), known as Djawa Engeki Kyōkai in Japanese. It was an umbrella organization funded and organized by the Sendenbu that provided resources to and directed all the island's major commercial troupes. On POSD's founding in Jakarta at the end of August 1944, it was foretold that the union would facilitate solidarity among its members, improve sandiwara's quality, and convey government messages to Java's fifty million people, thereby strengthening the war effort. A formal mission statement was delayed until a meeting held in Jakarta on 15 January 1945, where it was announced that POSD would serve to "to bring the values and business of sandiwara into alignment with the current holy war so that sandiwara can be an instrument in pursuit of the values of Independent Indonesia" (quoted in Kamajaya 1978, 424). All commercial sandiwara companies were compelled to join and fork over 3 percent of their monthly earnings. The head office was located in the offices of the state film company Eiga Haikyusha, with branch offices in Bandung, Yogyakarta, Semarang, Malang, and Surabaya. Meetings brought together theater workers from around Java, prizes were awarded for contributions to the field, and script competitions organized.

Under POSD, sandiwara became a form of mass culture, entering what Bourdieu (1985) calls the field of large-scale cultural production. Companies were “compelled” (Njoo 1950b, 63) to perform propaganda plays written in the central office, some of which were published in play anthologies and the POSD’s bulletin. These plays then had simultaneous premiers in all of Java’s major cities and were sometimes performed as well by troupes in Sumatra, Borneo, and possibly other islands. Sandiwara practitioners were treated explicitly as culture workers rather than artists. This, it was reported, was in accord with the official decision reached by the government advisory body Chūō Sangi-In (Central Advisory House) in its fourth meeting in Jakarta in August 1944 that all workers were to lend their strength to the war effort. Sandiwara practitioners could not afford to exclude themselves from this directive. They too had to “conduct business in accord with the Government’s guidance.”⁷ Technical supervisors employed by POSD ensured the quality of productions and monitored troupes to see that no deviations were made from core artistic and ideological concepts.

POSD was headed by the Sendenbu employee Hinatsu Eitarō, a Korean national born with the name Heo Yeong. Described by sandiwara writer-director Njoo Cheong Seng (1950b, 8) as “more Japanese than the Japanese,” Hinatsu came to Java with nine years of experience making *jidaigeki* (period drama) films in Japan. He remains a notorious figure in Korea because of the pro-Japanese propaganda dramas he wrote and directed, above all the volunteer recruitment film *You and I* that he made for the Korean Army Information Section in 1941. Another notorious Hinatsu product is *Calling Australia!* (titled *Gōshū no Yoboigoe* in Japanese), a propaganda film made in Java in 1943 that depicts Australian prisoners of war enjoying the good life in camps in West Java—swimming, playing billiards, eating steak and drinking beer, and staging amateur theater. Such scenes were, of course, complete fabrications, comparable to the lies staged for the camera in the 1944 Nazi film *Theresienstadt: Ein dokumentarfilm aus dem Jüdischen siedlungsgebiet* (Terezin: A documentary film from the Jewish Settlement Area). Hinatsu’s film probably was made to counter anti-Japanese propaganda regarding its poor treatment of Allied prisoners. Some have suggested that *Calling Australia!* might also have been intended to weaken Australian resolve and prepare the country for invasion.⁸

POSD’s inaugural production was Hinatsu’s play *Fadjar telah menjingsing* (Dawn has broken), performed for four nights in Jakarta and Surabaya in September 1944 to mark Japan’s promise that, at some undeclared future point, Indonesia would receive its independence (Hinatu [*sic*] 1945, 9–50). The contemporary story depicts various ways in which farmers and soldiers contribute

to the war effort and featured an all-star cast drawn from six of Java's major sandiwara companies. The play is noteworthy as the first stage appearance of the character of Amat, an enthusiastic *heiho* (auxiliary soldier) volunteer. Amat became a running character in POSD plays written by Kotot Sukardi, which were mandatory fare for sandiwara companies around Java and adapted to the kethoprak stage. Songs were written about Amat, and the phrases *toeroetlah Amat* and *toeroet sama Amat* (follow Amat's example) appeared endlessly on recruitment posters. Newspapers covered Amat Heiho's heroic exploits, his promotion to *heiho* second class, and his funeral after his death as a suicide bomber. Though a fictional soldier like Britain's Tommy Atkins, some seemed to believe him real (see, e.g., Pakpahan 1947, 118).

The blatantly propagandistic nature of the Amat plays and other POSD products caused grumbling from troupe owners dependent on box office income (Njoo 1950b, 63–64). One cannot ignore the rights of audiences, an unsigned article in *Djawa baroe* opined. Spectators are already receiving propaganda from the radio, the small meetings they attend in their offices and workplaces, monster rallies, and “everywhere and at all times.” From the theater, they “hope for something a bit different” (n.a. 1945a).

Despite such criticism, Hinatsu continued to hold a tight rein on POSD productions. Spectacles such as the revue show *Moesim boenga di Asia* (Flower season in Asia), which premiered on 8 December 1944 to commemorate the third anniversary of the Asia-Pacific war, were completely under Japanese control, with Japanese culture workers helming the direction, décor, music, dance, and songs (Hinatu 1945, 173–182; Kamajaya 1978, 424). But Hinatsu also cowrote a play with Kamajaya, who had worked previously with Andjar Asmara, and expanded POSD's stable of writers to include Kotot Sukardi, Armijn Pané, and the Tapanuli-born school headmaster J. Hoetagaloeng.

A few of the POSD-commissioned plays continued to be performed into the revolutionary period and beyond. The most famous perhaps is Kotot Sukardi's costume drama *Bende Mataram* (The Mataram Signal Gong), set in early nineteenth-century Java during the revolt led by Diponegoro. Sukardi's plays centers on a young man named Lagiono who wavers between siding with the rebel forces or with his father, who is loyal to the Dutch-backed kraton, referred to in the play as “the Company.” Menik, the girlfriend of Wiropati, his comrade in arms, persuades Lagiono that he is only in doubt because he has been duped by the propaganda of the Company. The play ends with Lagiono killing the traitorous Abdul Ngani before he betrays Wiropati to the Company, the unfurling of the red-and-white flag, and preparation for battle (Sukardi [1945] 2010). Plays related to Diponegoro and other rebels of legend such as Untung Surapati and



— MALAM INI DI-BANDOENG GEKIKO: —
„BENDE MATARAM” tjerita kaitipon sedjadian dalam perang-DIPO-
NEGORO karangan Ketot Soehardi, diselinggarakan oleh P. O. S. D. Mem-
banggoekan semangat perdjoangan bertjita-tjita.
Beli kartje siang jam 11 — 1.
A. 118

SANDIWARA DJAWA

Dibawah pimpinan P.O.S.D. dengan bantoean SENDENBU dan
DJAWA HOOKOO KAI

Mempersembahkan:

RENTJANA ISTIMEWA BOELAN & — 2605.

Moclat tanggal 15-2-2605 sampai tanggal 21-2-2605.

„BENDE MATARAM”

(Perdjoangan Pahlawan Pangeran Diponegoro).

Sandiwara penjebar semangat dalam 4 babak.

„Bende Mataram”, tjeritera yang terdjadi pada zaman Diponegoro.
Tjeritera yang sangat menarik, menggambarkan semangat rakjat melawan
pendjadjah Belanda.

Tjeritera yang sesuai dengan zaman yang berisi pembelaan rakjat yang
tertindas.

Pandji Agoeng Sang „Merah-Poetih” berkibar!
Rakjat bangkit!

Lebih baik hantjoer leboer membela Noesa dan Bangsa, daripada diindjak.
Indjak kaoem angkara moerka.

Pendapatan dalam Minggoe ini akan diserahkan kepada Fonds Perang
dan Kemerdekaan Indonesia (Djawa Hookoo Kai).

Menonton sambil berbakti!

Goebahan dan Pimpinan Badan Permoesjawaratan Tjeritera P. O. S. D.
Djakarta di Djakarta Gekiko dimainkan oleh „Sw. „Bintang
Soerabaja”.

Bandoeng	„ Bandoeng Gekiko	„	„	„	„Tjahaja Timoer”.
Semarang	„ Nanko Gekiko	„	„	„	„Bintang”.
Jogjakarta	„ Asia Gekiko	„	„	„	„Warnasari”.
Soerabaja	„ Soerabaja Gekiko	„	„	„	„Dewi Mada”.
Malang	„ Malang Gekiko	„	„	„	„Noesantara”.

Pendjoel kartjes:

Kantor Poest P.O.S.D. dan kantor.kantor tjabang P.O.S.D. Oentoek
Djakarta didjoel djoega di-Djakarta Gekiko (M. Besar) moclat poekoci 11
pagi.

Nasihat kepada Sandhuara-Sandhuara:

Maseklah seleksnja mendjadi anggota keloearga P.O.S.D., agar
tjita-tjita pembaharuan sandiwara dapat didjalankan dengan sebaik-
baiknja.
L. 1705

Advertisement for *Bende Mataram* (The Mataram Signal Gong), which premiered simulta-
neously in six cities by sandiwara companies affiliated with POSD. The play is promoted as the
heroic struggle of Pangeran Diponegoro, though Diponegoro himself does not make an ap-
pearance. “Better to be destroyed totally in defence of the nation, than trampled by the greedy.”
Asia Raya, 15 February 1945.

Sawunggaling had been banned by the Japanese authorities in mid-1943 on the grounds that they were difficult to stage and could lead to national idols being unintentionally mocked.⁹ More likely the authorities were worried that Diponegoro and other fighters might provide role models for rebellion against the Japanese. As the war ground on, there was an increasing need for heroes, and Diponegoro was the most available model for “awakening enthusiasm for the struggle.” Sukardi’s play not only invokes the historic rebel’s fighting spirit as a model for the struggle against British and American imperialism but also allows us to contemplate nineteenth-century equivalents of wartime spies, loyalists, enemy propaganda, and even the flag of the Indonesian nationalists.

POSD took further steps to use sandiwara as a propaganda tool by collaborating with Lily Somawiria, the director of the famed Sundanese-language sandiwara company Miss Tjitjih. It commissioned Somawiria to write and direct a number of plays, including a historical drama set in the time of the ancient Sundanese kingdom of Pajajaran, in a conscious attempt to reach the rural poor. Villagers had difficulty connecting to POSD’s Indonesian-language plays, both because of unfamiliarity with the language and alienation from their modern settings, but were deemed in great need of increased *semangat* for the war and knowledge about the goal of independence and the mobilization of agriculture. Somawiria’s plays were performed in Jakarta, Bandung, and a number of towns in West Java, and simplified versions were planned for Sundanese sandiwara companies with lesser technical capacities (n.a. 1945b).

From the Ashes of Defeat . . .

The tide of the war had turned against the Japanese after the bloody battle of Iwo Jima in February 1945. With defeat imminent in May 1945, the Japanese authorities permitted the formation of a group called the Exploratory Committee on Efforts to Prepare for the Independence of Indonesia and charged it to draft “the conceptual and institutional framework for an independent Indonesia” (Yampolsky 1995, 700). Seventy of Indonesia’s most prominent politicians, intellectuals, and religious leaders comprised the group. Cultural matters received only scant attention in their deliberations and the constitution drafted in July 1945. Point three of the Pantja Dharma (Five Duties), a credo of national identity that had been formulated earlier by Sukarno at a May 1944 meeting of the Japanese-sponsored Advisory Council, stated, “We shall make every effort to attain a lofty nobility by maintaining and enhancing our own civilization and culture, drawing upon all the cultures of the world” (Sukarno quoted in Mark 2003, 570). The draft constitution, in contrast, took a more restricted view of culture. Clause 33

stated, “The government must advance the national culture of Indonesia, and to that end [it must] advance the culture of each region, as pillars of that national culture” (quoted in Yampolsky 1995, 701). There was no recognition of interethnic arts and hybrid cultural formations, the enduring presence of European and Chinese arts not linked to specific regions, the metropolitan super-culture, or the many world cultures encountered through travel, reading, films, records, and acts of the imagination.

The inclusion of regional cultures as “pillars” of the national culture in the draft constitution was partially due to a point raised at the Exploratory Committee’s July 15 meeting by Supomo, a Leiden-trained lawyer who was appointed as Minister of Justice after independence. Supomo argued that “the cultures of Java, Bali, Sunda [etc.] are all Indonesian cultures. They must be respected, elevated. But this clause shows the desire for eventual unity and the birth of a national Indonesian culture by whatever means. Precisely what this [national] culture will be, depends upon the people of Indonesia later” (Supomo quoted in Yamin 1971, 317). Returning to this point later in the session, B. K. P. A. Surjohamidjojo, representing the royal court of Surakarta, warned cryptically about certain “streams” that were impinging on regional cultures so that they produce “100% Indonesian” products. National ideology cannot be imposed on arts and culture—doing so would not be “advancing” them, but rather destroying them. National culture should be granted its own arena (*lapangan*) to grow and develop in fitting channels. Implicitly recognizing the failures of Japanese-sponsored pan-Asianism, Surjohamidjojo said that beyond this national culture there would one day also be an organically formed “Greater East Asian culture, pure and beautiful” (quoted in Yamin 1971, 317).

Two emblematic artistic productions mounted in 1945 look backward at the great kingdoms of Java and Sumatra and forward to future glory, capturing the transitional mood and some of the anxieties of the last months of occupation. The first was the play *Mekar bunga Madjapahit* (The blossoming of Majapahit’s flower) by Rustam Sutan Palindih, which was produced by the sandiwara wing of Persafi (Persatoean Artis Film Indonesia [Indonesian Film Artist Union]) under the direction of R. Inoe Perbatasari at Jakarta’s old schouwburg theater in June 1945. The play retells the familiar Damar Wulan story. The playwright states in his play’s introduction that he intended to depict the Majapahit kingdom when it was past its peak. This historical blossom of civilization has wilted. The bloom will soon fall to the earth, but out of it will emerge new life. The play is thus instructive: collapse does not portend final defeat, because within it are the seeds of victory.

Palindih's play begins in the midst of civil war. Majapahit has been divided into a number of rival countries, alluding to the tripartite division of Indonesia under the Japanese, and is now threatened with destruction. Its survival depends on the return of Raden Gajah, the great hero, who is in fact Damar Wulan under another name. But Damar Wulan is uncertain whether the kingdom and its misguided leaders are worth defending against its enemies: "Majapahit has become weak and chaotic as its people are not respected, and are insulted, extorted, tricked, maltreated" (Palindih 1949, 27). Damar Wulan's introspective and ascetic tendencies, given such focus in Sanoesi Pané's earlier treatment, are here given short shrift, as in this exchange of the play's clown-servants:

Naya Genggong: He once meditated at Paluh Amba.

Sabda Palon: To contemplate the lifepath of this strange world?

Naya Genggong: This fake world!

Sabda Palon: Many in this world are fakes (22).

Anjasmara, Damar Wulan's beloved, urges action, not contemplation. "What is the first thing one gives to a starving person? Moral instruction?" (29). Damar Wulan eventually enters the fray and successfully vanquishes Majapahit's external enemies, only to be defeated by internal politics and sentenced to death. The play ends with a prayer from the noble Menak Koncar: "At some point in the future Majapahit will reincarnate in a New World, in the hands of a people with the *semangat* of Raden Gajah" (77). A review in the Jakarta daily *Asia Raya* highlighted the play's depiction of Majapahit's "high-ranking officials who only think of their own profits and hunger for influence and power" to the detriment of the people under these so-called leaders.¹⁰ Such a critique of leadership, except when narrowly targeting the colonial imperialists, would have been unthinkable earlier in the occupation.

The other emblematic production was *Gending Sriwijaya*, first performed at a political rally in Palembang in early August 1945. This song, with lyrics by the local politician Noengtjik A. R. (later to head Palembang's propaganda department) and music by the local composer Ahmad Dahlan Mahibat, was performed by the band of a local sandiwara troupe with a characteristically hybrid orchestration of "singer, *viol* (viola), guitars, harmonium, saxophone, trombone, double bass, *gendang* (two-headed drum), and jazz drum set" (Kartomi 1993, 40). The melody consciously evokes the traditional *kromongan* gong-chime ensemble associated with the Palembang palace, and its lyrics are a paean for Sumatra's glorious past:

I sing a tune again, the song Sriwijaya
 In art I enjoy again that happy era
 I recreate from the womb of that great time
 Sriwijaya with the great hermitages of the glorious masters (Kartomi
 1993, 37).¹¹

The song and the associated all-female line dance routine created later in the 1940s are today key symbols of Palembang local identity. Some apparently believe that this song-and-dance routine is a survival of the ancient Srivijaya kingdom (Taal 2002, 191), but more generally its creation is recollected in oral tradition as a subversive act of resistance against the Japanese (Kartomi 2012, 186). In fact the ritual recollection of the *semangat* of Srivijaya as inspiration to overturn hundreds of years of colonial oppression was a well-established propaganda trope under the Japanese, tapping into both colonial archaeology and prewar nationalism. Noengtjik himself appears to have been a leader in the Angkatan Pemoeda Sriwidjaja (Sriwijaya Youth Group), a political organization active before the war.¹²

Gending Sriwijaya likely became noteworthy as a traditionalist song-and-dance routine in part because of the propitious occasion at which it was first presented. It was performed during an official visit by a lecture tour group (*rombongan pedato berkeliling*) led by West Sumatran educational reformist Moehammad Sjafei to unveil the Japanese authorities' plans for a Sumatra-wide Committee for the Preparation for Indonesian Independence (Panitia Persiapan Kemerdekaan Indonesia) under Sjafei's leadership. Sjafei lectured the assembled masses on Japan's commitment to fostering the development of an independent Indonesia. After his eleven-day tour of South and Central Sumatra, he reported that (1) his delegation was respectfully received by both the people and the Japanese administrators everywhere they visit; (2) "the people's desire for independence was demonstrated by oaths to sacrifice their blood and souls"; (3) all layers of society are united; and (4) the people and government are also united, demonstrated by how the people helped the military and government in their affairs.¹³ *Gending Sriwijaya* built on the groundwork Sjafei himself had laid for the pedagogical arts (discussed in Chapter 9) and illustrates all four of Sjafei's points.

Indonesia's declaration of independence came much quicker than expected, only days after the bombing of Hiroshima and Nagasaki and the August 15 surrender of Japan to the Allies. On the morning of August 17, Sukarno stood on the front porch of his house in central Jakarta before a crowd of five hundred and read a short proclamation of freedom, with his political ally Hatta at his side. This was a performative speech act par excellence. Although the handwritten draft of the

proclamation attributes the document to *wakil-wakil bangsa Indonesia* (representatives of the Indonesian people), neither Sukarno nor others consulted possessed an official mandate.¹⁴ Sukarno's personal charisma and oratorical power made the words he uttered after the declaration—"So, Brothers! We are now free! Our nation and people are no longer bound by colonialism!"—believable and actual to Indonesians around the archipelago. Sukarno was, of course, an employee of the propaganda department during the occupation. Capitalizing on the recognition achieved through his many public speeches and media appearances during the occupation, and using the house his former overlords had given him as backdrop and stage, Sukarno performed independence and made it real.

The elaborate cultural infrastructure built up during the occupation was dismantled in the weeks ahead. Kōa Bunka Kaikan, a Japanese cultural center with branches in Jakarta and Surabaya, placed ads in the Jakarta newspapers in the last two weeks of August and first week of September to publicize that its courses would no longer meet, announced a public graduation ceremony for its students in its Japanese-language courses, and released plans to distribute gratis the library's Japanese-language books. Iida Nobuo, among the first *bunkajin* to arrive in Java and the last to leave, conducted a farewell Konsert Gembira (Happy Concert) on 1 and 2 September with a bill of light classics—Beethoven's Symphony No. 6 (Pastoral), Grieg's *Peer Gynt* suite, Johann Strauss's waltz *Vienna Life*, and the overture of Rossini's opera *Semiramide*—at the entertainment center Tokio Gekidjo, as Deca Park had been renamed during the Japanese occupation.¹⁵ A group of 151 puppeteers from all over Kediri who had been boarding in a school dormitory in Banjaran for a fifteen-day wayang course since the middle of August were informed by Japanese military propagandist Naiseibuchō of the war's end. At the graduation ceremony, Naiseibuchō expressed his hopes that the puppeteers would return to their places of origin to inform villagers of the war's end and of peace, and that their puppetry studies would be useful in this regard. One of the course's puppetry teachers responded on behalf of the puppeteers. He vowed that they would propagate the fruits of their learning and offer guidance to the poor. The puppeteers then received diplomas and sarongs as parting gifts.¹⁶ The painter Sudjojono recalled paying a final visit with Cornel Simandjoentak to the Cultural Center, where Sanoesi Pané was minding the shop. Cornel crassly demanded that "*Meneer*" Sanoesi hand over the key to the safe and close his eyes as they walked out with 60,000 rupiah—to be used for the revolution to come (Sudjojono quoted in Lapien 1988, 83).

Conclusion

Performing Arts after Colonialism

The artists and intellectuals who debated Indonesia's national culture into existence were faced with a central paradox for postcolonial praxis: "how to become modern and to return to sources; how to revive an old, dormant civilization and take part in universal civilization" (Ricoeur [1995] 2006, 47). This was a generation of Indonesians—wondrously recalled in Rudolf Mrázek's sepia-tinged colloquy, *A Certain Age: Colonial Jakarta through the Memories of Its Intellectuals* (2010)—who escaped "the grip of the past" (cf. Shils 1981, 36) and the impositions of traditional society by their early exit into Dutch-language formal education in Batavia and other cities of Indonesia and Holland. The "native intellectual," as depicted in Franz Fanon's 1959 essay "On National Culture,"

only has exterior relations with his people, he is content to recall their life only. Past happenings of the bygone days of his childhood will be brought up out of the depths of his memory; old legends will be reinterpreted in the light of a borrowed aestheticism and of a conception of the world which was discovered under other skies. [. . .] Anxiously trying to create a cultural work [. . .], he fails to realize that he is utilizing techniques and language which are borrowed from the stranger in his country. He contents himself with stamping these instruments with a hall-mark which he wishes to be national, but which is strangely reminiscent of exoticism. ([1961] 1994, 41)

Seen in this light it is no wonder why the educated Indonesian, Japanese, and Korean artists, intellectuals, bureaucrats, and *bunkajin* who congregated at the Cultural Center found common ground so readily in conceptualizing and implementing national culture, traditional and modern arts, civilization, and the East–West division. They were exotes with solidly modern cultural credentials, distanced from folk arts and cultural legacies. They held variant degrees of nostalgia for the collective and social forms of tradition, and they differed in the value they placed on "individual experience and individual protest" (cf. Jameson

1976, 108). There were fundamental differences also in their geopolitics and respect for Japanese culture. But they did not contest the dichotomy between traditional and modern societies. All took as given that, without their active intervention, tradition was essentially static, bound by cultural horizons, with little differentiation. Together, they worked through the arts to achieve a “modern society, culturally dynamic, oriented to change and innovation” (Eisenstadt 1973, 1). To enable this transition to modernity, they perceived that it was incumbent on them, as intellectual and artistic leaders, to modify and transpose elements of traditional practices (cf. C. Taylor 1999, 162). They were aware that national unity was a cultural accomplishment that had to be “achieved daily anew” (Bauman 2000, 178).

The question facing us now is “what to do—when modernity has become a polemical or suspect project—with this mixture of heterogeneous memory and truncated innovations” (Canclini 1995, 3). There is little use in limning the history of performing arts in colonial Indonesia if doing so only serves initiatives to revive past repertoires, enables projects to conserve artistic tools and spaces, or furthers schemes to restore past aesthetic norms. The disinterring of history will not sustain future creativity if this exercise merely buttresses an argument for Indonesia’s unique experience of modernity under the frameworks of “Asian modernity” or “multiple modernities.” For as Arif Dirlik points out, “‘multiple modernities’ suggests a global multiculturalism that reifies cultures in order to render manageable cultural and political incoherence—diversity management on a global scale, so to speak” (2007, 81). Rather, excavating and problematizing the colonial past might serve to refurbish the public sphere and provide points of orientation for future creativity through inculcating historicity, “the use of knowledge about the past as a means of breaking with it—or, at any rate, only sustaining what can be justified in a principled manner” (Giddens [1990] 1991, 50). Some seven decades after colonialism’s end, the performing arts are “simultaneously free from, and yet connected to and perhaps even haunted by, the legacies of the past in the present,” to cite Harry Elam’s discourse on “post-blackness” (2005, 382). But before considering the colonial period’s artistic legacy, altermodernity, and a recent flowering of retro heritage, let me tie up a few loose ends here. Chapter 11’s cliffhanger ending of the appropriation of the Cultural Center’s cash reserves by Indonesian revolutionaries may leave some readers eager to learn the fate of the Japanese occupation’s principal cultural actors and institutions. Others may wish to know how the performing arts were decolonized and fared under incipient national modernity. I will endeavor to be brief.

Fast Forward: 1945–1950

Sukarno declared Indonesia's independence in August 1945, but as historian Taufik Abdullah (2009, x) states, "It took about four-and-a-half years of armed and diplomatic struggle before the world recognized the sovereignty of the new nation-state." Both sides—the Indonesian revolutionary forces and the Dutch who were intent on recolonizing Indonesia—mobilized the arts in their efforts, starting with Bert van der Sprong's song "Ons Indonesia" (Our Indonesia). Composed in the Netherlands in July 1945, with "imitation gamelan" figurations on piano and melodies based on familiar kroncong tunes ("Nina bobo" and "Ayun-ayun"), the chorus nostalgically evokes colonial cuisine: "Our Indonesia, so delicious there, yes. With rice and [cooked] vegetables, hot sauce and porridge. [. . .] I wish I was there." One can only imagine the effects of this song on the salivary glands of Dutch colonials after five years of deprivation under German occupation and the inducement the song consequently gave to reoccupy "our" Indonesia.

The Dutch Orientalist memory of Indonesia was of toadying native elites and disorganized masses. Neither the returned colonizers nor the Allied forces that initially supported them were aware of the advances in Indonesian nationalism, anti-imperialism, and militarization that occurred under Japanese occupation. Indonesian artists and intellectuals who had collaborated with the Japanese well understood the power of propaganda and turned to the arts to stoke *semangat* for the revolution, invent forms for unisonance, and undermine Dutch claims to authority and power. Some artists, including poet Chairil Anwar, thought it best to forget the fascist past:

The [. . .] "Cultural Center" [. . .] made possible the development of strictly Greater Asian "art"—castor oil—cotton—increasing farm yields—Indonesians driven to Japan as coolies—put your pennies in the piggy bank—ship-building and all the rest. And also young artists turned into disciplined shock troops, within the confines of Greater Asian-ness, often powerfully confined with those limits!!! They were not allowed to know that hundreds of European artists (German, Italians), and even Japanese, when confronted with these spiritual (and physical) risks, [. . .] thought it better not to write than to do violence to truth and progress. (Anwar quoted in Raffel 1967, 228)

There was general agreement, however, about the need to reach out to the rest of the world to demonstrate that the revolutionaries were not Japanese puppets, but autonomous and proud possessors of their own culture and civilization.

Former members of Chairil Anwar's "New Generation" group at the Cultural Center started contributing to the struggle within days of the declaration of Indonesian independence. Under the leadership of Usmar Ismail, they commandeered a truck, which was used as a stage for dramatic sketches and songs explaining the significance of independence to the masses of Jakarta, in the mode of the occupation's mobile propaganda units. They called themselves *Seniman Merdeka*—which can be translated either as "Independent Artists" (stressing their break from the *Sendenbu*) or "Artists for Independence" (emphasizing their mission). The group disbanded after the Dutch reoccupied Jakarta with the assistance of the British armed forces. Members of the New Generation group also joined the partisan forces. Kotot Sukardi became a battalion leader. Cornel Simandjoentak was shot in the leg and died of tuberculosis in a sanatorium outside of Yogyakarta in 1946.

Inspired by Anwar's call for "vitality" in art, this group of young artists, remembered as Angkatan '45 (the Generation of '45), threw themselves into the struggle for independence, composing songs and painting at the front and staging dramas that gave models for heroism and expressed aspirations for self-determination. The most influential performing artist perhaps was Ismail Marzuki, a *kroncong* musician who had achieved some fame as a film composer before World War II.¹ He wrote his stirring and sentimental songs in response to actual events. Famously, Marzuki's march *Hallo-hallo Bandung* (1946) is a commemoration of the withdrawal of partisan forces from Bandung in March 1946, when strategic facilities in the southern part of the city were incinerated so that they would not fall into the hands of the enemy. Addressing the city in the second-person *kau*, and listeners in the intimate form of *bung* (brother), the song looks ahead to Bandung's reoccupation. "You are now a sea of fire but come on, *bung*, let's win her back" (Mintargo 2008, 89).² Other composers, including Cornel and Kusbini, rewrote romantic songs from the Japanese occupation and composed new songs in this idiom.

Anti-Dutch refugees from around Java and other Indonesian islands streamed into Yogyakarta, where the sultan welcomed them. Yogyakarta was declared the capital of the independent Republic of Indonesia, and its cultural infrastructure developed quickly. Large-scale *sandiwara* groups made Yogyakarta their base; amateur drama groups blossomed; independent workshops and studios (known at the time as *atelier* and later as *sanggar*) for the study of the arts developed; playwrights and directors, including Andjar Asmara, Usmar Ismail, and Armijn Pané, gravitated there and wrote new plays and theoretical texts. Many attempts were made to coordinate the diverse artistic activities in areas of Java under republican control. Various unions starting with the *Persatuan Usaha Sandiwara*

Indonesia (Indonesian Sandiwara Union) were proposed, but all failed, in part because they were viewed as being continuous with Japanese fascist organizations such as POSD. Indonesian youths around the archipelago were suspicious of all sorts of authority and called for the overturning of traditional structures.

Hinatsu Eitarō was one of the few *bunkajin* who elected to throw his lot in with the republicans and remain in Indonesia. Hinatsu, who changed his name after the war to Dr. Huyung (a transliteration of his Korean name), had been an authoritarian figure at POSD. He is said to have interrogated Kusbini about *which* country was pledged loyalty in the well-known anthem “Bagimu neg’ri” (For you, my country)—Kusbini was released only because he persisted in claiming that the country was Japan (Mintargo 2008, 51). But, as Hinatsu explained to a Korean colleague,

You [Koreans] all came here [to Indonesia] in a group to work for the Japanese military. But I on my own initiative persuaded the Korean Colonial Government to make [the film] *You and I* with the support of the Colonial Military Forces. Everyone knows about *You and I*. Everyone knows that Hae Young and Hinatsu Eitarō are one and the same. And in addition to that, my Korean isn’t even that good. I’m a Korean who knows almost nothing about Korean history other than what little I studied about in Tokyo. [. . .] If I returned to Japan now there wouldn’t be any jobs for me and if I returned to Korea, I’d most likely be branded a Japanese collaborator. (quoted in Baskett 2008, 89)

Dr. Huyung settled in Yogyakarta, where he wrote and directed plays in collaboration with Djadug Djajakusuma, and in 1948 established the Stichting Hiburan Mataram (Mataram Entertainment Foundation), which staged plays and put on other cultural events in Yogyakarta. He also founded the Cine Drama Institute and Kino Drama Atelier, independent Indonesia’s first college and high school for the arts, respectively, with backing from the Ministry of Information. Though their high-profile faculty included Ki Hadjar Dewantara, Armijn Pané, and Kusbini, both educational institutions were short-lived due to internal politics and the vicissitudes of revolution.

The different branches of the arts had fared unevenly under the Japanese (cf. Alisjahbana [1978] 2008, 193–194). Sandiwara and art music composed in the European style forged ahead during the Japanese occupation, but the traditional arts were relatively underdeveloped. The same remained the case during the revolutionary years. The young people who steered the Republic subsidized modern artists, but intentionally ignored traditional artists in the regions (Rosidi 1995,

18–19). Kridha Beksa Wirama was closed between 1945 and 1948, and other schools of traditional dance were similarly inactive or closed. Blackouts and the imposition of curfews meant that many traditional art forms could be performed in only a truncated fashion. Yet, kethoprak continued to draw large crowds, which some intellectuals interpreted as a worrying sign of nativism and a lack of commitment to the revolutionary struggle for national unity. There were calls to overturn tradition and renovate a dramatic art that had “relaxed into decadence.”³ The Sundanese writer M. A. Salmoen complained of the vacuity of Sundanese puppeteers who performed *ramai* (lively) plays without philosophical content. He claimed that wayang no longer offered a spiritual education, whereby a spectator could reflect and make corrections to his or her self-identity through wayang’s struggle of Evil versus Good. Salmoen asserted that in the Sundanese highlands there were plenty of performers capable of playing with wayang puppets, but no true *dalang* with mastery of wayang lore could now be found (Salmoen 1949, 272). Salmoen’s many publications on wayang in the 1940s and 1950s were arguably his attempt to rectify this situation.

There were sporadic efforts to use traditional arts as propaganda media to disseminate republican messages to the largely illiterate folk of Java’s countryside. *Wayang suluh* (“torch” wayang) was an official project of the Ministry of Information launched in 1947 at a youth congress in Yogyakarta (Kementerian Penerangan 1953a, 841–849; Mylius 1961, 96–103). This new genre of shadow puppetry enacted anticolonial struggles of the past (the rebellions led by Diponegoro or Untung Surapati), as well as key moments in the Indonesian revolution (the Battle of Surabaya, the Linggarjati Agreement). Fifty-two sets of shadow puppets, with figures such as a Red Cross nurse and President Sukarno, were distributed to puppeteers around Java. Wayang suluh performers were expected to keep up with current national and international politics, economics, labor conditions, and military affairs in order to be effective agents. A standard opening narration (*jan-turan*) explained how Indonesia was an independent nation located between Asia and Australia, rich in natural resources, democratic, and under the rule of law, with a red-and-white flag symbolizing bravery and purity, a stirring national anthem titled “Indonesia raya” that brings listeners to their feet, a respected president assisted by a vice president and ministers and other government officials all the way down to the village heads, and political party leaders who also help the president and develop the country and are unanimous in their belief that “once Independent, forever Independent” (*sekali Merdeka, tetap Merdeka*). Performances were to be limited to two to four hours, which meant dispensing with wayang’s traditional *pathet* (mode) structure. Puppeteers could adjust their musical accompaniment to audience taste—for example, by foregoing the use of

a gamelan so as not to offend orthodox Muslim ears or using Western musical instruments to reach out to foreigners.⁴

More organic in its origin and with greater affective power was an autobiographical song in the mournful *katoneng-katoneng* improvisational song genre by the Karo Batak singer Sinek beru Karo. This song, which lacks a title, describes Sinek's forced evacuation from a settlement on the outskirts of Medan because of Dutch military aggression and her wandering through East Sumatra in 1947. As Mary Steedly (2000, 838) emphasizes in her eloquent analysis, the song downplays elements of individual experience in order to resonate with "the common experiences of Karo refugees: displacement, terror, radical uncertainty, the heartache and freedom of modern homelessness." The improvised lyrics tap a rich oral tradition: "Scattered everywhere / like millet when it's threshed / the breath of some turned to wind / those already broken were broken again, brother / there were many ways of dying for our brothers who defended the nation" (828). The musical idiom's rapid-fire drums, squawking double-reeded *sarune*, rhythmically insistent gongs, and plaintive vocals (the genre derives from funerary singing) grant the song immediacy, indeed urgency and anxiety. The song was recorded in the 1950s and was still circulating in cassette form when Steedly conducted her fieldwork in the 1980s.

Under the Japanese, Indonesians were at liberty to explore national identity and commonalities with other Asian nations under the Greater Asian framework, but had been cut off from global cultural flows. There was now the desire for what Sukarno (quoted in C. Geertz 1973, 319) called *ke-up-to-date-an*: catching up on advances in European and American culture, developing new cultural repertoires, and asserting Indonesia's cultural place in the world. Angus Gillan, head of the British Council's Empire Division, toured Indonesia and other parts of Southeast Asia in October–December 1946 to assess possibilities for opening British Council offices in those locations. He concluded, "Three and a half years under Japanese domination and the difficult period after the Japanese withdrawal has resulted in increased political and educational aspirations, and a fuller sense of independence. The desire to renew old ties with the West is still there but on a different basis."⁵

The Japanese had forbidden the playing of jazz because it was perceived as an "African-American music" and a form of "Anglo-Saxon decadence" (Pasaribu 1955, 73). But the arrival of American, British, Dutch, and Australian soldiers in Indonesia to round up Japanese soldiers, confiscate weapons, evacuate Europeans, and reinstate Dutch colonial rule meant a return of American popular music, and it was not long before Jakarta was jitterbugging away in restaurants, night and day.

The Union of Art Circles (*kunstkringen*) was reestablished to support European artistic activities and bring foreign artists to Indonesia. The Radio Philharmonic Orchestra was formed in 1948, with all the musicians shipped over from the Netherlands to Jakarta at great expense. That same year Jozef Cleber, a trombonist in Radio Batavia's house band, formed a dance band called the Cosmopolitan Orchestra. Dutch concert pianist Geza Frid, who toured Indonesia in early 1949 under Union sponsorship, advised of the "necessity" of setting up a conservatory in Jakarta for the many talented pianists, violinists, and singers who could not afford European tuition (Frid 1949, 99). Thus the Dutch were rooting down in Indonesia, with no intention of leaving.

The Dutch foundation STICUSA (Stichting voor Culturele Samenwerking) was formed in 1948 to enable cultural exchange between the Netherlands and Indonesia. Indonesians were suspicious from the start of STICUSA's claim to being a "pure channel" without ulterior motivation by which "the best products of European culture" might be made "accessible in Indonesia" and vice versa (Dolk 2012, 63). As a result, STICUSA had only limited success in forging cultural relations with Indonesian artists. Its Jakarta representative Oscar Mohr invited Tapanuli-born musician Amir Pasaribu to accompany him on an expedition to study the folk songs of his native area in 1949. (The expedition accidentally strayed into conflict-rife Aceh, and the party was almost killed.) STICUSA funded Usmar Ismail to study film and theater in Amsterdam. Raden Mas Jodjana's dance film *God Shiva* (1955) was produced with STICUSA money. But generally artists and intellectuals were wary of collaborating with STICUSA, stamped by novelist Pramoedya Ananta Toer as a "colonial brain trust" (quoted in Dolk 2012, 72); in fact, Jodjana's film sealed his reputation as a Dutch collaborator. STICUSA formally severed its ties with Indonesia in January 1956, though it remained active in supporting cultural exchange with Suriname and other parts of the West Indies.

The Dutch political project to carve up Indonesia into a federation of puppet states, much as the archipelago had been divided under Japanese rule, had its cultural articulations. Cultural centers were envisioned for each state of the United States of Indonesia. Detailed plans were published in July 1949 for a Jajasan Pusat Kebudayaan Indonesia Timur (Foundation for the Cultural Center of East Indonesia), with its headquarters in Makassar's old Fort Rotterdam, the center of Dutch imperial power since its seizure in 1667. In a speech on 5 March 1949, East Indonesia's education minister Jan Engelbert Tatengkeng proclaimed that the foundation "must have connections with Leiden and Amsterdam, Paris and London, New York and Sydney, Cairo and New Delhi. Accept what you are lacking and give back a part of what is yours. "In this way, this Foundation will achieve its

aims, and become a *centrum* [center], that is a center for preserving old culture and developing new culture, and a center for the meeting of world cultures” (quoted in n.a. 1949, 12).

Makassar at this time was the capital of the State of East Indonesia (Negara Indonesia Timur, NIT), comprised of Sulawesi, the islands of Maluku, Western New Guinea, and adjoining islands, arguably the most pro-Dutch of the federal states, and it is noteworthy that its Cultural Center project survived in a modified form the dissolution of the United States of Indonesia in 1950.⁶ Yet all the same there was considerable cultural resistance to the Dutch during the revolutionary years, particularly among Makassar’s youth. A student group performed a sandiwara play there in 1948 about the Young Turks’ struggle against absolute monarchy in the Ottoman Empire. The audience had no trouble in reading a “Turkish” greeting as a surrogate for the Indonesian revolutionary salute *Merdeka!* (Independence!). It applauded lines about overthrowing the government and understood immediately that the white costumes and red handkerchiefs of a Torajan folk dance that accompanied the play were an allusion to the Republic’s red-and-white flag.⁷

The United States Information Service (established in Jakarta in 1946), the British Council, STICUSA, the Union of Art Circles, Dutch-sponsored cultural centers, and similar institutions were not the only channels open for international cultural exchange. Artists, intellectuals, and politicians of the revolutionary Republic undertook their own initiatives to translate ideas and contribute to global culture. The postwar influx of European and American books and magazines made Indonesian dramatists acutely aware of recent advances in world theater. The repertoire of plays from Japanese-era playwrights was tainted by fascism and not performable, and earlier generations of popular theater artists had transmitted scripts orally. Because there were thus few scripts available for staging,⁸ efforts were undertaken to translate and produce acknowledged masterpieces of world drama, including Henrik Ibsen’s *An Enemy of the People* (1882) and Rabindranath Tagore’s one-act play *Chitra* (1913). Trisno Sumardjo’s adept translation of *Hamlet* from circa 1947, which still holds up to critical scrutiny (Skupin 2013), was not written for the stage, but rather was meant to enrich Indonesian literature and provide a literary model for Indonesian playwrights. It was regarded as a successful test of the Indonesian language’s ability to translate foreign poetry (Situmorang 1951, 302).

Large-scale sandiwara companies such as Bintang Soerabaja continued to deliver potboiler romances and adventure stories to the masses. Republican playwrights based in Yogyakarta such as Djeliteng Suradji wrote propaganda dramas to provide role models for the revolution. Suradji’s play *Bunga desa* (Village

flower), about a composer who aspires to synthesize Western art and Javanese traditional music and to found a national symphony orchestra, is one such example ([1946] 2010, 147–178). But less tendentious and more psychologically nuanced plays were also being created that responded to international models.

The most important playwright to emerge during the revolutionary period was probably Utuy T. Sontani, who edited republican periodicals before moving to Jakarta in 1948 to work for the state publisher, Balai Pustaka. Sontani's early one-act character study *Bunga rumah makan* (The flower of the restaurant) was published by Balai Pustaka in 1948 and quickly championed by Sandiwara Ganeca, a modern theater ensemble that aspired to elevate Indonesian theater to world-class standards. In this play, a waitress named Ani ignores the calculated romantic advances of the restaurant's owner's son (whose suit is supported by the Islamic platitudes of a religious teacher who is a business partner of the restaurant owner), overcomes her physical attraction to an arrogant army captain, and finally resolves to quit her job and go away with a layabout youth (*pemuda pelancong*) she has just met. She admires this tousle-haired suitor for his truthfulness. "I'd rather be a bum than stay here like you, trading on your beauty and tricking men into spending their money here," he tells her (Sontani [1948] 1980, 29). Sontani's social realist play's dramaturgy and mis-en-scène are as modern as its ideology, with French scenes, interrupting telephone calls, shady business dealings of the restaurant owner that are never fully explained, and a restaurant setting with a radio and refrigerator.

Playwright, poet, and politician Rustam Effendi could still regale an audience at a sandiwara congress in Yogyakarta in 1948 with his observations of theater in the Soviet Union in 1937 (Effendi 1948). But Indonesians were anxious to send out new cultural delegations to share Indonesia's arts with the world, demonstrate their autonomy from Dutch colonialism and Japanese fascism, and gain new cultural knowledge. So Indonesia sent representatives annually to the World Festival of Youth and Students starting in 1947 (Lindsay 2012b, 204). The published song book for the youth choir performing in the 1949 edition of the festival in Budapest includes a familiar mix of patriotic songs like "Hallo-hallo Bandung" and folk song standards, with a particular emphasis on *lagu Ambon* from Maluku (Utusan Indonesia 1949). The Indonesian Information Office, set up in New York to counteract the anti-republican propaganda of the Netherlands Information Agency, organized dance performances under the supervision of Sukoro, a Santiniketan-educated diplomat and amateur dancer who was one of the office's employees. Sukoro sometimes teamed up with another New York-based diplomat, James Imam Pamoedjo, but also worked with the remnants of Devi Dja's dance troupe, as well as Retna Mohini (Cohen 2010, 203).⁹

Articles about Indonesian performing arts regularly featured in *The Voice of Free Indonesia*, an English-language magazine published between 1945 and 1947. The periodical was edited “by men who fight for freedom, justice, goodwill and understanding” and aimed to sway journalists and the diplomatic community to the partisan cause. Articles argued how wayang digests and remolds the Indian epics into an authentically Indonesian cultural expression; how Indonesian dramatists were compelled under duress to perform propaganda plays under the Japanese; how Japanese music was inherently alien to Indonesian culture and left no enduring imprint; and how Indonesia now wished freedom to develop its own culture. A long article surveying Indonesian dance and drama concluded that Indonesia’s variety of expression was proof that

the Indonesian people are a highly emotional nation, endowed with peculiar artistic gifts. Technically and rationally they are primitively equipped, but culturally they have their tradition of centuries old. In this way they can be ranked among other old nations in the world on the same degree of civilization. Indonesia stands on the threshold of a new era, an era of technical development and international cooperation, and it is with the fullest confidence that the Indonesian people, entering the new relationship among nations, based on equality and mutual understanding, will be able to adapt their inner culture to the modern currents of these times. (Soelarko 1946, 71)

Indonesian participation in the Asian Relations Conference hosted by Jawaharlal Nehru in New Delhi in 1947 seems to have been a major inspiration for the first Cultural Congress (Kongres Kebudayaan), held in Magelang on 20–24 August 1948. Invited as observers were Kou Yu Shou, Advisor on Far Eastern Affairs to the Office of the Director General of UNESCO (who had visited Jakarta earlier that month), and representatives from the British, American, and Indian consulates. (Though disappointingly the only foreign attendee to arrive in the end seems to have been the chauffeur of the Indian vice consul.) The Cultural Congress, with its “pre-advice” papers, debates, and conclusions, formally replicated the structure of Java Institute congresses.¹⁰ Philosophically, the Congress also retread ground familiar from the 1930s, with much discussion of how to define culture and art (e.g., “art is the birth of a living desire to understand oneself in beauty”) and synthesize East and West, the universal and particular. But there were some important breaks with the colonial past. The Java Institute had aimed primarily to preserve endangered local traditions and restore cultural relics, and its members fretted about contaminating Western influences. Participants at the

Magelang congress, in contrast, took it as a given that all people of the twentieth century were implicated in cultural exchange and that Indonesian culture would necessarily be influenced by outside nations.

Some speakers were ambivalent about recent artistic experiments in blending regional art forms in the name of nationalism. The example was given of a dance interpolating *srimpi* hand gestures with Malay folk dance footwork—which might be tasty like *gado-gado*, a mixed vegetable salad laced with spicy peanut sauce, but not necessarily art. However crude, such blending should not be automatically condemned because it might germinate into important models in the future. Artists needed to be given maximum latitude to pursue creative innovations, not subjected to a monolithic “system” (Sitompul 1950, 97).

Building on the discourse of New Delhi, speakers alluded to the “world-wide crisis in Western culture,” attributed to too much attention to economic matters, science, and politics and a lack of corresponding progress in the “inner life and consciousness” (Supomo 1948, 9). There was consensus that with Western culture in crisis, the “growth of new Indonesia’s culture can offer valuable assistance to world development in the fields of spirituality and culture” (Majur 1948, 26).

The Magelang Cultural Congress saw some falling out among the old guard. When Ki Hadjar asserted, “Indonesian culture is the essence and peaks of regional cultures, with the addition of modern culture, which is nationally oriented,” Armijn Pané quipped that “the new generation does not want a federative culture, but a single culture. The definition is not able to fulfil our desires now, and means that we are tied to old constructions” (Hadjar quoted in Purbopranoto 1948, 14; Pané translated by Jones 2013, 78). The painter Basuki Resobowo spoke contentiously of “disposing of tradition” (*membuang traditie*), by which, he later explained, he meant discarding sedimented ways of doing and thinking, not disposing of art objects. Younger participants criticized the pre-advice papers for being too theoretical and removed from artistic practice, overly intellectual, and individualistic. “Artists must know the people, and must know which direction our people are going and adjust their creations accordingly,” exclaimed poet-politician Asmara Hadi.

Perhaps even more important than all these words were the performances that concluded the congress, enacted to an audience including President Sukarno and the highest officials of the Republic. These “proofs of productivity in the artistic field, signs that the Indonesian soul was growing and flowering” were staged in the governor’s office, the same location where the rebel Diponegoro had been captured in 1830. The significance was lost on no one. There were old dances from Java and West Sumatra that had been reworked in new versions, Balinese dance

as performed by Javanese Taman Siswa students, and, most impressively, a demonstration of a set of twenty-two instruments called Musik Gentono attributed to the musical inventor Sastrowidatan, which combined features of gamelan and European musical instruments. At this outing, not only Javanese and European music were performed but also songs from China, India, and Egypt. Such an experiment in musical hybridity was of course not without precedent—reference has already been made to the one-man Raras Hadi gamelan—but this modernized gamelan served nonetheless to disturb preconceptions of Javanese tradition's fixity (Dungga and Manik 1952, 109).

An immediate product of the Cultural Congress was the establishment of the Indonesian National Culture Institute (Lembaga Kebudayaan Nasional Indonesia), which had the explicit aim of cooperating with other national cultural institutes, particularly in Asia. However, the Institute's charter document expressed some of the unresolved contradictions displayed by the Cultural Congress. On one hand, the charter defined Indonesian culture broadly as "the spiritual emanation of the Indonesian people which lives and grows among the various communities of all of Indonesia's islands." It was seen as the Institute's mission to "realize and animate" this spirit so that national culture could be "realized, grow, and flower." That is to say, Indonesian culture was viewed as plural and broadly inclusive, and the Institute's mission was to facilitate its organic growth. Sukarno's minister of justice, Supomo (1948, 9), argued that the culture to be supported must be "from the people, by the people, and for the people." But on the other hand the charter defined the Institute's function much more narrowly: it was to "shape cultural values which already pervade Pancasila, so that the spirit of Indonesian culture takes shape." Pancasila, the five-pillared state ideology fashioned in 1945 by Sukarno—with its vague invocations of belief in one God, civilized humanity, the unity of Indonesia, negotiated democracy, and social justice—was to be used frequently as a cultural weapon in decades ahead. Thus there were signs not only of continuity between the Institute and the authoritarian structures of Dutch and Japanese colonialism but also of emancipatory potential. The contradictions embodied in the following statement from the official "explanation" (*pendjelasan*) of the Institute's charter, are difficult to reconcile:

In minding all the products of Indonesian art, and also developing them, we hold onto the Indonesian cultural values already pervasive in Pancasila, and also utilize all valuable elements from all times and places. Through that, we will strengthen the universal character of Indonesian culture in addition to its national character. (Lembaga Kebudayaan Indonesia 1949, 13)

It is fitting that with decolonization in 1950 the Institute took over the operations of the Royal Batavian Society of Arts and Sciences, inheriting the management of its colonial collection of books and museum objects, while finding new ways to conceptualize and manage culture.

Traces of the more internationalist aspirations of the Cultural Congress are to be detected in the Testimonial of Beliefs enunciated by the Gelanggang (Arena) group of artists. Gelanggang, also known as Gelanggang Seniman Merdeka (Independent Artists' Arena), was not an artistic clique or formal organization, but rather a loose coalition of artists and art lovers assembled in 1948 by Chairil Anwar to advance Indonesian art in the spirit of freedom.¹¹ On 18 February 1950, the following credo appeared in the pages of the supplement to its magazine *Gelanggang*: "We are the legitimate heirs to world culture, and we are furthering this culture in our own way" (quoted in Lindsay 2012a, 10). Published a scant fifty-one days after Sukarno was handed the keys to the governor-general's residence, which he renamed Istana Merdeka or "Independence Palace," the Testimonial attests to the confidence of its principal author, the twenty-four-year-old dramatist Asrul Sani, and his Gelanggang confederates in negotiating Indonesian national modernity with world culture. It evidences their conviction in the centrality of arts and culture for shaping the identity of the new nation (10).

There are echoes in Gelanggang's Testament of Sukarno's Pantja Dharma from 1944. But interestingly Aoh K. Hadimadja (1952, 140) heard also reverberations of a prophecy made by British historian Arnold J. Toynbee. At a 1947 lecture at Senate House in London, Toynbee spoke of a "future world which will be neither Western nor non-Western but will inherit all the cultures which we Westerners have now brewed together in a single crucible" (1948, 90).¹² In this talk, which became a chapter in his influential 1948 book *Civilization on Trial*, Toynbee hailed the international students who flowed steadily to universities in Europe and North America. There, Toynbee understood, they gained awareness of the history of Western imperialism and colonialism. This meant that the "victuaries, living contemporaries" of Toynbee's London addressees—"the Chinese and the Japanese, the Hindus and the Muslims, and our elder brothers the Orthodox Christians"—recognize that "*our* past history has become a vital part of *theirs*" (90, 89). "An elite in all the non-Western societies has in fact by now successfully re-educated itself out of its traditional self-centered parochial point of view," stated Toynbee (83).

It remained for us, the academic audience addressed by Toynbee, to grasp the "manifest truth" (1948, 90) that the locus of power was shifting eastward and that once-partitioned cultures and histories had merged in the aftermath of more than four centuries of colonial expansion. "A readjustment of historical outlook" and

“a corresponding revision of methods of historical study” (90) were required. It was necessary to transcend the West’s parochial vision of its own history, which has little import “on its own account” (94) and to examine how Western modernity has served to unify cultures and societies of the world. The intention behind this book, in line with Gelanggang’s credo, was to articulate such a “change in historical perspective,” in Toynbee’s terms.

After independence

The 1951 founding of LEKRA (Lembaga Kebudayaan Rakyat, the Institute of People’s Culture)—the powerful cultural association that took its guidance from the PKI (Partai Komunis Indonesia, the Communist Party of Indonesia)—and the linkage of the arts to political parties that was to dominate the cultural sphere through 1965 prevented a broad-based coalition such as Gelanggang from emerging after independence. Armijn Pané and other nationalist intellectuals worried whether the modern construct of Indonesian culture would survive the transition to independence or whether it would be overwhelmed by nativist movements.

There was critical outcry against the film version of Pané’s play *Antara bumi dan langit* (Between heaven and Earth), retitled *Frieda* (1951), because of its cross-racial kiss between an Indonesian man and Eurasian woman. The “scandalous” kiss, intended to demonstrate inclusivity, was accused of being a sign of Americanization and an affront to Islam and Indonesian traditional values. This film and a long essay where he situated *Frieda* in a history of Indonesian film as a field of acculturation (drawing on anthropological theories of Melvin J. Herskovits) were to be Pané’s last significant contributions to Indonesian culture (A. Pané 1953b; Foulcher 1998). The film’s director, Dr. Huyung, went on to make three more films, including an adaptation of Sontani’s play *The Flower of the Restaurant*, before his death in 1952.¹³

Other major figures in performing arts also receded from view or moved from live theater into film as the large-scale sandiwara companies folded. Njoo Cheong Seng retired to Malang, where he was active in amateur Chinese community arts. Andjar Asmara returned to a career in journalism and was thereafter involved in theater only sporadically (Cohen 2010, 204–205). Usmar Ismail followed up his STICUSA fellowship with a Rockefeller fellowship to study film in the United States, Europe, Egypt, and Asia and later emerged as Indonesia’s most prolific and highly regarded film director.

Under the “tense conjunction of cultural conservatism and political radicalism” (C. Geertz 1973, 320) of Sukarno’s presidency, the traditional arts flourished

as never before. Musical, dance, dramatic, and puppetry traditions of Java, Bali, Sumatra, Sulawesi, and other islands, which had been relatively neglected during the 1940s, benefited from generous state patronage. Sukarno viewed traditional performance as a diplomatic tool to demonstrate Indonesia's cultural sophistication to the world. Multiethnic troupes were assembled and rehearsed in "training centers," and cultural missions sent abroad offered traditionally trained artists unique opportunities to learn from each other (Lindsay 2012b). Young performers became quickly adept at detraditionalizing and aestheticizing ritual arts for inclusion in pan-Indonesian programs. One of the most accomplished was the Buginese dance artist Andi Nurhani Sapada, famous for her condensed version of the ritual dance *pakarena* (Sutton 2002, 48–68).

KOKAR (Konservatori Karawitan Indonesia), a high school for gamelan and related performing arts, was established in Surakarta in 1950 to elevate and develop the arts "inherited from our ancestors" (Kementerian Penerangan 1953c, 452). Although KOKAR's focus was on the court arts of Surakarta, students also were exposed to music and dance from Bali, Sumatra, and other islands; Javanese folk traditions; and new compositional forms and techniques. Comparable conservatories at both the secondary and tertiary level were established subsequently in Yogyakarta, Denpasar, Bandung, Padangpanjang, Makassar, and Surabaya. Private dance *sanggar* multiplied in both urban and rural locations. The innovative gamelan composer Ki Wasitodipuro composed monumental tone poems on nationalist themes for gamelan, chorus, and soloists, as well as popular nationalist songs (J. Becker 1980, 37–65).

Another book would be required to deal with the six decades of artistic developments that followed these early years of independence. Some of these developments include social realism and LEKRA's patronage of the arts; translation of European dramaturgical and acting models; the rise of Islamic theater; infatuation with and resistance to American pop culture; the Cold War courting of artists by Russia and the United States; folkloristic dance and music on national and international stages and the creation of *sendratari* (dance-drama) spectacles; the depoliticization of art under Soeharto's New Order and the killing, imprisonment, and banning of "implicated" artists; artistic experimentation with tradition in the conservatories and the national arts center Taman Ismail Marzuki starting in the late 1960s; expressions of regional identity and the monitoring and codification of the traditional arts; centralized arts organizations including the national wayang associations Pepadi and Senawangi; arts festivals and competitions and the decline of regional diversity; cultural tourism; audiocassettes, television, and other mass media; rock, heavy metal, reggae, and other globalized forms of popular music; the expanding study of gamelan and allied arts abroad; absurdist

physical theater and contemporary dance; the emergence of hybrid music and dance styles drawing on Arabic and Indian popular culture, including *dangdut*; multinational recording companies and music videos; new and imported Islamic arts; Broadway-style musicals; ASEAN collaborations and cultural strife with Malaysia; intangible cultural heritage discourse and preservation projects; iconoclasm and moral panics; arts activism and networks, including alliances against the Sharia-inspired Anti-Pornography and Porno-Action draft bill; resurgent Chinese arts; video art, performance art, and installation art practices and formations; community and participatory arts; and international festivals and global, multi-arts collaborations. Rigorous academic research has been conducted on some of these topics, though much remains to be done.

Staging Colonial Modernity Today

In the estimation of Benedict Anderson (2008, 52–55), an enduring legacy of the New Order has been “national amnesia.” A sweeping orthographic reform was carried out early in the regime, which had the side effect of making all reading materials published before 1972 ideologically suspect. Simultaneously, the Chinese were pressured to Indonesianize their names and stop using the Chinese language in public. Caricature figures of the colonial past—lascivious Dutch overlords, noble victims of forced labor (*kerja paksa*), haughty and aloof kings and princes, bold freedom fighters—were reproduced endlessly in popular martial arts films, stage dramas, and school textbooks, while the colonial period’s debates, ethical uncertainties, opportunities, and dilemmas were erased or forgotten.

Much of the built environment, material culture, and cultural forms of the colonial past survive in Indonesia today, but the texts holding the keys to understanding this heritage are unavailable. There is not only enjoyment to be taken from the past; there is also a lack of regard for history’s “ruthless discipline of context” (E. P. Thompson quoted in Appadurai 1996, 17) in the recent flourishing of *tempo dulu* nostalgia for the cultural forms of late colonialism seen in heritage societies, films with colonial settings such as *Ca-Bau-Kan* (2002) and *Soegija* (2012), collective *plezier*-full excursions to “old town” quarters, dress-up events, themed cafés, calls for preservation of “deco” architecture, and “nostalgia markets” (*pasar kangen*) (Sastramidjaja 2010).¹⁴ Remnants of Indonesia’s modern past have been branded as retro heritage—“identity in tractable, alienable form” (Comaroff and Comaroff 2009, 10).

There are, nevertheless, performing artists both in Indonesia and abroad engaged in rigorous, extended dialogues with the colonial past to enrich present creativity and shed historical light on the contemporary. Starting in the 1970s,

director-playwright Nano Riantiarno has conscientiously studied the popular Malay-language theaters of the late colonial period—komedi stambul, bangsawan, tonil. Through his wide reading and discussions with earlier generations of practitioners, he has derived dramaturgical models for his own theatrical practice. While drawing in equal measure on the musical theater of Bertolt Brecht and Kurt Weill, he calls his plays for his company Teater Koma *opera* as a nod to the Malay operas of his predecessors. Nano Riantiarno and his wife Ratna, who is Teater Koma's producer and principal actress, speak of their company as *teater urban*—"urban theater"—and their development of an urban, middle-class public is inspired by the business models of the large-scale tonil companies of the 1920s and 1930s, particularly Dardanella.¹⁵ Nano Riantiarno's memory play, *Opera primadona* (1988), also adapted into a television miniseries and novel, centers on the rivalry between Dardanella and Miss Riboet's Orion. It is not only a meditation on life in the theater and changing aesthetic norms but is also a primer on past acting styles and staging practices, offering embodied access to the theatrical past.¹⁶

Sardono W. Kusumo, a traditionally trained Javanese dancer, choreographer, and filmmaker, works in a contemporary and intracultural idiom and has enjoyed international acclaim since his Avignon debut in 1973 (Murgiyanto 1993). Sardono's standing has allowed him to explore sensitive issues of environmental depredation, the representation of ethnicity and race, and neocolonialism in collaborative artworks. Sardono can be considered, in the terms of French curator Nicolas Bourriaud (2009), as an "altermodern" artist who draws deeply on an intimate knowledge of Javanese tradition while producing contemporary work that resonates with diverse global art forms he has encountered in his constant traveling. Sardono's dance theater work *Opera Diponegoro* (1995) is a critical intervention in global culture and politics. Produced in 1995 for the first Art Summit Indonesia, Sardono has revamped it regularly since, responding to changing casts of collaborators and political conditions of the time. In the informed analysis of Sumarsam (2013, 73), it is a work centrally concerned with collective representation and simultaneously an intensely personal, "liminoid" artwork that makes free use of a shifting stock of symbols of Javanese and world culture. Action unfolds within the space of colonial representation—in front of a projected image of the famous painting, *The Arrest of Diponegoro* (1857), by the European-trained Javanese painter Raden Saleh. Performances within this frame not only replicate colonial gestures and postures but also contest and even negate past inequalities and postcolonial legacies. Arts associated with the colonial period, such as wayang wong and langendriya, are pastiched *tanztheater*-style.

The 2010 production of *Opera Diponegoro* begins strikingly with the anguished contortions of Mugiyono, a traditionally trained Javanese dancer, to the

strains of the “Introitus” of Mozart’s *Requiem in D Minor*. Encircled by ropes and stripped to a loincloth, the dancer struggles against abjection and bondage by the Dutch imperialists depicted by Saleh in the projected painting, figuratively fighting against imprisonment by the chains of the past.¹⁷ This beginning differs strikingly from that in the 1995 version witnessed by Sumarsam (2013); then, before the play began, Sardono canvassed audience opinion about his portrayal of painter Raden Saleh. Recalling the Soeharto regime’s rhetoric of governing by “deliberation and consensus” (*musyawarah-mufakat*), Sardono asked his audience, “In the era of democracy, it is important that I ask the opinion of many people. . . . As Raden Saleh, should I wear a mustache or not?” After his quick survey, Sardono concluded, “Thank you for your opinion, because all opinions should be respected. I value your opinions, but I must insist that I will carry out my own opinion alone—Raden Saleh does not wear a mustache.” Audience laughter demonstrated a clear understanding of the hidden transcript in this meta-theatrical maneuver (Sumarsam 2013, 54).

In a *New York Times* interview conducted while rehearsing *Opera Diponegoro*’s 2002 production, Sardono protested the global neo-imperialism of George W. Bush’s “war on terror” by identifying strategically with Diponegoro as a villager who “related to the local culture and [. . .] transformed the Muslim religion into a more humanistic platform.”¹⁸ Tradition-based Javanese dancer Eko Supriyanto acted in this version as a Bush surrogate, riding a *kuda kepong* hobby-horse and wearing a cowboy hat and sunglasses. The dancer shouted directives into his mobile phone, threatening to jail Indonesian jihadi Abu Bakar Bashir in Singapore and promising to send troops to the Philippines to fight Islamic separatists.

Jompet Kuswidananto’s installation *Grand Parade*, which occupied the monumental Light Hall of Amsterdam’s Tropical Museum for five months in 2014–2015, similarly staged a confrontation of contrasting ideologies, cultures, and histories. In this installation, Jompet, an altermodern, contemporary visual artist who also works as a scenographer with the Yogyakarta experimental theater company Teater Garasi, recycles the sounds and spectacles of the politicized present in dialogue with Java’s colonial past. Like Sardono, his work breaches colonialist doctrines of authenticity, overturns “postcolonial exotic” (Huggan 2001) preconceptions, and trumpets its relevance to diverse global audiences, furthering world culture in its own ways.

In *Grand Parade*, ghostly battalions of marchers converge in a theatricalized space decked out with an iron lamppost, benches, multicolored banners, and stage lighting to stand in for an Indonesian public square. We see a squadron of red motorcycles with glaring headlights but no riders. A string of horses with

tacks and tails, but no bodies, bear the wares of a peasant market—a farmer's hat, prayer rugs, a plastic bag stuffed with plastic Batman masks. A truckload of Muslim women—represented by assemblages of head scarves (*jilbab*) and footwear—are en route to a demonstration with their drums and megaphones. A colonial marching army—with striped pants and pointy hats, pikes and snare drums, medallions, white-laced boots, feathered turbans, a shoulder brace with the insignia of Yogyakarta's kraton, and a monitor screening a solitary wayang wong dancer busking at the side of a congested road—stands at attention. We wander through this haunted space as banners flutter, animatronic hands clap, and drums sound. We sit on a bench and hear a snatch of a synthesizer playing a popular melody in an *unheimlich* mode, the voices distorted beyond recognition by amplification, xylophones, and the hum of a crowd.

Now, inspecting the texts of the hanging, multicolored banners, several layers deep, we read lyrics of political songs and anthems, performative declarations, and vows. The banners overlap, interrupt, and contest each other. A song from a 1950s student movement abuts an anthem of Soeharto's political party. Lyrics of



Grand Parade, an installation by Jompet Kuswidananto exhibited at the Tropical Museum in 2014–2015. This section of the installation restages an earlier piece titled *Java, War of Ghosts* (2009) by Jompet, now in the collection of Leo Shih. Image courtesy of the artist and Ark Galerie.

the parodic, hard rock “Slankers Mars” jostle with the pious march of a Muslim youth group. I gasp in recognition of “Genjer-genjer” (Lettuce), a folkloric song in the Osing dialect composed in 1953 by a LEKRA-affiliated East Javanese composer and banned by the New Order (Arps 2011).

We are not passive witnesses to Jompet’s mobilization of masses. With no master narrative to steer us, we must perforce find our own footing in this immersive environment. I remember the remnants of Indonesian colonial-era performances on display in the museum galleries above—sumptuous wayang kulit puppets from the princely houses of Java, extravagant masks from West Papua, a narrative banner by the Cirebonese folk artist Sitiswan depicting a long-ago forgotten trial. I recall a photograph of the gamelan played weekly in the Light Hall by Javanese sailors stranded in the Netherlands during World War II (Cohen 2014b, 255). I think about other Indonesian, Dutch, and international musicians, dancers, and puppeteers who have performed over the decades in the museum and the adjacent Tropical Theater, which closed in 2013. I am actively aware that the museum, founded in 1864 as the Colonial Museum, is also slated for closure: the future of this brick-and-mortar memorial to the Netherlands’ colonial and neocolonial entanglements is in suspension.¹⁹ I grasp a curatorial insistence of a dynamic relation to the past and read a projected hope for a democratic global future.

Through its strategic erasures and reflexive citations, the installation denies essences and foundations, repudiates the coherence of colonialist totalities, relativizes authoritative discourses, and gives voice to the suppressed (cf. Dirlik 2007, 65). Modernity, in Jompet’s carnivalesque imagining, is not an event to be depicted, but rather “explored and envisaged in a space finally divested of hierarchy, that of a globalized culture busy with new syntheses” (Bourriaud 2009, 186). The exhibition marks the closure of an era of colonial relations, but is neither a eulogy for nor a celebration of times past. Individual Indonesian artists, such as Jompet, will “still communicate in and play along with the old forms and institutions” and simultaneously withdraw to seek out “new niches of activity and identity” (Beck, Giddens, and Lash 1994, 20). On some occasions, they will throw their lot in with other Indonesians, accepting the formulaic truths of tradition that discriminate between “insider” and “outsider” as a condition of existence (79). On others, they will ally themselves with artists, sponsors, audiences, and institutions on different grounds—religion, sexual orientation, shared aesthetic values, love. In today’s globalized, post-traditional world, “we have no choice but to choose how to be and how to act” (75). We improvise and invent our always intertwined lives and arts—recapitulating, rebutting, and reinterpreting as we go.

NOTES

Introduction

1. This arts congress was the Sarasehan Wayang Indonesia, held as part of the Pekan Wayang Indonesia VI in Jakarta on 19 July 1993. The Pekan Wayang was a Soeharto-era festival that aimed to disseminate the New Order's five-year plans to the community of puppeteers. See Clara van Groenendael (1985).

2. Magical arts can be interpreted according to nonmagical rubrics. Clifford Geertz (1973, 448), for example, famously understands the function of the cockfight in Bali to be interpretive—"it is a Balinese reading of Balinese experience; a story they tell themselves about themselves"—but Geertz's critics argue that his dramaturgical construction of cockfighting as a status bloodbath is not supported by Balinese exegetes, who view it instead as an appeasement of chthonic spirits by the spilling of blood. Only once the ritual of cockfighting is aestheticized does it become a "philosophical drama" (417).

3. This point is borne out in the very first appearance of the term "performing arts" in the English language, where it is argued that is the task of the disinterested critic to improve the public ear, instill standards of judgment, and interpret meaning to the public of performing arts (Cooper [1711] 2011). The "knowing-that" of interpretation is thereby disaggregated from the "knowing-how" that makes performance.

The Indonesian translation of "performing arts," *seni pertunjukan*, is a newer coinage. Although the word "*pertunjukan*," from the Malay root *tunjuk* meaning to indicate or show, denoted exhibitions and enactments as early as the nineteenth century, the term *seni pertunjukan* achieved currency only in the 1950s and 1960s when the arts took on value as instruments for cultural diplomacy and intercultural communication. One of the earliest references to *seni pertunjukan* is a chapter title in a book for general audiences on Javanese shadow puppetry: "What are the reasons for the appreciation of *wayang kulit* as a performing art in this country and abroad?" (Sastroamidjojo 1964, 16). The term was subsequently picked up by scholar-dancer Raden Mas Soedarsono, who applied it in developing systems and norms for the maintenance of traditional arts and standards for generating "new creations" (*kreasi baru*) grounded in tradition.

4. "Tropical Express to Stay: New Items for Second Weeks Programme," *Times of India*, undated clipping from 1935, courtesy of Regina Schwartz.

5. Audio recordings offer the promise of another important source for twentieth-century performance history, but the major collections are mostly in private hands, and pickings available to scholars are slim. For a major study of early twentieth-century popular music see Yampolsky (2013). Relevant audiovisual materials, including available sources on the Internet, are referenced subsequently in notes.

Part I: “Every night there are entertainments”

1. *Bintang barat*, 28 May 1872. This item is unsigned but written in Wiggers’ style and, as the principal writer as well as editor, is almost certainly by him.

2. *Java bode*, 17 May 1862.

Chapter 1: Culture in Common

1. The eccentric landowner Augustijn Michiels, a Christian of mixed Bengali and Indonesian descent dubbed “Java’s last nabob,” owned an orchestra of slaves to perform so-called slave concerts (*slavenconcerten*) at his estate near Bogor. Michiels’ 1831 final testament lists thirty musicians hailing from the islands of Java, Sulawesi, Flores, and Seram, among them a “floutist-in-training” named Kommies from Batavia; a harpist named “Tonking or Colenetta” from Semarang; Bitjoe, a violinist from Pekalongan; a French horn player named Tollas from Manggarai on the eastern Indonesian island of Flores; a trumpeter with the slave name Pluto from Seram in the Maluku islands; and a bass player named July or Adonis from Dusung in South Sulawesi (van de Wall 1932, 92). According to one account, these “richly-costumed corps of slaves wore turbans” and “played European music very well” (Eysinga 1842, 354).

2. *Slompret Melayoe*, 10 January 1889, 25 April 1889.

3. Tanjidor bands enlivened weddings and similar occasions, and they also roamed the streets of Chinatown during the fifteen days of Chinese New Year, playing at Chinese houses for a small donation until this practice was banned as “begging” after independence (Tio T. H. [1959] 2006, 65). The word *tanjidor* is derived from the Portuguese *tangedor*, meaning “player of a stringed instrument,” and was broadened in Malay to mean “a musician who plays on a European instrument” (Dalgado 1936, 340), before being narrowed to refer to a specific musical genre. It has been argued that ex-slave musicians from eastern Indonesian islands formerly colonized by Portugal, who spoke dialects of Malay that were inflected by Portuguese, were involved in the genre’s creation.

4. See Yampolsky (2010, 2013) for more on kroncong’s history. The album *Kroncong: Early Indonesian Pop Music*, vol. 1 (Rice Records, 2006) provides an audio survey of kroncong.

5. The Bachelor’s Theatre opened in October 1814 with a performance of *The Heir at Law*, a five-act comedy by George Colman, the Younger, which had premiered six years earlier in London. Before the play, one of the Bachelor Theatre’s subscribers mounted the stage and stood in front of the curtain to deliver a poetic address to the audience. He jokingly pleaded indulgence for the amateur abilities of the all-male cast and offered a rationale for their enterprise: to replace the dread of disease that colored so much of European life in the tropics with “Mirth,” supported by “health, beauty, joy.” See “Private theatricals,” *The Morning Post* (London, England), 25 August 1815. The production’s success facilitated even more ambitious productions, including both parts of *Henry IV* in 1815, the first documented instance of Shakespeare being performed in the archipelago. Pace Winet (2010, 20–24) a dramatic performance in the fortress of Batavia in 1619 of a play about “the King of Denmark and the King of Sweden,” was likely not *Hamlet*, but rather I. I. van Wassenburgh’s *Historiaal spel van Koningh Reynier van Norwegen ende de schoone Langerta*, published in Rotterdam between 1610 and 1614 (Worp 1907, 290; Kurianingrat 1958, 4). The first published Dutch translation of *Hamlet* dates only from 1790.

6. By the twentieth century, tastes appear to have broadened: the published catalog of a lending library of a Surabaya art society includes plays by Shakespeare, Shaw, Corneille, Molière, Goethe, Ibsen, and Wilde in translation and their original languages (n.a. 1937).

7. Javanese nobles were formerly enthusiastic participants in jousting tournaments, known as *senenan*, after the Javanese word *senen* (Monday), the day of the week they were held. *Senenan* were popular through the end of the Java War in 1830 and the effective cessation of the Javanese nobility's military ambitions (Buddingh 1841; van Hoëvell 1858, 248–249).

8. For early *bedhaya* and *serimpi* films, see J. C. Lamster, dir., *Dansen van Bedaja's in den Kraton te Soerakarta* (Koloniaal Instituut, Amsterdam, 1912), <http://www.indonesianfilmcenter.com/pages/archive/watch.arvc.php?v=6009&title=Tarian%20Bedajas%20di%20Kraton%20Surakarta/> and J. C. Lamster, dir., *Dansen van Serimpi in den Kraton de Djocjarta* (Koloniaal Instituut, Amsterdam, 1913), <http://www.indonesianfilmcenter.com/pages/archive/watch.arvc.php?v=5833&title=Tarian%20Serimpi%20di%20Keraton%20Yogyakarta>.

9. *Menareh's* female singers were given the special prerogative of being able to sing “advice to and even criticism of the Sultan” (Kartomi 1994, 151) in semi-improvised lyrics unintelligible to outsiders: Pfeiffer speaks of “screeching song” (1856, 238).

10. Bandung's regent, Wiranatakusumah IV (r. 1846–1874), was considered a progressive official and loyal Dutch subject, and his mansion and the adjacent central mosque in Bandung's central square (*alun-alun*) had only been refurbished two years earlier as key parts of the regent's master plan for modernizing the highland planters' city. In common with many nineteenth-century Sundanese elites, Wirantakusumah's court was strongly under the cultural influence of the royal courts of Surakarta and Yogyakarta. This orientation might date to the seventeenth century, when Mataram captains fleeing their enemies after a defeat in a 1628 battle against the Dutch forces in Batavia set themselves up as lords in Pajajaran lands and became thereby “bearers of the Muslim court culture of central Java” (J. Taylor 2003, 157). Up until the end of the colonial period, Sundanese nobility imported dancers and teachers from the central Javanese heartlands to restore their arts to their “original” state (Bakrie Soeraatmadja 1939).

11. Pfeiffer refers to this as *bedogo*, evidently a mishearing of the Javanese word “*bedhaya*.”

12. The gifting of dancing girls was a well-established practice in Javanese courts, where female group dances were much more than aesthetic ornaments. Raffles notes that dancers attached to palaces were sometimes concubines of rulers (cf. Raffles [1817] 1830, 1:381). The *Wedha pradangga*, an early twentieth-century text on Javanese performance, describes an alternate practice said to have originated with Sultan Agung of Mataram. Each of the mighty king's high officials (the eight *bupati nayaka* and his *patih dalem*) was compelled to give his daughters or granddaughters to the king to constitute the nine *bedhaya* dancers. This reinforced solidarity with the court. “These nine leaders became like the main supports of a house, and every *bedhaya* performance reminds [the people] of these leaders' devoted service [to their king]” (Warsadinigrat [1972] 1987, 82). Whether the ruler received or gave women, the effect was much the same: the “dancers represent a gift, a token of devotion and submission from the political leaders to the ruler” to reinforce the realm's unity (Brakel-Papenhuijzen 1992a, 45). Female court dancers were expensive to train and maintain, and to economize Javanese nobles sometimes substituted boys dressed in women's dance costumes (Raffles [1817] 1830, 1:381).

13. Wayang wong is known as *ringgit tiyang* in polite Javanese and *wayang orang* in Malay/Indonesian.

14. See Soeharda (1934–1935). The Koninklijk Bataviaasch Genootschap van Kunsten en Wetenschappen, to use its Dutch name, also ran Batavia's main museum, known after independence as Museum Pusat and then Museum Nasional, or the National Museum in English. Javanese authors published huge numbers of wayang scripts, known as *pakem*, in the twentieth century (Soewirjo 1997; Kleinsmiede 2002). These published plays are very rarely performed: they are read for pleasure by wayang connoisseurs and consulted by puppeteers. Written texts were held up as examples of best practice, and the word "*pakem*" has become, over time, a synonym for aesthetic norms.

15. See, e.g., *Slompret Melayoe*, 11 June, 11 August, and 7 November 1885.

16. For example, in Surakarta in the 1820s it was said that the requisite condition for becoming a social dancer was catching and swallowing a fly, so that the dancer would lack shame (Winter cited in Pigeaud [1938] 1991, 86).

17. *Slompret Melayoe*, 19 March 1885, 8 August 1885.

18. I have found no independent account of the school, and it is possible that the ambitious regulations were never implemented.

19. The courts of Surakarta and Yogyakarta also created refined choreographies based on *taledhek* dancing, known as *gambuyong*, *golek*, and *bondan* (Brakel-Papenhuijzen 1995, 29–30). These dances could be presented on formal occasions, but until recently were never performed by members of the royal family, due to their licentious roots.

20. For a superb recording of gambang kromong, see Philip Yampolsky, producer, *Music from the Outskirts of Jakarta: Gambang Kromong* (Washington, DC: Smithsonian/Folkways, 1991). The equivalent ensemble in Semarang mixed Javanese xylophone, Chinese fiddle, flute, and wood block. See Liem (1933, 130).

21. *Bintang barat*, 22 May 1872. The Chinese in colonial Indonesia were governed along military lines, with captains, lieutenants, and majors.

22. For a summary of *Kandiawan* (Or. 2139), see Vreede (1892, 242–244).

23. For a colonial film of *wireng*, see J. C. Lamster, dir., "Dansen van Wirengs in den Kraton te Soerakarta" (Koloniaal Instituut, Amsterdam, 1912), <http://www.indonesianfilmcenter.com/pages/archive/watch.arcv.php?v=5835>.

24. *Wireng iyanan dalem ringgit madya* cited in Brakel-Papenhuijzen (2011, 221).

25. Older Javanese works of literature, most famously the *Serat Centhini*, compiled in Surakarta in the 1810s, describe and interpret artistic performances in episodes embedded within larger narrative frames. Tondhakusuma's book, in contrast, has a singular focus on arts, detailing terminology, formal characteristics, and slices of oral history in dialogue form. It offers, for the first time, a Javanese metacultural term to correlate with the European concept of "fine art": *karawitan*, a nominalization of the Javanese root word *krawit*, meaning "very fine and smooth." In Tondhakusuma's usage, *karawitan* encompasses the performance of tembang, gamelan, dance, and wayang, as well as gamelan making and wayang carving (Perlman 1991). Although *karawitan* was displaced as a cover term for the arts in twentieth-century Java by the Indonesian-language term *seni*, which among nineteenth-century Malay speakers likewise carried a primary meaning of "fine and small" (Iken and Harahap 1918), *karawitan* retains currency among educated speakers of Javanese and is the preferred designation for classical Javanese music, particularly gamelan, in the arts academies founded after independence.

26. The new puppets and accompanying gamelan pieces for *wayang madya*, which premiered in the Mangkunegaran court in 1872, were reportedly created under Mangkunegara IV's personal supervision (Drewes 1974). *Wayang madya* is significant as the first documented

theatrical adaptation of Ronggawarsita's universal history, a text that took on increasing authority in decades ahead. Though dismissed as a modern work of minimal philological interest when presented by Mangkunegara IV to the Royal Batavian Society of Arts and Sciences, the *Pustaka raja* was recognized by Javanese readers as a significant *bibit* or "seed" for ideas and stories (*Slomporet Melayoe*, 7 May 1889). As an article in the Javanese magazine *Kajawen* states, "The *Pustaka raja* is like a template [*babon*] for all literature. [...] Stories told by puppeteers originate there, resulting in the potential for very large numbers of plays. Also, it contains mundane and esoteric wisdom which can be extracted and [shaped into] books" (n.a. 1928, 243).

27. An early account by Isaïc Groneman (1882) mentions only the all-male Yogyakarta langendriya variant, in which the singer-dancers perform from a sitting, squatting, or kneeling position to respect the sultan's presence. According to Lelyveld ([1933] 1993, 143–145), the Yogyakarta version was created by Sultan Hamengku Buwono III's son, Bupati Nayaka Raden Tumenggung Purwodiningrat, in 1876.

28. Kiliaan's Dutch name indicates that legally he possessed European status, something obtainable for well-heeled Chinese who were fluent in a European language. A Mangkunegaran court manuscript from circa 1920 (translated in Brakel-Papenhuijzen 1995, 193) states that Kiliaan "was very fond of gamelan music and Javanese dance. Then with the help of Raden Mas Arya Tondhakusuma he arranged a dance from the story of Raden Damarwulan of Majapahit. As players they chose women only. The whole dialogue was in Javanese metrical verse (*tembang macapat*), accompanied by the sound of the *slendro* gamelan, differing according to the melodies of the poetry."

29. This might have only been a fragment—because it featured only three characters, the protagonist Damar Wulan, his clown-servant Dayun, and Damar Wulan's nemesis Menak Jingga (Pigeaud 1926).

30. *Langen mandra wanara* is said to have been created in 1890 by Pangeran Adipati Danureja VII, the *pepatih dalem* or prime minister of the Yogyakarta royal court.

31. Pigeaud (1929, 8; [1938] 1991, 61) mentions explicitly the inspiration of the Bima reliefs of the fifteenth-century Suku temple of Mount Lawu—a temple on Mangkunegaran land.

32. The emphasis on costume distinguished the Mangkunegaran version from Yogyakarta's wayang wong; for example, the typical head garb of Yogyakarta was a simple *udheng* (folded cloth) worn in the style of court soldiers (Schulze 1890: 330). According to Wiradat (1960), Tondhakusuma smoothed out the bold gestures of Yogyakarta's wayang wong, and greater stress was placed on dance to fit the large playing area of the Mangkunegaran's *pendhapa*.

33. One guildster in 1890 has roughly the same "purchasing power" as \$15 today. See <http://www.iisg.nl/hpw/calculate.php>.

34. Pigeaud (1929, 8) notes wayang wong adaptations of twelve *wayang purwa* plays staged between 1884 and 1887; two productions based on *wayang krucil* episodes from 1884 and 1885; and two based on *wayang gedog* plays from 1885 and 1886. For a film of court-style wayang wong, see *Java: Dans en Toneel (Deel 2)* (Nationale Filmfabriek Bloemendaal, 1921), <http://www.indonesianfilmcenter.com/pages/archive/watch.arvc.php?v=6054>.

35. Even such rustic folk arts as *reyog* masquerade were remolded under courtly aesthetic influences. One such revamped *reyog* group, a "new model" (*gagrag hanjar alias model baroe*), which featured an expanded gamelan ensemble, a variety of masked dancers, and *kuda kepeng* hobby horse dancers, was dubbed *reyog langendriyan* in recognition of its debt to the court arts. See "Hal Reijog," *Slomporet Melayoe*, 21 September 1889.

36. *Slompret Melayoe*, 11 July 1885.

37. *Slompret Melayoe*, 21 May 1885.

38. *Slompret Melayoe*, 10 December 1889.

39. *Serat Sastra Miruda* is popularly attributed to Kusumadilaga, a court official and arts expert, but is substantially the work of Kusumawardaya, a grandson of Pakubuwana IV and Javanese literati; Kusumawardaya's coauthor for *Kawruh topeng* was the courtier Raden Ngabehi Reksapraja. Both texts were products of what Sumarsam (1995, 64) calls the mestizo culture around the nineteenth-century royal courts of Surakarta and combine myth, legend, hearsay, and history. Whereas earlier Javanese texts concerned with shadow puppetry offered narrative exemplars for practice or interpreted the form's esoteric symbols, the *Sastra Miruda* issues didactic imperatives: "the *gender* player must be a woman"; "a puppeteer should not discourse on events outside the screen [e.g., related to everyday life], particularly anything vulgar, nor should he arrange a play in a way that bores spectators" (Kamajaya and Sudibjo 1982, 186, 188). The text was subsequently held up as "the Qur'an" of puppeteers (Soeharda 1934–1935). Both the *Sastra Miruda* and the *Kawruh topeng*, a short study of the history and structure of masked dance and drama (Pigeaud 1991, 43–59; Kusumawardaya and Reksapraja [1902] 1985), along with translations into Dutch, were shipped to the Netherlands in 1882 by the royal court of Surakarta to accompany masks and puppets displayed at the 1883 Colonial Exhibition in Amsterdam. The exhibition stimulated the interest of its curator, museum anthropologist Lindor Serrurier, resulting in a monumental ethnological study of Javanese shadow puppetry re-searched by questionnaires sent to regents around Java (Serrurier [1896] 1933).

40. *Slompret Melayoe*, 23 February 1889.

41. Like Java's "Europeans," more often than not the Chinese in the Indies were of mixed descent—so-called *peranakan* Chinese.

42. See inter alia Sie Pandjang, "Het Chineesch tooneel in Indië," *Het Nieuws van den dag*, 18 April 1892, and "Chineesche wajang," *De Sumatra post*, 14 September 1923.

43. In his diary, Hornstedt notes that the manuscript was subsequently translated into Malay for him by a Chinese acquaintance: the first recorded instance of a Malay-language play. Christina Scott, editor of a recent edition of the diary, informs me that the whereabouts of the original Chinese manuscript purchased by Hornstedt and the Malay translation are currently unknown.

44. On performance taxes in Batavia, see Cohen (2006, 171–175, 416).

45. *Tambahsia* was published in 1915, but is based, according to its subtitle, on "a true story that happened in Batavia around 1851–1856."

46. *Biang lala*, 26 August 1869.

47. Public theaters presenting Chinese opera were well established elsewhere in Southeast Asia, but were new to the Indies. See Vaughan (1879, 82–83) for an 1853 visit that the author made to see Chinese opera at Penang's "Theatre Royale."

48. *Bintang barat*, 13 August 1873.

49. *Bintang barat*, 27 October 1873.

50. *Bintang barat*, 8 November 1873.

51. *De locomotief*, 27 August, 28 August 1877. The concept of paying for Chinese opera remained novel to spectators outside the big cities through the 1880s, however. A bemused newspaper correspondent from the central Javanese town of Ambarawa details how paying different prices entitled some spectators to "rent" a chair or a bench seat while others were required to stand at opera performances (*Slompret Melayoe*, 27 April 1889).

52. *Slompret Melayoe*, 10 October 1889.
53. *Bintang Soerabaia*, 15 December 1888.
54. “Verhuur van kinderen,” *De Sumatra post*, 17 October 1930.

Chapter 2: Hybrid and Popular Entertainments

1. The precise identity of the troupe is uncertain, because there were a number of touring operations with similar names. Possibly it was the same outfit as the Olympic Circus, directed by the Prussian equestrian Kennebel, which played opposite Singapore’s London Hotel in 1851. See *The Straits Times*, 4 February 1851, 22 April 1851.

2. *Slompret Melayoe*, 3 October 1885.

3. In 1885, the regent of Ponorogo went so far as to advertise in Malay-language newspapers a reward of sixty guilders for a tiger to fight in an animal combat he was planning to stage to celebrate the end of the Islamic month-long Ramadhan fast (*Slompret Melayoe*, 18 July 1885).

4. Indonesians continued to produce similar humbugs through the century, with new mermaids (*duyung*) appearing as late as 1900. See *Bintang barat*, 11 March 1871, 15 March 1871; *Slompret Melayoe*, 29 August 1885; and *Primbon Soerabaia*, 13 October 1900.

5. This paragraph and the next are based in part on Cohen (2002b).

6. *Tjahaja India*, 11 May 1885.

7. *Tjerimai*, 30 August 1893.

8. *Het noorden*, 20 June 1930.

9. *Bintang barat*, 6 August 1872.

10. *Bintang barat*, 9 August 1872.

11. *Bintang barat*, 10 June 1871.

12. *Slompret Melayoe*, 7 December 1889. This same year Japan was threatening to cancel treaties with the Netherlands unless the Dutch granted the Japanese living in the Dutch Indies equal status to Europeans. See *Straits Times Weekly Issue*, 30 September 1889.

13. *Bintang Soerabaia*, 27 June 1891.

14. *Bintang Soerabaia*, 4 August 1900.

15. *Djawi-kando*, 25 April 1899.

16. *Slompret Melayoe*, 20 October 1885.

17. This Sundanese variant, now known as *wayang golek purwa*, was initially called *wayang gelung* (Juynboll 1901) after the archaic, curved headdresses (*gelung*) that distinguished the new Sundanese figures from the more contemporarily coiffured *wayang golek* of Cirebon.

18. Rod puppetry’s technological invention is apparent in one of the earliest published sources, a description of a dance-drama-cum-puppet-play performed as part of an evening’s entertainment at the Kanoman palace of Cirebon circa 1840 (Buddingh 1842). A rod puppet representing a princess emerges with a golden flower in its hand from the split skull of a dancer festooned with banyan tree twigs who portrays a giant. The article’s author was so impressed by the effect that he asked Cirebon’s regent how it could be realized in such close proximity to the audience without a glimpse of helping hands or strings. The regent reported that the only person who could possibly reveal the mechanism was the sultan himself; everyone else connected to it had taken a sacred vow never to tell. *Wayang golek*’s nineteenth-century popularity is further attested to by the introduction of a rod puppet *gambyong* dancer at the conclusion of *wayang kulit* and *wayang krucil* performances.

19. Until recently West Javanese rod puppeteers switched to using wayang kulit figures when called on to perform the sacred *Murwakala* (Origin of Kala) drama used for *ruwatan* (exorcism) purposes.

20. For colonial-era footage of wayang golek in both the Cirebonese and Sundanese styles of west Java, see J. H. Zandler, dir., *Nederlands-Indie voor 1942 (07)*, <http://www.indonesianfilmcenter.com/pages/archive/watch.arcv.php?v=1700>.

21. Unlike in Malaya, where the Arabic-based Jawi script was used, most Malay-language books published in Java used the Roman script. Muslims in Java with a *pesantren* education who were literate only in Arabic script feared that books published in Latin script promoted Christian values (*Bintang barat*, 4 September 1890).

22. The large population of Indians living in Singapore and elsewhere in the Straits Settlements made these parts natural destinations for enterprising Parsi theater companies. It was not until 1883 that a Parsi theater company, the Royal Hyderabad Theatre, is documented as having played in the Dutch Indies.

23. This affected speech style involved using an elevated, literary vocabulary and pronouncing the letter “r” as a guttural and the vowel “a” (in end positions) as the “eu” in entrepreneur (Parlindungan 1964, 536).

24. See also Robson (1969) for a detailed English-language summary.

25. The teachers’ training college (*kweekschool*) founded in Bukittinggi in the 1850s—known in the vernacular as the Sekolah Raja (School of Kings) because of its blue-blooded students—played a particularly pivotal role in standardizing the Riau dialect of Malay among bureaucratic-aristocratic elites and introducing modern ideas to several generations of Sumatrans.

26. *Hindia-Olanda*, 10 October 1893.

27. *Bintang barat*, 3 May 1892.

28. *Bintang barat*, 20 September 1892. Not all public theaters operating around this time in Sumatra had tainted reputations. The assistant resident H. R. Rookmaaker reports on a theater in the town of Rawas in the Palembang area where semiprofessional dancers without ill repute regularly presented concert dances (*tari*), such as *tari kipas* (fan dance) and *tari piring* (plate dance) (Winter 1901). This seems to be a commercialization of a much older south Sumatran custom whereby members of Malay communities gathered to sing pantun and dance in centrally located *balei* (village halls) (n.a. [1822] 1887).

29. *Komedi Jawa* might have been a development of a tradition of comic theater patronized by Sundanese regents, described by some European observers as “théâtre comique.” Buddingh describes such a comical drama at the mansion of the regent of Sumedang in which Chinese, Bengalis, and the blind were pilloried (Buddingh 1842, 354–355). It is not clear from Buddingh’s description whether this was a visiting or resident troupe. If the latter, it might have been a performance by an itinerant *longser* or *reog* folk theater troupe.

30. Salmoen (1949, 273) reports that this genre of theater experienced a resurgence at the end of the nineteenth century under the influence of komedi stambul. He explains that all-male performances of *kamed*i or *kamidi* (he uses both spellings) took place in *kabupaten* buildings and used Malay-language literature or Panji stories as source materials, with audiences limited to families and friends.

31. A. Th. Manusama (1922, 2) states that *dulmuluk* (also referred to as *komedi Abdul Muluk*) was brought to Java and Sumatra by a troupe from Johor. Plays were based on the histories of Malay kingdoms, with the Abdul Muluk story as a central repertoire item. According to

Manusama, music was provided by a seraphine organ, string instruments, and tambourine, though other sources refer to musical accompaniment styled after Chinese opera. At least until the 1980s a related form called *bedul muluk* was also practiced in the regency of Bulungan in East Kalimantan (Sutopo and Kasim Achmad 1982–1983, 70).

32. See *Bintang barat*, 3 October 1890 and 4 November 1890 for mentions of gambang kromong groups and harmonica-violin combos playing *lagu Persi* melodies. A variety of interrelated forms of Malay-language urban folk theater were still practiced on the margins of Jakarta into the 1950s. These included, according to one account, *dermuluk*, *wayang senggol*, *bangsawan*, and *lenong* (Kementerian Penerangan 1953b: 494). Only *lenong* survives presently.

33. *Bintang barat*, 5 November 1894.

34. Cirebon's wayang wong troupes performed with masks in an expanded version of topeng. One of the most traveled Cirebonese troupes was from the area of Palimanan, which remains a center for wayang kulit and topeng to the present.

35. *Bintang Soerabaia*, 27 December 1888.

36. *Bintang barat*, 9 October 1890. Different troupes playing Batavia had different styles and emphases. In one troupe, the clown servant Gareng spoke Javanese, whereas another featured a Sundanese-speaking Dewala. A gamelan was praised for being able to play European and Chinese musical pieces, as well as Javanese.

37. *Bintang barat*, 9 October 1890.

38. *Bintang barat*, 16 September 1890.

39. *Bintang barat*, 3 October 1890.

40. *Bintang barat*, 16 October 1890.

41. Koentjaraningrat admits that after World War II, the reputation of wayang wong was elevated somewhat due largely to the innovative Ngesthi Pandhawa troupe of Semarang.

42. *Bintang barat*, 27 October 1890.

43. *Bintang barat*, 28 October 1890.

44. *Bintang barat*, 31 October 1890.

Chapter 3: Modern Drama, Spoken and Sung

1. Episodes of the *Arabian Nights* had been appearing in Malay translation in newspapers for decades ("Aladdin" was first serialized in *Soerat chabar Betawie* as early as 1858) and published as books, though it was not until 1891 that a full Malay edition was released by the Batavia publishing firm Albrecht & Rusche.

2. In *ladon-diladon* style, an actor would enter and speak directly to the audience: "I am a king in the land of Baghdad; come, let us now take pleasure" (*adapun kami ini seorang raja di benua Bagdad; marilah kami sekarang bersenang-senang*)—and the orchestra would then strike up a tune (Penthul 1931).

3. This paragraph and the following discussion of stambul are based on Cohen (2009a).

4. *Bintang barat*, 25 June 1895.

5. *Pembrita Betawi*, 29 July 1895.

6. J. D. Charles van der Laan, an actor-director formerly associated with a British Indian theater company, introduced the practice of topping plays off with tableaux vivants, spectacular "living pictures" that staged moments of history or myth with music but without motion.

7. *Tjerimai*, 18 November 1893.

8. *Pembrita Betawi*, 18 March 1895.

9. *Pembrita bahroe*, 30 November 1896. See also Cohen (2014a) for a translation of a short story about a woman seduced into leaving polite society to join a stambul troupe.

10. See *Retnodhoemilah*, 21 May 1895, on Gan Kam's technical innovations and *Bintang Soerabaia*, 7 June 1894, on the innovations of a rival troupe directed by Tan Tjaj Howat.

11. *Bintang Soerabaia*, 21 August 1894; *Bintang Soerabaia*, 14 May 1900.

12. *Bintang Soerabaia*, 29 May 1900; *Bintang Soerabaia*, 26 July 1899.

13. Cohen 2002a, 111–112. Indra Zanibar was originally under the artistic direction of B. B. Wanteh (Camoens 1982).

14. Wayang Kassim was not the only Southeast Asian popular theater troupe to engage an English agent. Po Sein's troupe in Burma did the same. For a semifictional account of the latter troupe, see Sein and Withey (1965).

15. *Bintang Soerabaia*, 22 October 1902.

16. On Hans van de Wall's theatrical career, see Baay (1993).

17. Indies drama was the correlate of the Indies novel (*Indische roman*), a popular literary genre in the colony and the Netherlands since the nineteenth century.

18. In his unpublished autobiography, van de Wall (n.d.) mentions studying the work of Belgian playwright Maurice Maeterlinck and other European moderns before embarking on his playwrighting career.

19. For a plot summary of Ido's *De paria van Glodok* (The paraiah of Glodok, 1916), see Cohen (2006, 270).

20. For a cogent summary and analysis of *Karina Adinda*, see Winet (2010, 51–58).

21. See Krafft ([1895], 2010) for a translation of and commentary on a short komedi stambul script by H. Krafft that might have been intended for amateur companies.

22. Possibly the translation was to benefit Malay speakers who wished to follow the opera's plot. The plot might have been familiar to some already, because according to van Maurik (1897) the opera had already been adapted to komedi stambul.

23. The most worthy of further study is perhaps the Javanese-language script *Lara Mendut*, also known in Dutch as *De lotgevallen van Bok-Loro Mendoet* (1898; The adventures of Mother Loro Mendut). This play, based on a well-known legend, was “redacted in Javanese wayang play form” by Ko Mo An, a Javanese-Chinese architect, poet, contributor to scholarly journals, and a prominent member of Mataram, Yogyakarta's exclusive European club.

24. Wiggers' script contains stage directions and descriptions of scenery, and even occasional notes to performers, suggesting some familiarity with European theatrical conventions. But the play concludes in outline form, which makes it less than stageworthy. If intended for production, it would have been difficult to cast: certainly no komedi stambul actor would have been accustomed to memorizing so much dialogue. Jakob Sumardjo (1992, 112) makes the interesting suggestion that the play might have been performed by STOVIA students, referencing Lauw Giok Lan's comment, in the introduction to the Malay translation of *Karina Adinda* (1913), that STOVIA students often performed drama.

25. The so-called *passenstelsel* was a “pass system” that restricted movement and limited access to the hinterlands, ostensibly to prevent the economic exploitation of indigenous populations.

26. The anonymously authored, forty-one-scene *Cerita satu ibu tiri yang pinter ajar anak* (A stepmother with a talent for child rearing) performed by the amateur Kiong Ho Hie association and published in Batavia in 1917, follows the *ladon-diladon* stambul convention of characters introducing themselves to the audience on their first appearance. One scene's dialogue

reads in its entirety: “I am a tenant of Baba Ko Liang Siam, and every year when I am short on rice, I go to my landlord’s house to borrow rice from him. I am off to his house now, hoping he is there” (n.a. [1917] 2006, 72).

27. For biographical particulars see J. B. Kwee (1980) and Sidharta (1989, 2004).

28. Regulations of a 1930 playscript competition sponsored by the Surabaya branch of Hua Chiao Tsing Nien Hui (Overseas Chinese Youth Association) specifically state that “pieces written in stambul style will not be considered, regardless of the excellence of the play” (*Bintang Borneo*, 25 February 1930).

Chapter 4: Music on the Market

1. *Slompret Melayoe*, 31 December 1885.

2. There were precedents for the sale of wayang puppets and other instruments of performance at exhibitions. Ranneft (1894, 45–48) notes that gamelan instruments and a range of wayang puppets—from toy puppets crafted from grass called *wayang rumput* to *wayang inten* or shadow puppets decorated with precious stones (J. 1940)—were sold at an exhibition of native crafts held in Magelang in 1891.

3. For late colonial films of the Pasar Gambir, see H. J. A. Sanders, “De Pasar-Gambir te Batavia September 1934,” <http://www.indonesianfilmcenter.com/pages/archive/watch.arcv.php?v=5626&title=Pasar-Gambir%20di%20Batavia,%20September%201934>, and H. J. A. Sanders, “Gekleurde Film van Pasar Gambir te Batavia 1936,” <http://www.indonesianfilmcenter.com/pages/archive/watch.arcv.php?v=5629&title=Film%20Pasar%20Gambir%20di%20Batavia%201936>.

4. “Krontjong-concours,” *Het nieuws van den dag voor Nederlandsch-Indië*, 19 April 1917.

5. *Tjahaja India*, 16 April 1885. The *gending* with soft accompaniment refers to the *palaran* style developed at the Mangkunegaran court.

6. Music boxes and street organs, known as *orgel* in Dutch and Malay, were sold by department stores in many cities in the 1880s and 1890s. Advertisements from the period from 1893 to 1902 list organ rolls with music from stambul, *dulmuluk*, and the Parsi theater; kroncong tunes and gambang kromong pieces; Chinese music; Thai melodies; music from Sumatra; and Javanese and European music. Organs came in different sizes. Some had bells. An 1896 newspaper ad placed by the Batavia merchant Tan Hoe Lo hawked a hand-cranked organ measuring 60 × 81 × 57½ cm said to be “played on the streets of Batavia. People pay 1 guilder for 12 tunes, which last about a quarter of an hour, or 50 cents for six tunes. Hiring it for a night costs 15 guilders.” According to the ad, the organ had a “sweet and piercing flute sound.” It was sold with six stambul and six European music rolls for 250 guilders (*Bintang barat*, 16 September 1896). See further Cohen 2006, 154–155.

7. *Primbon-Soerabaia*, 22 September 1900.

8. For an influential study of the reception of the phonograph by indigenous peoples in the Americas and elsewhere, see Taussig 1993.

9. *Hindia-Olanda*, 5 September 1896.

10. The Hadhrami Arab cleric Sayid Usman bin Abdallah published in 1899 two fatwas that set out to prove that no spiritual benefits accrued from hearing phonographic recordings of the Qur’an and that the phonograph should be considered forbidden (*haram*) or at least to be avoided (*makruh*) because it distracted from the concentrated reading and internalization of scripture. These fatwas were nonbinding and seem to have made little impact; by 1902 a

preacher was using the phonograph for proselytizing in the central Javanese countryside (*Tjerimai*, 23 July 1902).

11. *Primbon-Soerabaia*, 16 August 1900.

12. The range of music that Tio produced went considerably beyond this, in fact. In 1914 Tio Tek Hong advertisements promote double-sided Odeon gramophone discs of kroncong and stambul songs with orchestral accompaniment, stambul instrumental numbers, *gambus* (Islamic lute music), a Batavia *strijkorkest*, Sundanese wayang wong clowning, Sundanese tembang from Garut, wayang golek from Bandung, and multivolume issues of stambul plays. See *Tjerimai*, 3 January 1914. For an important audio survey of recordings from colonial Indonesia and other parts of Southeast Asia, see *Longing for the Past: The 78 RPM Era in Southeast Asia* (Atlanta: Dust-to-Digital, 2013).

13. Yampolsky's estimate counts each side of a disc as a separate recording.

14. *Moestika*, 10 March 1928.

15. *Oetoesan Timoer*, 15 November 1933.

16. *Primbon-Soerabaia*, 8 January 1901.

17. *Bintang Soerabaia*, 27 October 1893.

18. *Slompret Melayoe*, 16 April 1898. See also Mak van Dijk and Schreuder 2007, 57.

19. See Mak van Dijk and Schreuder (2007) for an important study of these and other "Indies composers" and the complementary CD recording *Angin timur gelombang barat: De oostenwind golft naar het Westen* (Den Haag: Nederlands Muziek Instituut, 2005).

20. Theater and dance artists sponsored by the Union include Dutch cabaret and theater artist Cor Ruys (who toured in 1926, 1930, 1931, 1935, and 1937), German modern dancers Gertrud Leistikow (1924) and Niddy Impekoven (1930), the pathbreaking American interpretive dance company Denishawn (1926), and American "ethnic" dancer La Meri (1937).

21. Schramm and his wife left Java in 1938 and settled eventually in Australia.

22. Suwardi's ensemble originally went by the Javanese name Rukun Anggawe Santoso, a translation of the Dutch phrase Eendracht Maakt Macht, "In unity there is strength."

23. For an anthology of Fred Belloni's colonial-era recordings, see *Miss Riboet honderd jaar: Historische opnamen Miss Riboet en Fred Belloni* (Blimbing, 2000).

24. Amir Pasaribu is responding here to debates of the 1930s, summarized later, that position kroncong as a form of national culture.

25. *Het nieuws van den dag voor Nederlandsch-Indië*, 14 November 1919. Advertisements for Becker's Académie de Danse (located on Citadelweg, or current-day Jalan Veteran I), boasted that the dances he taught and performed were in accord with the standards established by the latest London congress of the Imperial Society of Teachers of Dance. See *Het nieuws van den dag voor Nederlandsch-Indië*, 4 February 1922.

26. *Het nieuws van den dag voor Nederlandsch-Indië*, 28 September 1920.

27. "Music: From Batavia," *Time*, 21 August 1939.

28. A lively compilation of archival recordings of jazz, Hawaiian, and other popular forms from the 1930s and 1940s is the CD *Hallo Bandoeng: Indië klassieken* (Favorite, 2005). Also worth listening to is the CD accompanying the exhibition catalog of period sheet music and other ephemera: Henk Mak van Dijk and Carl Nix, *Wajang foxtrot: Indië in klank en beeld* (Shiedam: Scriptum Art, 2011).

29. See *Pandji poestaka* 10, no. 76 (1932): 1192; *Pandji poestaka* 9, no. 88 (1931): 1381; *Pandji poestaka* 5, no. 29 (1927): 482; *Pandji poestaka* 16, no. 14 (1938): 260; *Pandji poestaka* 10, no.

8 (1932): 110; *Pandji poestaka* 4, no. 101 (1926): 2438; *Pandji poestaka* 4, no. 93 (1926): 2222; *Pandji poestaka* 4, no. 47 (1926): 1070; and *Pandji poestaka* 4, no. 51 (1926): 1166.

30. *Weekblad keng po* 4, no. 194 (1932): 2.

31. Saron played between 1924 and 1926 in the gamelan orchestra of the court of Surakarta under the direction of K. R. T. Wreksodiningrat. Wreksodiningrat was an enthusiast for American popular music such as the one-step and cakewalk, who adventurously adapted music from non-gamelan sources. He is credited with creating, in 1914, the first “multilaras” (cf. Weintraub 2004, 128) gamelan, a novelty item called “Gamelan Genta” that could play in both the traditional *slendro* and *pelog* tunings, as well as diatonically. Saron also worked with Raden Soemarno, a self-taught instrument maker who repaired and made European string instruments for Javanese elites, before forming his own company in 1932.

32. Saron’s instruments were competitive in price and quality with those imported from Europe: a 1939 advertisement for a Surakarta music store promotes double basses “made in Solo” at 73.34 guilders, whereas those “made in Europe” are priced at 80 guilders. See *Poestaka timoer* 1, no. 21 (1 December 1939): 5.

33. The late 1930s was a time when the record industry was reaching out to niche “ethnic” markets. In Sumatra, for example, one could purchase records of Batak Simalungan songs, *gambus* from Padang, a Minangkabau boy singer named Boeng Sjaugie, and traditional Minangkabau instruments such as *rebab* and *bangsi*.

Chapter 5: Ethnic “Awakenings”

1. *Bintang Soerabaia*, 27 December 1893.

2. Indeed, Kartini has such little interest in this popular stage performance that she neglects to note what sort of komedi she was attending—it is not clear whether she was at a European operetta or a komedi stambul performance.

3. *Bintang barat*, 17 May 1872. The word “Bambang” attached to both clubs suggests that members were young aristocratic Javanese men; “Nilo Sadhono” denotes tantric ritual and esoteric “black magic” used to acquire power, whereas “Plessier” (an alternate spelling for *plezier*) of course means pleasure.

4. “De feesten,” *Het nieuws van den dag voor Nederlandsch-Indië*, 4 May 1909, 1–2.

5. Wiranatakusumah was another of Snouck Hurgronje’s protégés, descended from a line of regents and educated in Dutch schools. Previously as regent of Cianjur he had revived the art of tembang, poetry sung to the accompaniment of kecapi (zither) and suling (bamboo flute), and he avidly patronized *degung* (a local gamelan form), wayang golek, and other arts.

6. Kartabrata, known familiarly as “Mama Etjen,” was an experienced amateur actor. During the Japanese period he headed the sandiwara (theater) division of Poesat Keboedajaan Priangan.

7. “Loetoeng Kasaroeng II,” *Nieuwe Rotterdamsche courant*, 6 November 1921, 11.

8. *De locomotief*, 30 August 1926.

9. Jong Java was originally known in fact as Tri Koro Dharmo; the change in name to Jong Java happened in 1918. Membership originally included Sundanese and Madurese students, but most withdrew by 1920 to form their own organizations. See van Niel [1960] 1984, 169–170.

10. For the annotated screenplay of Mannus Franken’s 1938 propaganda film *Tanah sa-brang, het land aan de overkant* (*Tanah Sabrang*, the land overseas), which features wayang’s clown servants in central roles; see Grasveld (1988). Representative advertisements with court

dancers can be found in *Bintang Borneo*, 5 April 1933; *Kajawen* 12, no. 8 (1937); and *Sinar-Sumatra*, 23 May 1938.

11. The technical term *ngembat*, for example, is defined by Holt (n.d.) as “raising arm (stretched) leading it from the wrist (hand hangs down at 90 deg. angle in *ngiting*) and stretching it to the side with a somewhat undulating movement, as the elbow bends slightly and the hand comes up above the lowering wrist, the whole finishing with a completed pushed-in elbow and a perfectly stretched arm with the hand in *ngiting*. (When perfect the arm should even have a protruding angle in the inside middle pushed out by the elbow-joint.)” For more on Holt, see Burton (2009).

12. Training was, of course, not entirely routinized; the charismatic Tedjokusumo was still very present in the lessons. In a tribute to her guru, Holt (1967, 153) describes how for decades “lithe and nimble, patient and humorous, [Tedjokusumo] has personally conducted the heavily attended dancing lessons and rehearsals for plays. [. . .] Seated cross-legged on a mat, the Prince knocks out the guiding signals for the dancers with a wooden mallet on the slit wooden signal box known as *keprak*. At intervals he demonstrates some movements to an awkward student.” Although Kridha was mostly dedicated to dance training, occasionally it staged innovative productions, such as a 1936 topeng revival at the Sono Budoyo Museum. This production was based on the Ken Angrok narrative in the *Pararaton*, an Old Javanese text extensively studied by Dutch philologists and historians with a story that had not previously been tapped as material for topeng (Pigeaud [1938] 1991, 119–120).

13. For a representative film of this late-colonial academic style of shadow puppetry, shot at the *pendhapa* of Tedjokusumo in Yogyakarta, see *Wajang Koelit* (ANIF, 1937), <http://www.indonesianfilmcenter.com/pages/archive/watch.arvc.php?v=6015>.

14. “Bataviasche Kunstkring: Retnowati Latip, Maurits Coronel,” *Het nieuws van den dag voor Nederlandsch-Indië*, 11 May 1933, 3; “Kunstkring: Dansavond Retnowati Latip,” *Bataviasch nieuwsblad*, 11 May 1933, 5. On Jodjana, see Cohen 2010, 106–139.

15. John Martin, “The Dance: From Java.” *New York Times*, 9 July 1939.

16. For a film of what appears to be an early version of *ibing keurseus*, see “Java: Dans en Toneel (Deel 1)” (Nationale Filmfabriek Bloemendaal, 1921), <http://www.indonesianfilmcenter.com/pages/archive/watch.arvc.php?v=6016>.

17. A. Soegija, S.J., “De dans bij de Javanen,” *Het Centrum*, 30 May 1925, 8.

18. “Jav. Kunstvereniging ‘Mardi Goeno’: Compromis dengan Nat. Indon. Kunstkring,” *Persamaan*, 18 June 1937.

19. *Dhagelan Mataram*’s original performers were clowns from the Javanese-language *ke-thoprak* theater who performed “extra” numbers, or skits, between acts of plays (Kementerian Penerangan 1953a, 692).

20. *Koemandang masyarakat*, 20 April 1940.

Chapter 6: Bali, Cultural Tourism, Modernized Arts

1. Balinese slaves traded to Batavia seem to have brought this practice with them, resulting in an offshoot form known as *ondel-ondel*. These body puppets are today a cultural emblem of Indonesia’s capital.

2. *Calong Arang* is an exorcistic drama that represents and expels harmful spirits causing the epidemics of the modern world, such as smallpox and cholera. The sacred masks are kept in temples, and performances are traditionally enacted adjacent to a burial ground.

3. For an important anthology of 1920s *kebyar* music, see Allan Evans and Edward Herbst, producers, *Bali 1928: Volume 1, Gamelan Gong Kebyar* (World Arbiter, 2009).

4. In the standard temple orchestra, *gender* metallophones replaced *gangs*, and in the cymbal family *rincik* replaced *ceng-ceng* (Seebass 1996, 80–81).

5. Janger resists standardization, with much variety in its expression. Some performances included stambul-style tableaux vivants and painted backdrops. Typically there was a master of ceremonies known as a *daag*, costumed sometimes as a Dutch general. There was legong-style dancing, acrobatics, polyrhythmic chanting, and clowning and sometimes a short *arja* or stambul play, an episode of the Mahabharata such as *Arjuna Wiwaha*, or a *barong* masquerade. Janger was a secular form, performed primarily for self-expression and enjoyment rather than profit, but in a village in Bangli it combined with *sanghyang* and became Janger Sanghyang Bobor, with performers going into a trance and dancing on coals. Girls in a 1930s club from Buleleng “wore shorts, showing their legs, a rather shocking exhibition for the Balinese, who called it *djanger melalong*, the ‘naked djanger,’ but it was popular among the rich Chinese” (Covarrubias [1937] 1950, 254).

6. *Insel der dämonen* was released in Britain as *Black Magic* and in the United States under the alternative titles of *Wajan*, *Son of a Witch*, and *Sins of Bali*.

7. Laurence W. Harrell, “If I just had my way—,” *Los Angeles Times*, 21 May 1939, H12.

8. *Sinar-Sumatra*, 20 September 1938.

Chapter 7: The Heyday of Popular Theater

1. “Orion-Park te Pekalongan,” *Cheribonsche courant*, 15 June 1923, 2.

2. See e.g., “De Komédie Stamboel: Heden en verleden,” *De Indische courant*, 2 February 1928, 2.

3. Miss Riboet was of Javanese descent, but her real name is unknown. Early in her career she was also sometimes referred to as Miss Bingah, Javanese for “Miss Happiness.”

4. *Het noorden*, 15 July 1929. For a compilation of Miss Riboet recordings, including an extraordinary radio broadcast touring the archipelago in song, see *Miss Riboet honderd jaar: Historische opnamen Miss Riboet en Fred Belloni* (Blimbing 2000).

5. For Dardanella’s recording of its theme song, with Miss Riboet II on vocals, see <http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=djOmxxOioEM>.

6. For a vivid account of the dissolute life of bangsawan actors in Medan see Appendix 25 of Parlindungan (1964). This unexpurgated portrait of the arts in Medan circa 1930 is prone to sensationalism; it makes for entertaining reading, but must be approached with caution. Parlindungan describes a city where the authorities turn a blind eye to gambling, nude floor shows, and vice to ensure that migrant plantation workers used up their savings and thus remained indentured.

7. Like many actors of his generation, Tan Tjeng Bok was also a talented kroncong singer. The album *Kroncong 3 Jaman* (Dian Record) is a late recording (with tracks recently uploaded to YouTube), but gives a sense of his warmth and personality.

8. Dardanella extra turns advertised in 1930 included songs from the Hollywood films *Fox Movietone Folies of 1929*, *The Broadway Melody of 1929*, *Dynamite* (1929), *Glad Rag Doll* (1929), *Rainbow Man* (1929), *Rio Rita* (1929), *The Hollywood Revue of 1929*, and *Rain or Shine* (1930); the 1928 American jazz hit “Nagasaki” by Harry Warren and Mort Dixon; and the sentimental song “Laugh Clown Laugh,” recorded by Harry Richman in 1928. See *De Sumatra Post*, 17 November 1930.

9. See Astaman ([1931] 2010) for an example.
10. *Het noorden*, 10 May 1932.
11. M. A. Soekinah subsequently was known as Nyi Lurah Sukarini. Sumarsam reports in an e-mail communication of 23 January 2011 that she was married to the well-known Javanese musician and composer R. Ng. Martopangrawit.
12. “Dardanella menoeroet zaman,” *Soeara-kaoem*, 31 May 1930.
13. “Balinese Dances in Singapore,” *The Straits Times*, 9 January 1935, 13.
14. “Tooneelclub ‘Monte Carlo’ dengan Ir. Soekarno,” *Sinar-Sumatra*, 24 December 1938.
15. *Dr. Sjaitan* (Dr. Devil), based on the 1931 Universal Pictures horror film *Frankenstein*, depicts a brilliant and amoral scientist named Dr. Moezaky who reanimates corpses by transplanting the hearts of living people into them. It was advertised in its Bengkulu revival as “the pinnacle of ‘devilry,’ the pinnacle of action, the pinnacle of excellence, the pinnacle of ‘science and spirit and thrill’ [English in original], the pinnacle of anything previously shown in Bengkulu!” (quoted in Setiyanto 2006, 202). Handbills warned that the play was not suitable for children under the age of ten. In his autobiography, Sukarno (1965, 130) wrote, “Like all my works, it had a moral, the underlying message being that the lifeless body of Indonesia would somehow rise and live again.”
16. The concept of five substances is a classical esoteric concept normally referring to air, fire, water, earth, and spirit or ether. My thanks go to my NIAS colleague Marco Pasi for this explanation.
17. Aw. Rata, “Pereubahan diatas panggoeng: Dipandang dengan katja mata agama,” *Pedoman masjarakat*, 10 November 1937.
18. *Pedoman masjarakat*, 22 November 1939.
19. Ki Hadjar himself later attributed the coinage of the word “sandiwara” to Mangkuningara VII.
20. H. K., “Seni sandiwara Indonesia diwaktoe sekarang,” *Pelita rakjat*, 23 October 1948, 4.
21. See <http://www.helenmarshall.co.uk/tobong.html>.
22. Paku Alam VII, the prince of Yogyakarta’s Pakualaman royal house, was then known as K. G. P. A. A. Prabu Suryadilaga. No specific name seems to have been given to the ensemble or form, and it is not clear whether this novelty was repeated (Jumeiri n.d.).
23. “Oude en nieuwe kunst op de Djokjasche jaarmarkt-tentoonstelling,” *Het nieuws van den dag voor Nederlandsch-Indië*, 19 July 1927, 5.
24. Brooks Atkinson, “Java after Dinner,” *New York Times*, 9 July 1933, 11.
25. I would like to thank Jan Mrázek for his kind assistance in translating and summarizing relevant sections of Vaníčková’s thesis.
26. “Verboden voorstelling,” *Het nieuws van den dag voor Nederlandsch-Indië*, 8 February 1929, 2.
27. *Pewarta-Deli*, 13 January 1931.
28. “Communistische vereeniging ter Sumatra’s Oostkust,” *De Indische courant*, 10 December 1929, 6. Kethoprak survived in Medan and other cities of north Sumatra into the 1980s and later. It was known in two variants: Javanese-language kethoprak (known as *kethoprak blangkon* or *kethoprak neng-nong*) that was accompanied by gamelan, and Malay-language *kethoprak dor* that was accompanied by a syncretic ensemble of *jidor*, *kenrung*, Javanese drum, and harmonium. See Subanindyo (1995).

29. See the many newspaper articles on randai published in *Sinar-Sumatra* in July through December 1938. For a period recording by the randai artist Djamris Batagah, listen to *Randai Parjdain*, <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=lhtuBPJG81A>.

30. “Peladjaran terledoer karena randai,” *Sinar-Sumatra*, 5 July 1939.

31. For a documentary film about randai incorporating colonial-era footage, see Wim van Zanten and Bart Barendregt, directors, *Told in Heaven to Become Stories on Earth: A Story of Change in Randai Theatre of the Minangkabau in West Sumatra using Visual Documentation from the 1930s* (Leiden: University of Leiden, Institute of Cultural and Social Studies, 2000).

Chapter 8: Performing the Arts of Nationalism

1. The linguistic novelty of this play “offered in the censer of Malay” (*tersembah kedalam perdoepaan Bahasa Melajoe*) is evident in a four page glossary appended to its first edition in which Javanese, Arabic, Old Javanese, and other out-of-the-ordinary words and terms are translated into both Malay and Dutch.

2. The union of Sumatrans might be seen as a direct precursor to the dominant nationalist conception of the unity of Indonesia, imagined to be the sum of the archipelago’s *pribumi* (native) inhabitants, and therefore exclusive of Europeans, Indo, Chinese, and other “foreign Asiatics” who occupied a different status under colonial law, with greater rights and privileges.

3. “Toneel: Vereeniging Medan perdoepaan anak Soematera di Betawi,” Undated clipping (circa 5–6 July 1926) from unknown newspaper, Sinematek Indonesia archive.

4. There are other nationalist plays from the 1920s and 1930s that seem to be unpublished and consequently are not likely to be extant. One is Muhammad Yamin’s *Kalau Dewi Tara sudah berkata* (When Dewi Tara has spoken, 1932), apparently about the marriage of a princess from the Sumatran kingdom of Srivijaya to the king of the central Javanese Śailendra dynasty. Another lost play is *Manimporok-cyclus* (Manimporok cycle), possibly based on the myth of Kalangi and Manimporok from the Minahasa of North Sulawesi.

5. For a translation, see S. Pané (2010).

6. The building was also known informally as the Indonesische Clubhuis. It is today a museum called Gedung Sumpah Pemuda.

7. “Njanji Kebangsaan,” *Persatoean Indonesia*, 1 December 1928.

8. “Tida mau kasi hormat ‘Wilhelmus,’” *Bintang Borneo*, 25 March 1930; “Indonesia Raja,” *Sinar-Sumatra*, 31 October 1939.

9. For a compilation of contributions to this polemic, see Mihardja ([1948] 1998).

10. “Cultuur,” *De Indische courant*, 5 December 1933, 1.

Part III: “No more musicians, no more writers”

1. This recording was made over a ten-day period in December 1942. A group of Indonesian students from the Sarekat Indonesia student society first wrote out the lyrics of the song and they were recorded in Kōsaku’s house. A Japanese choir studied the lyrics and recording and had their pronunciation corrected by R. Sudjono, the Indonesian language instructor at the Tokyo Foreign Language School. The Japanese choir then recorded Kōsaku’s arrangement with orchestral backing. Reputedly, thousands of copies of the recording, along with thousands of Indonesian flags, were lost when the *Sakura Maru* sank in Banten Bay. For further details, see Ichiki Tatsu, “Bendera merah putih,” *Tjahaja*, 21 September 1944, 1; Sudjono 1970, 59–60.

Chapter 9: Toward Greater East Asian Culture

1. “Pertoendjoekkan Kesenian Indonesia,” *Kalimantan Raya*, 6 April 1942, 8.
2. Other propaganda plays by Japanese and Indonesian authors produced by the academy, including *Pendekar Asia* (Asian warrior), *Iboe berdosa* (Sinful mother), and *Ratoe Asia* (Queen of Asia), met with critical success when they toured around Java.
3. See, e.g., the advertisement in *Pewarta perniagaan*, 21 August 1942, 2.
4. Ferry Kok, “Kesenian tari Indonesia,” *Tjahaja*, 28 December 1942, 3. This article was reprinted in part in the 1943 *Soeara Asia* annual under the title “Tarian diatas panggoeng” and Dewi Mada’s byline, suggesting that it was ghostwritten on behalf of the company.
5. *Bengawan Solo* was a hit among Japanese as well as Indonesians, and continued to be sung by Japanese military personnel after their return to Japan. See Kartomi (1998).
6. “Goeroe2 membentoe sandiwara ‘Soembawa,’” *Borneo shimboen* (Bandjermasin), 4 July 1944, 2.
7. When Sinar Matahari disbanded, its Chinese director Oei Boen Tjæ formed a new company called Tjahaja Selebes made up of out-of-work laborers in Bone.
8. “Pemerintahoean,” *Sinar matahari* (Ambon), 1 September 1943, 1.
9. “Kesan dari panggoeng sandiwara,” *Tjahaja*, 9 March 1943, 4.
10. Tjahaja Timoer was founded on 6 April 1943 as Matahari. It changed its name to Tjahaja Timoer on 1 October of the same year.
11. Compare on this point Lindsay (2012b), who argues for the importance of exchange among artists participating in cultural missions abroad in the postindependence period for the development of cultural nationalism.
12. An exception to the revival of tradition was found in Aceh, where the performance of *seudati* dance was discouraged by making it difficult to receive performance permits. *Seudati* was a competitive form attracting rowdy crowds and reportedly resulted in “theft, extramarital sex, fights, and so on.” See “Permainan seudati diboebarkan polisi: Doe orang kepalanja telah dimasoeakkan dalam tahanan,” *Atjeh sinbun*, 18 August 1943, 2.
13. Machjar Angga Koesoemadinata, “Apakah moesik Indonesia (gamelan) ada goenanja oentoek pembangoen semangat?,” *Tjahaja*, 8 September 1942, 3. The slowing down of Sundanese music mirrors the slowing down of kroncong tempos, which allowed for more elaborate and tuneful vocal lines and the adaptation of foreign songs and idioms. See Yampolsky (2010, 2013).
14. “Poesat Kesenian Priangan Syuu,” *Tjahaja*, 5 February 1943, 3. The Poesat Kesenian Priangan was very active in the first months of 1943, but its functions seem to have been taken over by the Poesat Keboedajaan Priangan, founded in September 1943 as a branch of Jakarta’s Cultural Center.
15. “Perkoempoelan keboedajaan ‘Sendangan,’” *Pembangoenan*, 18 December 1943, 2.
16. “Menghideoepkan kesenian Indonesia asli,” *Borneo simboen* (Balikpapan), 29 January 1944, 2.
17. “Gamelan Djawa model baroe: Persis piano,” *Pembangoenan*, 21 June 1943, 5; “Moerjaraas Radya-Poestaka: Demonstrasi gamelan Raras-hadi,” *Sinar matahari*, 1 July 1943, 2.
18. Bang Bedjat, “Wajang, berbasa Nippon,” *Pembangoenan*, 28 July 1943, 5.
19. See, i.e., Salmoen (1943a, 1943b).
20. When this kidung was printed in an article on ludruk’s history (Iswojo 1943), the author added that there was no need to explain the meaning of the text—the poetic form of the

kidung would have been intimately familiar to many readers, and its core propaganda messages (such as the idea of Japanese soldiers as being at the frontline of the war, while Javanese farmers and others providing needed goods and services manned the back) were being aired and reinforced across so many media as to be entirely self-evident.

21. “Oentoek merajakan hari tanggal 8 Desember,” *Tjahaja*, 10 November 1942, 1.

22. Domei, “Stèlèng hidoep-kesenian: Kesenian dan hidoep haroes satoe,” *Asia Raya*, 3 April 1943, 1.

23. As Minister of Education and Culture during the Sukarno period, Prijono is sometimes credited with coming up with the concept of staging “the Ramayana ballet” at Prambanan, which originated the *sendratari* dance-drama form in 1961. It is thus not surprising that some writers refer to *Banjaransari* as a *sendratari*.

24. “Goena mentjatat nama-nama kaoem intellek Indonesia, pemimpin peroesahaan dan pemoeda serta pengandjoer lainnja,” *Tjahaja*, 10 November 1942, 2.

25. “Boeat kepentingan doenia sandiwara,” *Tjahaja*, 20 January 1943, 1.

26. “Film-film Amerika-Inggeris dihapoeskan,” *Asia Raya*, 30 March 1943, 1.

27. “Pentjataan kaoem keboedajaan,” *Asia Raya*, 15 July 1943, 2.

28. Comprehension of what was being sung and acted seems to have been partial, at best. The Japanese songbook *Njanjian Nippon oentoek anak-anak* (Japanese songs for children), which went through four printings between October 1942 and February 1943, contains solfège notation and transliteration of Japanese lyrics, but no translations (Waraita and Badan Pengarang *Sinar Matahari* 1943).

29. “Hasil pertoendjoekan wajang beber,” *Soera Asia*, 25 September 1943, 2.

30. “Hidangan semangat bagi pegawai syutyō,” *Soera Asia*, 3 February 1944, 2.

31. “Pertjoendjoekan ‘kamishibai’ mendapat perhatian besar,” *Pewarta Selebes*, 26 February 1944, 3.

32. “Rombongan penhiboer kesenian keliling,” *Tjahaja*, 15 February 1944, 2.

Chapter 10: The Cultural Center

1. “Popular Education and Cultural Section,” in Allied Translator and Interpreter Section, South West Pacific Area, *Monthly Propaganda Report from Java [December 1943]*, ATIS Enemy Publication 211 (n.p.: National Archives of the Netherlands, 1944), WO208/2483, 14.

2. The Cultural Center had four main divisions—literature; painting and carving; music; and theater, dance, and film—while a fifth one, the administrative division, oversaw activities and policies. Advisory and consulting boards were made up of both Japanese military personnel and noted Indonesian intellectuals and artists, including Hussein Djajadiningrat, Poerbataraka, Muhammad Yamin, Agus Salim, Ali Sastroamidjojo, Basuki Abdullah, and Sudjono.

3. Pasaribu is said to have spent fourteen months playing cello with a Filipino band on a Japanese cruise ship before studying cello and piano for three and a half years at the private music academy Musashino Academia Musicae in Tokyo. In 1940, he joined the studio orchestra of the Batavia branch of the Dutch East Indies Radio Broadcasting Corporation (NIROM). He was one of only three non-Europeans in the ensemble at the time. See Sitorus 2009, 27–34.

4. Soendoro, “Kemadjoean seni soera,” *Pembangoenan*, 16 August 1943, 2.

5. The new lyrics of “Bengawan Solo,” published in the Indonesian press in September 1944, were attributed to Colonel Takahashi Kōryō, who was appointed as chief of the Sendenbu in Java in April 1945, but it seems more likely that they were a Cultural Center product.

6. “Bei mir bist du schön” (originally “Bei mir bistu shein”) is a Yiddish theater song popularized by an Andrews Sisters recording of 1937.

7. To illustrate what he meant by “overacting,” a loan-term still in circulation in Indonesian theater circles, Armijn Pané described a scenic type that would have been familiar to all experienced stambul and tonil spectators, in which a mother is forced to leave her baby. The mother caresses her child, cries, puts her down, walks a few steps away, runs back to her, kisses her and cries some more, walks away a bit farther, and runs back again—a sequence repeated several more times, acted in a spotlight with sentimental musical accompaniment.

8. The play was said to have been written during the period of 1 July 1943 to 6 July 1945, perhaps corresponding to Amal’s term of employment at the Cultural Center.

9. “Lagoe tentara pembela: Tjiptaan Keimin Bunka Sidosjo,” *Soeara Asia*, 20 November 1943, 4.

10. It was published by the state publisher Balai Pustaka in 1943 as the first volume in a projected world drama series called *Tonil Aneka Warna* (A variety of theater). Norway’s declaration of neutrality at the start of World War II and Ibsen’s popularity in Japan explain why this European playwright could be performed.

11. Darmawidjaja, “‘Ibsen’ diatas panggoeng,” *Asia Raya*, 10 May 1944, 2.

12. Ibid.

13. It is because of transpositions of this sort, perhaps, that one reviewer remarked that Armijn Pané’s adaptation was “full of impressions that precisely address and are of value to everyday life.” “*Ratna dimoea tjorong radio*,” *Pewarta perniagaan*, 1 June 1943, 2.

14. “Sajembara memperkaja kesoesasteraan dan kesenian dalem masa peperangan,” *Pewarta perniagaan*, 23 January 1943, 1.

15. The introduction likens the play to Ibsen’s early plays *Brand* and *Peer Gynt*, in which a protagonist stands for a class of people: the female character “Partiwi” (Earth, in literary Javanese) is symbolic of the land of Indonesia, which offers sustenance to Pandoe Setiawan (Faithful Guide, symbolic of Indonesia’s youth), Priajiwati (Female Nobility, symbolic of the upper classes), and Nadarlan (the Netherlands) alike.

16. “Perlombaan mengarang (diselenggarakan oleh Borneo Simboenja),” *Borneo shimboen (Bandjermasin)*, 17 July 1943, 1.

17. Abdoerrachman Noor, “Pengoerbanan membawa keinsjafan.” Twelve installments: *Borneo shimboen (Bandjermasin)*, 28 January 1944, 2; 29 January 1944, 2; 30 January 1944, 2; 1 February 1944, 2; 2 February 1944, 2; 3 February 1944, 2; 4 February 1944, 2; 5 February 1944, 2; 6 February 1944, 2; 8 February 1944, 2; 9 February 1944, 2; and 10 February 1944, 2.

18. Yasuda was assisted by R. M. Winarno (formerly of Badan Persiapan Poesat Kesenian) and writer-director Raden Ariffien (who had worked with Yasuda at Sekolah Tonil).

19. K. Jasoeda, “Langkah baroe dalam doenia sandiwara,” *Sinar matahari*, 13 November 1943, 2.

20. “Mengadakan pertoendjoekan leloetjon,” *Asia Raya*, 5 June 1943.

21. “Hasil perlombaan leloetjon meroentoehkan Amerika/Inggeris di Pasar Malam Djakarta,” *Pembangoenan*, 10 July 1943, 3.

22. Maya was briefly resuscitated around 1949 to stage plays written by company members Usmar Ismail and Abu Hanifah after they were published by the Balai Pustaka.

23. Kikuchi Kan’s play had already been translated into English under the title “The Father Returns” and published in Japan in 1925. Ismail almost certainly worked from the translation rather than the Japanese-language original.

24. “Poesat Keboedajaan dan kapas,” *Pembangoenan*, 23 September 1943, 2; Ismail and Simandjoentak (1943). This was one of a number of such study tours undertaken by Cultural Center staff. In December 1943, Usmar Ismail and fellow writer Inoe Kertapati lived for three days in the barracks of the soldiers of Tentara Pembela Tanah Air. Usmar Ismail wrote about his experience in a piece of participatory journalism titled “Three Days as a Soldier.” See Usmar Ismail’s two-part article, “Tiga hari djadi Pradjoerit,” in *Tjahaja*, 22 December 1943, 2 and 23 December 1943, 1.

25. It is significant in this regard that despite shortages of materials the number of European-style Indonesian painters was said to have doubled or even tripled during the war years. See Holt 1967, 200; Jones 2003, 82–83.

Chapter 11: Domination and Resistance

1. According to Mark (2003, 576), the concept of *gotong-royong* was introduced by the Japanese as a rough equivalent of the Japanese term for corvée labor, *kinrô-hôshi*. The concept outlasted the occupation and is still evoked as a symbol of traditional Asian values.

2. Esde, “Karena mentjemarkan nama Kei Bodan,” *Pembangoenan*, 18 August 1943, 6.

3. Kementerian Penerangan (1953d, 851). There are a number of alternate versions of this couplet. Peacock ([1968] 1987, 30) glosses the poem as “living under Japanese rule is like living in a birdcage.”

4. “Toeana Doerasim poelang ke’alam baka,” *Soeara Asia*, 3 July 1944, 2; Im. S., “Tjak Doerasim,” *Soeara Asia*, 4 July 1944, 2.

5. “Lagoe kebangsaan Indonesia Raja mendjadi sempoerna,” *Soeara Asia*, 18 November 1944, 1–2.

6. “Pemboekaan latihan dalang: 151 orang dalang seloeroeh Kediri Syuu digemblang,” *Soeara Asia*, 16 August 1945, 2.

7. “‘Perserikatan Oesaha Sandiwara Djawa’ didirikan,” *Asia Raya*, 31 August 1944, 1.

8. For a fine documentary (also available on YouTube) about *Calling Australia!*, see Shirley (1987).

9. “Tjeritera2 Pangeran Diponegoro, Oentoeng Soerapati dan Sawoenggaling tidak boleh dimainkan oleh sembarang sandiwara,” *Asia Raya*, 14 July 1943, 2.

10. “Mekar Boenga Madja Pahit,” *Asia Raya*, 5 June 1945, 2.

11. Quoted with permission of the translator Dr. Karen Sri Kartomi Thomas.

12. See Taal (2002, 191) and “Boeng Karno Selamat,” *Tjahaja*, 15 June 1942, 2.

13. “Kesan-Kesan perdjalanana P.T. Sjafei ke Sumatera Tengah dan Selatan,” *Tjahaja*, 13 August 1945, 1.

14. In the typed version of the proclamation the words “representatives of the Indonesian people” are changed to “on behalf of the people of Indonesia.”

15. Advertisement for “Konsert Gembira,” *Asia Raya*, 31 August 1945, 2. The concert was actually scheduled to be held twice, on 1 and 2 September 1945.

16. “Penoetoeapan latihan dalang,” *Soeara Asia*, 29 August 1945, 1.

Conclusion

1. Marzuki’s prewar film opus includes *Sarinah* (1931) and the hit film *Terang boelan* (1937).

2. For an anthology of nationalist songs popular in the 1940s, see the CD accompanying Gommers-Dekker (2011).

3. Dewantara (1946, 11); Seniman, “Ketoprak,” *Soeloeh ra’jat*, 13 September 1947, 3.
4. For an evocative set of *wayang suluh* photographs, see <https://nobodycorpfound.wordpress.com/2012/08/16/wayang-suluh-perjuangan>.
5. Sir Angus Gillan’s Report on South-East Asia as the result of his tour, October/December 1946, British Council Archives, BW122/2, registry file CL/IDS/689/1, Volume 1, National Archives (UK). The report goes on to say that “generally in spite of political suspicions the war may have left there is a genuine desire for a greater knowledge of the things of Britain.” After much deliberation, the British Council established its office in Bandung in 1948.
6. The center was renamed the *Jajasan Pusat Kebudayaan Indonesia* (Foundation for the Center of Indonesian Culture), with J. E. Tatengkeng as head.
7. “Sandiwara Sawiregadging,” *Siasat* 2, no. 64 (23 May 1948).
8. “Bimbingan sastra,” *Mimbar Indonesia* 3, no. 7 (12 February 1949): 17, 21.
9. Among other performances, Pamoedjo, Sukoro, and Retna Mohini performed a suite of dances for the Ballet Society in 1947, with gamelan-based music arranged for piano by Colin McPhee, and Sukoro performed Javanese dance for television at the NBC studio of New York in July 1948. The broadcast reportedly attracted 1.5 million viewers (X 1949, 12).
10. The proceedings of the 1948 Cultural Congress are published in a special issue of the journal *Indonesia: Madjalah Kebudayaan* 1, no. 1–2 (June–July 1950), and quotes are from this issue if not otherwise specified.
11. “Perkoempoelan kesenian ‘Gelanggang’ didirikan di Djakarta,” *Pelita rakjat*, 5 February 1948: 1. See also Rosidi (1997, xv), wherein *Gelanggang* is described as a *paguyuban yang longgar* (loose community).
12. Hamidjaja cites Ulrich Huber-Noodt’s Dutch translation of Toynbee’s book, *Beschaving in het geding* (1948). Toynbee was well known to and often cited by the *Gelanggang* generation of artists and intellectuals. In 1956, Toynbee conducted a much-heralded twenty-day lecture tour of Indonesia.
13. Huyung’s life is the subject of a documentary film, which unfortunately is still unavailable for purchase: Kim Jae-Bum, dir., *A Filmmaker with Three Names* (Shin Dong A Panavision, 1997).
14. The notion of *tempo dulu* (“times past”), often cast in the old-style spelling *tempo doelo*, is imported from a Dutch postcolonial context (Goss 2000), but has changed in contemporary Indonesia from political memory work to a ludic framework. The emergence of colonial nostalgia in contemporary Indonesia was the discussion of extensive discussion at the workshop, “Colonial Nostalgia: Memories, Objects and Performances,” held at the KITLV/Royal Netherlands Institute of Southeast Asian and Caribbean Studies in Leiden on 27–28 October 2011.
15. Interview with Nano and Ratna Riantiarno, 3 January 2011.
16. See, for example, Monda Gianes, “‘Opera Primadona’: Sebuah lakon yang memainkan kisah lakon,” *Riau pos*, 15 September 2013. For further on Riantiarno’s relation to Indonesia’s theatrical past, see Cohen (2006, 376–379).
17. “Sardono W. Kusumo. Tari Opera Diponegoro.flv,” <http://youtu.be/m2Uel1z5E8U>.
18. Jane Perlez, “Solo Journal: A Rebel’s Opera: Muslims Meet Cowboy George,” *New York Times*, 4 March 2002, A4.
19. The Tropical Museum (Tropenmuseum) is funded by the Ministry of Foreign Affairs development budget, and its collections focus on parts of the world formerly colonized by the Netherlands, as well as on countries in receipt of Dutch foreign aid. In 2011, the ministry an-

nounced it would suspend funding due to cuts in aid spending. The library of the adjacent Royal Tropical Institute was closed and its collections deaccessioned in 2013. In 2014, the Tropical Museum, Leiden's National Museum of Ethnology, and the Africa Museum in Berg en Dal merged formally into the National Museum of World Cultures. Although there have been no official announcements of the Tropical Museum's closure, staff I spoke to in December 2014 expressed uncertainty about their future employment.

GLOSSARY

- adat*. An Arabic-derived word for “custom” denoting local practices not associated directly with normative Islam or other religions.
- alun-alun*. The public square or large courtyard adjacent to *kraton* and regency offices, an important site for public entertainment and ceremony.
- alus*. The Javanese word for refined, connoting refinement in artistic form and execution as well as manners. *Alus* resonates with European conceptions of “fine arts” and the gentility of the aristocracy.
- angklung*. Tuned bamboo shakers traditionally played as part of a larger musical ensemble to accompany masquerades and processions in Java. All-angklung choirs gained popularity after the 1938 invention of diatonic angklung.
- arja*. A form of danced opera with a diverse repertoire that enjoyed popularity in Bali in the late colonial period.
- bangsawan*. A Malay-language popular musical theater that originated as a local response to Parsi theater in Penang and spread to the rest of the Malay world by the end of the nineteenth century. Bangsawan was originally accompanied by a hybrid ensemble of Indian, European, and Southeast Asian instruments, but the orchestration was thoroughly Western by the 1920s.
- Batavia. The name for present-day Jakarta during the Dutch colonial period, the capital and most trendsetting city of the Dutch Indies.
- batik*. Textiles manufactured by hand through a process of wax-resist dyeing, considered an important marker of status and identity in traditional Java. Also spelled *bathik* in Javanese.
- bedhaya*. An extremely refined form of Javanese court dance with eight or nine identically dressed female dancers accompanied by a full gamelan orchestra. Also spelled *bedoyo* or *bedaya*.
- Boedi Oetomo. “Beautiful Endeavor,” a political and cultural membership organization dominated by *priyayi* elites, founded in Batavia in 1908.
- Bratayuda*. A Javanese telling of the Sanskrit *Bhāratayuddha*, a section of the Mahabharata narrating the cataclysmic war between the Pandhawa and Kurawa brothers.
- bunkajin*. Japanese for “person of culture,” referring to the civilian Japanese and Korean arts workers who created and disseminated pro-Japanese propaganda during the Japanese occupation.
- cakalele*. A generic name for the war dances of Eastern Indonesia, particularly the islands of Maluku, which in premodern times served to excite warriors and terrify enemies.
- Calon Arang*. A form of Balinese ritual drama in which the terrifying witch figure of Rangda is vanquished and appeased as a means to overcome evil influences and dispel epidemics.

concours. A Dutch word meaning “competition.” Competitions of various performing arts were common in Indonesia from the 1910s, often in the context of *pasar malam*.

dalang. See *dhalang*.

Dardanella. The most popular theater company in Indonesia circa 1930, known for its Malay-language adaptations of Hollywood films as well as original plays, interspersed with a variety of extra turns.

dhagelan Mataram. Literally “Matarm-style comedy,” a form of Javanese-language sketch comedy that became popular with radio and recordings in the 1930s.

dhalang. The name for the puppeteer-storyteller in wayang kulit and the narrator in wayang wong, also spelled *dalang*. Dhalang are honored in Java, Bali, and other parts of western Indonesia for their esoteric lore, and until the twentieth century most were of hereditary descent.

dulmuluk. A form of Malay-language theater from Sumatra with stories based on the 1847 Malay narrative poem *Abdul Muluk*, which enjoyed some popularity in Java in the late nineteenth century and is still practiced in South Sumatra.

gambang. A wooden xylophone and also the name for a hybrid Chinese-Sundanese musical genre (now known as *gambang kromong*) that accompanied *wayang cokek* dance parties and *lenong* folk theater in old Batavia.

gambuh. A form of courtly Balinese dance drama enacting stories based on the Malat epic recounting the adventures of Prince Panji.

gambus. A short-necked lute derived from the Yemenite *qanbūs* associated in Indonesia and elsewhere in the Malay world with Islamic music.

gamelan. The ubiquitous musical ensemble made up of gongs, chimes, hand drums, and sometimes other instruments as well as vocalists practiced in Java and neighboring islands. Gamelan is played at social events, but more often accompanies ceremonial functions such as processions, as well as dance and theater. Gamelan is both the name for the set of instruments and the genre of music. There is no set size for a gamelan, and there are numerous regional varieties and subtypes.

gedebus. Also known as *debus*, a display of invulnerability magic generally to gamelan accompaniment, associated particularly with the Banten region of western Java. The genre’s name is derived from the word “debus,” referring to the iron spikes that performers use to skewer themselves as a sign of their faith in Allah.

gendang. The Sundanese and Sumatran versions of Javanese *kendhang*.

gendhing. A class of refined and structurally elaborate musical pieces for gamelan orchestra.

gending karesmen. A traditionalist form of Sundanese music theater created in the 1920s.

hikayat. A Malay-language prose poem, sometimes mined for stories by the Malay popular theater.

Indische toneel. Dutch for “Indies theater.” It was a Dutch-language art theater with plays addressing issues of topical interest to Dutch colonial elites. Plays were performed in both Indonesia and the Netherlands in the late colonial period.

Indo. Short for Indo-European, meaning a person of mixed “native Indonesian” and European descent. Though of mixed race, Indos in the colonial period had the same legal status as Europeans if they were officially recognized as the offspring of a European father, but there was systemic social prejudice against them.

“Indonesia raya.” “Great Indonesia,” Indonesia’s national anthem, composed by Wage Rudolf Soepratman in 1928.

- janger*. A modern potpourri Balinese performing art combining chanting, theatricals, and acrobatics, extremely popular with Balinese youth in the 1920s and 1930s.
- Java Institute. A scholarly society founded in 1919 to preserve and promote the indigenous cultures of Java and neighboring islands, known in Dutch as the Java-Instituut.
- jingju*. A form of traditional Chinese opera, also known in English as “Peking Opera” and associated with Beijing, which combines singing, acting, dance, acrobatics, and instrumental music.
- kaba*. Minang oral literature that is considered an important expression of *adat* (customary) values.
- kabupaten*. Literally “the place of the regent,” the home-cum-office of a regent. The kabupaten is the center of local government, and the *pendhopo* fronting it and adjacent *alun-alun* are often important sites for public performance.
- kamishibai*. A Japanese form of itinerant storytelling with pictures, harnessed as a tool for propaganda in occupied Indonesia.
- kawi*. Old Javanese, the ancient literary language of Java, Bali, and Lombok. Kawi texts are quoted in performances of wayang and other forms of traditional theater.
- kebyar*. A modern form of Balinese gamelan involving virtuosic solo and ensemble playing and associated with a suite of similarly virtuosic dances.
- kecapi*. A plucked zither-like instrument played in Sumatra and western Java. In West Java’s Sundanese highlands it is associated with bardic storytelling and a form of chamber music patronized by aristocrats known as Cianjuran, *tembang Sunda*, or *kecapi-suling*.
- kendhang*. The set of hand drums of gamelan and other Javanese musical ensembles that play a central role in conducting music. Also spelled *kendang*.
- kepatihan*. Literally “the place of the Patih,” the manorial residence of the vizier (*patih*) of a royal court.
- keprak*. A percussion instrument that plays a key role in accompanying dance movement.
- kethoprak*. A Javanese-language vernacular theater, accompanied by gamelan since the 1930s, which enacts a variety of stories, including ones based on Javanese history and legend.
- komedi*. A Dutch-derived Malay word for commercial entertainment, appended to all sorts of amusements. *Komedi kuda* or the “horse show” is the Malay name for the circus, *komedi Jepang* referred in nineteenth-century Indonesia to Japanese acrobatics, *komedi monyet* was the dog-and-monkey show, whereas a *gedung komedi* meant a brick-and-mortar playhouse, or *schouwburg* in Dutch.
- komedi stambul*. A popular Malay-language musical theater with singer-actors accompanied by Western instruments that enjoyed popularity throughout Indonesia until the 1920s.
- Komodie Stamboel. The name of the first *komedi stambul* company, founded in Surabaya in 1891.
- Kridha Beksa Wirama. A school for training in Javanese court-style dance and other performing arts founded in Yogyakarta in 1918, abbreviated as Kridha or KBW.
- kraton*. A royal palace or royal court, properly the residence of a king, but sometimes used informally to refer to other princely mansions.
- kroncong*. Also spelled *keroncong*, the name for a popular style of music that was associated with Indos in nineteenth-century Batavia and spread to the rest of Java and nearby islands in the 1890s. Kroncong originally referred to a small guitar of local manufacture, but became a generic name for this popular Malay-language song form accompanied by European-style instruments.

kroncong baru. “New” *kroncong* music, a more polished and less folksy version of *kroncong* that developed with the expansion of the recording industry in the 1920s and 1930s.

kuda kepang. A form of masquerade and trance dance in which riders mount woven bamboo hobbyhorses and become possessed by horse spirits through the trance-inducing music of a small gamelan. Also known as *jaran lumping* and *jathilan* in Javanese.

ladon-diladon. A theatrical practice associated with *komedi stambul* (and Parsi theater and *bangsawan* before it) of an actor introducing himself to the public on his first appearance on stage.

lagu seriosa. Literally “serious songs” in Malay, denoting European-style art music.

langendriya. A form of courtly dance drama accompanied by gamelan orchestra with a repertoire based mostly on Damar Wulan legends. Also known as *langendriyan*.

legong. A court-based genre of Balinese dance performed by two or three prepubescent girls, considered to be a foundational form for many other dances.

lenong. A form of folk drama once popular in the area of Batavia that enacts stories of everyday life and popular legends to the accompaniment of *gambang kromong*.

ludruk. An East-Javanese all-male folk theater that in the 1890s was commercialized as a form of *komedi* and in the 1920s was politicized and became an important soapbox for advocating the rights of workers. Also spelled *ludrug*.

Mahabharata. An epic imported from India to Java, Bali, and other Indonesian islands in the first millennium centering on the deeds of the five noble brothers known as the *Pendhawa*, all sons of Hindu gods. Although the majority religion of Java has been Islam since at least the seventeenth century, the *Mahabharata* remains popular as a source for wayang plays.

Majapahit. This illustrious Javanese kingdom reached its peak of glory in the fourteenth century under Hayam Wuruk. With tributaries from around Indonesia and further afield, it is a key symbol for Indonesian nationalism.

opera derma. Literally “charity opera,” a form of Sino-Malay community theater often linked to charitable causes.

opera Melayu. Literally “Malay opera,” an alternate designation for *bangsawan*, *komedi stambul*, and related Malay-language musical theaters.

palaran. A genre of Javanese gamelan music emphasizing singing over softly playing instruments.

panggung. An elevated stage, associated in the nineteenth century principally with *komedi* performance, but later common to all performing arts.

pantun. A four-line Malay poetic form, sometimes spelled *pantoun* in English and French, which deploys often allusive symbols for social communication. Also the name of a storytelling form performed by a solo bard in the Sundanese highlands of West Java to the self-accompaniment of *kecap* (zither) or *tarawangsa* (fiddle).

Parsi theater. A commercial Indian theater that achieved huge popularity with Southeast Asian audiences in the nineteenth century, resulting in numerous imitators and offshoots.

pasar malam. Literally a “night fair,” a key venue for entertainment, propaganda, and business in early twentieth-century Indonesia.

pathet. A Javanese term for mode in gamelan music, with different *pathet* corresponding to the acts or major structural divisions in a wayang play.

pelog. One of the two major tunings of Javanese and Sundanese gamelan that uses a selection of notes from a seven-tone scale.

pencak silat. Martial arts, also known as *penca*, *pencak*, or *silat*.

pendhapa. An open-air covered pavilion, normally constructed adjacent to the house of a Javanese king or courtier and used as a space for performances and ceremonies. Also spelled *pendopo*.

pesindhen. The female vocalist of Javanese and Sundanese gamelan. Many *pesindhen* through the twentieth century doubled as *ronggeng*, and it is still common to see *pesindhen* stand up and dance in gamelan performances.

plezier. The Dutch-derived Malay word for “pleasure” or “amusement,” generally involving attendance at an entertaining public event. Also spelled *plessier* and *plesier*.

POSD. Perserikatan Oesaha Sandiwara Djawa, or the Sandiwara Union of Java, a wartime umbrella organization founded in 1944 that brought together all of Java’s major *sandiwara* companies to utilize them for wartime propaganda.

pribumi. An Indonesian/Malay term meaning “indigenous,” sometimes also translated “son of the soil.” This term is sometimes used to refer to “native” Indonesians (i.e., Indonesians who are not of Chinese, European, Indian, or Arab descent). The term is more or less a translation of the Dutch *inlander* (native) and carries with it some of that term’s colonial baggage.

priyayi. The hereditary blue-blooded elite of Java, who under colonialism gradually transformed into the white-collared civil service.

pusaka. The Javanese word for a magically potent or sacred heirloom, which can take a material form (such as a mask) or immaterial form (such as a *bedhaya* dance).

Ramayana. An Indian epic imported to Java, Bali, and other Indonesian islands before 1000 CE. The Ramayana tells the story of the abduction of the beautiful Sinta by the ogre king Rahwana and of Sinta’s rescue by her husband Rama and his army of monkeys. It is generally less popular in Java than its sister epic, the Mahabharata, but despite centuries of Islamization remains an important source for wayang plays.

randai. A modern Minangkabau folk theater enacting *kaba* stories, usually performed by all-male ensembles at ground level.

rebab. A spiked fiddle that is the single bowed instrument in Javanese gamelan. This instrument has a central role in leading the ensemble and in traditional Java was the instrument of choice for amateur musicians of high status.

rebana. A frame drum, also the name of a genre of music that uses these instruments associated with Islam. Also spelled *rabana*.

ronggeng. A female social dancer paid to dance to gamelan accompaniment with male clients in dance parties, generally assumed to also be a sex worker. Also known in some parts of Java as a *tandak* or *taledhek*.

salendro. A Sundanese variant of the Javanese *slendro* tuning.

sandiwara. A term for spoken-language drama, literally “secret proclamations,” that emerged in the late 1930s among nationalist circles to replace the Dutch-derived term *tonil*.

sanggar. Art studio or workshop, which often functions as a space for rehearsal, training, and sometimes performances, referred to as an *atelier* through the 1950s.

schouwburg. A Dutch word for a brick-and-mortar public theater with a proscenium stage, known in Malay as *gedung komedi*.

Sekaten. An Islamic holiday commemorating the birth of the Prophet Muhammad, which is an important annual public celebration in the Javanese royal courts.

semangat. The Indonesian translation of the Japanese term *seishin*, connoting “enthusiasm” or “spirit,” to be harnessed for the war against the Allies and later for independence or other causes.

Sendenbu. The Propaganda Department during the period of the Japanese occupation, known as the Barisan Propaganda or “Propaganda Front” in Indonesian.

silat. See *pencak silat*.

slendro. One of the two major tunings of Javanese gamelan that uses a five-tone scale.

serimpi. A courtly Javanese dance form featuring two pairs of female dancers, and sometimes props such as decanters or pistols, accompanied by a gamelan orchestra. Also spelled *serimpi*.

STOVIA. An abbreviation of School tot Opleiding van Inlandsche Artsen, meaning School for Training Native Doctors, founded in Batavia in 1902. It was the first tertiary-level institute of higher education open to non-Europeans in Indonesia.

strijkje. The Dutch word for a string orchestra, made up of string instruments and sometimes harp and woodwinds, which accompanied balls, tea dances, and other polite social occasions. Also known as a *strijkorkest*.

suling. A bamboo flute that can be either side- or end-blown.

sulukan. The mood songs sung by a puppeteer or narrator in a wayang performance with texts often derived from the twelfth-century Old Javanese version of the *Bhāratayuddha*. An individual song is sometimes referred to as a *suluk*.

syair. A Malay-language narrative poem. Syair often are mined as a source for Malay plays.

tableau vivant. French for “living picture,” a popular nineteenth-century theatrical pastime in which frozen assemblages of costumed actors reproduced well-known images. Tableaux vivants commonly concluded *komedi stambul* performances and also found their way into other cultural expressions.

taledhek. See *ronggeng*.

Taman Siswa. “Garden of Pupils,” a national independent educational movement inspired by Tagore, Montessori, and Fröbel founded in Yogyakarta in 1922.

tandak. See *ronggeng*.

tayuban. A dance party in which male clients dance with *ronggeng* to gamelan accompaniment. Protocol for these parties is sometimes very rigid, and *tayuban* served traditionally to profile men’s status in local communities.

tembang. A Javanese tradition of sung poetry, part of the so-called *alus* art complex.

terbangan. An Islamic musical form combining the playing of frame drums (*terbang*) with songs of praise.

THHK. An abbreviation of Tiong Hoa Hew Koan, the Chinese Association formed in 1900 that advocated for Chinese rights and aimed to instill a sense of Chinese identity in people of Chinese descent in Indonesia.

tonil. Spoken-language drama in Malay and other languages of Indonesia, a European-derived art of the twentieth century. It is derived from the Dutch word for theater (*toneel*, also spelled *tooneel*) and is sometimes also spelled *tunil*.

topeng. Mask-dance or masked theater practiced in different regional varieties in Java, Bali, and other islands of western Indonesia. Topeng also sometimes refers to the mask itself.

tuán. A Malay honorific and polite term of address for adult men, typically Europeans. Alternately translated as “Mr.,” “master,” or “my lord,” it has a slightly obsequious tinge. Also spelled *tuwan*.

- wayang*. A generic name in Java for all sorts of theater (including puppetry, scroll theater, dance theater, and Chinese opera) and for some forms of social dance (e.g., *wayang cokek*), but in common parlance is used to refer specifically to puppet theater, whether *wayang kulit* or *wayang golek*. Individual puppets can also be referred to as *wayang*.
- wayang beber*. An ancient form of storytelling in which a solo narrator accompanied by a small gamelan tells a story illustrated on a scroll that is gradually unrolled (*mbeber*) over the course of a night.
- wayang cokek*. A social dance form patronized primarily by Chinese in old Batavia (present-day Jakarta) in which male patrons dance with a professional female dancer, known as the *cokek*, to the accompaniment of a hybrid ensemble of Chinese and Sundanese musical instruments.
- wayang golek*. Rod puppet theater, a traditional theater of West and Central Java that uses rounded puppets carved from wood and is accompanied by a gamelan orchestra. In the Sundanese highlands of West Java, plays are mostly based on the Mahabharata and Ramayana, but in other areas of the island other repertoires dominate.
- wayang krucil*. A variety of Javanese wayang puppetry, now rare, with flat wooden puppets enacting Javanese legends to the accompaniment of gamelan. Also known as *wayang klithik*.
- wayang kulit*. Shadow puppet theater, a traditional or tradition-based theater practiced today in both Indonesia and Malaysia and their diasporas, which uses flat puppets carved from animal hide interposed between a tautly stretched cotton screen and a light source. Generally stories are based on the Mahabharata and Ramayana, and in Java plays are accompanied by a gamelan orchestra.
- wayang orang*. See *wayang wong*.
- wayang wong*. A form of dance-drama practiced in both Java and Bali in which dancer-actors take on the roles of the puppet characters of *wayang kulit*. In Java, narration and “mood songs” (*sulukan*) are sung by an off-stage narrator, known as the *dhalang*. Musical accompaniment, like in wayang kulit, is provided by a gamelan. Java has both a courtly variety known today as *wayang wong pendhapa* (pavilion wayang wong) and a popular variety called *wayang wong panggung* (stage wayang wong). Wayang wong is also known as *ringgit tiyang* (in high Javanese) and *wayang orang* (in Malay and Indonesian).

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